

THOSE WHO NO LONGER RUN



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a science-fiction novel

EXPANDED AND REVISED EDITION

*“Peace does not eliminate selection.
It only moves the place where it happens.”*

A GUIDE TO THE WORLD

Term	Meaning at the beginning of the novel
Arua	a tidally locked world, with one hemisphere scorched by light and the other frozen; abundant life survives in the Twilight Belt between them.
The Nivari	a social, fertile species acutely sensitive to danger; they have lateral eyes, mobile auditory sails, powerful hind limbs and cities dug or grown beneath rock.
The Long Quiet	four centuries without war, maintained through the rotation of the provincial Houses, restrictions on weapons, the management of births and central control of food, light and infrastructure.
The Great Hearing	a computing network that correlates the cities' vibrations, population registers, production and ecological models; it makes recommendations, and institutions often claim merely to carry them out.
The Chamber of Measure	the institution that allocates birth rights and the Belt's resources.
Ivarra and Vaor	respectively, the central capital of peace and a border domain where yields are falling, the population is concealed and the old answers no longer suffice.

CHARACTERS AT THE BEGINNING OF THE STORY

Sava Ilen — a demographer in the Chamber of Measure; she believes in the necessity of limits but knows their administrative cruelty.

Oru Ven — Sava's partner and an engineer of the root network; he regards peace as an ecosystem to be repaired, not revered.

Nemi — their daughter; sensitive to sound, curious and close to her uncle.

Taren Ilen — Sava's younger brother; diagnosed in childhood with a delayed flight reflex.

Seln Aru — the Custodian of Ivarra; he defends the planetary order with a lucidity that rarely presents itself as violence.

Daran Veyr — the lord of Vaor; cultivated, provocative and convinced that the centre turns the death of the provinces into procedure.

Vessa Dahr — a doctor serving Vaor's unregistered communities.

Raal — a leader of nivari struck from the registers and driven towards the galleries of the Night.

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PART I

THE LOW PEACE

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CHAPTER I

PEACE BENEATH THE STONE

SAVA · IVARRA · THREE DAYS BEFORE THE FESTIVAL OF RETREAT

For four centuries, Ivarra had known no war. In that peace, everything dangerous had either been removed from the world, moved into a museum, or renamed a procedure.

Sava Ilen woke before the morning signal, both auditory sails raised and her heart racing at a sound she could not locate.

She lay motionless in the sleeping niche. In Ivarra's homes, the walls were not entirely rigid. The ceramic root from which they had been grown retained a calculated elasticity, so that footsteps, blows and serious faults could be felt through the bones before they reached the ears. The floor was now sending her small, rapid vibrations. Not an alarm. Not a collapse. More like one light object striking another, with a persistence that belonged only to children.

Sava climbed down from the niche and opened the room's panel.

Nemi stood barefoot in the shared gallery, her festival ribbon hanging over one eye. She was trying to strike the floor three times without her bone toy jumping out of a chalk circle.

"Shadow, shelter, silence," the little girl said. "But if I strike too slowly, the instructor says the predator hears me between the beats."

"The predator is a sheet of cloth pulled along a wire."

"In the drill. In ancient times it was real."

Nemi was six standard years old, an age at which a nivar could read, calculate simple rations and generate enough worry for three adults. Her lateral eyes followed the chalk circle and her mother's expression at the same time. Her long sails trembled at every sound in the pipes. The medical system called this sensitivity auditory hyperreactivity. Oru

called it an abundance of attention. Sava, who had access to the complete file, called it nothing at all.

“Go back to bed,” she said. “The signal hasn’t come.”

“Taren isn’t asleep.”

Sava turned one sail towards her brother’s room. No breathing, no rustle. The bed was empty.

“How do you know?”

“His door doesn’t smell of sleep.”

The smells of families mingled in the city’s narrow spaces: baked root, warm down, tool oil, the sweet secretion parents used to mark their children in crowds. Nemi was right. Cold gallery air was coming from Taren’s room.

Oru appeared from the kitchen with a cup between his teeth and two plates in his hands. The short fur on his forearms was stained green with nutrient, though he had washed before sleeping. Root-network engineers wore their work in their skin more than they wore uniforms.

“He’s gone to startle training,” he said. “He left me a message.”

“At this hour?”

“The machines are more convincing when the body hasn’t fully woken up.”

Sava took the cup he held out to her. The infusion was bitter and too hot.

“Does that seem normal to you?”

“No. But normality is precisely what they’re treating him for.”

Oru sat on the floor, his back against the curved wall. Nivari could use chairs, but few preferred them. A body raised above the floor lost the information carried by vibrations, and four centuries had not been enough to make that loss comfortable.

Nemi slipped between them and took a slice of baked root.

“Taren says the machine gets scared faster than he does.”

“Taren says a lot of things when he doesn’t want to answer,” Sava said.

“Do you always answer?”

Oru lowered one sail to hide a smile.

“Your mother answers in tables,” he said. “If the question won’t fit in a table, she puts it in the next cycle.”

Sava nudged a tool he had left on the floor towards him with her foot.

“And your father repairs imaginary pipes during meals.”

Oru was already watching a projection above his wrist. The supply network in the western Belt appeared as a pale branching structure. Three nodes blinked yellow.

“They’re not imaginary. Vaor has lost pressure again.”

“Vaor loses pressure every cold season.”

“Not in the same pipes. The deposits are moving towards the centre.”

“Send the report to infrastructure.”

“I’ve sent it four times. The Great Hearing says the readings are still within the compensation range.”

“Then they are.”

Oru switched off the projection and looked at her with his whole attention. For a nivar, this meant turning the head almost squarely towards someone and giving up half the field of vision. The gesture could be tender or aggressive. With Oru, it was usually a request that she stop hiding inside her profession.

“When did you start talking about the system as though it were the weather?” he asked.

“When I found out how many things break if every official thinks they’re cleverer than the model.”

“And how many break when no one does?”

Nemi looked from one to the other, chewing slowly. Sava did not want the little girl to turn every minor disagreement into a danger signal. She lowered her voice.

“After the Festival, I’ll read the raw data. I promise.”

“You said that after the last Festival too.”

“I didn’t promise then.”

Oru accepted the distinction with a movement of his sail. The morning signal came through the floor: two low pulses, then one long one. The city woke around them. Doors slid open. Water began flowing through the washing pipes. Somewhere a child cried, another laughed, and the footsteps of thousands of inhabitants gathered into a murmur carried through the building’s roots.

The peace of Ivarra had a sound. It was not silence. It was the predictable noise of bodies that knew where they had to go.

• • •

The Reflex Therapy Centre occupied an old level of the city, built before ceilings had been lowered to the height considered reassuring. The training room therefore seemed too vast. The lights were buried in the floor, and above them lay darkness. Machines hung there like animals that had not yet learned to come down.

Taren stood in the middle of the circle, his hind paws apart and his arms at his sides.

A mechanical arm shot out from the left. He should have crouched before he saw it fully. Taren turned his head, followed the joint, noticed the wear at the gripping end, and only then took a step.

The arm struck his shoulder.

“A delay of four tenths,” the therapist said. “Again.”

“Sensor three makes a sound before it starts.”

“In real life, danger often makes a sound.”

“Then it isn’t unexpected.”

The therapist’s name was Mera Sol, and she had treated him since he was seven. Back then, Sava would bring him by the hand and sign every consent form so hard that the tablet retained the marks of her fingers. Mera had known his bursts of anger, the periods when he had refused synthetic veyrin, and the year he had bitten two assistants. She considered him intelligent, exhausting and biologically uncooperative.

“The aim isn’t to be surprised,” she said. “The aim is for movement to come before analysis.”

“That sounds like the definition of a mistake.”

“For your ancestors, analysis before movement meant death.”

“My ancestors didn’t live beneath thirty metres of rock, and they didn’t have doors that closed themselves.”

“Your body doesn’t know that.”

“My body seems to be the very thing that does know.”

Mera stopped the machine. She approached without haste. She was small, with short auditory sails cut straight across, an old fashion among therapists, who maintained that patients became calmer when their expressions were easier to read.

“The Festival is in three days. You’ll take part in the supervision group, not in the children’s circle.”

“Nemi asked me to stand beside her.”

“Nemi has instructors.”

“The instructors tell her to run according to the marker, not according to what she sees.”

“It’s a group exercise. They have to react together.”

Taren looked at the mechanical arm. A patch of black down was glued to its end, part of the predator costume. As a child, it had frightened him. Now he could see the seam.

“When everyone reacts together, who checks whether the signal is right?”

Mera drew a slow breath.

“Taren, society cannot be built around your exception.”

“I didn’t ask for that.”

“You ask every time you turn a simple instruction into a debate about truth.”

He smiled without amusement.

“Sava says the same thing in more words.”

“Sava is trying to keep you alive.”

“I know.”

That was the part that made resistance difficult. Sava had not sent him to therapy out of shame. When he was eight, she had found him watching a cable fire while the other children fled. She had dragged him away from the smoke and cried only after they got home. Their parents had died two years earlier, crushed in a transport tunnel. Sava had become sister, guardian and official of survival on the same day.

Taren agreed to another series. An unexpected bell. A tilting floor. The smell of blood. A silhouette dropping from the ceiling. Each time, his body gave him a moment in which he could look before he became afraid. Each time, the machine called that moment a defect.

When he came out, Sava was waiting in the gallery.

“You missed breakfast.”

“I didn’t know that was a crime.”

“Not yet. The Chamber is working on the classification.”

They walked towards the central levels. Taren was a head taller than she was, but he still carried something of the child she had pulled through the smoke: a hesitation before coming closer, as though every affectionate gesture first had to be checked for traps.

“Mera says you’re not allowed beside Nemi’s circle,” Sava said.

“Mera doesn’t have a child in the circle.”

“Neither do you.”

“That’s why I can keep an eye on yours.”

Sava did not answer. The gallery widened towards Low Square. Workers were putting up the ritual shadows of saryxes, black sheets stretched over carbon frames. An enormous wing descended from the ceiling, moved by winches. Children stopped to watch it until the adults drew them closer to the walls.

Taren stood still in the stream of passers-by. People skirted him in irritation.

“What is it?” Sava asked.

“The third frame has been moved.”

“They’ve changed the route.”

“No. The wires descend towards the north, but the cloth is facing as though it were coming from the Day.”

“They’re probably adjusting it.”

Taren looked longer than necessary. Sava touched his arm.

“Not every mismatch is a warning.”

“I know.”

“Then come on.”

“But every warning begins as a mismatch.”

• • •

At the Chamber of Measure, Sava’s day passed among birth applications, relocations and food calculations. On her office wall, the Twilight Belt was reduced to a coloured strip. The scorched Day appeared white, the Night dark blue, and between them the habitable

region pulsed. From a distance, the planet looked simple. The problems began when you enlarged the image enough for the families to appear.

At the end of the working day, the system automatically opened her personal file.

ILEN-VEN APPLICATION / SECOND BIRTH / DEFERRED: 5.7 YEARS.

Sava knew all the reasons before she read them. The density of the district. The food quota. The family's genetic history. Nemi's hyperreactivity. Taren's delayed reflex. The model did not forbid. The model recommended waiting until waiting would make the decision pointless.

She closed the file and deleted the notification from the shared space. Oru would find out. Not that evening. Not with the Festival so close and Nemi practising the signal on the floor.

When she returned home, she found all three of them in the shared gallery. Oru was trying to mend the ribbon. Nemi stood still, tormented by the effort. Between his fingers Taren held a small carbon mechanism taken, probably without permission, from the Festival props.

"Where did you get that?" Sava asked.

"It was broken."

"That's not an answer."

"From the square."

"Worse."

Taren showed her the piece. On its inner surface was a trace of black substance, like sticky powder.

"Synthetic down," Sava said.

"Perhaps."

"You brought scrap props home to prove to me that perhaps it's something else?"

"I brought it because it smells of protein."

Oru took the piece and held it near his nostrils. His sails lifted a little.

"It has an organic smell."

"Adhesive," Sava said. "The material is kept in damp storerooms. It gets contaminated."

Nemi leaned forward, fascinated.

"Is it from a real saryx?"

"There are no real saryxes in Ivarra," Sava said. "They disappeared before your grandparents' grandparents were born."

Taren put the piece on the table.

"Then we have no reason to hurry."

Sava looked at him. She knew his way of constructing doubt: he asserted nothing, merely left a door ajar and waited for the others to hear the draught.

"Tomorrow you take it to the laboratory," she said. "Tonight we eat."

Nemi lifted her repaired ribbon.

"Will you stay with me at the Festival?"

Taren looked at Sava, not at the child.

"Outside the circle," Sava said. "Where you won't get in the instructors' way."

"Close enough to see me?" Nemi asked.

"I can see you even when you're not close," Taren replied.

The little girl accepted the promise. Later, after the lights went out, Sava heard him leave his room again. She did not stop him. She told herself he was taking the piece to the laboratory. She told herself her brother was eighteen and entitled to his own anxieties. She told herself the city was safe.

Beneath the homes, beneath the square and beneath the galleries that public maps called sterile foundations, an old pump ran for seven seconds.

In an unnumbered tank, something small unfolded its membranes and struck the glass once.

CHAPTER II

THE SHADOW AT NOON

TAREN AND SAVA · IVARRA · YEAR 412 OF THE LONG QUIET

Before the attack, Ivarra had not seen a predator up close for four centuries. Citizens knew its shape from lessons, museums and ritual games; they no longer knew its smell.

Taren reached Low Square before the public gates opened. He liked Ivarra in the hours when the city did not yet have to pretend to be inhabited. The elastic floor carried only the vibrations of the assembly crews. The air smelled of washed clay and winch oil. The black cloths of the ritual shadows hung motionless beneath the ceiling, and without the crowd and music they looked less like the saryxes in the textbooks than clothes hung out to dry by a careless god.

At the edge of the children's platform, a technician was checking the retreat markers. He lit them one by one: blue for the firstborn, green for the food carriers, white for the adults who were symbolically meant to stay behind. Taren watched him retrace the route three times, each time in the same order.

"Marker seven is too close to the railing," he said.

The technician did not look up.

"It passed inspection."

"If two children jump at the same time, one will hit the edge."

"The exercise doesn't include long jumps."

"They don't read the instructions when they're frightened."

The technician turned a single sail towards him, sparing the rest of his attention.

"You're the apprentice who doesn't get frightened enough, aren't you?"

There was no cruelty in his voice. Only the satisfaction of someone who had found the right drawer for something inconvenient.

“That’s what it says.”

“Then let the ones who do get frightened design the route.”

Taren could have moved the marker himself. The adhesive was fresh, and the platform still empty. He imagined the report: unauthorised intervention, disruption of a public ritual, repeated oppositional behaviour. He settled for remembering the spot.

Beneath the platform was a service hatch that the plans described as cable access. The seal had been changed during the night. The old sealing material was grey; this one had a strip that was still glossy. Taren knelt and laid two fingers on the floor. He felt the pumps, the winches and the crews’ footsteps. Lower down, after a pause too regular to be silence, came a scratch.

“What are you looking for?”

Mera Sol stood behind him. The therapist wore the green cloak of the medical corps and an expression in which fatigue mingled with the anticipation of a familiar conversation.

“The cables,” he replied.

“Have you found them?”

“I’ve found a hatch.”

“Impressive progress.”

She held out a yellow access band.

“You’ll stay in the outer sector. Nemi can see you, but you don’t go onto the platform unless an instructor calls you.”

“What if the instructor can’t call?”

“Then you follow the general signal.”

“That’s exactly what we’re practising: following a signal regardless of what happens.”

Mera turned her whole head to look at him.

“We’re practising not turning six thousand individual reactions into a collective crush.”

“And does it work?”

“For four hundred and twelve years.”

Taren stood. The question in his mind — *how many times has it been tested?* — remained unspoken. Mera had heard it anyway. She touched the thin bandage on his palm, left by the carbon piece he had taken the day before.

“Sometimes,” she said, “the fact that something can fail doesn’t mean you have to help it fail.”

“I haven’t helped it.”

“Yet.”

• • •

When the gates opened, Ivarra entered the square in disciplined waves. Families from the central districts came through the broad galleries, scented with sweet root; workers from the outskirts descended the service stairs, the smell of metal and mycelium in their fur. Members of the provincial Houses wore their domains’ colours, but no insignia of rank. During its year of residence, each House had to offer the capital an image of submission, even if the cut of its cloak preserved the memory of armour.

Nemi found him before Sava did. Her white ribbon sat crookedly between her sails, and the left tip trembled so fast that the fabric rustled.

“You came.”

“I promised.”

“Mother says promises don’t change probabilities.”

“Your mother uses probabilities so she doesn’t have to say she’s afraid.”

“Is she afraid today?”

Taren searched the terrace for his sister's figure. Sava was talking to Oru, but one sail remained turned towards the children's circle.

"A little," he said. "It's a healthy amount."

Nemi laid her palm against his breastbone. Children could feel another person's rhythm more easily than their own pulse.

"You aren't."

"I am."

"It doesn't feel like it."

"With me, it arrives later."

The instructor called the group. Nemi let go of him, then turned back after two steps.

"When it arrives, can you still choose?"

Taren had no time to answer. The children were arranged in circles, the gates closed, and the deep opening gong swallowed every small sound.

The opening gong sounded from the central vault. Six thousand auditory sails folded at once. Conversations died away. Seln Aru appeared on the Custodian's platform, dressed in white, the hems of his cloak embroidered with the pattern of the ancient escape tunnels. He was not old, though the fine lines around his nostrils made him look tired. His body was small and controlled; no gesture exceeded the ceremonial space allotted to his office.

"Today we remember," he said, "that we survived not because we were the strongest, but because we knew when to disappear."

The crowd struck the floor once with their hind limbs. The vibration rose through the railing into Sava's bones.

"We remember that life does not demand triumph. It demands continuity."

The second blow.

“We remember that our ancestors’ heroism was the number of those who returned.”

The third blow rolled through the city, taken up by the secondary squares, the schools, the mycelium factories and the Gardens of Kinship, where the families of the provincial Houses lived as guests of the capital. Three low pulses, older than language: shadow, shelter, silence.

Sava felt them in her chest too. However much she despised the festivities, her body knew what the signal meant. For a moment, every exit from the square lit up in her mind. The northern tunnel, too narrow. The western gallery, crowded. The Chamber stairs, protected by fire doors. Around her, thousands of brains were drawing the same map without being asked.

The ritual shadows descended from the ceiling.

They were black cloths stretched over carbon frames, modelled on the silhouettes of the extinct saryxes. Their wings spanned ten metres and moved with the help of almost invisible wires. Each year, the shadows crossed the square, and the children had to recognise the direction of attack and retreat in the correct order: the little ones first, then the food carriers, and last the adults able to block the entrances. No one spoke of the fact that in a real attack the order had almost always been reversed.

The first shadow passed without incident. The children crouched, then ran in short arcs towards the blue markers. Nemi lost her ribbon. Oru made a triumphant sound.

The second shadow descended lower. Taren stepped back with Nemi’s group, but a fraction too late. A supervisor caught his arm and pulled him out of the path.

“You see?” Sava said. “He’s learning.”

“He doesn’t look happy.”

Taren never looked happy when he managed to behave normally.

The shape in the north caught Taren's attention a moment before Sava recognised it. Not because he saw better, but because he was looking at precisely the things the ceremony had declared irrelevant: the cables, the air currents, the blind spots between the cloths. That shadow was attached to no wire. It moved by its own effort, and when it drew its membranes together, Taren saw a joint that did not belong to the props.

He wanted to shout. Before he could draw breath, the creature fell.

The third shadow was not part of the ritual.

Sava noticed it because it came from the wrong direction. The mechanical cloths moved from the Day towards the Night, imitating the flight of saryxes that rode the warm currents. The shape in the north was moving against the air, close to the vault. It was smaller than the props, and its edges trembled irregularly.

For a heartbeat, Sava's mind tried to fit it into a category: maintenance drone, a break in the ceiling, fallen material. Then the shape closed its wings and dropped.

Seln Aru was still speaking.

"Peace is not forgetting, but the disciplined memory of danger—"

The creature struck the schoolchildren's platform with a wet sound. It had six limbs, two of which unfolded into grey membranes. Its head was narrow, with no visible eyes, and its mouth opened vertically, from its chest almost to its brow. Its skin was covered in black down that absorbed the light.

No one moved.

That was the first mistake.

The Festival had taught them that shadows had routes and that signals came before danger. Thousands of bodies received the impossible image, but waited for permission to understand it.

The saryx drove its forelimbs into a supervisor. The sound its mouth made was not a howl, but a vibration so low that the floor carried it before ears could hear it.

The crowd broke apart.

The panic was nothing like the drills. It had neither direction nor centre. The floor had become a single creature striking in every direction, and the vibrations were so dense that Taren could no longer distinguish Nemi's footsteps. An adult slammed into him from the side. Another caught his arm and pulled him towards the exit. Taren tore himself free, not out of courage, but so that he could see.

Later, in the recordings, the first seconds would seem slow. Each body could be followed separately, each choice frozen and discussed. From within, there were no choices, only a succession of pressures: a back against a chest, a shoulder against a cheek, claws on the floor, the sudden smell of alarm glands. The little ones had vanished below the adults' waists. Three bodies covered marker seven.

Nemi was no longer there.

Later, Sava could not remember how she had come down from the terrace. She remembered only separate details: Oru's hand vanishing from hers; a child crushed against the railing; white ribbons floating in the air; the Custodian being evacuated through an opening that had appeared on no public plan. Nivari ran well when they had space. In an enclosed square, each leap became someone else's obstacle.

Taren remained standing.

Not out of resolve. Not at first. His body had not issued the command the other bodies had received. He saw the creature, saw the fallen supervisor, and saw Nemi, too small to get through the mass of adults, being pushed towards the centre of the square.

Curiosity lasted a moment.

In that moment he noticed that the saryx turned its head towards vibrations, not images. He noticed that the Festival props hung from

carbon rods three bodies long. He noticed that everyone running offered the creature a field full of signals, while he, motionless, did not exist for it.

Then fear came. It came late, but it came whole, like a door opening onto a vacuum. The muscles of his hind limbs tightened so hard that his joints hurt. His auditory sails flattened against the back of his neck. His mouth filled with a metallic taste.

He could run. The service tunnel was seven leaps away.

Nemi fell.

Taren tore a rod from the mechanical shadow's support. The carbon cut his palm. He moved not towards the exit but sideways, stepping lightly, his weight on the front of his paws. The saryx raised its membranes and attacked a running figure. Its claws tore through a cloak and exposed a thin, white back.

Taren struck the floor once.

The creature turned towards the vibration.

He struck again, closer.

"Taren!" Sava shouted from somewhere in the crowd.

The third time, he did not strike the floor. He drove the rod into the vertical opening of the mouth.

The rod vibrated in his hands. Taren did not know whether it was the carbon, the creature or himself that was shaking. The saryx was lighter than it had seemed as it fell. Its membranes smelled of warm mould and sour milk. Up close, the black down was not uniform: each filament ended in a hook that caught dust, skin and threads of cloaks from those it touched.

He saw the mouth closing on the rod and understood, with the cold clarity that therapy had tried to remove from him, that the first strike had not been fatal. The creature followed vibrations. The crowd offered it thousands. He had to offer it just one.

The saryx closed over the rod. The force of its jaws cracked the carbon, but the tip had gone far enough in. Taren felt resistance, then a soft giving way. The creature struck him with one of its limbs. A claw opened his shoulder and flung him across a blue marker. Pain made the world clear.

Nemi was two steps away. She was crawling towards him, one auditory sail torn at the tip and her eyes so wide that the black irises seemed to fill her head.

“Don’t run,” Taren told her.

It was the most absurd thing anyone could say to a nivar child.

“Stay down. Don’t strike the floor.”

The saryx thrashed around the rod. Its wings beat the air, and black down rose in clumps. Taren stood. Every limb was trembling. He moved forward when his body demanded retreat, and pushed again.

This time, the rod pierced the back of the head.

The creature stopped.

Not immediately. First it drew its membranes around Taren like a cold cloak. Then the vertical mouth opened without a sound. Clear fluid ran down the carbon rod and gathered in his cut palm. The smell was unexpectedly sweet.

Taren held the rod until someone grabbed him from behind and pulled him away. The saryx fell onto its side.

The square was still emptying. Those who had not seen the creature die were still running. Those who had seen it had stopped at a distance and were watching Taren with all their auditory organs turned towards him. For the first time in his life, he had a city’s whole attention.

Sava reached Nemi and gathered her to her chest. Oru appeared a few moments later, limping, with a cut above his eye. He touched his daughter, then Sava, then turned towards Taren.

Oru caught his wrist before the medics reached him. There was blood on his cheek, and it was not his. With his other hand, he held the back of Nemi's neck, pressing her to his chest. The little girl was not crying. Her sails remained folded so tightly that the tip of the injured one had turned white.

"You're hurt," Oru repeated, as though the sentence could restore the order of things.

Taren looked at the opening in his shoulder. The edges of the wound pulsed faintly. Fear had arrived in full now, after there was nothing left for him to do with it. His knees were shaking. His teeth knocked together.

"Not badly," he said.

Sava laid her palm against his cheek, then immediately drew it back, as though closeness were too painful. There was a long scratch on her arm. Taren saw her eyes searching, by professional reflex, for the number of living people around them.

"Did you know what to do?" she asked.

"No."

"Then how—"

"I saw what it was doing."

Nemi lifted her head from Oru's chest. Her voice came out thin.

"You told me not to run."

"Yes."

"Was that allowed?"

Around them, agents of the Quiet were trying to rebuild a world in which the question made sense. They lifted the wounded, closed entrances, put screens around the corpse. Taren looked at the black body lying across the blue markers, then at the children who still did not dare get up.

“No,” he said. “But it was true.”

CHAPTER III

THIRTY-SEVEN ABSENCES

SAVA · IVARRA · THE FIRST TWO DAYS AFTER THE ATTACK

In Ivarra's reports, the attack lasted ninety-three seconds. For those who had survived it, it continued in smells, startles and unfinished sentences long after the square had been washed.

The doctor asked Taren to hand over the carbon rod. He first used the gentle voice reserved for the wounded, then an administrative tone, and finally called an agent. Taren held the object in both hands. Dried blood had glued his fingers to the cracked surface.

Taren looked at his shoulder. Blood was running down his arm in thin lines.

"Not badly."

"You killed a saryx," Oru said.

The word passed through those around them like a disease. Saryx. A creature children drew without believing it had existed. A form preserved in genetic museums so that peace would have a past.

"There are no saryxes," someone said.

"There isn't this one any more," Taren replied.

It might have been a joke, if his voice had not been so quiet.

The Custodian's agents entered the square in formation. They carried no visible weapons; the white uniforms of the Quiet had no pockets large enough to hide any. Two lifted the wounded. Four others unfurled an opaque screen around the corpse. A doctor approached Taren, sprayed coagulant on his shoulder and asked him to hand over the rod.

Taren did not let go.

"It's contaminated," the doctor said.

“So is my hand.”

“Your hand can be cleaned.”

“Then clean the rod too.”

Sava saw his jaw moving. His front chisel teeth had emerged a little from beneath his lip, a threat reflex that the well brought-up controlled before the age of six. The agent behind the doctor took a step.

“Taren,” she said. “Give it to him.”

He turned his whole head to look at her. For a few moments, he was not her brother. He was an animal covered in blood, black down stuck to his chest, with an expression Sava had never seen on any nivar’s face: not anger, not panic, not relief.

Pleasure.

Not the pleasure of pain or death. It was closer to the deep satisfaction of a jammed mechanism beginning to move again. For once, the world had asked of him precisely the thing for which he had been treated as defective.

After letting go, he could no longer stop shaking. The doctor laid him on a low stretcher and injected him with a veyrin precursor. The substance warmed his throat, quickened his pulse and made the edges of the square seem closer. It was the treatment he had received in childhood, when the therapist wanted to teach his body the correct order: first terror, then thought.

This time, the order made him nauseous.

“I don’t want any more,” he said.

“You’re having a severe delayed reaction.”

“The danger has passed.”

“That’s precisely why your body is releasing it now.”

“Let it.”

The doctor hesitated. The agent who had taken the rod was looking towards the corpse, not at them. Around them, the wounded were being separated by the colour of their bands. Red for those who might die, yellow for those who could wait, white for those whose wounds had already been closed by the administration of death. Taren saw a child's ribbon beneath a white cloak and sat up too quickly.

"It isn't Nemi," Sava said.

He did not know where she had come from. She was pressing a dressing to his shoulder and spoke in the voice of someone who had repeated the sentence to herself.

"Nemi is with Oru. They're taking her to the auditory infirmary."

Taren sat back. On the other side of the square, a parent was striking the floor rhythmically, calling a child who would never answer again. The agents were asking him to stop so that the medical signals could be heard. He went on. One blow, a pause, two blows. The child's name in a language older than words.

"Thirty-seven," Sava said.

"You've counted already?"

"The estimate."

"I didn't ask you how many."

She took her hand off the dressing.

"Then I don't know what you asked me."

Neither did he. Sava was doing what she had done after their parents died: gathering the world into numbers small enough to carry. Taren remembered the day the tunnel collapsed, the smell of dust and the register open on their table. Sava was fourteen and had read the identity column eight times, as though a spelling error might give her family back.

"Go to Nemi," he said. "I'm not dying."

Sava looked at him. For a moment, he saw her anger: not at him, but at having to choose again whom to protect.

“Don’t decide that on your own.”

“Then tell the system to postpone it.”

It was not a good joke. Sava left anyway, because Nemi was calling her from the corridor.

• • •

The auditory infirmary had been designed for quiet, but after the attack quiet had become a form of threat. The children lay in shared rooms, four to a room, with damped floors and dimmed lights. Nemi refused to stay on the bed. She had crouched beneath it, in a space no adult could enter without crawling.

Oru sat on the floor an arm’s length away. Sava remained in the doorway.

“May I turn off the light?” he asked.

“No.”

“I’ll leave it on.”

“And the door.”

“The door stays open.”

Nemi clutched the torn ribbon in her fist. The transparent splint on her sail held its edge in place, but any movement in the corridor made her start. When a trolley passed the room, she struck the floor three times with a hind paw. The children in the other beds answered before the nurses could stop them. Within moments, the whole wing was vibrating with the shadow signal.

Sava felt her body preparing to run.

“There’s nothing here,” she said too quickly.

From beneath the bed, Nemi’s eye turned towards her.

“That’s what you said at home too.”

Sava sat down. She could find no administrative wording that could get past that sentence.

Oru laid his palm on the floor.

“Can you feel the pump?” he asked.

Nemi did not answer.

“It’s the water pump. Two small pulses, one long one. It isn’t a signal. It’s just pushing water up to level four.”

After a while, the child’s hand came out from beneath the bed and settled beside his. Oru named each vibration: the medical lift, the air pipe, the passing of the night shift. He did not say they were safe. He said what they were.

Sava listened to him and understood why Taren had saved her daughter. Not because he had felt no fear, but because, for a moment, he had named the things around him correctly.

• • •

By evening, Low Square had been washed. The Festival’s black cloths had vanished, and the information channels were broadcasting the same wording: an experimental organism, accidentally released from a research facility, had caused a crowd incident. Custodian Seln Aru had appeared with a mourning band on his arm and praised the discipline of the emergency services. Not a single name had been spoken.

At the Chamber of Measure, Sava received the preliminary list of victims.

Thirty-seven dead.

One had injuries caused by the saryx: the supervisor attacked at the beginning.

Twenty-nine had been crushed.

Four had died after jumping into a service shaft.

Three children had been suffocated by the bodies of adults trying to protect them.

Sava read the report twice. In the “institutional cause” column, all thirty-seven deaths were classified as accidental biological release. She moved the cursor. The system demanded high-level authorisation for any correction.

“It wasn’t the saryx,” Oru said from the doorway.

Nemi was asleep in the infirmary, sedated. Oru had refused to go home and had washed the nutrient stains from his arms, but green remained beneath his nails.

“It started because of it,” Sava said.

“But it didn’t kill them.”

“The distinction won’t help their families.”

“It might help us.”

Sava closed the report. On the wall, the Twilight Belt’s population map pulsed with thousands of points of light. Each point was an authorised birth, a death, an approved migration. The system showed her an orderly world in which life could be preserved by counting.

“Not tonight,” she said.

“Especially tonight.”

Oru came in and sat on the floor beside the desk. Nivari avoided high chairs; even after four centuries without aerial hunters, the exposed position remained uncomfortable.

“I ran past Nemi,” he said.

Sava looked up.

“No.”

“I didn’t step on her. But I went past her. For a moment. I saw the exit, and my body chose it before I understood that she wasn’t with me.”

“You came back.”

“Taren didn’t have to come back.”

“Taren is ill.”

Oru raised both sails towards her.

“Do you still believe that?”

Sava wanted to answer. Instead, she reopened the report and looked at the figures. An incident. Thirty-seven dead. An anomaly. A rescuer who had not run.

Oru did not leave after the conversation. He took off his footwear and stayed beside the desk. Sava kept reading the list until the names no longer resembled people. At the seventeenth, she recognised a woman who had applied for a third birth two months earlier. She had been refused. Her two children had survived, but were left without a parent. The model would distribute them among the relatives with the lowest housing burden.

“We have to tell them the truth,” Oru said.

“Which truth? That an animal was released and we killed one another trying to run from it? Each family will choose the half that suits them.”

“Then we tell both halves.”

“The channels have already received the wording.”

“You’re in the Chamber.”

“The Chamber counts. It doesn’t speak.”

“Everything it counts becomes what the others are allowed to say.”

Sava rubbed her eyes. In the next room, an operator was processing compensation claims. Each time he validated a death, the floor transmitted an almost imperceptible pulse to the central archive. The system remembered without grieving.

“I ran too,” she said.

Oru looked at her.

“You went back to Nemi.”

“After I hit the railing. I didn’t turn back. I was deflected.”

“You can’t judge a body’s first two seconds.”

“I judge entire lives on the basis of percentages.”

“That’s precisely why perhaps you should start with your own.”

Sava raised a sail in irritation, but did not send him away. Between them settled the familiar weariness of people who love each other yet live in different moral systems. Oru repaired what he touched. Sava decided what could not be repaired without breaking something else.

Before they could continue, a request from the Restitution Service appeared on the screen: two families had identified one body, and its release had to be authorised by a Chamber official. On an ordinary day, the dispute would have been resolved through genetic fingerprints and scent histories. After the attack, the sensors had been contaminated with festival substances, blood and the foam used to wash the square. The system offered a probability of ninety-six per cent. Neither family accepted the remaining four.

“I can send someone else,” Sava said.

Oru looked at the request.

“You can. But you won’t.”

The restitution hall had been set up in the storeroom where, the day before, traders had kept trays of baked root. The sweet smell lingered in the walls and now mingled with antiseptic. Thirty-seven low niches had been separated by grey cloths. A number pulsed above each one. There were no names until official confirmation; the administration avoided giving grief the wrong identity.

At niche fourteen, three adults and a child were waiting. Two of the women wore the same House band, but did not look at each other. The man stood with his forehead against the wall, listening to the city’s

vibrations as though the person behind the cloth might send a signal through the pipes.

“I’m Sava Ilen,” she said. “I’ve come for the confirmation.”

The older woman held out a family plaque.

“She is my daughter, Lera Naur.”

The other woman raised her sails.

“She is my partner, not the property of House Naur.”

“I didn’t say she was my property.”

“You asked for her to be returned to your family’s cavity.”

“Her ancestors are there.”

“She left that place so she could live with me.”

The child held on to the hem of the second woman’s coat. He had a scratch on his cheek and a yellow band on his wrist, a sign that he had been treated for chest compression. He was not crying. He watched the niche number, which lit up and went dark with each breath of the air system.

Sava opened the file. Lera had two recognised addresses, a reproductive bond ended twelve years earlier and a care contract with the woman beside the child. Funeral law had been written in an age when a person belonged to a single House, a single home and a single cavity after death. The Quiet had changed families faster than it had changed the forms.

“We can divide the ashes,” Sava said.

Lera’s mother turned towards her.

“She wasn’t a ration.”

“That wasn’t what I meant.”

“But that’s what you know how to do. Divide what there isn’t enough of.”

Oru took a step, but Sava touched his arm. The woman had a right to that cruelty. Perhaps not towards her; perhaps towards the only uniform she could find.

“You’re right,” Sava said. “The procedure wasn’t made for the life she lived.”

Lera’s partner looked at her for the first time.

“Then don’t use the procedure.”

Sava cancelled the automatic allocation and entered joint funerary custody. The system marked the decision in red, demanding an exceptional reason. She wrote: “The life of the deceased person encompassed a greater number of family relationships than this form is capable of representing.” The field accepted only a hundred and twenty characters. The last words disappeared. She rephrased it until the sentence fitted.

The cloth drew back far enough to allow confirmation. Lera Naur’s eyes were closed, and a dark mark ran along her jaw. She had not been touched by the saryx. The report said she had died of compression near the service shaft. Her arms were still clasped around an empty space.

The child came closer.

“She put me underneath her,” he said.

No one answered.

“She told me not to move. I moved.”

Her partner gently drew him back.

“It wasn’t because of you.”

“If I’d stayed still, would she still be alive?”

The question was not the age of the child who had asked it. Sava looked in the file, though she knew there was no answer there. The crowd model could simulate pressure, directions, the probability of survival. It

could have calculated a world in which the child had not moved. It would have produced a percentage and, with it, a new guilt.

She closed the file.

“Did she get you out of there?” she asked.

The child nodded.

“Then the last thing she did worked.”

“But she died.”

“Yes.”

Sava did not add that sometimes a thing could work and still destroy the person who had done it. The child would learn that soon enough.

On the way out, an official asked her to validate the institutional cause of death. “Accidental biological release” appeared on the screen again. Sava opened the locked field and used her emergency rank.

“What are you writing?” Oru asked.

“Death through protection in a crowd incident.”

“That’s a new category.”

“It exists now.”

The official folded his sails uneasily.

“If we separate the causes, the compensation will be contested. The families of those crushed can demand accountability for the management of the square, not just for the animal’s release.”

“They can.”

“The Chamber will have to open inquiries.”

“Then it will.”

On the way back, they passed through Low Square. The wash water had been drained, the stalls put up, the cracks in the floor covered with resin. A group of workers was reinstalling the Festival panels for the mourning

ceremony. The imprint of a body remained on one of them; the resin had made it shine. The supervisor ordered it sanded down.

Sava stopped until the trace disappeared.

“Tomorrow,” Oru said, “people will cross this place without knowing where it was.”

“They have to be able to cross.”

“That doesn’t mean they have to forget.”

Sava watched the worker vacuuming up the dust. The capital was very good at the distinction between restoration and memory. It restored immediately. It kept memory beneath levels the public could not access.

When she returned to the office, the change she had introduced had already propagated through the system. Thirty-six files awaited reclassification. Each family now had the right to ask not only what had triggered the incident, but what had actually killed their person.

“You’ve just turned a statistic into thirty-seven inquiries,” Oru said.

“No. There were thirty-seven before I counted them.”

The door opened.

The door opened. Taren came in without asking permission. His shoulder had been bandaged, and the fur on his chest was still damp from decontamination. In his hand he carried a piece of black material no larger than a leaf.

Sava stood.

“Where did you get that?”

“From the membrane. It got caught in the bandage.”

“It has to be handed over to the laboratory.”

“The laboratory already knows what it is.”

He laid the piece on the desk. In the light, it looked less like down than a network of fine filaments, each ending in a microscopic hook.

“Seln says it escaped from a facility,” Taren continued. “The agents say there are no other specimens. The doctor said the species can’t reproduce in our climate.”

“And?”

“There was milk in its ventral tissues.”

Oru came closer.

“Was it female?”

“It was feeding something.”

The room became very quiet. In the wall, the root network pumped water with a slow, almost organic rhythm.

Sava reached towards the fragment but did not touch it.

“It could be a hormonal reaction induced in the laboratory.”

“It could,” Taren said.

“Then why have you come?”

Taren turned his head towards the map of the Belt. The points of red light reflected in his lateral eyes, so that he seemed to be looking at the world and at something outside it at the same time.

“Because when I pushed the rod, I heard two beats beneath the floor.”

Sava felt her sails rise on their own.

“What kind of beats?”

“Not from the crowd. From below. One, then another. Like an answer.”

“The pipes vibrate.”

“I know how pipes vibrate.”

Oru laid his palm on the floor.

“The genetic museum’s old tanks are beneath the square.”

Sava looked at him.

“They were emptied eighty years ago.”

“That’s what the registers say.”

Taren smiled for the first time since the attack. It was a small, almost embarrassed smile, but the white chisel teeth showed again.

“Then the registers should be the first to run,” he said.

The blows in the tank were not heard by the public. The lower-level sensors recorded them and classified them as structural expansion. A tired operator confirmed the classification without opening the waveform.

Taren, Sava and Oru nevertheless went down as far as the first seal. They had no access below it. The gallery was narrow, its walls made of old alloy, and the lights came on late, letting the darkness run ahead of them.

Taren laid his palm on the door. Nothing.

“Perhaps you heard the echo of the struggle,” Sava said.

“Perhaps.”

“Or a ventilation mechanism.”

“Perhaps.”

Oru examined the console. Someone had replaced the access seal with a new one, then falsified its installation date. The trace was small: a batch of polymer that had not existed on the declared date.

“It’s been opened,” he said.

Sava looked down the empty corridor. In Ivarra, doors opened for the authorised; the idea that authorisation could lie seemed more serious than a forced entry.

From beyond the alloy came a light touch. Not a blow. A claw testing the surface.

All three remained motionless.

Taren turned his head towards his sister.

“Now you know why I don’t want to be the first to run.”

CHAPTER IV

THE CHAMBER OF MEASURE

SAVA · IVARRA · THE THIRD DAY AFTER THE ATTACK

The Chamber of Measure preserved peace through a simple and impossible arithmetic: each permitted life had to occupy the place of a life ended or a harvest still uncertain.

The Chamber of Measure did not forbid births. It placed them in the future.

That was the official wording and, on most days, Sava managed to believe it. Arua could not be made larger. To the east, living tissue cooked in the open air, and water boiled in the surface fissures. To the west, gases froze in hollows and winds carried needles of solid nitrogen. Between them lay the Belt: a fertile strip seven thousand kilometres long, maintained by orbital mirrors, geothermal channels and a demographic discipline older than every building in Ivarra.

Each family received the right to a first birth. The second depended on deaths, root yields, space available in the depths and the region's genetic diversity. A third was rare. A fourth existed only in the provinces' obscene songs.

Nivari generally lived between fifty and sixty standard years and matured quickly. Without predators and restrictions on births, the models showed that the population would double every six years. Within a single lifetime, the Belt would become a hungry mass driven towards fire and ice.

Peace meant more than the absence of death. It meant administering those who were not yet allowed to exist.

On the morning after the Festival, Sava received two hundred and eighty-four applications. The system had sorted them by urgency, which usually meant by the likelihood that the applicants would cause a scene.

The first to enter were two growers from the South Root district. The woman was visibly pregnant, though their permit had been deferred for four years. She kept her auditory sails tightly folded and breathed through her mouth so as not to smell the office's antiseptic.

"We're not asking for an exception," her partner said. "We're asking for it not to be called a violation."

"A deferral was issued," Sava replied. "You acknowledged receipt."

"We acknowledged that we'd read it. Her body acknowledged nothing."

The woman looked up. Nivari eyes did not meet easily; to look directly, they had to turn almost the whole head. Her gesture was therefore more brutal than an accusation.

"When we received the first deferral, I was twelve," she said. "At the second, I was fifteen. Now I'm nineteen. I may have six more years in which I can give birth. How much future must we be given before it becomes a form of no?"

Sava opened the file. The couple's genetic prospects were good. But the southern districts' food reserves were below the threshold, and seven hundred births had been moved to the next cycle.

"The child will not be taken away," she said. "No law allows that."

Her partner gave a short laugh.

"Of course. We'll only lose our housing rights, our extra ration and our trades. The child will stay with us while we're moved towards the edge of the Night. Very peaceful."

Sava felt one of her sails turning towards the door. Her body was assessing the exit, though there was no danger. She forced her attention back.

"I can reclassify the pregnancy as documented contraceptive failure. You'll receive a labour sanction, not relocation."

"It wasn't a failure," the woman said. "We wanted it."

“Then I can’t help you.”

“You can help us. You don’t want to lie to the system.”

“The system isn’t a person I can lie to.”

“Then why are you sitting here?”

After they left, Sava kept the file open. She changed a nutrient-absorption parameter and sent it through the model again. The application went from red to yellow. Probable contraceptive failure. A sanction of a hundred and twenty hours of public maintenance.

The growers left behind two wisps of grey down and the sweet smell of a pregnancy approaching term. Sava called up the next file, but the system asked her to confirm the sanction. The cursor pulsed above the word **intentional**.

She changed it to **probably accidental**.

In the Chamber of Measure, mercy had no field of its own. It had to be entered as measurement error, data loss or sample contamination. Good officials learned to falsify just little enough for the whole to remain true. Perfect officials no longer noticed they were doing it.

Sava remembered her first day at work. She had been thirteen and was still in mourning for her parents. Her mentor, Lio Marr, had shown her the map of the Belt and told her to look at the red points.

“Each one is someone we say no to,” he had explained. “If we cannot bear that, we’ll say yes to everyone, and in twenty years there will be no one left to say anything to.”

At the time, the sentence had seemed mature. Now it seemed only a blade kept well sharpened.

The rest of the morning left her no time to think about her mentor. The Chamber called the next applicants, and the wall projected a family so large that the silhouettes had to be shrunk to fit.

They called themselves the House of Cloth, though they belonged to no political House. Twelve adults lived together on a mushroom farm,

raised eighteen children and were requesting four births in the same cycle. The eldest of them spoke: Yara, with broad sails and down cut short from working among spores.

“Your model treats us as twelve separate pairs,” she said. “We share food, sleep and care. A child doesn’t lose a parent when there are eleven others around.”

“The model treats consumption,” Sava replied. “Four simultaneous pregnancies reduce your production at precisely the time your needs increase.”

“Then we rearrange our shifts.”

“You’ve had two deficits in the past five years.”

“Because the city sent diseased spores and called it harvest variation.”

The official beside Sava opened the history. Yara was right: the loss had been assigned to the farm, though it came from a contaminated central batch. If the error was corrected, the family met the threshold for three births, not four.

“Three now, the fourth after two cycles of stable production,” Sava said.

Yara did not accept immediately.

“Which of the four people waits?”

The Chamber could calculate rations, obstetric risks and genetic diversity. It could not decide who would bear the deferral without turning administrative order into an intimate hierarchy.

“You decide,” Sava said.

“Then you’re not giving us three permits. You’re giving us a conflict.”

“The alternative is for me to choose the body.”

Yara looked at her with a weariness free of hostility.

“You say you don’t intrude into the family. Then you leave exactly enough food for the family to intrude into its own bodies.”

In the end, they accepted. By the time they left, the twelve had already divided into two camps. Sava heard them arguing over who had worked more and who had waited longer. Her decision had preserved the Belt's arithmetic and moved the violence inside a house.

The next file belonged to an orbital-mirror technician, Lir Sen, and his partner. Service in the swarm automatically gave him reproductive priority because of radiation and mortality. Neither of them wanted children. They asked for the right to be transferred to his partner's sister, who had been deferred three times.

"Permits aren't property," the official explained. "They can't be transferred."

"Then why does my service produce them?" Lir asked. "If they're compensation, let me choose what they compensate for."

"They are a measure to ensure the continuity of exposed lineages."

"I don't want the continuity of my lineage."

Sava read the sister's assessment. She was healthy, a grower in a region with a temporary surplus. She had been rejected only because the order of the lists gave precedence to hazardous occupations.

"I can't transfer the right," she said. "I can correct the region's priority and open a new place."

The official leaned towards her.

"The surplus is projected for a single cycle."

"Then the authorisation is tied to that cycle."

"What if the harvest falls?"

"We'll reduce other consumption."

"Which?"

Sava stopped. Every act of mercy required an accounting victim, even if it had no name yet. Lir was looking at her. He had not come to ask for generosity, but consistency.

“The district’s ceremonial budget,” Sava said. “The Festival has a two-per-cent reserve.”

The official blinked.

“Ceremonies are protected.”

“Children aren’t?”

The permit was issued through a budget correction. A few weeks later, the district would protest that the Festival routes could not be fully repaired. No one would connect the old railing with a child not yet born. The Chamber lived on such invisible connections.

The last applicants of the cycle wore around their necks the black thread of the Whole Hearing, an old tradition from the galleries of the Night. They believed that every birth brought the community a combination of hearing that had never existed before, and that choosing embryos by scores meant closing off part of the world before it could be heard. They had refused the mandatory genetic testing.

“The test doesn’t oblige you to select,” Sava said. “It only identifies risks.”

“An identified risk becomes a reason for deferral,” the man replied.

“Sometimes.”

“Then the test chooses even if we don’t.”

His partner had a mutation that could cause complete deafness in one child in six. The Chamber recommended an embryo without the marker. The two wanted random conception.

“If the child is born without hearing,” Sava asked, “can the community support the implants and tactile education?”

“Yes.”

“Do you have space?”

“We’re building.”

“Food?”

“We share.”

“Promises aren’t enough.”

The woman untied her black thread and laid it on the table.

“Your model doesn’t promise there will be food in fifteen years either. It only turns its uncertainty into authority over me.”

Sava approved the birth, requiring a community care fund. She did not know whether she had protected autonomy or transferred a risk onto a child who could not consent. The Chamber demanded that every question end in a green or red field. Life continued in areas the interface could not colour.

After they left, the room stood empty for a few minutes. The official sent Sava the cycle report: seven approvals, nine deferrals, two sanctions, one budget correction. The equity indicator had risen by a tenth. No column showed the quarrels, the shame or the future moved from one body to another.

Then the system automatically opened her own file.

The next cases followed without a break. A family line requested reproductive rights after its only child died in Low Square. An elderly woman sought custody of the three newborns her daughter had hidden in a heating pipe. A high-ranking official asked for his embryo to be exempted from screening for “affective instability”, because the trait had belonged to a famous composer.

At midday, Sava reached her own file.

She had not opened it for eight months.

ILEN-VEN APPLICATION / SECOND BIRTH / DEFERRED: 5.7 YEARS.

The official reason was the district’s density. The real reason appeared only in the professional layer of the data: Nemi carried a rare combination of auditory hyperreactivity and a tendency to panic. She was not ill. She was simply closer to the ancestors than the model liked.

The Chamber recommended that the line not be multiplied until a compensating partner appeared in the next generation.

Taren, with his lack of flight, was considered equally unsuitable from the opposite direction.

Her personal file remained closed, but the number 5.7 continued to exist at the edge of her vision. Five years and seven tenths were not a future. Nivari had no true seasons on Arua; they measured time through changes in orbital light, harvest cycles and the rapid ageing of children. In 5.7 years, Nemi would be almost an adult. Sava would be twenty-nine, and the risk of giving birth would have risen enough for the model to recommend another deferral.

During lunch, Oru came to the Chamber with two containers of mycelium soup. He was not allowed in the decision area, so they ate in a corridor niche beside a decorative map of the ancient migrations.

"Nemi is asleep," he said. "Taren is sitting beside her door, frightening the nurses."

"How is he frightening them?"

"He asks why they give her sedatives before explaining what sounds she's hearing."

"That isn't a medical question. It's an accusation with a question mark."

Oru held out the container. Sava took it, trying not to show him that her hands were shaking.

"You opened our application again," he said.

It was not a question. In families, the systems shared too many traces for complete lies.

"It appeared automatically."

"And?"

"Nothing new."

"Five point seven?"

Sava looked at him.

“You checked.”

“You hid the notification.”

“I didn’t want this conversation today.”

“You chose the day for both of us.”

A woman passed through the corridor and lowered her sails, pretending not to hear. Privacy in Ivarra did not mean the absence of witnesses, but their agreement not to remember.

“The model says Nemi carries my family’s hyperreactivity,” Sava said. “And the Ilen line has Taren’s deviation too. It recommends that we wait for genetic compensation.”

“A child isn’t a statistical repair.”

“Precisely because a child isn’t, we can’t ignore what we pass on.”

“We gave Nemi good hearing, a good mind and a mother who knows every reason she should never have existed.”

Sava put the container down.

“Don’t say that.”

“I’m not the one saying it. The Chamber says it. You only lend it your voice.”

Oru regretted it at once. It showed in the way both sails lowered, but the sentence remained between them.

“I changed the growers’ file,” Sava said after a while.

“What file?”

“An unauthorised pregnancy. I spared them relocation.”

“And that’s supposed to prove to me—”

“I’m telling you I’m not the Chamber’s voice.”

“Then who are you when it comes to us?”

The answer was interrupted by the vibration of a priority message. The Custodian's white seal appeared on Sava's wrist.

The lift to the Lower Archive did not descend immediately. The doors closed, the light went out, and the cabin remained motionless while the system checked the occupant's scent, body mass, heart rhythm and vibrational profile. The two agents beside Sava did not speak. They carried no visible weapons, but the soles of their uniforms had heavy inserts, unusual in a city where the floor was meant to be felt.

As they descended, the sound of Ivarra thinned. First the voices disappeared, then the district pumps, then the tremor of the trains. Only the friction of the cable and her own heart remained. Sava's body had not been built for such isolation from the herd. Her sails swivelled uselessly, searching for information.

"How far down are we going?" she asked.

The agent on her right answered:

"Below what is counted."

The cabin stopped with a jerk. The door opened onto the grey alloy of an age the capital preferred to keep in museums. The air was cold and dry and carried a faint smell of living protein.

Sava took two steps, then saw Seln Aru beside the first tank.

In the transparent liquid floated a mouth not yet born.

CHAPTER V

THE LOWER ARCHIVE

SAVA AND TAREN · IVARRA · THE END OF THE WEEK

The Cleansing had turned predators into exhibits and peace into infrastructure. The Lower Archive preserved proof that neither had been final.

The Lower Archive did not exist on the public plans. Sava descended in an unmarked lift with two agents of the Quiet. The door opened beneath the level of the old tanks, into a gallery so low that she had to keep her auditory sails folded. The walls were not grown from root but cast in a grey alloy, technology from the time of the Cleansing.

Seln Aru was waiting beside a transparent tank.

A saryx embryo floated inside.

It was the size of her palm, its wings drawn around its body. A thin cord joined it to a nutrient membrane. Beyond the first tank stretched dozens more, some empty, others inhabited by shapes Sava recognised from textbooks on the vanished ecosystem: fissure hunters, worms with radial jaws, blind birds that sensed the warmth of blood.

“The tanks were declared emptied,” she said.

“They were declared closed,” the Custodian replied.

“The report uses the word ‘sterilised’.”

“The public report.”

Seln moved his fingers across the glass of the tank. The embryo contracted.

“The Cleansing was the greatest biological intervention in our history. We eliminated ninety-two species that ate us, parasitised us or competed with us for edible roots. Twenty-three were essential nodes in the food

webs. We replaced their functions with engineered organisms. Most systems work. Some only appear to.”

“You keep copies for restoration.”

“We keep options.”

“And one of the options ate a supervisor.”

The Custodian turned his head towards her. His whole attention was cold, not aggressive.

“One of the options was released. It did not escape.”

Sava felt the impulse to look behind her.

“By whom?”

“Access was authorised under the identity of Reu Tal, a former curator of the genetic museum.”

“I don’t know the name.”

“He died thirty-one years ago.”

An agent held out a data slate. The recording showed the seal opening four days before the Festival. A completely covered figure entered the room and transferred three incubators onto a service trolley. The image preserved no scent, temperature or proportions. The Great Hearing had reconstructed the route as far as the tanks beneath the square, where the signal was lost.

“Three,” Sava said.

“Yes.”

“Taren heard two answers beneath the floor.”

Seln did not seem surprised.

“Your brother notices things the others cover with their own noise.”

“Why did you summon me?”

“Because you work with populations. I want to know who benefits from fear.”

“Anyone who sells shelters, medicines or authority.”

“Too general.”

Seln set off along the tanks. Sava followed, the agents keeping their distance.

“Over the past twenty cycles,” he continued, “the border provinces have requested exemptions from the biological protection law. They say the replacement organisms no longer keep the root consumers under control. They say clandestine gangs steal harvests and retreat into the Night. They ask for the right to form guards, to carry thermal projectiles, to kill.”

“The Chamber refused.”

“Correct.”

“You think a provincial House released the saryx to demonstrate the need for weapons.”

“I think peace produces industries of danger just as war produces industries of safety.”

They reached an empty tank. Fresh traces of condensation remained on the glass.

Sava approached the empty tank. There was a recent scratch on its metal rim, hastily covered with lacquer. A sweetish smell, the same one she had noticed on the fragment Taren brought, came from the ventilation filter.

“How many mature specimens were kept here?” she asked.

“None,” Seln replied.

“You said the animal was released, not raised.”

“It was taken out as an embryo. Incubation took place in the museum tanks.”

“Using what food?”

“The biomass missing from the agricultural chambers.”

Sava looked at the data slate again. The route had gaps precisely where the public maps became schematic. Someone not only knew the city beneath the city, but knew what the Great Hearing could not see.

“Why don’t you stop all the trains and search the Houses?”

“Because fear needs a story before it will accept a search. If we supply it, the author of the attack will receive more than they asked for.”

“Aren’t thirty-seven dead enough for a story?”

Seln laid his palm on the glass of a tank. Inside, a small creature with radial jaws contracted towards the warmth.

“Too many for truth and too few for stability,” he said. “Families want personal answers. Institutions can offer only repeatable ones.”

“That is a way of saying lie.”

“It is a way of saying time.”

Sava understood then why the Custodian always seemed tired. Not because doubt gnawed at him, but because he considered himself the only adult in a world of quick reactions. It was a cold arrogance, but not a simple one. He really did see how many systems could break.

“The domain of Vaor has lost twenty-one per cent of its harvest,” Seln said. “Its lord, Daran Veyr, is in the capital for his year of residence. Today he will request defence rights again.”

“And you will refuse again.”

“Of course.”

“Then what do you want from me?”

“For you to go to Vaor and verify the data.”

Sava stopped.

“I’m not an agricultural inspector.”

“No. You are one of the few demographers who have ever corrected a decision of the Great Hearing without leaving enough traces for a sanction.”

Sava held her breath.

“I don’t know what you mean.”

“The growers from South Root will be grateful.”

Seln kept walking. There was no threat in his voice. That was why it was a good threat.

“Vaor declares four hundred thousand inhabitants,” he said. “Consumption indicates at least four hundred and seventy thousand. Either they are hiding births, or they are feeding something that does not appear in the registers. I want to know which possibility is more dangerous.”

“And Taren?”

“What about him?”

“You didn’t bring me here to talk only about figures.”

The Custodian stopped at the end of the gallery. Behind the glass, a fissure hunter opened its many eyes and closed them again.

“In our society, each generation contains a few thousand individuals with a reduced flight reflex. Most die in accidents before maturity or are chemically stabilised. Some become good technicians. A few seek danger with the persistence of those who want to prove that their diagnosis is an insult.”

“Taren doesn’t seek danger.”

“Yesterday he went towards it.”

“To save a child.”

“Motives are the stories behaviour tells after it has happened.”

Sava raised both sails.

“You’re talking about my brother as though he were a variable.”

“That is what you do with other people’s children.”

The blow was precise. Sava could find no answer that was not defensive.

“I do not intend to arrest him,” Seln continued. “Nor to turn him into a symbol. Both would be mistakes. He will go with you to Vaor as your security officer.”

Sava laughed in disbelief.

“There is no such position.”

“There will be by sunset.”

“You believe the saryx’s release is connected to Daran Veyr, and you’re sending him the very individual who killed one?”

“I am sending a question to a place that claims to need an answer.”

“And if you don’t like the answer?”

Seln folded one sail in an almost amiable gesture.

After giving Sava her assignment, Seln led her into a side room. There were no tanks there, but old maps of the Belt, drawn before the Great Hearing. The provinces appeared as networks of independent tunnels linked by narrow corridors. Each House marked its territory with a symbol of dentition: long chisels, split chisels, edges painted with ochre.

“Before the Quiet,” Seln said, “one House did not conquer another’s city. It blocked its water and waited for births to do the rest.”

“I know the history.”

“You know the version in which the Custodian persuaded the warriors to lay down their weapons. The truth is that they were exhausted. Peace won because it allowed them to keep their descendants and some of their prestige.”

He pointed to a circle drawn around Ivarra.

“The Houses’ annual residence is not a ceremony. Nor are the Gardens of Kinship an elite school. They are well-treated hostages. If Vaor rises, Daran knows that half his nephews, nieces and cousins sleep under my control.”

“And yet you think he would release a saryx in their square.”

“Perhaps precisely because they are there. A leader who wants to change the rule must show that the rule does not protect even his own.”

Sava looked at the maps. Four centuries of peace had removed the weapons, but not the architecture of suspicion. The provincial cities sent their children to the capital; the capital sent them food, light and models. Each side called the exchange cooperation so as not to have to call it a guarantee.

Seln detached the map of Ivarra from its frame. Behind it was a handleless door fitted so closely into the alloy that Sava had mistaken it for the wall. The Custodian pressed his wrist against an old reader. The mechanism answered with a heavy crack, unlike the discreet sounds of the modern city.

“Since you know the history,” he said, “you should see the place where it stopped.”

A narrow staircase descended beyond the door. The air was dry and tasted of metal. No living root crossed the walls; the builders of the Cleansing had feared that the city’s organisms could carry poison, spores or signals between the factions. Each surface had been isolated from the others. Sava could hear her footsteps without the reassuring vibration through which inhabited buildings usually answered the body.

The room below did not look like a monument. It was a defensive shelter left almost intact: water containers, dismantled filters, sleeping hollows dug one above another, and a pipe plugged with fragments of furniture. Pale circles marked the floor, traces of the vessels in which emergency food had been grown. Along one wall, someone had scratched lines in groups of nine.

“The third siege of Ivarra,” Seln said. “Eighteen hundred people stayed here for twenty-six days. The House of Ochre controlled the water gallery. The House of the Core controlled the exits to the surface. Each waited for the other to run first.”

Sava counted the groups of lines until she gave up.

“Who won?”

“The fungus in the filters.”

He lifted a mineralised sieve. Black filaments remained imprinted in its mesh.

“It came in from the food tanks. It sickened both sides. When the gates opened, the warriors could no longer hold their weapons, and those they were supposed to protect were trying to kill them for water.”

In a lower sleeping hollow lay a small belt reinforced with bone plates. It had been made for an adolescent. On the inside, its owner had scratched three names and, beneath them, a series of shorter notches.

“Couriers,” Seln said. “Small bodies fitted through the ventilation ducts. The Houses selected for hearing, speed of maturation and the ability to stay awake under stress. The children who returned were praised. Those who refused were called gentle and received less food.”

“The textbooks say the warriors kept children out of combat.”

“The textbooks are written for the children we want to keep out of combat.”

Sava touched the belt. The material crumbled at the edge, and she withdrew her fingers.

At the far end of the shelter, a door had been welded shut from the outside. Old blows marked it, some at adult height, others much lower.

“Who was in there?”

“The sick. The first Aru was the quartermaster who ordered it sealed. He did not found the Quiet with a speech. He kept the infection from rising

into the city and left two hundred and twelve people to die behind this door.”

Sava turned towards him. For the first time, the Custodian’s name no longer seemed a neutral title, but an inheritance.

“And he was rewarded.”

“He was the only administrator who still had water, registers and a functioning distribution network. The reward came after necessity, then was rewritten as virtue.”

“Why do you keep this?”

“For the same reason we keep the embryos. An institution that destroys its past runs out of warnings. One that exposes it to everyone risks turning the warnings into models.”

Sava looked at the welded door. The argument repelled her precisely because she understood the mechanism. Children learned by imitation. So did Houses. An atrocity described precisely enough could become an instruction.

“Did you inherit the decision too?” she asked.

“I inherited the conditions in which someone will have to make it again.”

“Is that what you tell yourself so you can sleep?”

Seln ran his fingers over one of the low dents.

“I don’t sleep well.”

The answer asked for no pity. That was precisely why Sava believed him.

On the way up, she noticed thin channels cut into the steps. They had been made to drain blood or collect water; she could not decide. In modern cities, every structure had one declared function and ten hidden ones. In the old shelter, the functions had never been separated.

When they reached the maps again, their gentle light seemed indecently clean. Seln put the plan of Ivarra back over the door, covering the shelter with the drawing of a pacified capital.

“What aren’t you telling me?” she asked.

Seln raised a sail, almost appreciatively.

“Many things. Some because I don’t know them.”

“About Taren.”

“Your brother is not the first individual with a reduced reflex to be used in a time of crisis. During the Cleansing, such individuals entered nests, led predators into traps and stayed beside unstable machinery. Afterwards, almost all their lines were reproductively discouraged.”

“Why?”

“Because a society may need a few who do not run. It cannot trust an entire population that does not know when to.”

Sava felt anger rising in her throat.

“The Chamber still screens out the trait.”

“The Chamber screens out many biological memories of the age when we killed one another.”

“And now you’re sending Taren to do exactly the thing for which you prevented his line from continuing.”

“I did not build the contradiction. I merely recognised it in time.”

• • •

On returning to the inhabited levels, Sava found Daran Veyr waiting in the provincial audience hall. He was a head taller than the Custodian and wore Vaor’s brown cloak, reinforced at the edges with plates of fossil wood. For four centuries, the Houses had been forced to leave their old armour in museums, but each had turned its clothing into subtle memories of it.

Daran stood in the centre of the hall, exposed, ignoring the cultural reflex to remain close to the walls. When he saw her, he turned his whole body towards her.

“Sava Ilen.”

It was not a question.

“Lord Veyr.”

“Yesterday your brother did something ugly and necessary.”

“He did something necessary. The ugliness came before.”

Daran briefly showed his chisel teeth, a provincial smile too broad for the capital’s taste.

“In Vaor, the distinction between before and after does not feed us.”

“You’ll have the chance to show me the data.”

“The data are the corpses of the roots. You may count them.”

“That is what I intend.”

“And Taren?”

Sava noticed that he had not asked whether Taren was coming, but was already laying claim to him.

“Taren decides for himself.”

Daran Veyr did not leave after their brief conversation. He followed Sava to the exit gallery, keeping the polite distance of two arm’s lengths. His guards — officially, ranking servants — moved without a sound, though they wore heavy footwear. In Ivarra, only those who wanted to conceal vibrations learned to walk like that.

“You’ve seen the archive,” he said.

Sava stopped.

“I don’t know what you’re talking about.”

“The smell of preservative stays in the fur. Beneath the stone, the capital keeps precisely the things for which it denies us weapons.”

“What are you really asking for, Lord Veyr?”

“The right for my people not to die administratively.”

“A beautiful turn of phrase doesn’t turn a guard into an irrigation channel.”

“Nor does an official one turn hunger into a deferral.”

Daran came close enough for Sava to see the small notches in his chisel teeth. In the old provinces, fighters marked every kill. These could have been decorative; that was precisely why they were unsettling.

“Vaor has been losing roots for six years,” he continued. “We report the larvae, the changing humidity, the thefts and the collapse of the replacement organisms. The Great Hearing replies that the Belt’s total yield compensates. The centre calls it peace when death happens far enough away.”

“And a saryx in Ivarra brings it closer.”

For the first time, his smile disappeared.

“You think I released it.”

“I think you benefit.”

“Benefit is not evidence. Otherwise, the Chamber of Measure would be guilty of every child not born.”

He bowed very slightly.

“Come and count us. But count what the system has decided does not deserve a number too.”

• • •

In the family apartment, Taren was packing the few things he owned: two uniforms, a tool for sharpening his chisel teeth, a reading slate, the black fragment he should have handed over to the laboratory. Nemi sat

on the bed, watching him. The tip of one sail had been stitched and held in a transparent splint.

“Mother says Vaor is cold,” she said.

“Mother tells the truth when she talks about temperatures.”

“Are there monsters there?”

“They’re everywhere. They usually hold office.”

Nemi thought about it.

“What office do you hold?”

Taren fastened his bag.

“They haven’t invented my name yet.”

Sava came in in time to hear.

“You don’t have to come.”

“The Custodian said I do.”

“I can challenge the appointment.”

“Why would you?”

“Because Seln is using you as evidence. Daran will use you as a flag. Neither of them is interested in you.”

“Yesterday no one was interested in me. It was simpler, not better.”

Oru leaned against the doorframe. He did not intervene. Taren touched Nemi’s splint with an unexpected gentleness in his bandaged fingers.

“When the shadows came,” he said, “everyone knew what they had to do. I didn’t. For a moment, I was the only free person in the square.”

“You were the only defective one,” Sava replied.

“Perhaps freedom is the beautiful name we give a defect when it becomes useful.”

He lifted his bag and walked past her.

“We leave on the first Night train.”

“Taren.”

He stopped.

Sava wanted to tell him about the three incubators, the identity of a dead man and the hidden tanks. She wanted to tell him that the province was waiting for him too eagerly for the meeting to be accidental. Instead of all that, she asked:

“What did you feel when you killed the creature?”

Taren kept his back to her. His sails moved slowly, listening to the room, the pipes, the whole city.

“That the world had stopped lying to me,” he said.

After Taren left, Sava stayed in his room. The bed had not been made. In the open drawer she found his old therapy records, which he had kept despite claiming not to care about the diagnosis. Each showed the same graph: stimulus, delay, reaction. At seven, the delay had been 0.8 seconds; at twelve, 0.5; in recent months, 0.4. An entire life reduced to the interval in which the others ran before him.

Oru came in and closed the drawer.

“You shouldn’t read that without him.”

“I signed for the treatments.”

“Then you’ve read them enough.”

Sava sat on the edge of the bed.

“Seln knew. They used people like Taren during the Cleansing, then reduced their reproductive rights.”

“It isn’t surprising.”

“It should be.”

“It should,” Oru said. “But systems keep the tools they condemn. They give them another name and lock them away until they need them.”

“He’s coming with us.”

“I know.”

“And Nemi.”

Oru’s sails rose abruptly.

“No.”

“The school gardens are closing for the inquiry. I can’t leave her with relatives; half the city is under investigation, and the other half is spreading rumours of saryxes in the pipes.”

“Then I’ll stay with her.”

“We need you in Vaor. Agricultural consumption and the root network are the key to the data.”

“The Custodian has thousands of engineers.”

“None I trust.”

Silence tightened between them. Nemi appeared in the doorway, carrying her small travel bag. She had heard enough.

“Is Vaor cold?” she asked.

Oru closed his eyes for a moment.

“Yes.”

“Are there monsters?”

Sava answered before he could:

“There are problems we don’t understand yet.”

“Taren says monsters hold office.”

“Taren says things that sound good and are hard to use.”

Nemi put her bag on the bed.

“Then I’m coming to see what you use.”

Before bed, Nemi began saying goodbye to the apartment. She did not call it that. She went from room to room, recording the sounds she knew on her slate: the pump on level four, the vibration of the neighbours' lift, the crack of the load-bearing root when the orbital mirror changed the angle of the light. For each recording, she said the place and time, like a very small technician.

"You can't take the house with you," Sava told her.

"I'm not taking the house. I'm taking what the house does when no one is talking."

Oru, kneeling beside the service wall, was detaching their personal connections from the root network. The living strands withdrew slowly into niches, leaving transparent droplets behind. The apartment would be allocated to another family before their train reached Vaor. In Ivarra, space did not remain sentimental.

Nemi went into her room and pulled a box of useless objects from beneath the bed: a red stone from the surface, two dried plant membranes, a festival figurine and the milk tooth the Chamber had requested for the genetic archive, but which Oru had declared lost.

"Only what fits in the bag," Sava said.

The child placed the box beside the luggage.

"It fits if I take out the clothes."

"It's cold in Vaor."

"Then I'll wear all the clothes."

Oru laughed, then stopped, surprised by his own sound. It was the first time any of them had laughed since the square. Nemi looked at both of them, checking whether it was allowed. Sava felt how quickly children turned their parents' state into natural law.

"Take the stone and the figurine," she said. "The membranes will crumble. The tooth stays here."

"Why?"

“Because it belongs to the archive.”

“Then do I belong to the archive too?”

Sava opened her mouth and closed it. Oru took the tooth from the box and wrapped it in a piece of cloth.

“She’s taking it,” he said.

“It’s undeclared genetic material.”

“It’s a piece of our child.”

“That’s exactly why the rules exist.”

“The rules exist for samples, not memories.”

“You can’t separate the two.”

Nemi held the bag open between them. The argument had not grown louder, but her sails followed every change in tone.

Oru put the tooth in the inner pocket.

“Then let someone record that I chose wrong.”

Sava wanted to force him to leave it. It would have been simple: a notification, a departure inventory, an agent on the platform. Instead, she sat beside Nemi and folded the clothes so that there would be room for the stone.

“Record our room too,” she said.

Nemi switched on the slate. For a few moments, all three were silent. They could hear the root strands withdrawing from the wall, their breathing and, very far away, the mourning blows still travelling through the city. The apartment was not quiet. It never had been. Until then, they had simply known the names of all its noises.

• • •

A few minutes after mid-cycle, the Great Hearing issued an automatic correction to Vaor’s census. The estimated population was not four

hundred and seventy thousand, but five hundred and twenty-three thousand.

Sava opened the data's provenance layer. The correction had been triggered by enormous nocturnal consumption in twenty-seven agricultural chambers declared abandoned.

The pattern did not resemble the feeding of adults.

Sava projected the consumption pattern over the map of the abandoned chambers. The pulses were short and frequent, clustered around the hours when the automated inspections recalibrated their sensors. A hidden population knew not only how to live outside the registers, but when the system blinked.

At the edge of the model, a second anomaly appeared: small quantities of protein transported from Vaor to Ivarra over the past eight months. The destinations had been erased, but the accumulated mass corresponded to the three incubators.

"Someone is feeding children and predators through the same hole," Oru said.

Sava looked at the two superimposed patterns. She did not yet know whether they were the work of the same network or whether one injustice had been used to conceal another.

On the room's wall, the departure time lit up in white.

NIGHT TRAIN · 03:10 · FOUR AUTHORISED PASSENGERS.

Below the list appeared a note added by the Custodian's office:

SECURITY OFFICER: TAREN ILEN.

For the first time, her brother's defect held an official position.

PART II

USEFUL MONSTERS

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CHAPTER VI

THE NIGHT TRAIN

SAVA · THE ROAD BETWEEN IVARRA AND VAOR

The trains towards the edge of the Night had been built to make distance bearable. Passengers spent most of the journey beneath rock and saw the world only when they could no longer get off.

The Night Train left Ivarra without windows.

As far as the border of Vaor, the tunnel followed the safe depth, where rock retained heat and no traveller had to see the surface. Only after thirteen hours did the carriages rise towards the Belt, and their walls become transparent. Beyond them, Arua unfolded like a wound between two infinities.

To the east, the Day was a reddish-white plain beneath shimmering air. To the west, the Night began under a wall of blue clouds, its glaciers faintly reflecting the light of the orbital mirrors. Between them stretched the low forests of mineral ferns, the black channels and the mounds of buried cities. The star Vei never rose or set. It hung at the same height, a red coin driven into the horizon.

The nivari in the carriage instinctively pressed towards the side away from the window. Even after centuries of safety, the open surface quickened their hearts. Sava too felt the impulse to crouch. Taren stood straight, looking at the sky.

“Doesn’t it bother you?” Oru asked.

“What?”

“The fact that there’s no ceiling.”

Taren raised a hand towards the glass.

“There is. It’s just very far away.”

Nemi laughed. Sava had not wanted to take her, but the Chamber of Measure estimated the inspection would last three months, and the capital's Children's Gardens had been closed after the attack. Oru had come officially as a root-network engineer, unofficially because he refused to leave his family divided after almost losing it in the square.

In the family compartment, Nemi had built a shelter from two blankets and Taren's bag. She did not want to sleep, but she did not want to see the door either. Each time the train changed speed, she pressed her palm to the floor and asked what came next.

"A compensation node," Oru would answer.

"How do you know?"

"The vibration comes from both sides. The brakes are only at the front."

"And now?"

"A side pump."

"And now?"

"Taren is chewing too loudly."

A sound that might have been laughter came from the shelter. Taren stopped chewing his dried root and put it aside.

Sava worked at the folding table. The Great Hearing had sent her Vaor's files in separate layers: official population, estimated consumption, food requests, deaths, migrations. The data did not match even when she excluded the abandoned chambers. The hidden children left traces in everything they consumed, but appeared in none of what they were granted.

"Eighty thousand?" Oru asked, looking over her shoulder.

"At least. Perhaps a hundred and twenty."

"How do you hide one city inside another?"

"You don't hide it from the people who live there. You hide it from the one counting at a distance."

Taren turned one sail towards them.

“And what if Daran isn’t lying about the harvests?”

“He lied about the people,” Sava said.

“That isn’t an answer.”

“It’s a reason to check everything.”

Oru touched the network map. Vaor’s main pipes appeared as thin veins, many with low yields.

“The loss can’t come only from the extra bodies. The flow drops before it reaches the inhabited areas.”

“The animals Daran was talking about?”

“Or diseased roots. Or theft. Or someone is diverting nutrient into the chambers declared empty.”

Taren picked up his food again.

“The same explanation can feed both children and saryxes.”

Sava stopped working. Nemi was not meant to hear. From the shelter, the little girl said:

“I know what a saryx is.”

“That is precisely the problem,” Sava replied.

At the change of cycle, a servant of House Veyr brought dinner and a message: Daran was inviting Taren to the provincial carriage. Taren declined. Ten minutes later, Daran came himself.

The lord of Vaor did not seem offended by the cramped space. He sat on the floor between Oru’s tool bag and Nemi’s shelter, his stiff cloak taking up half the compartment.

“In my House,” he said, “a guest who refuses a meal suggests that the host wants to poison him.”

“In Ivarra, a lord who comes uninvited suggests the same thing,” Taren replied.

Daran laughed. Nemi poked her head between the blankets to look at him.

“Are you the one with the cold city?” she asked.

“I’m the one trying to keep it warm.”

“Mother says you lied about the children.”

Sava closed her eyes. Daran turned his attention to the little girl.

“Your mother is right.”

“Why?”

“Because the truth sent to Ivarra came back with less food than it had left with.”

“That doesn’t make sense.”

“You’ll discover that many adult things are made precisely so they won’t make sense to children.”

Sava intervened:

“Don’t use my child as a platform.”

“I’m not using her. She asks better questions than the inspectors.”

Daran held out a slate to Taren. The screen showed three attacks on Vaor’s transports: masked figures, thermal lights, chaotic flight. In the final frame, a worker remained on the floor.

“This one died a month ago,” Daran said. “No House agent fired. No thief had been killed before then. Something has changed.”

“The weapons,” Taren said.

“And the people using them.”

“Who supplied them?”

“If I knew, I wouldn’t have let you refuse the meal.”

Sava took the slate. The metadata had been scrubbed, but not completely. A series of identifiers came from the central inventory.

“These projectiles were manufactured in Ivarra.”

“Almost everything capable of hurting us is manufactured there,” Daran said. “Some of it under the name of medical instruments.”

Before leaving, he stopped beside Nemi’s shelter.

“When the train rises to the surface, don’t look only at the sky,” he told her. “Look at the line between light and darkness. That’s where we live.”

“Why don’t you build closer to the light?”

“Because it burns us.”

“Closer to the darkness?”

“Because it freezes us.”

Nemi thought about it.

“Then your city has nowhere to run.”

Daran looked at her a moment too long.

“Exactly.”

The train slowed shortly after Daran left, but the vibration was nothing like braking at a compensation node. First the regular rumble beneath the floor disappeared. Then a dull blow passed through the carriages, followed by a silence so complete that Sava heard the liquid moving in Nemi’s container.

The little girl came out of the shelter.

“What’s that?”

Oru pressed his fingers to the floor. He waited. Nothing.

“I don’t know.”

It was the first answer of that kind he had given her since they left. Nemi drew her blanket around her shoulders.

The lights switched to backup. The conductor’s voice came from the corridor, reassuring and prepared too quickly: a technical stop at Root

Six, no danger, no access outside, the journey to resume after the ventilation was checked. Taren stood before the announcement ended.

“‘No danger’ means they haven’t decided whose it is yet,” he said.

The compartment door remained locked. Oru took a service blade from his bag, detached the control cover and pressed two contacts. The mechanism gave way with a guilty sound.

The corridor was crowded. Passengers from the centre kept their luggage close, their sails lowered so as not to touch anyone. In front of the freight carriage, three employees of House Veyr were trying to push back a group of people dressed in work cloth. They wore no passenger wristbands. A woman held a child against her abdomen, and a boy Nemi’s age pressed his sleeve over his mouth and coughed without a sound.

“Back into the agricultural compartment,” one of the employees ordered. “The ventilation is restarting.”

“That’s where it stopped,” the woman replied.

Oru walked past him and opened the freight door. The air inside was damp and heavy. Mesh beds had been stretched between crates of spores, filters and nutrient tubes. Twenty-seven people shared the space reserved, by volume, for sixteen tonnes of equipment. Condensation ran down the walls. An older man was trying to turn a jammed fan by hand.

“Stop it,” Oru said. “The motor’s overheated.”

“If we stop, the children have no air.”

“If you keep at it, the coil catches fire and no one does.”

Oru pulled out the control box. Behind the grille he found a thick felt of black dust, textile fibres and dried spores. The filter had not been changed for three cycles. Yet the label showed the last inspection signed two days earlier.

Sava opened the manifest. There was no group of travellers. The carriage was transporting “biological auxiliaries for crop restoration” and thirty-two units of “temporary manual capacity”.

“Units,” she read.

The woman with the child heard her.

“It’s cheaper than people.”

“Who registered you this way?”

“The station. Vaor sent work contracts, but Ivarra didn’t approve the migration. So we aren’t migrating. We’re being delivered.”

“Where are you from?”

“Vel Four. The southern mirror was moved, and the starch ferns died in two weeks. We were told to wait for redistribution. We waited until we’d eaten the seed.”

Sava searched for Vel Four. The region appeared stable, its production decline classified as normal variation. No report of evacuation. No unusual death. Only a small rise in “contractual mobility”, the precise term under which the people before her had disappeared from one community without appearing in another.

“The child has a fever,” Taren said.

He did not mean the one in the woman’s arms, but the coughing boy. The boy instinctively recoiled when Taren approached. His movement was so fast that he hit the wall and shielded his head before understanding that no one was attacking him.

Nemi held out her water container.

“I’m Nemi.”

The boy looked first at her hand, then her face, then the corridor behind her. His lateral field searched for an exit with every breath.

“Kol,” he said at last.

“How old are you?”

“Ten.”

He was only a year older than her and a head shorter. Nemi made no comment. She held the container until he drank.

The conductor appeared with Daran. The former wore an immaculate cloak and the expression of someone informed that reality was violating his procedure. Daran did not seem surprised.

“The compartment must be cleared,” the conductor said. “Passengers without status cannot enter the passenger carriages.”

“Then open the empty carriages,” Sava replied.

“They’re reserved for the provincial delegation.”

Daran raised a hand.

“The delegation can stand.”

“The safety regulations—”

“The safety regulations have just transported twenty-seven people without air,” Oru said. “Don’t invoke them again until I’ve repaired what they signed off on.”

The House employees began moving the families. Passengers from the centre stepped aside, but not all willingly. A woman drew her child close when Kol passed, as though hunger could be transmitted by touch. An old man protested that he had paid for quiet. Taren looked at him until he lowered his sails and fell silent.

Sava stayed beside the manifest with Daran.

“You call them freight.”

“I take them where there is food.”

“In a carriage that almost killed them.”

“The station saved on the filter. The House paid for a new one.”

“After falsifying the inspection.”

“An official falsified it so the transport wouldn’t be stopped. If he’d reported the fault, the train would have left without them.”

Sava looked at him. She hated the way every abuse in Vaor came with an explanation reasonable enough to divide the blame among victims, officials and distance.

“You could have requested a humanitarian route.”

“I requested six. The Chamber replied that Vel Four had no verified demographic surplus.”

“Because the people had been removed from the registers as ‘units’.”

“They were removed after the refusal. The order matters when you’re looking for the guilty. It doesn’t feed them when you find them.”

Oru called for a cooling kit. Daran went to fetch it himself. Sava did not know whether the gesture was useful or calculated to be seen. With him, the two possibilities never excluded each other.

The repair took almost two hours. Oru improvised a filter from the membranes of a germination crate, while Bes, the Vaor technician travelling in the provincial carriage, restored the power supply. Throughout, Kol stayed in the family compartment. Nemi showed him how to recognise pumps by their vibration. He showed her a code of knocks used in Vel Four when the dust made voices useless: two for water, three for danger, four slow ones for someone left behind.

“Where we live, four slow ones means the meal is ready,” Nemi said.

“Then where you live, no one gets left behind hungry.”

It was not a joke. Nemi did not laugh.

When the train started again, Kol and the others were allowed to remain in the passenger carriages. The conductor demanded Sava’s signature for the deviation. She signed and added the actual number of people. The system immediately flagged the discrepancy with the manifest.

A question appeared on the screen: *Do you wish to report a classification error?*

Sava pressed **yes**.

Then the second appeared: **Reporting may suspend transport pending clarification. Continue?**

She stopped. In the compartment, Kol had fallen asleep with Nemi's container in his arms. The woman from Vel Four had covered him with her own cloak. If Sava continued, the train could be stopped at the next node and the people sent back to a place without a harvest. If she did not, their transport remained legal only because they had not been considered people.

She saved the report locally and deferred transmission.

It was exactly the kind of compromise she had condemned in others: truth kept in a drawer until it became safe. For the first time, she understood how little corruption, from within, resembled a clear choice.

• • •

When the walls became transparent, Nemi did not scream. She pulled the blanket over her head and refused to come out. Oru sat beside her and described what he saw without making her look: mineral ferns bending in the wind, black pipes, condensation towers, blue snow towards the Night. Taren remained at the window.

The sky made him feel not small, but unfinished. In Ivarra, every ceiling told you how much room there was and where the world ended. Here, nothing brought the gaze to an end. The red star did not move, and the shadows pointed forever in the same direction. Their ancestors had crossed this strip in short leaps, stopping only beneath roots or rocks. Taren felt their desire for shelter in his limbs, but above the fear settled the same curiosity that had kept him in the square.

At last, Nemi peered out from the blankets with one eye.

"The ceiling is very far away," she whispered.

"That's what I told your father."

"It might fall."

“Then we’ll have time to see it coming.”

Sava heard and looked up from the data. To Taren, the sentence was reassuring. To her, it described every catastrophe.

As they entered Vaor, the train slowed. Scratch marks appeared on the tunnel walls, sparse at first, then so dense that the rock looked combed by claws. Oru brought his face close to the window.

“Those aren’t thermal cracks.”

“Root consumers?” Sava asked.

“Too high. And too large.”

The train stopped before the station.

The lights went out for a moment, then returned on backup power. Three faint vibrations rose from the floor. The travellers folded their sails, and some were already standing to move towards the exits.

Taren laid his palm down.

“It isn’t an alarm,” he said. “The intervals are equal.”

“Perhaps the local system uses a different code,” Sava said.

“Their bodies wouldn’t use a different code.”

The door between the carriages opened. An official of House Veyr entered, breathing hard.

“A herd has broken the main pipe. We’ll have to walk into the city.”

“What herd?” Oru asked.

The official avoided answering.

They got off into a service tunnel. The floor was covered with pieces of shattered ceramic root and a nutrient liquid that smelled of fermented sugar. Two hundred metres ahead, the pipe had been split open like a broken bone. Around it moved dozens of grey animals, low and broad, with translucent plates on their backs. Some were Nemi’s size, others

almost as big as an adult. They drove their jaws into the pipe's tissue and tore out the living fibres.

"Glassbacks," Oru said. "I thought they only remained in the western reserve."

"The reserve hasn't had a fence for seven years," the official replied.

"Why haven't you driven them away with ultrasound?"

"They've got used to it."

"Chemical repellents?"

"They eat them."

One animal lifted its snout. Its small eyes expressed no fear, because it had evolved after the Cleansing, in a world with nothing to hunt it. It approached the group and bit a traveller's bag.

Taren pushed it away with his foot. The glassback came straight back.

"The biological protection law allows lethal removal when vital infrastructure is threatened," Sava said.

The official lowered his voice.

"Only with approval from Ivarra. The latest request is nine months old."

Taren looked at the pipe. Nutrient spilled into the tunnel and vanished through the grilles. In the city, every litre would be deducted from rations.

"Do you have cutting tools?"

"For roots, not animals."

"Any tool cuts if you don't ask what's written on it."

Sava caught his arm.

"You have no authority."

"I'm the security officer. The position was invented yesterday. Its limits haven't been set yet."

Daran Veyr appeared from the back of the column. His provincial cloak was drawn tightly around his body, and he watched Taren with interest.

“The limits are usually set after the first act,” he said.

Taren took a bladed hook from a technician, a tool used to strip diseased tissue from pipes. He approached the animal that had attacked the bag. The glassback did not run. Taren set the blade beneath its neck plate and pulled.

The death was less dramatic than the one in the square. The animal contracted, made a wet sound and fell. The others kept eating.

A few travellers turned their heads. A mother covered her child’s eyes. Daran did not move.

“One changes nothing,” Taren said.

“You’ve just broken a planetary law,” Sava replied.

“Then the law should come and repair the pipe.”

Twelve young people appeared from the side gallery. They wore no House insignia, and their clothes were sewn from scraps of agricultural fabric. They moved with their backs close to the walls, but none recoiled at the sight of blood.

The one in front was a short female with an old notch in her right sail.

“Will you give us tools?” she asked.

Daran raised an eyebrow.

“Who are you?”

“The ones who eat from this pipe when there’s nothing left in the depot.”

“Your names.”

“We have none in the registers.”

Vessa Dahr took each of them in with a single glance. She recognised Sava by the Chamber badge, Oru by his green nails, Nemi by the splint

on her sail. With Taren, she paused at the bandage on his shoulder and the way he held the dirty hook.

“The others are waiting for you to tell them what to do,” she said. “We have no time left to wait.”

She slipped through the false panel. Beyond it there was no station lighting, but rows of small lamps connected directly to the pipes. The air was warmer and damper. It smelled of bodies, milk, mould and soup thinned too many times.

The sound of children came before the sight of them.

Sava stopped on the threshold. Her map had shown empty agricultural chambers. Ahead, a little girl was falling asleep in a harvest basket, two adolescents shared a bowl, and beneath every root an inhabited niche opened. It was not a temporary camp. It was a city that had learned to leave no administrative traces.

Vessa took off her stained gloves.

“Welcome to the population that was not supposed to exist,” she said.

CHAPTER VII

THE SECOND VAOR

TAREN · VAOR · THE FIRST WEEK

The “second Vaor” appeared on no map. Yet it had midwives, markets, rules of neighbourliness, debts, songs and dead — all the things through which a crowd becomes a city before the state grants it a name.

The young woman’s name was Vessa Dahr, and she was a doctor only because no one else had agreed to care for the hidden settlements. She led them through a gallery concealed by insulation panels. Beyond it, beneath the agricultural chambers declared abandoned, stretched a second Vaor.

There were no squares, schools or separate dwellings there. Families slept in niches dug between the supply roots. Children ran naked through the warm steam, so many that the floor vibrated continuously beneath their footsteps. Sava reflexively counted the first twenty small bodies, then gave up. Every adult carried the scent of more relatives than any legal file allowed.

“How many?” she asked.

Vessa pulled off her gloves, stained with the animal’s blood.

“Here, eleven thousand. In all the chambers, perhaps eighty thousand.”

“The model indicates more.”

“The model includes glassbacks. They like the nutrient mixture for newborns.”

“Did Daran know?”

“Daran knows as much as it is useful for him to know.”

The lord of Vaor had entered the chamber behind them. He did not deny it.

“Without these children,” he said, “the domain’s population would have fallen below the maintenance threshold within two generations. The capital grants us births according to reported yield. Yield falls because the mirror system favours the central districts. With less food we get fewer births; with fewer births we have fewer hands; with fewer hands we produce still less. Your Measure kills us without spilling blood.”

“You concealed eighty thousand people,” Sava said.

“I refused to declare them impossible.”

“And now you can’t feed them.”

“That is why I requested the right to defend our harvests.”

Sava looked at the children. Most had unusually mobile auditory sails and started at every noise. A few, however, watched Taren without blinking. A very small girl approached and touched the bandage on his shoulder.

“Are you the one who killed the shadow?” she asked.

The news had travelled faster than the train.

The girl who had asked Taren about the shadow was called Eri, and she was not seven or eight, as he had assumed. She was fourteen. Malnutrition had kept her body small, and an early pregnancy was hidden beneath a loose tunic. When Vessa asked her to take the dressings to the clinic, Eri stood carefully, bracing one hand against the wall.

Sava noticed the movement.

“Is she pregnant?”

“Not in the registers,” Vessa said.

“That isn’t what I asked.”

“Then you know the answer.”

The clinic occupied a former germination chamber. The beds were lowered shelves, separated by packing cloth. In one corner, three

newborns slept in a transport tray warmed by a pipe. None wore an identity bracelet.

Sava opened her terminal.

“I can issue temporary status. Without it, they can’t receive medical rations, vaccinations or places on a train.”

An old woman immediately drew the nearest child to her chest.

“And once you give them a number, where will you move them?”

“I’m not the one who moves them.”

“Your number makes them movable.”

Conversations stopped around Sava. To the people below, the Chamber badge meant neither food nor recognition, but a door that could open onto expulsion. She realised she had come prepared to find fraud, and that to those before her, her very existence was the threat.

She closed the terminal.

“Then I’ll start without names,” she said. “We count pipes, beds and portions. The identities stay with you until we establish what protection they can receive.”

“And if you can’t establish it?”

“Then at least I’ll know exactly how large the lie is that we’re leaving them in.”

Vessa looked at her with less hostility, but no more warmth.

“Here, accuracy is an expensive form of compassion.”

• • •

Oru spent the first day in the galleries. Vaor’s root tissue was old, repaired dozens of times with incompatible organisms. In some places, fibres had grown through metal and used it as a skeleton; in others, maintenance bacteria had formed white crusts that strangled the flow. Workers marked problems with knots of string because the official sensors had been disconnected to conceal consumption.

A technician named Bes showed him a jammed valve.

“If we register it, Ivarra sees the flow,” he said. “If we don’t, we don’t get the part.”

“How do you repair it?”

“We take the part from another pipe and hope that one doesn’t break in the same cycle.”

“That isn’t repair.”

“It’s Vaor.”

Oru took off his cloak, pushed half his body into the opening and began clearing the deposits. After an hour, his fur was matted with nutrient and his face black with mineral. Bes watched him in amazement.

“Engineers from the capital send drones.”

“Drones can’t smell what’s gone wrong.”

“Neither will you after another hour.”

Oru laughed. It was the first time since the Festival that Sava had heard no worry in his laughter. Work made him whole. In Ivarra, the network was so well maintained that his profession had become the interpretation of models. Here, every decision flowed immediately through a pipe and reached someone’s bowl.

Sava found him in the evening, eating beside the workers. She held out a towel.

“You missed the meeting with Daran.”

“The pipe couldn’t be deferred.”

“Daran can.”

“Then why do you look tired?”

She sat down. Around them, people ate a paste of fermented root, sourer than the capital’s food. No one spoke of the dead in the square or the mission. They discussed a filter, a couple who had separated, a child

who had stolen salt. Life continued not through solemnity, but through small problems that refused to wait for the great answers.

“They don’t want to be registered,” Sava said.

“I understand them.”

“Without registers I can’t demonstrate the need.”

“You can demonstrate consumption.”

“The centre will call it inefficiency.”

Oru broke off a piece of mycelium bread and gave it to her.

“Then show it how inefficiency lives.”

The workers’ meal continued long after the bowls were empty. Not because they had extra food, but because each vessel had to be rinsed in the same water, which was then poured into a crop tank. In Ivarra, cleaning made things disappear. Here, nothing disappeared; it simply passed into another use.

Bes led them into a side gallery where his family shared three niches with two other families. There was no door. A fibre curtain separated the space from passers-by, and plaques bearing names, debts and care shifts hung on the wall. Sava counted without meaning to: seven adults, twelve children, two visible pregnancies and an old man whose breathing had a wet wheeze.

“Don’t bother,” Bes told her. “The number will change by morning.”

“Is someone being born?”

“Moving in. Or making up. Sometimes it’s the same thing.”

The children ate first, from a shared vessel. The smallest had settled in the centre, where the adults’ bodies protected them from the draught. No one had asked them to. The group’s shape closed around them whenever someone passed quickly through the gallery. Sava noticed the movement and thought of the Chamber’s simulations, in which a family was a set of individual consumers linked by degrees of kinship. No model

represented the way one sail raised in alarm raised all the others before the danger was known.

Nemi sat beside Kol, the boy from the train. He had arrived with the group from Vel Four and had been assigned temporarily to Bes's family because his mother would be working the night shift. The two were trying to break apart a piece of hardened bread without crumbling it. A smaller girl watched them and, each time they managed to break off a corner, took it and ran.

"She's stealing," Nemi said.

"She's four," Kol replied.

"She's still stealing."

"At four, if you can take something from beside two older children, you deserve it."

Sava waited for Bes to correct him. He was pouring soup for the old man and did not seem to have heard. At last, Nemi broke off a piece and deliberately placed it close to the edge. The girl took it, but this time stopped a few steps away and brought them a lump of grey salt in return.

"Now it isn't stealing," Kol said.

An argument broke out at the end of the gallery. Two women were tugging at the same small sack of salt, and a circle had formed around them. They were not shouting. Their voices stayed low, but their feet struck the floor in short rhythms, carrying anger through the whole room. The children stopped eating. The adults' sails rose at once.

"Salt from the depot," Bes explained. "Each niche receives an amount according to its numbers. One says the other has listed her dead child as alive."

Sava stood.

"I can check the rations."

Bes touched her arm.

“That’s exactly why you shouldn’t be the first to step in.”

The old man with the laboured breathing emerged from the crowd. He sat on the floor between the women and struck once with his heel. Everyone fell silent. He was not the formal leader; Sava learned later that he had been chosen only for this dispute, because he was related to neither woman and could no longer consume salt for medical reasons.

Each woman gave her version. The first, Nea, had raised her sister’s child after her sister’s death and counted him in her own niche. The second, Lemi, maintained that the same child also appeared in his father’s niche, producing two portions. Nea admitted it. The father had been away on outside work for six days, and his portion would have been withdrawn if the family reported his absence. They had used it to feed a sick newborn.

“So she lied,” Lemi said.

“Yes,” the old man replied.

“Then the salt is ours.”

“Not all of it.”

He divided the sack in three. One share went to Lemi’s family, one to Nea’s, and the third to the clinic caring for the newborn. Nea had to take on two condensation shifts for the wronged niche. The absent father would remain registered until his return, but his portion was publicly marked. If he came back and demanded it, the whole gallery would know which child would be left without food.

“You’ve legalised fraud,” Sava said after the circle dispersed.

“We’ve made it visible,” Bes replied.

“And if everyone lies for a real need?”

“Then we learn that the rule produces more needs than it can bear.”

“Or that there aren’t enough resources.”

“We know that already. We don’t need the capital to explain hunger to us.”

Sava looked at the plaques on the wall. They were not registers in the Chamber’s sense. Some names were scratched out, others moved between niches, others accompanied by signs she could not read. Yet the local system kept a precise memory of obligations. The difference was not between order and chaos, but between an order that accepted the exception in plain sight and one that hid the exception in the data to preserve its elegance.

Later, the children began a game. One struck the floor in a code, and the others had to reach the right niche without speaking. Nemi thought it was a competition and ran. Kol caught her cloak.

“The first one doesn’t win.”

“Then who does?”

“The group, if no one is missing.”

The codes represented accidents: smoke in the upper gallery, a collapse, contaminated water, a blocked entrance. The older children carried the little ones. Those with poor hearing kept a hand on the wall. In each round, someone deliberately stayed behind, and the group had to notice. There was no prize. At the end, an adolescent counted breaths and sent them back if they were not all there.

“Do they do this for fun?” Sava asked Eri.

“We do it because two years ago a pipe caught fire and seven children ran the wrong way.”

“Did they die?”

“Three did. Afterwards, the little ones started being afraid of the drill. Vessa said we should turn it into a game.”

Nemi came back sweating, holding the hand of the little girl who had stolen the bread. In the last round, Nemi had been chosen to stay behind. Kol had found her by the mineral smell of the splint on her sail.

“We don’t have this game in Ivarra,” Nemi said.

“Don’t pipes burn in Ivarra?” Eri asked.

“They do,” Sava replied. “But we have doors that close themselves.”

“Then your doors play your game.”

Before sleep, a young woman began a song, and the others answered with gentle blows on the floor. The verses listed the names of galleries, springs and places where the root was thick enough to withstand a collapse. It sounded like a lullaby. It was also an evacuation map. At the refrain, the children named those who had to be looked for first: the little ones, the sick, those without hearing, then anyone who did not answer.

Sava listened and wondered how many of Vaor’s practices had been called primitive only because they did not fit a central protocol. Then she looked at Eri, pregnant at fourteen, at the newborn fed through a lie and the old man breathing without medicine. Their community was not a pure alternative to the Chamber. It was an intelligence built under pressure, capable of turning deprivation into solidarity and solidarity into obligation. It protected those it could. It put the others to use early.

Nea held out a blanket to Sava.

“Sleep beside the wall. If the smoke signal comes, the children go over you.”

“Is there room for everyone?”

Nea looked at the already full niche.

“No. But we all sleep.”

That night, Sava slept in Eri’s family niche. It was wide enough for four, but nine people lived there. The little ones lay in the centre, the adults at the edges. When someone turned, everyone else had to move. Sava felt every breath through the floor and understood why the people below did not react to crowding as those in the capital did. They had not been selected for quiet. They had been forced to invent it.

At mid-cycle, Eri woke and went out. Sava followed her to a condensation basin.

“Vessa says you’re not allowed to carry water,” she said.

“Vessa says a lot of things when she isn’t the one who has to do them.”

Sava took the container.

“Who is the father?”

Eri raised one sail.

“Why? So you can fill in the field?”

“So I know whether he’s here.”

“He is. He won’t be given a name either.”

“A child without an identity can’t travel, can’t inherit space, can’t enter an official school.”

“A child with an identity can be taken away.”

“We don’t take children.”

“You move them with their parents to places where they die more slowly and call it redistribution.”

Sava held the container beneath the drip. Each drop sounded too loud.

“I can’t change anything if I don’t know who you are.”

“Perhaps the problem is that you only change what you can count.”

Eri took the water and left. Sava remained beside the basin until the pipe stopped.

• • •

Taren spent the same night with the children in the lower chamber. He had not meant to. A little girl had asked him to repeat how he had killed the saryx, and the story had drawn other children. In their version, the creature grew larger each time. By the fourth telling, it had eyes of fire and had swallowed half the square.

“That’s not how it happened,” Taren said.

“Then tell it better,” a boy replied.

He showed them the rod, the position of the mouth, the way the animal followed vibrations. The children did not want metaphors. They wanted details they could use. How had he held his hands? Where had it hurt? Had he been afraid? Why had he not run?

“I was afraid,” he said. “It just didn’t tell me what to do straight away.”

“It tells us,” Eri said from the doorway.

Taren looked at her. No one had told him about her pregnancy, but now he saw it.

“And do you listen?”

“Sometimes. Other times I have nowhere to go.”

The sentence followed him as Vessa led him towards the dead man’s room.

“How?”

Taren sat at her level.

“I stayed where I was until I saw what could be done.”

“Mother says to run before I see.”

“Your mother wants you to live.”

“Don’t you?”

Taren hesitated.

“Not only that.”

Vessa heard his answer. She had already examined him with a doctor’s eye: the position of his shoulders, the lack of residual trembling, the way his attention did not jump towards every exit.

“You’ve been treated for delayed dispersal,” she said.

“Eleven years.”

“With synthetic veyrin?”

“Until I was fourteen.”

“Why did they stop?”

“I started biting the therapists.”

Vessa showed her chisel teeth in a quick smile.

“Good biological response.”

Sava came closer.

“It’s a dysfunction, not a virtue.”

“In Ivarra, perhaps. Here, half the accidents happen because workers abandon their tools at the first signal and block the tunnels. When the gangs from the Night turn up, the guards run away along with the thieves.”

“What gangs?”

Daran folded his cloak over his arms.

“Nivari without a House. Unregistered children from other domains, expelled when they grew up. They steal food, batteries, medicine. They don't usually kill.”

“Usually?”

“Until last month, never.”

Vessa led them into a side room. A worker's body lay on a low platform, covered to the chest. His throat had been cut with a narrow blade. There were no defensive wounds on his hands.

“He froze,” she said. “They asked him for the depot code. He stood still and hoped they would leave. A good reflex against a hunter looking for movement. Less good against someone who knows what a code is.”

A simple shape had been drawn in blood on the wall above the corpse: an oval and two lines pointing forwards, like a face seen from the front. Faces were almost absent from nivar art. Portraits were made in profile,

to keep the eyes in their natural position. There was something obscene about the image.

“What does it mean?” Sava asked.

“That they didn't turn to run,” Vessa replied.

In the frontal drawing, the eyes were two short lines directed at the viewer. For a nivar, a face seen this way could not properly encompass the field of vision. It had to relinquish half the world to give the other person its full attention. That was why the image suggested not only courage but a threat: *I see you, and I accept not seeing what comes from the side*.

Taren touched the dried blood on the wall.

“The thieves drew this?”

“Or someone wants us to think so,” Vessa said.

“Daran?”

“Daran prefers symbols he can control.”

“Seln?”

“Seln prefers not to leave blood on walls.”

Vessa covered the dead man. His name was Deh, he was twenty-two, and he had three younger brothers. He had guarded the depot because the job came with an extra ration. He had not been a soldier. There were no soldiers.

A series of knocks came from the main gallery: one, a pause, two close together.

Vessa's sails rose abruptly.

“The northern depot.”

On their way out, they found the young people who had killed the animals gathered around Taren. Some still carried their dirty hooks. When the signal repeated, almost all of them took a step back.

Taren thought of Eri: sometimes fear tells you what to do; sometimes there is nowhere to go.

He took a step forwards.

Seven followed him.

CHAPTER VIII

THE NORTHERN DEPOT

TAREN · VAOR · THE EIGHTH DAY

At the northern depot, peace did not end with a declaration. It ended when a group of young people entered a corridor that everyone else was leaving.

That same evening, Taren gathered the twelve young people beside the broken pipe. Thirty more joined them, then seventy. Daran had provided hooks, nets and masks. Sava drafted a provisional authorisation for lethal removal, limited to organisms affecting the infrastructure. It was legal only if someone accepted a generous interpretation of the word provisional.

Taren showed them how to move without striking the floor. How to lure the animals with vibrations produced at a distance. How not to leap back when the jaws snapped shut. He had learned these things nowhere. He worked them out as he explained them.

Some of the young people could not do it. At the first attack, they broke formation and retreated. Taren did not scold them. He moved them to the nets, to carrying, to cleaning the pipes. Those who stayed beside him acquired a new kind of silence.

By the change in orbital light, they had killed a hundred and nineteen animals. The meat, declared unfit for consumption under central law, was taken to the hidden chambers. For the first time in many days, the children ate until their bellies rounded.

Vessa had stitched a new cut on Taren's forearm. They sat together beside the tunnel entrance, watching the workers repair the pipe.

"In the old populations," she said, "one in several thousand was born like you. Most disappeared before they reproduced. The predators did the selecting for us."

“Now the Chamber does it.”

“The Chamber is gentler. It lets you live. It just makes sure there don't become too many of you.”

Taren looked at the children sharing the meat.

“Here, no one made sure.”

“Exactly.”

“How many are like me?”

Vessa turned one sail towards the group of young people. Seven still stood beside the carcasses without avoiding the smell.

“Enough for a team,” she said. “Not enough for a world.”

Three knocks sounded from deep in the tunnel.

This time the intervals were uneven. The first came alone. The other two, close together.

Vessa stood up.

“That's the northern depot code.”

A young man came running, a cut on his cheek.

“The people from the Night have come. Twenty, maybe more. They have thermal projectiles.”

Everyone around them took a step back.

Taren took one forwards.

Seven of them followed him.

Leth was the last of the seven. Taren could hear his breathing a few steps behind, too fast for the short run. The young man was sixteen, with thin arms and a left sail that had not fully risen since a childhood infection. During the killing of the animals, he had worked at the nets, far from the jaws, but he had come now because his brother was guarding the depot.

“You can stay at the junction,” Taren told him.

“No.”

“It isn't a test.”

“I know.”

“Then why are you shaking?”

Leth looked at him with one eye.

“Because I don't want to die.”

It was a better answer than all the declarations Taren had heard since the square.

“Stay behind Vessa. When she says down, you crouch. When she says out, you leave. Don't interpret.”

“And you?”

“I interpret.”

They reached the depot at the same time as the second projectile. The heat melted an edge of the ceiling, and the smell of burnt stone filled the gallery.

The northern depot had been designed for petty theft, not defence. Its doors opened wide, its corridors were straight, and its alarm system transmitted vibration in every direction. By the time Taren arrived, the local guards had already crowded into the evacuation gallery, each trying not to be last.

The first thermal projectile struck the ceiling a pace from him. The rock reddened and swelled, then burst into molten drops. The seven who had followed him threw themselves to the ground. Taren remained standing a fraction longer, long enough to see where the light had come from.

“Turn everything off,” he said.

“They see heat,” Vessa replied. “Darkness won't help us.”

“Not for them.”

He tore the alarm panel off the wall and broke the transmission fibre. The floor stopped pulsing. In the sudden silence, the attackers could no longer count the fugitives by their footsteps, and the defenders no longer received the biological command to scatter.

“Cover the hot pipes with wet sacks,” Taren continued. “Open the cold rooms. I want steam.”

No one asked him for authorisation. Sometimes a position became real only because the others had no time to invent a better one.

The young people moved. Vessa pulled two guards back from the evacuation gallery and sent them to the valves. Cold air flooded the depot, met the warm nutrient leak, and filled the corridors with dense mist. To the projectiles' thermal senses, every cloud became a target.

“How many?” Taren asked.

A guard pressed his jaw to the floor, trying to distinguish the vibrations.

“Maybe twenty. Maybe thirty.”

“Stop listening to the floor. They know you're listening to it too.”

To demonstrate, Taren threw a metal rod into the corridor on the left. The attackers fired at once. Three thermal needles passed through the mist and struck the empty wall.

“Listen to the air,” he said.

The sails around him rose. Amid the hissing of the valves and the dripping pipes, they could hear controlled breathing, the rustle of clothes, one chisel tooth involuntarily rubbing against another.

Taren divided the group in two. He had no military training; no one did. He used instincts that culture had kept separate: the silence of the hunted, the approach from the side, the violent leap of the hind limbs, the ability to change direction without warning. The only novelty was that none of these served retreat any longer.

They found the first three attackers beside the seed chamber. They wore black ceramic masks with the frontal shape drawn in white. One held a homemade thermal projector; the others were loading sacks.

Taren raised his hand. His group stopped.

He could have let the thieves leave. The food in the room would have kept the hidden settlements for two days. A well-aimed projectile could kill. Behind him, one of the young men, Leth, was shaking so hard that the rod he held struck the floor rhythmically.

The armed attacker turned his mask towards the sound.

Taren leapt.

His hind limbs propelled him through the mist. He struck the attacker's wrist before the needle discharged. The thermal light passed beside Vessa and charred the sacks against the wall. The other two retreated, not towards the exit but into opposite corners, forcing them to divide their attention.

Taren seized the projector. The attacker did not let go. They looked at each other in profile, each with one eye on the other and one on the corridor. Then the black mask came closer until their foreheads collided.

"You're the one from the capital," the stranger said.

"You're the one who cut the worker's throat."

"He had the code."

"You could have left him alive."

"He could have given it to us."

The stranger thrust the weapon between them. Taren caught his forearm and felt a thin, bony body beneath the clothes. He was not fighting a warrior, but someone who had eaten too little for too long.

To the right, Vessa struck a second attacker with a hook. Leth ran. The third thief fired after him. The thermal needle entered Leth between the shoulder blades and came out through his chest in a white cloud.

Leth's death stopped nothing. His body fell, the next projectile came, and Vessa had to step around him to reach the attacker on the right. Taren saw the young man's face for only a fraction of a moment: the quiet surprise of someone who had thought death would have time to announce itself.

A rule broke inside him.

Taren felt something inside him break, not like pain, but like a rule.

He struck the stranger with his forehead. The mask cracked. The projector fell. When the stranger tried to retreat, Taren followed. He struck him in the knee, then in the throat, then once more after he had fallen.

Vessa caught his shoulder.

"Enough."

Taren turned towards her with his mouth open. His front chisel teeth were a few centimetres from her throat. Vessa did not move.

It was not an absence of fear that held her there. Taren could smell it clearly. Fear came through her skin, bitter and sharp. But she had chosen an action different from the one her body demanded.

Taren closed his mouth.

The attacker on the floor tore off his mask. He was young, perhaps Taren's age, with a circular scar around his muzzle.

"Raal," Vessa said. "I thought you were dead."

"I am, in the registers."

"Who gave you the projectiles?"

Raal spat blood.

"Those who have enough."

Footsteps came from the neighbouring corridors. The rest of the gang were approaching, but not in an attack formation. They called the names of the three. Children could be heard among the voices.

Taren looked at Leth's body. Smoke still rose from the wound. The young man had run and died precisely because he had run in a straight line.

"How much food do you want?" Taren asked.

Raal laughed and groaned at the same time.

"All of it."

"How much do you need to leave?"

"We aren't going anywhere. The Night pushes us back, the Day burns us, the domains remove us from the registers. This is the only place with food."

"And the only place you rob."

"Because it's the only place that gave birth to us."

When the rest of the gang appeared, Taren still held Raal's arm twisted behind his back. The attackers did not advance. There were fourteen adults and six children, all thin, dressed in layers patched with thermal insulation. One boy's toes were blackened by frostbite. A woman wore two empty batteries round her neck like ornaments.

"Put down your weapons," Taren said.

"Let Raal go," the woman replied.

"Weapons first."

The children pressed against the wall. One was crying, but without a sound. Vessa moved slowly between the two groups and knelt beside Leth. She put her fingers to his throat, although the hole in his chest made the gesture pointless. Then she covered the body with her own cloak.

"One of ours is dead," said a young man behind Taren. "We're not giving them food."

"Whose was he?" Raal asked from the floor. "Yesterday he didn't have a proper number. Today he's yours because he died with you?"

The young man raised his hook. Taren gestured for him to lower it.

“How long can you last in the Night?” he asked Raal.

“Without batteries, two cycles. The children, one.”

“Why don't you come to the hidden chambers?”

“Because Daran takes every body he sees and puts it to work for a House's debt. We have no House.”

“But you were born here.”

“That's precisely why we know what his promises are worth.”

Taren released the pressure on his arm. Raal struggled to his feet. The circular scar around his muzzle was the mark of a thermal mask worn too long.

“The projectiles,” Taren said. “All of them. You get food for three days and a charged battery. After that, come without weapons and we'll talk.”

“Talk about what?”

“How you stop killing people for codes.”

“And you stop removing us from the world?”

“I can't promise on behalf of the world.”

Raal bared his chisel teeth, not in a smile.

“Then promise on behalf of your blade. It's the only institution that arrived in time.”

Daran Veyr arrived with forty House agents after the fighting was over. The steam had dispersed, and the surviving thieves sat disarmed in the seed chamber. Taren had given them twenty sacks and asked for the thermal projectiles in return. Raal had agreed only after Vessa had bound his broken arm.

“You paid them for stealing,” Daran said.

“I bought the weapons.”

“With my food.”

“With the food of the children you don't officially acknowledge.”

Daran looked at Leth's body, then at the seven young people remaining beside Taren. Five had blood on their clothes. Two had drawn on their chests, with a finger, the frontal sign found on the dead man's wall. Not in white, like the thieves, but in Leth's red.

“You lost one and gained a symbol,” Daran said. “A favourable exchange by the rules of history.”

Taren caught the edge of his cloak and pulled him close.

All the House agents took a step, but Daran raised his hand.

“You knew they would come,” Taren said.

“I knew lack of food would bring them, sooner or later.”

“You left the depot with guards who couldn't fight.”

“None of our guards can fight. That's why I brought you.”

“You didn't bring me.”

“Do you think Seln Aru sends questions without someone having written to him first?”

Taren let him go. Daran smoothed his cloak.

“Vaor needed a fact the capital could not postpone,” he continued. “Now we have a death, clandestine weapons and a gang controlling the frontier galleries. Tomorrow I will ask again for the right to a guard.”

“Leth didn't die for your petition.”

“The dead don't keep their reasons. The living use them.”

Sava arrived before Taren could hit him. Without thinking, she placed herself between them, her body turned face-on to her brother. She saw him notice the gesture.

“Daran,” she said, “any petition will include the fact that you concealed the population and left the infrastructure unprotected.”

“Include the fact that a Chamber official authorised the killing of a hundred and nineteen protected organisms.”

“I saved a vital pipe.”

“And I'm trying to save a vital domain.”

“By provoking a crisis.”

“The crisis existed. I merely gave it a room with light.”

After Daran left, the depot smelled of steam, blood and charred seeds. Taren helped lift Leth. The young man's brother had arrived by then; he was the guard who had fled first into the evacuation gallery. When he saw the body, he sat on the floor without a sound.

“He told me to stay behind,” he said. “I told him he was a child.”

Taren did not know whether he was speaking to him.

“He came for you.”

The guard looked at him.

“Then you let him.”

Vessa stopped cleaning her instruments. Taren felt all the available answers: Leth had chosen; no one had been forced; the attack would have killed more without them. All were true. None could be placed beside the body without becoming obscene.

“Yes,” he said.

The guard struck his forehead against the wall once. Vessa caught him before the second blow.

The following night, at the simple ceremony in the hidden chambers, Leth's mother asked that the frontal sign not be drawn on the dead man.

“He didn't have the sign when he left home,” she said. “Don't put it on him after he can no longer say no.”

Daran had sent a brown House cloth. The woman refused it. Sava had offered her an official posthumous registration, which would give the family a compensatory ration. This she accepted.

"Isn't it the same thing?" Nemi asked after the ceremony. "You're still putting something on him after he's died."

Sava straightened her cloak.

"The ration helps his brothers."

"And the sign helps the others be brave."

"That's precisely why it's more dangerous."

Nemi looked towards Taren. He stood alone beside the water pipe, his hands washed and blood still caught beneath his chisel teeth.

"Is he dangerous?"

Sava did not answer at once.

"Yes," she said at last. "And sometimes his danger helps us. That's the part you have to remember whole."

• • •

Over the following days, Daran turned the death into a file, Sava into a procedural violation, and the lower chambers into a song. Taren tried to preserve the order of events. He repeated that Leth had run. He repeated that Raal had not been defeated, but bought. He repeated that the attackers had been hungry.

No one really listened. People were not looking for accuracy; they were looking for a form in which a young man's death could be something more than loss.

On the fifth day, Raal returned alone and unarmed. He put the last battery on the table, although it was still half charged.

"You said we'd talk."

"About codes," Taren said.

“Codes are what people who have food talk about. I want to talk about who guards the door after you open it.”

“You want to join the unit.”

“I want to see whether the ones with blades still eat first when there's no more fighting.”

Taren pointed to the training circle.

“Then you start at the bottom.”

Raal raised one sail towards the suspended trunk.

“Everyone who claims not to have an army starts with an exercise,” he said.

CHAPTER IX

THE FIRST FACE

SAVA, TAREN AND VESSA · VAOR · THE FIRST TWO MONTHS

The First Face began as a temporary authorisation to protect agriculture. It became an institution when the inhabitants began to imagine their future through it.

In the days that followed, the story changed every time it was told. At first, seven young people had defended the depot. Then there had been five. Then three. In the version sung in the hidden chambers, Taren had fought forty thieves alone, and Leth had died without taking a step back.

Taren corrected every version until he understood that truth was not competing with lies. It was competing with need.

Daran received approval for a “temporary agricultural protection unit”, limited to a hundred members and without the right to thermal weapons. That same day, three hundred young people presented themselves at the depot. Most were unregistered. Some had come for food. Others because they had heard that unit members would get rooms of their own. Many watched Taren with the kind of attention he had received only once before, after the saryx's death.

Vessa examined them. She measured their reaction time, veyrin secretion, hind-limb density and ability to remain functional under alarm vibrations. Sava found her in a room full of young people waiting to have blood taken.

“You're creating a biological register for combat,” Sava said.

“I'm creating a medical register.”

“You're selecting them for lack of fear.”

“No. Half the good ones are very frightened. I select them for what they do while they're afraid.”

“It's the same distinction the Chamber uses when it claims it doesn't prohibit births.”

Vessa closed the test tube.

“Then perhaps I learned from the best.”

A genetic model hung on her wall. Several lines intersected around a group of neural markers.

“Taren's trait isn't a single thing,” she continued. “The delayed response comes from seven known variations, and probably others. In the registered population, the combination appears in one in nine thousand. Here, among those born without filtering, it's one in seven hundred.”

“Because of inbreeding?”

“Partly. But mostly because families hide those whom the capital would treat or sterilise.”

“We don't sterilise.”

Vessa looked at her face-on.

“What do you call a permit postponed beyond reproductive age?”

Sava felt her own file like an invisible wound.

In the courtyard of House Veyr, Taren was teaching recruits to stand before a suspended weight. A root trunk swung towards their chests, and they had to evade it at the last moment, not by fleeing but with a short turn that preserved their position. Those who retreated too early left the circle. Those who waited too long were struck.

Taren did not know how to teach. At first, he demonstrated everything once and assumed the others had seen what he had seen. Raal made him repeat it. Vessa explained why a recruit was shaking. Sava asked him to write rules before every improvisation became a tradition.

The three were neither subordinates nor friends. That was precisely why the unit did not yet speak with a single voice.

In the morning circle, the recruits assembled in groups of twelve. Some came from the unregistered chambers, where they had learned to sleep amid noise and share every object. Others were legal children of the House, accustomed to regular portions and the idea that authority smelled of their own family. The first despised discipline; the others despised dirt. Taren mixed them deliberately.

One day an administrator's son, Emon Veyr, refused to clean the post's latrine.

"I came to guard pipes," he said.

"A latrine is a pipe," replied Oru, who was there for a repair.

The recruits laughed. Emon flushed beneath his fur.

"My father runs the Warm district."

Raal held out the brush.

"Then you have family experience of what piles up when no one cleans."

Taren stopped Raal before the joke became a fight, but put Emon on cleaning duty for three cycles. On the fourth day, Emon worked without being called. Later, he would command a Vertical House and claim his discipline had been born there. No song would mention the brush.

The first exercise outside the courtyard was scheduled in a disused irrigation gallery. Daran wanted spectators. Taren refused them. He said a unit that learned to be watched before it learned to make mistakes would hide every mistake. Daran agreed and sent only two House men, three scribes and an image operator.

"These are spectators," Taren said.

"These are administrative continuity," the operator replied.

Raal put him out the door. The scribes stayed because Sava insisted that the exercise have an independent report.

The gallery had been chosen for its three exits, an old pump and enough space for the groups to lose one another without getting far apart. Oru had checked the structure that morning. He marked a crack on the wall and asked Taren not to let more than forty people into the central chamber.

"I have a hundred," Taren said.

"Then rotate them."

"They need to learn to move together."

"The root isn't impressed by your educational needs."

Taren divided them into three groups. The first had to guard the pump while Raal triggered noises and lights in the side galleries. The second carried empty containers as if they were wounded people. The third received contradictory information and had to decide what to pass on.

The rule was simple: the position had no value in itself. The pump was to be defended only while it supplied the district. If the pressure passed the threshold, it had to be abandoned and shut off from outside.

"Then why teach them to stay?" Emon Veyr asked.

"So they can leave a place because they've decided to, not because the first body in front of them ran."

"It looks like the same movement."

"From outside, many moral things look like muscles."

The exercise began badly. At the first signal, two groups crowded towards the same exit. At the second, the recruits from the lower chambers completely ignored an order from a House son. At the third, a young man stood so still before a suspended weight that it struck his shoulder.

Taren stopped the mechanism.

"Why didn't you turn?"

"You said not to run."

“I told you to preserve the function.”

“The function was the position.”

“No. The function was to stop the weight touching the pump. If it hits you and you fall onto it, you've lost both.”

The young man held his shoulder and seemed more ashamed of the correction than of the pain. The others watched him with admiration. He had been struck and had not moved. The lesson his body conveyed was simpler than Taren's explanation.

Vessa took him out of the line.

“He has a fracture,” she said.

“I can continue.”

“That's exactly why you won't.”

In the second group, Raal used an alarm device from the old depots. The sound was not loud, but it contained the low frequency that awakened the dispersal reflex. Sails rose together. Some recruits lost their central vision. Others flattened themselves against the floor. Emon started towards the exit, stopped, and returned to the container he was supposed to carry.

“You ran,” an unregistered young man told him.

“I came back.”

“In a fight, the first part is enough.”

“Then why do we practise?”

The argument did not end. The floor rose beneath them.

It was not part of the exercise. The old pump received a pressure surge from the active network, and the crack Oru had marked opened. A jet of hot nutrient struck the wall. The swollen root split along a length of three metres, and the chamber began to fill with sweetish steam.

Taren shouted the order to retreat.

Most did not move.

They thought this was the real test, hidden inside the exercise. Taren saw in their faces the determination not to be the ones who had run. His myth had already become stronger than his order.

“Get out!” he repeated.

A recruit raised the empty container as a shield and advanced towards the pump. The jet flung him back. Vessa dragged him by the leg. Raal began beating the evacuation rhythm, but the alarm drowned out the vibration.

Oru slipped towards the side console. He needed the manual key beyond the crack. Emon saw it in a bracket, a few steps from the jet. He leapt, grabbed it, and rolled to Oru. He had not held his position; he had crossed the chamber and returned. The young man from the lower chambers, the one who had accused him of fleeing, positioned himself behind him and shielded him from falling pieces of root.

Together they held the valve until Oru locked it.

The pressure fell. The steam thinned. Five wounded people lay on the floor, and a hundred people no longer knew whether they had passed the test.

Taren took them all up out of the gallery and seated them in a circle. He was furious, mostly with himself.

“I ordered a retreat.”

“We thought you were testing us,” someone said.

“I was. You failed because you preferred the story about courage to the information in front of you.”

“But we saved the pump,” Emon said.

Oru, covered in nutrient, raised the key.

“The pump was out of service. The surge came because the network was rerouted for the unit's new rooms. You risked lives to save an object that supplied no one.”

Silence settled over the circle. For the first time, the recruits looked at the pump not as the symbol of their mission but as an old component no one had checked thoroughly enough.

“Then what should we have done?” asked the young man with the injured shoulder.

“Found out what you were protecting,” Taren replied.

That same evening, he wrote the unit's first rules. Sava helped him remove words that could be interpreted as unlimited oaths. Oru removed technically impossible formulations. Vessa demanded a rule allowing the doctor to take any member off duty without the commander's approval. Raal insisted on the right to refuse an order that turned retreat into an execution.

The final document had nine lines.

Protect the person before the sign.

Protect the function before the position.

An ordered retreat is not flight.

Surrender ends the fight.

Fear does not determine rank.

The other four described food, weapons, reporting and responsibility for the wounded. Those would be quoted least often.

Vessa also revised the selection criteria. They rejected candidates who felt no alarm at all, because some had nerve damage and others failed to notice danger to those around them. Points went to those who could convey information while their hands shook, those who returned for a person without losing the way, and those who admitted when they had not understood an order.

“We aren't building individuals without fear,” she told Daran when he came to see the wounded. “We're building groups that don't let one person's fear become everyone's direction.”

Daran looked at the bent key, the bandaged shoulder and the crack in the wall.

“That sounds less memorable.”

“Then it's probably truer.”

By morning, the House channel announced “the Face's first trial”: a hundred young people had stayed in a collapsing gallery and saved Vaor's network. Neither the disused pump nor the ignored retreat order appeared.

Taren demanded a correction. The channel added at the end that the incident had been “also a lesson in the limits of courage”. The headline remained.

Emon received nine bonding requests that day. The young man who had stayed beneath the weight received twelve. No one sent Oru any.

Nemi watched from a platform, her splint removed and the tip of her sail still crooked. When Taren took a break, she brought him water.

“Was Leth brave too?” she asked.

Taren sat beside her.

“I don't know.”

“He ran.”

“Yes.”

“Then he wasn't.”

“Courage isn't a shape your legs make.”

“What is it?”

Taren looked at the circle. A small recruit, trembling, let the trunk pass so close it tore a few hairs from his cheek. The others shouted with joy.

"It's a story the living lay over the body's reactions," he said. "Sometimes the story holds. Sometimes the body breaks it."

"What story do you have?"

Before he could answer, the courtyard floor vibrated. It was not an alarm. The recruits had struck the ground once, all together, for the one who had remained in the circle.

Taren felt the pulse rising through his bones.

"I don't know yet," he said.

But that evening, when the temporary unit's hundred members received their grey cloaks, they all stitched the sign of a face seen from the front onto their chests.

In the Chamber's register, the unit bore a twelve-word bureaucratic name.

In Vaor, it was already called the First Face.

At first, the sign of the Face was drawn with cheap pigment. Everyone made it a little differently. On some, the oval was narrow and the eyes long; on others, the shape resembled Raal's mask. Vessa forbade drawing it on skin with caustic substances after three recruits burned their chests. The ban made others want to do exactly that.

Nemi watched the change at close quarters. The children from the lower chambers now played "the depot": one was a thief, another Taren, and the rest had to stay still until the signal. No one wanted Leth's role.

"In the old game, everyone wanted to be the child who reached the shelter first," Sava told Oru.

"Games don't predict the future."

"They rehearse it."

Oru knelt beside a pipe and listened to the flow.

"Then perhaps we should give them other things to rehearse."

He organised a workshop where the children repaired small roots, grew bacteria and learned to read pressure. Five came at first. There were eighty in Taren's courtyard. After a pipe repaired by Nemi supplied a mushroom garden, the number grew to twelve.

"You can't compete with a blade using a valve," Sava said.

"I'm not competing. I'm trying to make the valve visible."

This became one of their quiet arguments. Sava feared that protection would gain prestige precisely because it could be made into a story. Oru maintained that the problem was not the fighter but the invisibility of those who kept the world functioning. Both were right, which made the argument hard to end.

• • •

During its first two months, the First Face fought no one.

It guarded pipes, escorted trains, repaired gates and killed animals that could no longer be driven away. Taren divided his unit into groups of twelve, small enough to move through tunnels and large enough to prevent one person's panic becoming everyone's direction. He taught them to distinguish the body's alarm from the information in the alarm. He made them train in darkness, in steam, in noise and in long silences.

At first, Vaor's inhabitants avoided them. When a patrol passed, conversations stopped and children were pulled towards the walls. After the depots remained full for three weeks in a row, fear changed into something else.

Growers began leaving warm portions at the entrances to the posts. Traders offered clothes without payment. Families with adolescents came to ask when the next selection round would open. Songs about Leth appeared on the local channels, the young man who had run and who, in the songs, had no longer run.

The mating register changed fastest.

Vessa showed Taren the figures one evening in the infirmary set up beneath the House courtyard. A screen displayed a hundred names and, beside each, the number of private bonding requests. Members of the First Face received, on average, nine times as many messages as other young people of the same age. Those wounded in the depot fight received twenty-three times as many.

“You can't tell them to stop,” Vessa said. “The messages are legal.”

“The births aren't.”

“In the lower chambers, that didn't stop them before, either.”

Taren scrolled through the list. His name had no number, only an overload sign.

“Delete them.”

“They aren't mine.”

“Then don't show them to me.”

“You need to understand what you've done.”

“I guarded food.”

“You changed what is desired.”

Taren looked up. Vessa's coat was open at the neck, and the scar on her right sail ran almost to her temple. She did not have the smooth beauty of those selected by the capital's registers. Her body preserved accidents, deprivations and decisions.

“Do you think it's bad?” he asked.

Vessa had not shown him the register to provoke him. The figures frightened her. Until then, the unregistered population had chosen partners mainly according to proximity, resources and sufficiently distant kinship. In just six weeks, the Face symbol had become a stronger reproductive advantage than living space.

“It isn't just attraction,” she explained to Sava. “Families believe a child connected to a fighter will get food and protection.”

“Will they?”

“Daran makes sure they do.”

“Then it isn't natural selection. It's resource policy.”

“Nature doesn't ask through which institution the resource reaches the body.”

Sava examined the messages. Some were direct, others almost commercial. Whole families offered a better room, access to food or care for existing children in exchange for a bond with a member of the unit. It was not the romance simplified by the songs. It was a population shifting its risk towards those who seemed able to carry it.

“We have to separate rations from unit status,” she said.

“Then the fighters will refuse patrols.”

“People repair pipes without receiving nine bonding requests.”

“Because no one sees them when they succeed.”

Vessa looked at her with an almost tender weariness.

“You think the problem is that Taren is becoming too important. The bigger problem is that everyone else is beginning to feel useless.”

That evening, Sava found Taren repairing a net alone. She told him about the figures.

“I can't control what they want,” he replied.

“You control who gets food, rooms and the sign.”

“I don't allocate rooms.”

“Daran does it in your name.”

“Then stop him.”

“That's exactly what I'm trying to do.”

Taren passed the thread through the net. His fingers moved clumsily; fighting came more easily to him than fine work.

“All my life you've told me my trait mustn't be passed on,” he said. “Now you're telling me it's being passed on too fast. I don't know what you want me to do with that change, Sava.”

“Understand that it isn't about you.”

“Everyone tells me that while arranging things around me.”

The following day, Daran Veyr granted every member of the unit a provisional right to one birth, transferred from the House quota. He had authority to allocate only twelve such rights a year. He issued a hundred. Sava entered his hall with the documents in her hand and threw them onto the root table.

“Revoke them.”

Daran went on eating. He was cutting a piece of glassback meat, a food forbidden in Ivarra that had become a delicacy in Vaor.

“On what grounds?”

“There is no quota. There is no food. There is no space.”

“Food has increased by fourteen per cent since Taren's patrols began protecting the pipes.”

“For two months. These children will eat for twenty years.”

“Some will die before then.”

“That is not a planning model.”

“It's the only model nature uses.”

Sava pushed one of the documents under his hand.

“You granted the right not to the workers repairing the network, not to doctors, not to growers. To those who wear the sign of the Face.”

“They made the surplus possible.”

“And you want more like them.”

Daran chewed slowly.

“Don't you?”

“I want a population not to be built to suit the fashion of a crisis.”

“Your Chamber builds it to suit the fashion of peace. You select obedience, a rapid alarm response, tolerance of crowding. Through postponement, you eliminate everything that makes administration difficult. I choose individuals who stay when a pipe breaks.”

“You choose individuals who guard your power.”

“Of course. Just as Ivarra chooses individuals who count it.”

Daran kept the issued permits. Sava marked them as disputed, and the Great Hearing could not validate them while the population register remained incomplete. In practice, nothing stopped. Couples formed, pregnancies appeared, rooms were divided.

At the cloak ceremony for the second group, Daran climbed onto the platform uninvited. He spoke of Vaor's continuity, of children who no longer had to be hidden, and of those who stood between food and chaos. Taren let him finish. Then he spoke.

“The sign doesn't make you more valuable,” he told the recruits. “It makes you more visible when you're wrong. The food you guard isn't yours. The person who runs isn't prey. Someone who surrenders isn't material for your story.”

The words were good. Yet the crowd listened chiefly to the grey cloak, the scar on his shoulder and the fact that Daran stood one pace behind him.

After the ceremony, a mother brought him a six-year-old child and asked him to test the child's reflex.

“Too young,” Taren said.

“Not for the Chamber. The Chamber assessed him at three.”

“We aren't the Chamber.”

“Not yet,” the woman replied.

Taren looked at the crowded courtyard. On one side, Oru was teaching children to graft a root. On the other, Raal was showing recruits how to take a weapon from someone's hand. The activities took place beneath the same roof, but only one drew spectators.

For the first time, Taren understood Seln's warning. He had not merely become an answer. He had begun to change the questions.

CHAPTER X

THE CHILD WITHOUT A NUMBER

ORU AND TAREN · VAOR · THE TWELVE DAYS OF ISOLATION

Vaor was not threatened by a single shortage. Food, light, space and legitimacy supported one another; when one failed, all the others became political.

In the seventh week, Oru took Nemi to the surface. It was not a children's outing. He needed someone small enough to enter a secondary channel and attentive enough to tell him what she saw. Sava would have refused, but she was meeting Daran, contesting the First Face's permits.

They emerged through a covered shaft. The Belt's air struck them cold, laden with minerals and the sour smell of silicon ferns. There was nothing overhead. Nemi immediately crouched beneath the edge of the hatch.

"We don't have to go far," Oru said.

"How far is far?"

"Twelve steps."

"Yours or mine?"

"Yours. I'm old and I cheat."

He was twenty-four, but Nemi accepted the joke. They came out. The red light of the star Vei fell almost parallel to the ground and stretched their shadows to the next hill. To the west, the Night was an ever-present blue edge. To the east, the air shimmered with heat.

Oru opened the channel. Inside, the nutrient roots were covered in a white crust. Nemi crawled in and touched the central fibre.

"It's soft."

"Where?"

“Beyond the node. And it smells sweet.”

Oru cut a sample. The root bled sugar-rich sap, exactly the signal that attracted glassbacks.

“Sick?” Nemi asked.

“Tired.”

“Do roots get tired?”

“Everything that does someone else's work for too long gets tired.”

In the field, a grey herd moved unhurriedly. The animals did not lift their heads at the sight of them. They had no enemies. They ate whatever they found and reproduced until the food ran out. Oru looked at the bare ground behind them and sensed in the image a simplified version of his own people.

“Why don't they run away from us?” Nemi asked.

“They haven't learned they should.”

“Are they like Taren?”

“No. Taren knows he should. He just has time to ask himself whether it's worth it.”

A glassback approached. Nemi pressed against him. Oru raised a rod, and the animal bit its end. It was heavy, healthy and absurdly incautious.

“When you take something out of a world,” Oru said, “it isn't only that thing that disappears. Everything that no longer has to respond to it changes.”

“The saryxes?”

“The saryxes too. And us.”

Oru was waiting for her in the agricultural tunnels. In three months he had grown thin because he forgot to eat while working, but his eyes were alive. He had uncovered an old section of the root network and was projecting flow models above it.

"I've found why the crops are failing," he said.

"They're being eaten."

"That's the symptom. Look."

He enlarged the image of a root. Mineral deposits were constricting the transport fibres.

"For millions of years, the Belt's soil was fertilised by the carcasses of large predators and their excretions. After the Cleansing, we replaced the cycle with engineered bacteria. The bacteria began losing their synthetic plasmids thirty years ago. Ivarra compensates with nutrients from reactors. Vaor gets too little. The roots weaken, the animals sense the released sugar, and they come."

"Can you repair the bacteria?"

"Temporarily. But the ecosystem will find another way to escape the function we've imposed on it."

"What do you propose?"

Oru opened a second image. A slender animal with four limbs and long jaws pursued a herd of glassbacks in an ecological reconstruction.

"Edge hunters. They ate root consumers and moved nutrients between areas. There are still embryos in the capital's reservoirs."

Sava felt a cold that did not come from the tunnel.

"You want to bring predators back."

"Sterile. Monitored. Few."

"After the Low Square?"

"Precisely after the Low Square. We confused safety with simplification. We removed everything that could hurt us and discovered that some of it had been holding the world up."

Sava watched the simulation. The hunters ran in arcs, choosing the weak individuals. The herd moved, and behind it the soil recovered.

“Taren will love the idea.”

“I’m not doing this for Taren.”

“No one thinks they’re doing anything for him. And everything is beginning to arrange itself around him.”

Oru closed the model.

“Not around him. Around a need. If it hadn’t been Taren, Vaor would have invented someone else.”

Ivarra rejected the restoration project in seven minutes. The reply bore the Great Hearing’s automatic signature and cited psychological risk to the population. Oru submitted it again, with crop-loss estimates. It was rejected in three minutes.

The third time, he attached images of the malnourished children in the hidden chambers.

Sava found Oru’s message about the edge hunters just as she was leaving Daran’s hall. The permits remained active, and Vaor’s master had told her politely that a rule impossible to enforce was no longer a rule, but decoration.

She met Oru in the agricultural tunnel. Nemi slept in a tool cart, a sample of white crust in her fist.

“You took her to the surface without telling me.”

“If I’d told you, you’d have refused.”

“That’s not an argument.”

“It’s a prediction.”

Sava wanted to argue, but she saw how thin he had become. His shoulder bones stood out beneath the fur. He spent his nights among the pipes and his days explaining to the locals why repairs could not produce food immediately.

“Have you eaten?” she asked.

“Nemi has.”

“That isn't what I asked.”

“Then probably not.”

She took a ration from her bag and put it in his hand. Oru ate without resisting. After a few mouthfuls, he said:

“The hunters are the right solution.”

“There is no right solution. Only one whose problems we can't see yet.”

“I know. But I prefer a living problem that adapts to a dead network we force to imitate an ecosystem.”

“And if one attacks a child?”

“Then it will be killed.”

“By Taren.”

Oru put the food down.

“Not every sentence has to end with your brother.”

“In Vaor, more and more of them do.”

“Perhaps because you push them there. So you don't have to see that the problem was already in the system you're defending.”

Sava looked at Nemi. The little girl slept with one sail raised, listening even in sleep.

“I'm afraid,” Sava said.

Oru did not answer at once. She rarely used the word without adding a probability.

“Of what, exactly?”

“That Taren is right too soon. That Daran is making him necessary. That you're bringing predators back and I can no longer tell whether I'm protecting the world or only the version of it I know how to work in.”

Oru touched her hand.

“Then stay close enough to see when we're wrong.”

It was the last quiet promise between them.

Instead, Seln Aru requested a direct conversation.

His face appeared on the apartment wall, slightly distorted by the transmission delay. Behind him, a white gallery in Ivarra and part of a mourning flag were visible.

“Your report is overdue,” he told Sava.

“The data are more complicated than the estimate.”

“Does the hidden population exist?”

“Yes.”

“Has Daran Veyr formed a unit beyond the authorised limit?”

“Yes.”

“Does your brother command it?”

“Officially, he trains it.”

“Sava.”

“Yes.”

Seln folded one sail, a sign of fatigue.

“The dissolution order goes out today. Taren must return to the capital for assessment. Daran will be replaced pending the inquiry. The unregistered population will receive temporary status and be redistributed.”

Oru approached the transmission.

“Redistributed where? The central Belt is at capacity.”

“To districts with labour shortages.”

“The edge of the Night,” Sava said.

“Some settlements are there.”

“You’ll move tens of thousands of children into the cold to save a table.”

"I'll spread the pressure before it breaks the domain."

"And the ecological restoration?"

"We will not reintroduce hunting organisms into a traumatised population."

Oru raised his voice.

"The population will be more traumatised by hunger."

"Hunger can be distributed. Fear cannot."

Taren had entered the room without them hearing him. He wore the First Face's grey cloak and a working blade at his hip, still technically an agricultural tool. He stopped within the transmission's range.

"Is that why you're calling me back?" he asked. "To distribute fear?"

Seln looked at him for a long time.

"I'm calling you back because you've become an answer before we've established the question."

"The question is who guards the food."

"Today. Tomorrow it will be who guards the guards. After that, who deserves to have children. I see Daran has already reached the third question."

Taren glanced at Sava. She realised he knew about the permits.

"I didn't ask for them," he said.

"You don't have to ask for power to benefit from it," Seln replied. "Return voluntarily. The unit will be absorbed into the agricultural services. No one will be punished."

"And if not?"

"The trains to Vaor stop. The mirrors' light quotas are revised. Every illegally issued birth right is revoked."

Daran appeared in the doorway, drawn by the conversation. He smiled without pleasure.

“That's the capital's peace,” he said. “It doesn't hit you. It moves the light a little farther east and waits for you to freeze.”

“Daran Veyr,” Seln said, “you are removed from the administration of the domain until the inquiry is concluded.”

“Come and replace me.”

The transmission broke off.

Seln had not stopped it. All the lights in the room went out at once. The floor stopped vibrating. The ventilation sank into a sigh and died.

For a few moments, there was only the sound of their breathing.

Then, through the rock overhead, the sky lit up.

The solar storm struck Arua's illuminated side like an open hand. The orbital magnetic fields deformed, the mirrors moved into their safe position, and the Great Hearing fragmented into thousands of local nodes. In Vaor, backup systems started one by one, but the link to Ivarra did not return.

Daran took off his ceremonial cloak and left it on the floor.

“How long are we isolated?” he asked.

Oru checked the dead terminal.

“Maybe two days. Maybe twenty.”

“Then, for twenty days, the Custodian's order does not exist.”

Sava turned to Taren.

“The unit stays within the limit. You accept no more recruits. You use no thermal weapons.”

Taren was listening to something else. Far away, from the city's tunnels, came an irregular pounding. Not an alarm signal. Thousands of people were striking the floor, each in a different rhythm, after learning that the link to Ivarra had failed.

“It isn't a unit any more,” he said. “It's the only thing that can receive orders.”

That night, Daran opened House Veyr's museum armoury. The ceremonial blades, magnetic-arc projectiles and old armour had been preserved for four centuries as objects of a shame left behind.

By morning, all were missing from the display cases.

When the museum armoury opened, people did not immediately rush for the weapons. They stood in the doorway, looking at the objects in the cases: curved blades, magnetic bows, armour plates, helmets that forced the auditory sails to remain directed forwards. Every piece carried a label about the barbarity of the past. Some also bore the names of House Veyr's ancestors.

Daran took out the first blade. He tested its balance with a familiarity that betrayed practice in secret.

“They're ceremonial objects,” Sava said.

“Ceremonies are how we preserve an object's use after pretending we've forgotten it.”

Taren took nothing. He kept his working blade.

“Who distributes them?”

“The House.”

“Then only the House will have weapons.”

“The House preserved them.”

“The city preserved the House.”

Raal laughed behind them.

“Here is the first quarrel of the army that doesn't exist.”

Taren divided the weapons among the groups and ordered every piece to be publicly registered. Daran agreed too easily. By morning, a third of the inventory had disappeared before being counted.

• • •

The first birth of the new age took place in darkness, beside a draining water tank.

The mother was one of the unregistered, a fourteen-year-old grower named Eri. Labour had begun six hours after the storm, while the main systems were still unresponsive and the House infirmary was occupied by the injured. Vessa found her crouched between two pipes, with three other women holding her body so she would not strike the floor at every contraction.

Taren had come to check the rations. He stayed at the entrance, useless and unable to leave.

“Bring water,” Vessa told him.

“The tank is below the emergency quota.”

“Then bring emergency water.”

He left and returned with his own flask. Vessa used it to wash away the blood. The child was born small, eyes closed and auditory sails pressed to its skull. It made no sound until Vessa tapped it lightly between the shoulder blades. Then its body arched and a thin cry filled the chamber.

All the adults startled.

Taren did not.

Eri noticed.

“Touch him,” she said.

“Why?”

“So the first thing he feels won't be a frightened person.”

Taren held out a finger. The child gripped it with disproportionate strength. There was no authorisation bracelet around the mother's wrist, and the medical terminal could not issue an identity without a connection to the Great Hearing.

“What's his name?” Taren asked.

“Sio.”

“His House name?”

Eri looked at him as if the question were indecent.

“He has none.”

One of the women dipped her finger in the blood on the floor and approached the child. She wanted to trace the First Face's frontal sign on his chest.

Taren caught her hand.

“No.”

“He was born under your protection.”

“Protection isn't ownership.”

“Then what does he get?”

Taren looked at the child without a number, born in a city cut off from the world.

“Time,” he said. “For now, that's all.”

Sio slept through his first hours in a filter box lined with clothes. Vessa had no incubator, and the room's temperature was falling. Taren kept the box beside the hot-water pipe and changed the child's position every few minutes so his skin would not burn.

Eri watched him with eyes clouded by exhaustion.

“You don't look as though you know how to hold a newborn.”

“I don't.”

“Then why don't you give him to someone else?”

“You gave him to me.”

“I wanted to see whether someone who kills can hold something without squeezing too hard.”

“And?”

Eri closed her eyes.

“I don't know yet.”

Nemi came with Oru and sat beside the box. She looked at the child's tiny hands.

“Is he allowed to exist?”

Sava, standing in the doorway, felt the question like a blow.

“He already exists,” Oru replied.

“That's not what I asked.”

No one found an answer that did not reveal too much.

Outside the room, Vaor organised itself in the dark.

During the twelve days of isolation, time became Vaor's currency.

The backup network could sustain full ventilation for nine more days, agricultural lighting for six, heating in the outer chambers for four. Oru reorganised the flows and gained a few hours here, a day there. Sava calculated rations by age and activity. Daran turned the calculations into orders. The First Face enforced them.

Hierarchy appeared before anyone gave it a name.

Those repairing the pipes received larger portions. Those guarding the repairs received the same. Doctors and nursing mothers came next. Children, the elderly and the sick had a protected quota. The rest of the population shared what remained.

On paper, the system worked. In the galleries, every category became a judgement on the value of a life.

On the fifth day, two hundred inhabitants of the Warm quarter gathered at the central depot. They had heard House agents were hiding food. The rumour was false, but not absurd. Daran had indeed kept a private reserve; Taren had discovered it and moved it to the public depot the night before.

The crowd did not know that. They saw only closed doors and grey cloaks in front of them.

“Open up!” someone shouted. “Our children are getting half portions!”

“All children get the same quota,” Taren replied.

“Yours don’t.”

“There is no ‘ours’.”

A stone struck his chest. The First Face members raised their working blades. Taren gestured for them to lower them.

The crowd pushed.

Nivari were not built for frontal pressure. At the first contact, those behind leapt forwards while those in front tried to retreat. Bodies became entangled. A woman fell. Taren heard the sound of the Low Square before he saw the danger: the shortening collective breath, claws scraping the floor, panic finding its direction.

He had struck a saryx with a rod. Here, there was no single body against which to direct his strength.

He turned to the depot door and opened it.

The people stopped, surprised. Inside, the shelves were almost empty. Thirty sacks lay on the floor, each marked with the day on which it was to be opened.

“This is all the food,” Taren said. “If you take it now, you’ll eat for three days. On the fourth day, you’ll come back, and there’ll be nothing here. The first person who thinks this is a lie can come in and count.”

An old man walked past him. He counted the sacks. Then he counted them again.

“The House has its own reserve,” someone said.

Taren pointed to the sacks in the corner, their Veyr seals cut.

“That was it.”

Daran, standing behind him, said nothing. His face remained calm, but his smell turned bitter.

“Then why do the guards get full portions?” a woman asked.

Taren held out the blade he wore at his hip.

“Take it. Go to tunnel four. There are seventeen glassbacks beside the air pipe. If they break it, we lose heating for three quarters. Stay there six hours and you get my portion.”

The woman looked at the blade. She did not take it.

“I don't want to be like you.”

“I don't want you to be hungry either. But these are the things we have to choose between.”

The crowd dispersed without violence. That evening, however, someone wrote on the depot wall: THOSE WITH BLADES EAT FIRST.

The sentence on the depot became a real problem. The First Face received full portions because patrols and repairs consumed energy. With every day of isolation, the explanation turned into a privilege. Some members began taking their food before leaving for their posts, afraid none would remain. Others kept portions for their families. Taren punished the first two and discovered that one of them had three hungry brothers.

He took away his cloak for one cycle, then sent the family his own ration. The gesture was retold as proof of nobility. Taren considered it proof that the regulations did not know what they were doing.

Sava calculated the distribution in a cold hall. Daran demanded more for workers, Vessa for the sick, Raal for the children from the Night, and Oru for systems that could not explain why they needed food: technicians, pumps, bacterial cultures. Every request was justified. Their sum exceeded what existed.

“The Chamber does this every day,” Daran said. “Why is it hard for you now?”

“Because here I see the faces.”

“Then perhaps all Chambers should be built beside empty depots.”

Raal came on the seventh day.

His gang emerged from the Night galleries with no visible weapons, carrying three backup batteries and two wounded people. Frost had whitened the edges of their sails. The children walked in the middle, tied to one another with a rope so they would not get lost in the blizzard.

“I heard you opened the depot,” Raal told Taren.

“Not for you.”

“You opened a door. That's enough.”

He offered the batteries in exchange for food and the right to join the unit. Daran wanted them arrested for their previous thefts. Sava requested their temporary registration. Vessa treated them before the argument was over.

Taren took Raal into the training circle.

“You killed a worker,” he said.

“Yes.”

“Why should I trust you?”

“You shouldn't. Put me where your distrust is useful.”

Taren threw him a rod. The suspended trunk began to swing.

Raal did not retreat too early. Nor too late. He turned around the weight and pushed it from behind, redirecting it towards Taren.

Taren barely evaded it.

For the first time, the recruits laughed at their commander.

“Good,” Taren said. “You'll lead the third group.”

“That's it?”

“That's it until you make a mistake.”

“And after?”

“Depends who survives the mistake.”

That same day, Oru opened a portable genetic reservoir Daran had kept in the House archive. Inside were six edge-hunter embryos, stolen decades earlier from the capital's collections. Daran claimed he had not known about them. No one believed him.

Oru showed Sava the sterilisation sequences.

“They can't reproduce. We can stop their metabolism remotely. They'll hunt only glassbacks; their receptors have been restricted.”

“That's what they said about the substitute organisms.”

“The difference is that these evolved for the function. They weren't designed to imitate it.”

“And if one attacks a child?”

Oru looked at her wearily.

“Then Taren will kill them, and you'll remind me for the rest of my life that you were right.”

Sava touched the reservoir's glass. The embryos did not yet resemble anything alive.

“I'm not afraid of being right,” she said. “I'm afraid every problem is starting to have the same solution.”

“Death?”

“A dangerous thing, controlled by someone who promises it will remain useful.”

Oru closed the lid.

The edge hunters were taken out of the reservoir on the ninth day. They had slender bodies, coarse fur and jaws less impressive than in Oru's reconstructions. The first woke slowly, sniffed the air and tried to hide beneath the laboratory table.

“That's the predator?” Nemi asked.

“It's a cub,” Oru said.

“It's afraid.”

“Things that hunt don't stop being things that can be hunted.”

Taren sat at a distance. The animal pointed its muzzle at him and growled. Everyone else took a step back. Taren did not.

“Don't provoke it,” Oru said.

“I'm not doing anything.”

“To it, staying may be something.”

Taren deliberately moved back. The hunter came out from beneath the table. Oru smiled.

“See? Sometimes flight is a tool.”

“Don't tell Sava you won this argument.”

“I'll send her a report in triplicate.”

For a few moments, before the backup lights flickered again, the room resembled a family sharing a joke.

On the eleventh night, Vessa entered Taren's room. There was no mating ritual between them, no request sent to the system. She unfastened her cloak, touched the scar on his shoulder and said:

“I don't want a permit from Daran.”

“Neither do I.”

“I'm not talking about us. I'm talking about a child.”

Taren remained still. In another time, it would have been a declaration of affection. In Vaor, it was also a political, biological, perhaps military decision.

“Did you choose me because I have a delayed response?” he asked.

“I chose you because you know you have it.”

“That's not the same thing.”

“No choice has a single cause. The Chamber lies when it claims it can separate love from statistics.”

Vessa rested her forehead against his.

“The children of the First Face will be born anyway,” she said. “Daran wants that. The families want it. The bodies want it. The difference is whether we acknowledge what we're doing.”

“And what are we doing?”

Vessa did not leave after resting her forehead against his. Taren's room was a guard alcove with a mattress, a lamp and three maps. Nothing suggested someone lived there except an unwashed bowl and a badly folded blanket.

“I don't want to be your symbol,” she said.

“I didn't ask.”

“That's precisely what worries me. The best symbols are made from people who claim they never wanted to be.”

“Then why did you come?”

Vessa picked her cloak up from the floor and hung it on a peg.

“Because when you held Eri's child, you were afraid of breaking him. Because at the depot, I stopped you. Because I don't know how long this part of you will last.”

Taren looked at her face-on. The gesture was hard to sustain; his peripheral field disappeared.

“And you want a child before it disappears?”

“I don't want to leave it only to Daran to decide what reproduces out of the crisis.”

The sentence was too cold for the closeness between them. Vessa knew it. She touched his cheek.

“And I want you,” she added. “I don't know how to separate that from the rest.”

“Neither does the Chamber.”

“The Chamber pretends.”

When the light went out for the third time, they stayed in the dark. The floor carried the city's footsteps, thousands of uncoordinated rhythms. Taren listened until, among them, he began to distinguish Sio's small beats in the next room.

The following day, the Great Hearing returned.

CHAPTER XI

THE GENTLE MIST

SAVA · VAOR STATION · AFTER THE CONNECTION WAS RESTORED

After the connection was restored, neither Ivarra nor Vaor uttered the word war. Each side preferred terms that preserved the appearance that only the other had broken the peace.

The connection to Ivarra returned the following morning.

Every screen lit up at once. Seln Aru's face appeared in houses, depots, hidden chambers and the courtyard where the First Face trained.

“Citizens of Vaor,” he said, “the storm has passed. Planetary order has been restored. Daran Veyr is charged with usurpation, demographic concealment and illegal distribution of weapons. Taren Ilen is suspended from every position and must be handed over to the central authorities. Anyone carrying out his orders after this message excludes themselves from the protection of the Quiet.”

Taren stood in the centre of the courtyard. Around him, four hundred First Face members listened.

The message repeated.

No one moved towards him.

Raal raised a hind limb and struck the floor once.

Vessa struck a second time.

The third beat came from the child without a number, through the heel of the mother holding him to her chest.

Then all of Vaor answered.

The pounding on the floor continued for almost a minute. It had not been planned. It had begun in the First Face's courtyard, passed into the hidden chambers and risen through the official galleries. Some struck

three times, others only once. There was no common code yet; there was only the refusal to surrender Taren.

Sava stood at the edge of the courtyard and did not strike. Nemi held her hand. Oru was beside them, dirty from the backup network, two fingers bandaged after a repair.

“What does it mean?” Nemi asked.

“That they don't want him to leave,” Oru said.

“Why isn't Mother answering?”

Sava looked at the four hundred grey cloaks. Around them, people who two months earlier had pulled their children towards the walls were now raising their fists. Daran stayed at the back, letting the image seem spontaneous.

“Because my answer would mean something else,” she said.

“What?”

“That I'm choosing their side.”

“Aren't you with us?”

Sava bent to the child's level.

“I'm with you. With your father. With Taren. With the people here. The problem is that all those things can end up on different sides.”

Nemi freed her hand and struck the floor. Just once. Sava did not stop her.

• • •

In the days that followed, words became the adults' preferred weapons.

Wars did not begin in the Long Quiet. Administrative incidents began and refused to end.

Daran Veyr did not declare Vaor's independence. He announced the temporary suspension of compliance with central orders pending assessment of their demographic effects. He did not mobilise an army.

He expanded the agricultural protection unit to twelve hundred members. He did not seize the trains. He introduced a health inspection so slow that no transport from Ivarra could pass.

Seln Aru replied with equal care. He did not impose a blockade. He recalculated energy and food quotas based on the domain's actual population, reducing per-person allocations by thirty-one per cent. He did not send troops. He sent mediators, public-order specialists and six carriages of medical equipment.

In the third carriage were two tonnes of aerosolised veyrin.

Sava learned this from the loading list, two hours before the train arrived.

"It's a sedative," Daran said. "A sedative doesn't conquer a domain."

"In low concentrations, it reduces the alarm reflex," she replied. "In high concentrations, it blocks coordination and initiative. They want to come in without a fight."

Taren was studying the station map. The First Face had occupied the access junctions, but he had forbidden thermal projectiles in inhabited spaces.

"We can stop the train in the outer tunnel."

"If you break the magnetic conduit, we lose our only transport link to the centre," Oru said.

"If you let them in, they'll put us to sleep."

"We don't let them open the tanks."

Sava looked at Daran.

"Accept the mediators. Send half the guard out of the station. Let them see there's no insurrection."

"There is," Daran said.

Sava had known Mern Sai since their training years. They had learned together how to draft a refusal that did not cause panic and how to tell a

family that its future had been moved beyond its own reproductive lifetime. Mern was good at it. He did not lie; he arranged truths so the decision seemed inevitable.

Before the train arrived, he sent her a private message.

SAVA. DON'T TURN A LOCAL ERROR INTO A PLANETARY RUPTURE. BRING TAREN TO THE NEGOTIATIONS. I CAN GUARANTEE HE WON'T BE IMPRISONED.

She replied:

CAN YOU GUARANTEE THE POPULATION WON'T BE REDISTRIBUTED?

Mern did not answer directly.

I CAN GUARANTEE INDIVIDUAL ASSESSMENT.

Sava knew what that meant: families separated according to their ability to work, children sent where there were beds, adults to districts requesting labour. No one would be punished. Everyone would be administered until the community disappeared.

Oru read her messages.

“Do you still believe him?”

“I believe him when he says he doesn't want war.”

“And Seln?”

“Yes.”

“Then why are they bringing gas?”

Sava looked at the loading list. Two tonnes. Too much for a simple precaution, too little for the whole city. Calculated for the station, for the leadership and for anyone who might gather to watch.

“Because they think war only begins when someone dies,” she said.

Oru pressed his forehead to hers.

“After this, we're leaving.”

“Where?”

“Anywhere Nemi can sleep without asking what's coming through the floor.”

“That place doesn't exist.”

“Then we'll make it smaller. A room. A tunnel. A life where we don't have to save a civilisation before dinner.”

Sava smiled wearily.

“After the negotiations.”

“After the negotiations,” Oru repeated.

• • •

The negotiations lasted forty minutes.

The central delegate, Mern Sai, had been Sava's colleague at the Chamber of Measure. He had the soft voice of those trained not to stimulate panic and wore an unmarked cloak. He demanded Taren's surrender, the unit's disarmament and access to the House registers. In return, he promised amnesty for the unregistered population and a reassessment of quotas.

“Reassessment when?” Sava asked.

“In two cycles.”

“The children eat in the meantime.”

“They'll receive emergency assistance.”

“After you redistribute them.”

Mern folded one sail.

“We cannot administer eighty thousand people in infrastructure designed for fewer.”

“They've been administered until now by people you say aren't competent.”

“They've been hidden and underfed.”

“And now they're seen and threatened.”

Behind Mern, central agents were unloading crates marked medical. Taren recognised the shape of the pressure tanks.

“Stop unloading,” he said.

Mern did not turn.

“First-aid equipment.”

“Then open a crate.”

“I don't answer to orders from a suspended individual.”

Taren gestured. Twenty First Face members advanced.

The central agents raised short white projectors. They were not lethal weapons. In the culture of the Quiet, that distinction carried the weight of absolution.

Mern said a single word:

“Now.”

The tanks opened.

The mist was transparent at first. It came through the valves like slightly cooler air, smelling sweetly of wet bark. Sava felt the effect before she saw the cloud: her muscles relaxed, her auditory sails lowered, and urgency disappeared from her thoughts. She knew she had to flee the station. The idea was clear and utterly unimportant.

Taren drove his chisel teeth into the inside of his lip until he tasted blood. The pain kept him functional.

“Masks!” he shouted.

The First Face had come prepared. Those at the front covered their muzzles and attacked the tanks, not the agents. Raal threw a blade and cut the first pipe. Gas burst towards the ceiling. Vessa pulled Sava behind a panel.

The mist reached Sava like a false kindness. Every urgent thought lost its edges. Mern stood two paces away; she could have hit him, torn off his mask or closed the valve. Instead, she remembered an afternoon at school when they had shared a root cake, and it seemed absurd that two people who knew each other could end up on opposite sides of a table.

Vessa pulled her behind the panel and pressed a mask to her muzzle.

“Take small breaths,” she said.

“It's quiet.”

“It isn't quiet. It's incapacity.”

Around them, the station came apart in slow movements. A child fell and remained on the floor, watching the feet stepping around him. A central agent took off his helmet, probably convinced the medical apparatus was safe. Raal struck him. Mern shouted orders that even his own people no longer considered important.

Oru was in the ventilation room beneath the station.

When the detectors registered the aerosol, the automatic system closed the dampers to prevent its spread. It was the correct procedure for a biological agent. In a crowded station, it meant the gas stayed concentrated exactly where it had been released.

Oru opened the first channel manually. The mechanism crushed two of his fingers, but air began to flow. The second damper was blocked by roots grown over its shaft. He took the cutting tool and entered the duct.

Above, the first central agent died.

Raal struck him with his knee and tore off his mask. The agent fell, inhaled veyrin and lay motionless. A First Face member, a young man from the hidden chambers, raised a museum blade and drove it into his throat.

“He was down!” Taren shouted.

The young man stared at the corpse, astonished by his own arm.

“He was getting up.”

“He wasn't getting up.”

Another white projectile burst against the wall. Taren turned, too late to stop the response. Three central agents were hit by thermal needles fired from the gallery. Their ceremonial armour offered no real protection. One caught fire.

The gentle mist filled with the smell of burning flesh.

Taren struck the floor three times, slowly. The retreat signal. The First Face ignored him. The fight had given each of them a narrow tunnel of attention, and at its end there was no longer a commander, only the body in front of them.

Then Taren threw himself between the two groups.

He took a white needle in his shoulder and a blade in his thigh. He struck Raal with the flat of his weapon, then his own recruit, who was trying to kill a second fallen agent. He shouted until his voice cracked.

“Anyone who strikes after surrender leaves the Face! Anyone who pursues someone fleeing stands alone!”

Taren did not remember the white impact in his shoulder. But he remembered the face of the recruit who had killed the fallen agent. His name was Sef, he was fifteen, and he had been selected for his ability to remain functional under alarm. There was no hatred in his eyes. There was the horror of discovering his hand had done something before the rule reached it.

“Drop the blade,” Taren told him.

Sef did not answer.

“Drop it.”

The blade fell. Taren sent him to the rear, then saw a second body catch fire. The code did not yet exist. It had to be invented while it was being broken.

Mern Sai lay beside the negotiating table, his mask torn. Sava crawled to him.

“Stop the tanks.”

“They're automatic,” he whispered. “Thirty minutes.”

“There are children here.”

Mern looked at her without expression, sedated by his own instrument.

“It was calculated for five minutes of exposure.”

The floor shook.

In the ventilation room, Oru had managed to open the second damper. The accumulated pressure drove the mist into the old ducts. Some went out towards the surface. Some entered the maintenance chambers where dozens of children had taken shelter.

Nemi was among them.

When the gas entered, the children stopped looking for the exit. They sat along the wall, drowsy, while an overheated pipe began burning the insulation above them.

Oru heard the fire alarm and crawled through the duct. The veyrin made his limbs heavy. He found the first grille, tore it off and fell into the children's chamber. He lifted them one by one, pushing them towards the open tunnel. An adult could have carried two. He carried three, returned, then four small ones at once, tied to his body with his own cloak.

On his last return, Nemi had still not come out.

He found her beneath the burning pipe, watching the flame with sedated curiosity. He took her in his arms. The insulation came away from the ceiling.

When Taren arrived, the fire was out, but part of the chamber had collapsed. He pulled out seven children. The eighth was Nemi. Oru held her beneath him, protected from the stone that had crushed his back.

He was still alive.

Sava came running, her mask hanging round her neck. She fell beside him and tried to lift the slab. Taren caught her before she broke her hands.

“We need a jack,” she said. “Oru, stay awake. Vessa's coming.”

Oru blinked slowly. Blood came from his nostrils.

“Nemi?”

“She's alive. She's here.”

The little girl pressed against his shoulder, crying without a sound.

“The dampers,” Oru whispered.

“They're open.”

“Good.”

“Don't talk.”

“You were right.”

Sava brought her forehead close to his.

“About what?”

“Solutions.”

His breathing grew irregular.

“Don't give the dead reasons they didn't have,” he said. “I didn't die for Vaor. Or for Taren. I wanted to get our child out of here.”

Vessa arrived with her instruments. She looked at the position of the slab, the colour of Oru's mucous membranes and the amount of blood. She did not lie.

“I can sedate him.”

Sava made a low, ancestral sound. It was not crying yet. It was the body learning before the mind.

“No,” Oru said. “Enough quiet.”

When the slab fell onto Oru, the air duct opened fully and drew the smoke upwards. For a few seconds, the children's chamber became clear. Later, Nemi remembered that light: red, trembling, with particles of ash rising towards the grille. Her father was above her, and his back no longer had the right shape.

"Don't leave me," she told him.

"I'm not leaving," Oru replied.

It was not a promise about life. It was one about the last moments. Nemi did not understand the difference.

After he died, Sava stayed beside the body until Vessa closed his eyes. Taren took Nemi out of the chamber. The little girl bit his arm and struggled to go back.

"He said he wasn't leaving!"

"I know."

"Then lift the stone!"

Taren held her while she hit, scratched and screamed. The child's body wanted to run from death and towards it at the same time. There was no exercise for that.

• • •

By the end of the day, the death toll had reached a hundred and six. Twenty-eight were central agents. Thirteen belonged to the First Face. The rest were inhabitants, most crushed, suffocated or caught in the fire while veyrin suspended their reflexes.

Daran appeared on every Vaor channel and called the event the Mist Massacre. He showed the children's bodies. He showed the armed central agents. He did not show the first First Face member who had killed a fallen opponent.

Seln Aru replied that a non-lethal device had been sabotaged by insurgents and that the deaths were the consequence of armed resistance.

He did not show the order to bring two tonnes of aerosol into a crowded station.

Truth was divided so precisely that each side received exactly the amount it needed for hatred.

At Oru's ceremony, Sava refused House Veyr's flag. She also refused the white ribbon sent by the Chamber of Measure. They buried him in the fertile layer beneath a new crop, according to the root engineers' custom.

Taren stood apart. When the ceremony ended, Sava came to him.

"Daran will use his death," she said.

"I know."

"Seln will use it."

"I know."

"Will you use it?"

Taren looked at the fresh earth.

"I can't promise I won't."

Sava struck him. Her palm split his lip.

Taren did not defend himself.

"Then at least don't call it courage," she said.

That night, the First Face wrote its first code on the station wall: no killing after surrender; no pursuing those who flee; guarded food does not belong to the guard; children do not wear the sign; an order demanding the death of the unarmed is not an order.

Beneath the five rules, someone added in dried blood:

PEACE FIRED FIRST.

Taren erased the sentence.

There was not enough room at Oru's ceremony for everyone who had come. The root engineers wore green stains on their forearms,

deliberately left there. The children from his workshop had brought a root they had grafted; the joint was crooked and would probably not survive. Sava asked for it to be planted anyway.

Bes, the local technician, told how Oru had stuck his head into a pipe on his first day. Eri said he had repaired the clinic's heating without asking the children's names. Raal stood at the edge, without the sign on his chest. Daran came with an escort and left when Sava refused the House cloth.

After striking Taren, Sava looked at her palm. His blood remained on her fingers.

"I'm sorry," she said.

"You aren't."

"No."

Taren wiped his lip.

"Oru was right about the hunters. They went into the field today. They followed the herd, but they didn't attack anything of ours."

Sava closed her eyes. Even dead, Oru continued to send consequences.

"Don't make a lesson of this."

"No."

"Don't make his death a reason for what comes next."

"I can't promise."

After the blow, the code was written on the station wall. Taren reread it several times. Five sentences born of failure, not virtue.

When someone added **PEACE FIRED FIRST**, he rubbed out the words until his fingers bled.

By morning, they had been written again, larger.

That same morning, observers in the Night reported the central column approaching Deaf Lake.

CHAPTER XII

DEAF LAKE

TAREN · THE EDGE OF THE NIGHT · SEVEN WEEKS LATER

Deaf Lake was a place where vibrations were lost in ice and steam. For a species that had built its society on warnings transmitted through the floor, the absence of an answer made it almost uninhabitable—and suitable for an ambush.

Two days before the battle, Taren walked the route with Raal. The wind from the Night slipped beneath their improvised armour and froze the moisture in their fur. Every time they emerged from the shelter of a rock, Taren's body calculated the distance to the next tunnel mouth.

"You're looking for places to run," Raal observed.

"Everyone does."

"Not everyone admits it."

On the lake, the ice was translucent. Beneath it, large bubbles of steam could be seen, trapped like organs in a frozen body. Oru had marked unstable points with technical symbols. Taren recognised his handwriting: quick lines, abbreviations no one else fully understood, little observations about pressure. At one junction he had written: *do not open both valves simultaneously; the basin breathes badly*.

"That's exactly where you want to bring them," Raal said.

"Yes."

"Would your engineer have approved?"

"No."

"Then why are we using his plan?"

Taren put the slate in his pocket.

"Because the dead can't defend their purposes."

Raal looked at him, probably remembering Daran's words about Leth.

"You learn fast."

Taren did not reply.

In camp, the First Face numbered twelve hundred members. The number sounded like an army, but the bodies behind it were growers, guards, thieves, adolescents and a few former House agents. Only a hundred had seen fighting at the depot or the station. The rest had practised with suspended trunks and unloaded weapons.

Taren divided the groups according to who knew whom, not rank. Those who had grown up together could recognise one another's panic before it became flight. Raal asked for the members from the Night to stay separate.

"They don't trust the House people," he said.

"That's precisely why we mix them."

"You don't build a society in battle."

"Then what do you build?"

"A situation in which the society that follows will belong to those who remain."

Taren put Raal at the tunnels, where his decision could save or bury the entire flank.

On the night before the attack, no one slept. Some sharpened blades that were already sharp. Others sent messages to their families. One young man recited the surrender instructions like a prayer. Taren walked among them and found nothing useful to say. Courage, sacrifice, defence—all the words seemed borrowed from stories written by survivors.

Vessa called him to the lakeside.

The central army was coming from the Night, where there was no road.

Seln Aru had chosen the route because Vaor controlled the trains and the eastern galleries could be collapsed. Four thousand agents, technicians and House Selc volunteers advanced along the Belt's frozen edge, protected by thermal suits and low vehicles. Officially, their mission was to restore planetary infrastructure. Their inventory included dispersal cannons, immobilising foam and enough veyrin for three more stations.

They had no combat experience.

Neither did the First Face, but it had survived a trial.

Taren chose to stop them at Deaf Lake, a depression covered in porous ice, twenty kilometres west of the inhabited chambers. There, the wind from the Night erased smells, and the snow hid the mouths of the old geothermal tunnels. Oru had mapped the area before he died. His working slate still marked the points where underground heat had thinned the ice.

Taren held the slate in his palm when Vessa came beside him.

She wore armour made of hardened root plates, too large for her body. In recent days she had eaten little and vomited twice during training. Taren had not asked. Before a battle, bodies had a right to their own secrets.

"I'm pregnant," she said.

The wind folded both her sails eastwards.

Taren looked at the lake.

"How long have you known?"

"Since before the mist."

"Why did you come here?"

"Because I'm a doctor."

"There are other doctors."

"And because I want to see what kind of father I'm choosing before I let him become a story."

Taren turned his whole body towards her.

“I don't need this now.”

“Now is exactly when you need it. If you die, the child will be raised by those who use your death. If you live, it will be raised by what you do today.”

“You could lose it in the cold.”

“You could lose twelve hundred people. Don't turn care into a privilege just because it's yours.”

She took the slate from his hand and pointed to two places.

“These tunnels connect. If we open the valves, the steam will weaken the ice beneath the central flank.”

“Oru marked the area as unstable.”

“That's why it will work.”

Taren wanted to tell her he had chosen none of this. That the saryx had fallen in front of him, that Daran had put weapons within reach, that Seln had sent gas, that every step had been a response to something already done. But the child in Vessa's picture turned defence into an excuse. A future needed more than an explanation of causes; it needed someone who accepted having taken part.

“If I live,” he said, “I don't want Daran to name the child.”

“Then live long enough to argue with him.”

“You stay at the medical post.”

“I'll stay where I can save the most people.”

“That's an order.”

Vessa came closer. She did not raise her voice.

“You said protection isn't ownership. Don't make me the first exception.”

Taren lowered his gaze. Power was simple when directed at an enemy. Beside those he loved, every boundary resembled possession.

“Then promise me you’ll leave if the line falls.”

“I promise I’ll decide when the line has fallen.”

It was all he would get.

Three kilometres to the west, Aven Sor received the same hours under a different name. For the central army, the night before the battle was “the final phase of service deployment”. Seln’s orders avoided every military word. The agents were to restore access, isolate armed elements and protect the population from escalation.

On the maps, Vaor appeared as an infrastructure problem surrounded by civilians.

Aven had set up his post in a converted distribution vehicle. Around him, officers rehearsed dispersal routes and technicians checked the foam cannons. Most agents carried weapons that immobilised. The thermal blades were sealed for extreme situations. The word **extreme** had no shared criterion.

Iren Sol, the mirror technician, arrived with the geothermal map.

“The lake route isn’t safe,” he said.

“The models show it as stable under our weight.”

“The central models don’t include local pipes. There are temperature anomalies beneath the ice.”

“How large?”

“We don’t know. Vaor switched off the sensors.”

Aven enlarged the image. The alternative route passed through a gorge where the tunnels could be collapsed. The lake was open, visible and, according to every simulation, allowed deployment without close contact.

“The Custodian approved the route,” he said.

“The Custodian approved the model.”

“It's the same decision.”

Iren looked at him face-on.

“Only for the person who won't be walking on the ice.”

Aven did not punish him. He asked him to mark every suspicious point and ride in the second transporter, not the front line. Iren refused.

“If the relays break, I need to be beside command.”

“You have two children.”

“That's precisely why I want this mission finished before it's called a war.”

Outside the vehicle, the agents ate in groups of twenty. They had been trained for crowds, fires and evacuations. They had learned that a frightened group seeks openings and that slow pressure can push it without visible violence. Few had killed an animal larger than farming insects. Yet some sharpened their sealed blades with stones brought from home.

Aven walked among them. A House Selc volunteer asked whether the First Face really faced forwards in battle.

“It's a sign,” he replied.

“In the images, they don't seem to run.”

“The images begin after those who ran have left the frame.”

“Then why does the world follow them?”

Aven looked towards the lake's dark line.

“Because the rest of us made retreat into an administration.”

He had not meant to say it. The young man did not understand and returned to his weapon.

An hour before departure, Seln appeared on the channel. His face was evenly lit, without a background.

“Avoid casualties,” he said. “Taren Ilen must be separated from the population. Daran Veyr will negotiate when he can no longer use the unit as proof of sovereignty.”

“If they offer armed resistance?” Aven asked.

“Maintain proportionality.”

“In relation to what?”

The pause was very brief.

“Systemic risk.”

Aven knew the language. It meant local losses could be accepted if they prevented the revolt from spreading. It also meant no one would later be able to point to the exact moment the order had become permission.

“I want authorisation to retreat if the terrain differs from the model,” he said.

“You have it.”

“Without central confirmation?”

“You have it,” Seln repeated.

The connection closed. Aven should have felt free. He felt abandoned inside a decision broad enough for any outcome to be attributed to him.

Iren was recording a message for his children. Aven saw him stop three times before sending it. At last, the technician deleted the solemn beginning and said only that he would bring them a piece of deaf ice, if the containers could preserve it.

“Do you think we’ll fight?” Aven asked him.

“I think each side has prepared an explanation for why the other started.”

At the instruments' artificial dawn, the vehicles set off. The public services' white cloths unfurled in the wind. The agents looked at them as a guarantee they were not an army. From a distance, to those in Vaor, the white resembled the mist that had killed their people.

• • •

The central army appeared on the horizon as a moving stain. It carried no war flags; such objects did not exist. Public-service white cloths fluttered on the vehicles, signalling that any resistance would be classified as an attack on civilian aid.

Daran Veyr had asked Taren for a visible victory.

“We mustn't just stop them,” he had said. “The other Houses must believe Ivarra can be defeated.”

“Then send yourself to the front,” Taren had replied.

Daran had stayed in Vaor, for continuity of leadership.

The First Face split into three. Raal led the group hidden in the lake tunnels. Vessa remained at the medical post behind them. Taren took four hundred members onto the open surface, where any healthy nivar felt the need to run even before the enemy appeared.

He asked them to run.

When the first dispersal projectiles struck the snow, Vaor's line broke. The fighters leapt eastwards in irregular arcs, exactly like a crowd without command. The central agents advanced. Their cannons projected foam that froze on contact and immobilised limbs. Several First Face members were caught; one fell face-down in the snow and suffocated before he could be turned over.

The central commander, Aven Sor, saw the retreat and sent his right flank forwards. His training had been in disturbance control: constant pressure dispersed groups, and fugitives were not to be pursued beyond the inhabited area. But Vaor was retreating towards its own chambers. If he let them go, the mission failed.

Aven followed them.

Taren ran ahead of the line, every muscle begging him not to turn back. The plan had been simple in the hall. On the surface, under projectiles and wind, feigned flight quickly mingled with the real thing. Some

passed the marked point. Others threw down their weapons to leap faster.

Taren struck his heel against the ice once.

The sound was lost in the wind, but the resonator at his foot amplified it through the layer below.

In the tunnel, Raal felt it. He opened the first valve.

Steam rose into the pockets beneath the lake.

The second beat.

The groups on the sides stopped running and descended into the concealed tunnel mouths. Those who did not remember the plan followed them by reflex.

The central army reached the thinned ice.

The third beat.

Taren turned.

Four hundred bodies did the same. It was not a natural manoeuvre. To present their faces, nivari had to fight the position of their eyes, the orientation of their limbs, every gene telling them their backs should already be far away. The grey line turned towards the white.

The others burst from the tunnels.

Raal opened the second valve. The ice gave way beneath the central vehicles. It did not break into water; underneath was hot geothermal mud. Two transporters tilted and sank halfway. Steam covered the flank. The agents, trained to hold formation before a crowd, found themselves attacked from the sides and below.

When the ice gave way, it did not sound like a fracture. It was felt through the soles: a sudden lowering of the world. White vehicles tilted, agents clutched one another, and steam erupted in columns that hid the star Vei.

Taren turned with the line. For the first time, the manoeuvre rehearsed in the courtyard carried the weight of real bodies. Some did not stop. They kept running towards Vaor. Taren saw them disappear into the white and felt anger, then envy. They had accepted what their muscles demanded. He had used the very instinct to flee as bait, and now had to persuade a thousand bodies to betray it.

The first agent he struck was an older woman. She held a dispersal tool and shouted that she was a technician. Taren's blade stopped before her throat; he hit her with the hilt and took her weapon. To his right, another Face member did not stop. Black blood spread across the ice.

The code existed, but the fighting made it hard to read.

Steam erased their field of vision in less than ten seconds. Taren could see only bodies entering and leaving the white. The signs on cloaks disappeared beneath moisture. For a species accustomed to tracking the world's edges with lateral eyes, the battle suddenly became a tunnel without walls.

To his right, Emon Veyr fell onto a central agent. Both had lost their weapons. The agent was smaller and was trying to free his foot from frozen foam. Emon raised his short blade.

"Surrender!" he shouted.

The agent could not hear him. His helmet covered his sails. He struggled and searched for something at his belt.

Emon struck the helmet, not the throat. He broke the visor and repeated the order. The agent took his hand from his belt. He held a medical kit.

"Technician," he said.

The same word the woman Taren encountered a few moments later would shout. Emon pulled him out of the foam and pushed him towards the prisoner line. A Face member reproached him for wasting time.

"At the gallery, you ran," he said. "Now you're hesitating."

"Now I know what I'm protecting," Emon replied.

In the tunnel, the second valve did not open fully. Raal felt the resistance through the handle. Mineral deposits had blocked the shaft, exactly as Oru's slate warned. Two people helped him. If they forced it too far, the pipe could rupture the gallery and boil them before the lake gave way.

"Open it!" a young man shouted.

"Slowly."

"Taren gave the third signal."

"Taren is above and can't feel the valve."

The young man pushed. The shaft moved abruptly, and the sideways jet stripped the skin from his arm. Raal knocked him to the floor and closed it a fraction. Above, the ice groaned. Around him, the fighters waited for the order with their eyes raised, as though authority could descend through rock.

"Now," Raal said.

They opened it together. The ceiling vibrated. A piece of root broke free and struck a woman on the head. She did not get up. Raal had no time to learn her name. He ordered the others out through the northern mouth and stayed last to lock the valve in position. Years later, songs would say he had stood alone beneath the lake. In reality, two people came back for him, and one cursed him all the way for wanting to turn a technical task into a memorable death.

At the medical post, Vessa lost track of the order of the wounded after the first minute. The central foam caused hypothermia, the mud burns, and blades mixed tissue with armour fibres. She tied three bands to her arm: one for those who could wait, one for those who needed immediate treatment and one for those she could no longer save. After five people, the colours were covered in blood and ceased to be useful.

An agent in white was brought beside a Face member. Both had burns over half their bodies. The assistant asked whom to treat first.

"The one breathing worse."

“He's central.”

“His lungs don't know that.”

The Vaor fighter heard her and caught her wrist.

“I came with you.”

“Then help me and breathe for one more minute.”

She fitted the agent with the breathing tube. The fighter survived. The agent did not. Later, the first man's family would say Vessa had chosen the enemy. In the medical report, the choice appeared as a twenty-three-second difference in saturation.

On the surface, signals were being lost. Taren struck once for the right flank and received two replies from different directions. One Face group had descended into the wrong opening and emerged behind its own people. For a few moments, two grey formations attacked each other in the steam. They recognised their shared smell only after the first death.

Taren shouted for them to stop, but the wind took his voice. He made his way to a messenger's fallen resonator. A foam projectile struck his thigh and froze his knee. He cut the material away before it hardened, losing a strip of skin with it. Around him, the battle had no centre. His plan continued through hundreds of people remembering different fragments.

He saw an agent raise a blade over a fallen recruit. He struck him from the side. Then he saw a Face member attack the same agent after his weapon had been taken. He stopped him too. In less than a minute, both sides had considered him a traitor.

“The signal!” he shouted to those around him. “Three short beats means stop!”

“They haven't surrendered!” someone replied.

“You aren't listening any more either!”

When he found Aven beside the transporter, Taren had not reached the enemy commander as in a duel. He had reached him because every other

part of the field had become impossible to control. Capturing him was the only command simple enough to cross the steam.

Taren reached Aven Sor beside the overturned transporter. The central commander held a foam projector and was trying to organise the retreat.

“Stop the attack!” he shouted. “The mission is cancelled!”

Taren knocked the weapon from his hand.

“Hand over the vehicle codes.”

“You attacked the planetary services.”

“You entered with gas a domain that had just buried its children.”

“I didn't order the mist.”

“And I didn't order every blade surrounding you.”

Aven looked around. First Face members were approaching. Some wore the frontal sign on their masks. In their eyes was the same pleasure Sava had seen when Taren killed the saryx, now multiplied by belonging.

Aven lowered his hands.

“I surrender.”

Taren struck the ground three times, quickly. The new signal to stop fighting.

On the left, a group kept pursuing the fleeing agents. Raal ran after them, caught up, and knocked down the first Vaor fighter before he could drive his blade into a white back.

“The code,” Raal said.

“They killed us at the station.”

“The code.”

The young man spat at him. Raal broke his arm.

Raal broke the fighter's arm without looking towards Taren. The gesture was effective and disproportionate. The young man was no longer

pursuing anyone. The pain made him fall, and two comrades immediately understood the order.

“You could have stopped him another way,” Taren said.

“Yes.”

“Why didn't you?”

Raal watched the fleeing central agents.

“So the others would understand faster.”

Taren should have punished him. Instead, he ordered him to take the prisoners to the rear. He chose efficiency in a situation where every second mattered. Later, when situations would be constructed precisely to make seconds matter, he would remember that compromise.

The battle lasted twenty-seven minutes.

Three hundred and nineteen central agents and a hundred and four First Face members died. Another two hundred fell into the hot mud; Vessa treated burns until her hands shook. She did not ask which side the wounded belonged to. Taren sent the prisoners to carry the bodies.

Sava arrived from Vaor after the fighting stopped. She had passed through days of mourning without crying in front of anyone. When she saw the field, she stopped.

Arua's snow was not naturally white. Its nitrogen crystals reflected the star's red light and had the colour of pale flesh. Nivar blood was almost black. From a distance, the dead looked like holes opened in the ground.

“Did you win?” she asked Taren.

He stood beside Aven Sor, who had surrendered his codes.

“I stopped them.”

“That isn't what I asked.”

Taren looked at the disarmed central army, the captured vehicles and the First Face members striking the ground in a victory rhythm. The vibration passed through the lake and raised small waves of snow.

“Yes,” he said.

Sava approached a covered body. She recognised a mirror technician's uniform, not an agent's. He was very young.

“Did he know how to fight?”

“No.”

“Then whom did you defeat?”

Sava knelt beside the dead technician. His badge read *secondary mirrors, eastern sector*. He carried no weapon. He had probably been sent to restart the nodes once the agents took the ground.

“His name was Iren Sol,” Aven Sor said. “He had two children.”

The central commander was disarmed, with a cut on his forehead. Sava knew him from reports, not personally.

“Why was he in the front line?”

“He wasn't. The line broke over us.”

“Who decided on the route across the lake?”

“The Custodian.”

“Did he know it was unstable?”

Aven looked at Oru's slate in Taren's hand.

“The central maps didn't show active valves.”

“Because Vaor hid the network,” Sava said.

“Because Ivarra would have shut it down,” Taren replied.

Truth passed from one to another like a weapon no one wanted to hold for long.

• • •

The messages arrived before the dead were lifted.

House Orm in the south requested twelve First Face instructors. House Tel was suspending its year of residence in Ivarra and requesting

weapons. Three communities without a House declared they would no longer transmit birth registers. In the capital, the provincial families in the Gardens of Kinship had been moved into guarded compounds for their own safety.

Daran broadcast images of the sunken central vehicles and announced “the victory of a local administration against a disproportionate intervention”. He did not utter the word war.

In the medical camp, Vessa showed Taren a trembling image of their embryo. It was only a pale curve and a rhythmic point.

“It survived,” she said.

The victory beats came from outside. Three, pause, three, pause. The old signal for shadow, shelter, silence had been turned inside out. Now it meant: stop, face, attack.

Taren touched the screen.

“What will we tell the child happened here?”

“The truth,” Vessa replied.

“Which one?”

Vessa looked at the dead through the tent entrance.

“The one they'll have to move beyond.”

At artificial sunset, Taren sent the same reply to the three Houses:

I WILL NOT SEND YOU WARRIORS. SEND ME THE YOUNG PEOPLE WHO NO LONGER HAVE A PLACE IN YOUR PEACE.

Before sending his reply to the Houses, Taren walked among the wounded. A central agent asked him for water. A First Face member refused, saying their own reserves were low. Taren took his container and gave it to the prisoner. The gesture stirred a murmur around them.

“They brought us the mist,” someone said.

“This one wasn't at the station.”

“He wore their white.”

“So when he wears our cloak, will he be allowed to be thirsty?”

No one answered. Taren moved away, aware that a just sentence did not change the distribution of resentment.

At the medical post, Vessa showed him the embryo. The pale curve pulsed. Taren did not feel the simple joy he had expected; he felt a fear more precise than all the others. The child would be born into a world where its father's victory had just set twelve trains in motion.

“Don't send instructors,” Vessa said. “Daran wants branches of his own.”

“If we don't send them, they'll make their own.”

“Then bring them here. Make them see the dead as well as the images of victory.”

Taren wrote the message.

I WILL NOT SEND YOU WARRIORS. SEND ME THE YOUNG PEOPLE WHO NO LONGER HAVE A PLACE IN YOUR PEACE.

After it was sent, the pounding spread across the lake. Three, pause, three. Fine snow leapt above the ice like shivering skin.

Taren listened to the new signal and understood it could no longer be withdrawn. A code becomes tradition not when it is declared, but when people use it to recognise one another.

Within a week, twelve trains set off for Vaor.

PART III

THE VERTICAL HOUSES

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CHAPTER XIII

AFTER VICTORY

SAVA AND NEMI · VAOR · THE NEXT TWO YEARS

The victory at Deaf Lake did not produce peace, but a period in which every institution claimed the emergency would end after the next temporary measure.

Two years after Deaf Lake, the first towers appeared on Arua's surface.

They had no clear function. Weapons could be mounted more safely underground, and solar storms made height a vulnerability. The builders claimed the towers allowed surveillance of the roads. Sava knew drones could observe the roads better.

Their real usefulness was to be seen.

For thousands of generations, nivari had hidden their homes from the sky. Even Ivarra's palaces lay beneath rock, their entrances imitating folds in the terrain. Daran Veyr raised the first tower above Vaor, a brown blade of fossilised root visible to the edge of the Night. He placed the First Face's frontal sign at its summit.

"It's an insult to instinct," he said at the inauguration. "That's why it's art."

The other Houses imitated him. Towers became depots, command posts, shrines to the dead and places where young people climbed to prove they could sleep beneath a sky without a ceiling. A new political expression formed around them: the Vertical Houses.

Ivarra called them emergency regimes.

The emergency had already lasted twenty-seven months.

In the registers, the twenty-seven months between the lake and the tower occupied only a few lines: stabilisation, population integration,

reconstruction, defensive reorganisation. For those who had lived them, nothing had been stable.

In the first week after victory, Vaor did not know what to do first with survival. The clinics were full, the main pipes worked only a few hours each cycle, and central prisoners received the same food as the fighters who had captured them. That had been Taren's rule. On the third day, a mother came to the Civil Office and asked why the agent who had burned her home received medicine while her son waited.

Sava had no answer that did not resemble cruelty.

"Because he's wounded now," she said.

"And when was my son?"

"Then he should have received it too."

"He didn't."

"I know."

"Then your equality begins exactly after it would have helped us."

The woman left before Sava finished explaining the law, prisoners and what kind of people they would become if treatment depended on hatred. In the report, the case appeared as a "dispute over clinical priority". Sava erased the phrase and entered the woman's question exactly. Daran approved the change, then projected it in a speech about Vaor's nobility. The woman asked him to remove her name. Daran removed the name and kept the pain.

In the second week, demobilisation began. Taren sent home half of those who had fought at the lake. Two days later, three communities asked for their guards back: depots had been attacked, former central agents wandered without food, and groups wearing the Face sign were confiscating things in victory's name. Taren sent temporary patrols and forbade them to stay more than one cycle in the same settlement.

The patrols returned after a cycle, then again. Sleeping places were built for them. A technician was assigned to repair their weapons. A kitchen

was allocated exclusively to guard shifts because they could not wait in civilian queues. Every measure was temporary. Together, they formed an institution.

Raal handled recruitment and brought Taren candidates no school would have accepted: over-impulsive youths, women who had defended their alcoves with tools, former thieves who knew the Night roads, central agents who could no longer return to Ivarra. Taren rejected those who demanded rank before training and those who spoke too often of blood.

“You'll keep only the ones who lie better,” Raal told him.

“Then stay and show me which ones they are.”

“I'm an excellent liar.”

“That's why I keep you close.”

In the second month, Daran proposed a Festival of Staying. He wanted enormous cloths, fires on the surface and the dead people's names projected onto rock. Sava showed him the calculation: the ceremony's materials could repair two reservoirs and feed the clinics for nine days.

“People don't live on nutrient alone,” Daran said.

“They die very concretely without it.”

“They need to know what the others died for.”

“The dead no longer need your explanation.”

The ceremony took place anyway, but without fires. Workers hung a piece of burnt pipe at every entrance. Each family wrote its own name, without Daran being able to choose the order. Some pieces carried thanks to the First Face. Others accused Daran, Ivarra, the Chamber or even Taren. One carried only the words: *we don't yet know why*.

For Oru, Nemi chose a green piece cut from the pipe he had opened before dying. She wanted to write “he saved the children”. Sava stopped her.

“He did more than his last act.”

“Then what do I write?”

They stayed a long time beside the crooked root planted at the ceremony. The graft looked sick, but Bes had found a living strand and connected it to a water circuit. Around it, the soil smelled of wet minerals and ash.

Nemi wrote: *Oru Ilen. He repaired what he could touch.*

“It doesn't say he was my father.”

“Those who know you know.”

“But a long time from now?”

Sava thought of all the people reduced in archives to a function or a relationship with someone more important.

“Add that too.”

Beneath the first line, Nemi wrote: *He was my father, and not only that.*

In the fourth month, the children began playing Deaf Lake. Some were agents running across the ice, others Faces striking imaginary valves. No one wanted to be the civilian caught between them. When an instructor tried to introduce the role, the children turned it into the person who brought water after the fighting.

Taren watched once. He saw a boy imitate the way he had raised Oru's rod. The movement was wrong and heroic. He showed him the correct angle, then regretted it. The next day, all the children repeated the gesture better.

“You gave them the lesson they wanted to hear,” Vessa said.

“He could have broken his shoulder.”

“Now he'll break it precisely.”

Vessa worked in the united clinics of the upper and hidden cities. Some doctors refused patients without identities because medicines had to be accounted for. She introduced a provisional register based on biological

traces rather than names. Sava approved it as a six-month measure. After six months, she extended it. After a year, the system became the basis of the new demographic administration.

In the seventh month, the first restored harvest did not cover consumption. The Civil Office reduced adult rations by eight per cent. The Faces requested an exemption for fighters. The Hands requested one for heavy labourers. The clinics requested one for pregnant women and the sick. Every request was right, and together they left only children and officials to bear the reduction.

Sava called the representatives together and placed bowls on the table containing the proposed portions for each group.

“Eat,” she said.

No one began.

“This isn't serious negotiation,” an Orm commander protested.

“It's the only serious part. The rest is titles.”

In the end, the reductions were shared, but the Faces received supplements before patrols and the workers after shifts. The difference seemed technical. By year's end, children already knew a fighter's cloak got them through the food queue faster.

In the eleventh month, Daran began the tower's foundations. Officially, it was a communications relay and a depot in case the galleries collapsed. The design included ceremonial spaces, balconies and a platform too wide for any antenna. Sava refused the materials. Daran obtained contributions from the Houses and voluntary labour from young people who wanted to wear the Face sign.

“Voluntary?” Sava asked.

“No one is obliged.”

“What do they get?”

“Priority in selection for the Corps.”

“Then the labour is the price of rank.”

“All skills have a price.”

She tried to impose wages and shift limits. The young people protested that sacrifice could not be salaried. Their parents protested that they could not eat sacrifice. Daran accepted payment and named every ration “recognition of foundation”.

The second year had no visible beginning. Nivari did not live under seasons, and Vei's light remained motionless. Time showed itself in bodies. Nemi had grown enough that Oru's cloak no longer touched the floor when she wore it. Sen had learned to stand holding Vessa's arm. Eri had given birth and returned to the clinic before Sava considered her healed. Kol, the boy from the train, was already working on filters beside Bes and sending half his ration to his family, who had stayed in Vel Four.

On the surface, the foundations finally rose beyond the edge of the rock. The first vertical plate cast a new shadow over Vaor's entrance. The inhabitants came out to look at it. Some beat the Face rhythm. Others pressed against the walls when the wind made it crack.

No one ordered the crowd to stay.

Yet most stayed until the shadow became part of the city.

The first tower rose slowly, as a building site that consumed people and materials rather than a monument. The fossilised root had to be cut into plates, heated, pressed and transported to the surface. Twelve workers died in the first year: three fell, four froze after a lift failure, five were crushed when a beam came loose. Daran called them founders. Sava entered them in the register under construction accidents.

The difference was not merely vocabulary. Founders' families received homes near the tower and additional birth rights. Accident victims' families received standard compensation. After Sava insisted, the two categories were unified. Daran accepted and renamed every accident a founding sacrifice.

“You can't win with him,” Aven Sor told her.

The former central commander now worked in the Civil Office. Ivarra had demanded his return for an inquiry; he had refused, probably knowing he would be made responsible for Deaf Lake. In Vaor, both sides distrusted him, and that was precisely why Sava considered him useful.

“I'm not trying to win,” she replied. “I'm trying to get the families food.”

“He knows. That's why he lets you correct the effect and keeps the story.”

Their office occupied a former storage hall. On one wall hung the population map, now updated with the inhabitants below. On another were the First Face's orders, the Houses' requests, energy quotas and the list of central prisoners. Every day, Sava moved bodies between categories and tried to keep the categories from becoming destinies.

Aven brought a new request. A group of sixty captive technicians wanted to stay in Vaor. Ivarra declared them illegally detained; Vaor considered them protected guests.

“Why don't they go back?” Sava asked.

“Some have families here. Others fear a trial. Seven say they get more food. Two believe in the cause.”

“Only two?”

“Causes are easier to declare when they don't include the ration.”

Sava approved individual choice and requested interviews without the Face present. The following day, Daran announced that the central specialists had freely chosen to contribute to Vaor's rebirth. It was true. It was not the whole truth.

That was how the new order was built: from correct sentences narrowing until they left no room for another interpretation.

• • •

In the first months after the lake, Taren slept in guard posts and refused House apartments. When the tower reached its fourth level, Daran offered him a room at the top.

“From there you can see every road,” he said.

“The drones see them better.”

“From there, every road can see you.”

Taren refused. Yet First Face members began climbing at night. They slept beneath the sky on platforms without edges and came down in the morning with wind-inflamed eyes. The ritual was called **the open vigil**. Taren banned it after the first fall. The young people moved it to other Houses' unfinished towers.

Vessa told him he no longer controlled what he had inspired.

“I didn't inspire the towers.”

“You made standing still admirable. The tower is your body turned into architecture.”

“Then it should have a broken shoulder.”

Vessa did not smile. She held Sen to her chest. The child was almost a year old and followed sounds with an attentive slowness. He did not startle at training blows, but cried when Vessa left the room. His biology fitted neither Daran's hopes nor Sava's simple fears.

“Sleep at home tonight,” Vessa said.

“I have an inspection in the eastern tunnel.”

“You have people for that.”

“That's precisely why I have to go. They're beginning to think rank means exemption.”

“And you're beginning to think absence from the table is a virtue.”

Taren looked at the child.

“I don't know what to do with him.”

“Hold him. Talk to him. Be here often enough that you don't become only the face on the banners.”

Sen reached towards his scar. Taren took him awkwardly. The child gripped the edge of his burned sail and pulled. Taren flinched. This time Vessa laughed.

“He has a good reflex,” she said.

Taren stayed until Sen fell asleep. At mid-cycle, a messenger came for him. A House Orm patrol had confiscated an unregistered community's food and invoked the Code. Taren left without waking Vessa.

In the morning, Sen opened his eyes and found only his father's cloak on the peg.

• • •

Sava tried to preserve for Nemi a life that was more than history being written. She enrolled her in the civil school, imposed sleeping hours and forbade her to carry the short blade Raal gave every child in his workshop. Nemi listened and found technically compliant alternatives. She attended school, then spent her evenings in the Face archive. She slept the required hours, but read in the dark with a covered slate. She did not wear the blade; she kept it in her bag.

One evening, Sava found her copying reports from Deaf Lake.

“Why these?”

“The numbers don't match.”

“Which ones?”

“Daran says three hundred and nineteen agents died. Aven's list has three hundred and eighteen and one missing technician. The technician's body appears among the dead, but his family still receives a prisoner's ration.”

Sava took the slate. Nemi was right. A small error born of chaos.

“We'll correct it.”

“The family will lose the ration.”

“They’ll get death compensation.”

“Less.”

“We can’t keep a dead man as alive.”

Nemi looked at her.

“Why? The Chamber kept living people as nonexistent for years.”

Sava sat beside her daughter. It was impossible to explain the ethics of registers without defending their hypocrisies.

“Because if we change the truth every time it produces a good result, soon only those who control the register will decide what is good.”

“Then his family will eat less so the register can stay pure.”

“No. We’ll change the compensation.”

It took them three weeks and two arguments with Daran. The family received the same ration. Nemi learned a lesson Sava had not intended to teach: truth was necessary, but without power it remained a form of exact cruelty.

Nemi had grown quickly. At the age when Ivarra’s children began studying rituals, she knew how to read military maps, recognise by smell who was lying under interrogation and repair a ventilation valve. She remembered little of her father’s death. She remembered very well that Taren had taken her out of the chamber.

On the morning of the tower’s inauguration, she came to her mother’s office with an apprenticeship application for the Memory Corps, the archivists who accompanied the First Face and recorded its orders.

“No,” Sava said.

“You haven’t read it.”

“I know what it is.”

“I’m not asking to fight.”

"You're asking to go with those who fight and turn what they do into history."

"Someone has to write the truth."

"Everyone says that before finding out who pays for their food."

Nemi turned her head face-on.

"You worked for the Chamber of Measure."

Sava felt the blow and, at the same time, pride that her daughter had found it.

"That's precisely why I know."

"Uncle Taren approved."

"Your uncle doesn't decide for you."

"You do?"

"Until you're an adult."

"In the lower chambers, people my age already have children."

"And half of them have ruined bodies before they're twenty."

"But they existed without asking permission."

Sava took the application. Beneath Taren's signature was a note: ARCHIVE ONLY, NO FRONT LINE. A precaution that reassured and infuriated her equally.

"A month's trial," she said. "You stay in Vaor."

After the trial month was approved, Nemi hugged her so quickly Sava had no time to prepare her posture. Then she left to receive her Memory cloak.

Sava remained alone in the office. From a drawer she took her old Chamber of Measure badge and Oru's green ribbon. One represented the institution that had given her the language of limits; the other, the man who had taught her that living systems did not respect limits merely because they were well calculated.

On the surface, the tower's inauguration gongs began to sound. The floor carried them down to the office. They were neither the three retreat beats nor the Face code. Daran had invented a new rhythm: one long beat, two short, one long. It meant **we stand and are seen**.

Sava put on Oru's cloak and went up.

CHAPTER XIV

THE CHARTER OF CONTINUITY

VESSA AND SAVA · VAOR · THE THIRD YEAR OF THE CONFLICT

The Charter of Continuity was presented as a temporary measure to coordinate the Houses. In practice, it turned crisis occupations into social ranks and momentary advantages into hereditary probabilities.

The tower hall still smelled of heated resin. The wall plates had not fully settled and cracked with every gust. The House representatives pretended not to hear. Admitting that a vertical building unsettled them would mean acknowledging that the old biology survived beneath the new armour.

Before the meeting, Sava visited the communal kitchen. Daran had turned the inauguration into a celebration, and delegates' portions were doubled. In the lower tunnels, the children's quota had been reduced by five per cent after the new recruits arrived. Sava ordered half the official meal sent to the clinics.

The tower administrator looked at her in horror.

"The master approved the menu."

"The Civil Office approves rations."

"The guests will notice."

"Exactly."

When the meals reached the hall, the representatives found smaller bowls and a note on Vaor's actual consumption. Daran read it, smiled and asked for the note to be preserved in the archive as an example of shared austerity. Sava understood again that he could turn any resistance into part of the spectacle.

In the new tower's hall, Daran had gathered representatives of seven Houses. The tables were arranged in a circle, but his chair stood on a

barely perceptibly higher platform. Each delegation had come with its own Face Corps, its own code and its own version of who had first invented the sign.

Taren stood beside the entrance, not beside Daran. Scars whitened his shoulder and thigh. He had worn armour so long that the down beneath the plates no longer grew evenly. Beside him, Vessa held a one-year-old child, Sen. The boy watched the crowd without moving his head in bursts and did not startle when the gong opened the meeting.

Vessa noticed. Sava noticed that she had noticed.

“The markers?” she asked quietly.

“He has five of Taren’s seven combinations,” Vessa replied.

“Did you select the embryo?”

“No. I left it.”

“That’s still a choice.”

Sen began crying at the second gong. He was not frightened by the sound; he was hungry. Vessa breastfed him while the delegates discussed who deserved reproductive rights. The gesture disturbed them more than the genetic maps. Biology present in the room, with the smell of milk and a child tugging at clothing, made abstractions harder to pronounce.

Daran opened the document.

On the platform, Daran was presenting the Charter of Continuity. The document divided the population into four functions: the Faces, who defended; the Hands, who produced; Memory, who administered and recorded; the Protected, who could not directly sustain the community. Each category had different rations, obligations and reproductive rights.

“You called children, the sick and the elderly ‘the Protected’,” Sava said when her turn came. “It sounds better than dependants.”

“Language’s role is to make reality habitable,” Daran replied.

“The Faces receive two birth rights. The Hands one. Memory one every two cycles. The Protected none without an exception.”

“Those who defend continuity must be able to continue it.”

“You select military obedience and call it biological merit.”

A House Tel representative struck the table.

“Our Faces die three times more often than growers. Without additional children, their lines disappear.”

“Perhaps an occupation demanding so many deaths shouldn't be passed on as a privilege,” Sava said.

Daran showed his chisel teeth in a controlled smile.

“Occupations aren't passed on. Useful properties are.”

“Let Vessa speak,” someone said. “She has the data.”

Every head turned towards the doctor.

Vessa put Sen in a carrier and projected genetic maps above the table.

“In twenty-seven months, members of the Face Corps have produced four times more children than the Belt average. Not only because of permits. Partner choice has changed. Families hide births to connect a line to a known fighter. Some Houses offer food for embryos selected by alarm-response markers.”

“Does it work?” the Tel representative asked.

“We don't know what ‘works’ means. A reduced reflex can come with impulsiveness, fragmented sleep, aggression between siblings and lower contextual empathy. You're selecting a package, not a virtue.”

“But it produces fighters.”

“Sometimes. It also produces criminals unafraid of punishment.”

Daran leaned forwards.

“Your recommendation?”

Vessa looked at Taren, then at the child.

“No embryo selection without a public register. No additional rights granted solely by status. Monitoring across three generations.”

“Three generations?” the Orm representative laughed. “Ivarra could attack us in three weeks.”

“Biology won't hurry for your politics.”

“Yes, it will,” Daran said. “Biology has always hurried when death became frequent.”

The discussion did not end with the vote. House Nur's representative, the only one to vote against alongside Sava, asked for an objection to be recorded: categories were to be reviewed annually, and no child could inherit rank before adult assessment. The amendment was formally accepted, then weakened by an annex allowing Houses to offer “early functional education”.

“You've just invented inheritance without naming it,” Sava said.

“We've invented training,” Daran replied.

“A child raised in a tower from the age of three won't have a choice equal to one raised in a workshop.”

“An engineer's child doesn't have the same choice as a musician's either. Families transmit skills.”

“And access.”

“Access is accumulated skill.”

Aven Sor, present as a civil observer, asked who would classify the population.

“Memory,” Daran replied.

Every gaze turned to Sava.

“No,” she said.

“Your office holds the registers.”

“Precisely. An institution distributing rations mustn't also decide the reproductive value of functions.”

“The Chamber of Measure decided both.”

“And the result is why we're here.”

In the end, the Charter created three commissions: one of the Faces, one of the Hands and one of Memory. Each had to approve reclassifications. The Protected had no commission of their own; their interests were presumed to be represented by everyone.

“That means no one,” Vessa said.

No one answered her.

• • •

The first consequences appeared before the electronic ink had settled. A woman named Rema came to the Civil Office with her nine-year-old son. The child had a deformity of the hind limbs and worked excellently with fine instruments. The Charter had classified him as Protected because he did not meet the production standard and could not enter the Corps.

“He was getting an apprenticeship permit in optical repairs,” Rema said. “Now the workshop says the places are for Hands.”

“He can be reclassified according to aptitude,” Sava replied.

“The Face commission requires a community-service test. He can't pass the running test.”

Sava called an official. He confirmed it: the form had been copied from military selection and applied to every category because it was the only standardised test available.

“He repairs lenses,” Sava said. “Why does he have to run?”

“For evacuation,” the official replied.

“During the attack in the square, those who ran killed thirty-six people.”

The official folded his sails, confused. The regulations contained no field for irony.

Sava approved the exception and, the following week, discovered eight hundred more. The Charter had been written to make the world legible in a crisis. Applied to life, every category produced edges people fell into.

Vessa brought her a separate list. Seventeen women had been pressured into bonds with Face officers in exchange for their families' reclassification.

"Pressured by whom?"

"Parents, administrators, sometimes their own partners. There is no written order."

"Then how do I punish it?"

"You can't. You can remove the reward."

"The Council won't revoke the additional rights."

"Then the reward will find bodies."

Sava looked at Sen, asleep on Vessa's arm.

"You let him carry Taren's markers."

"Yes."

"Aren't you afraid they'll make him exactly what the Charter wants?"

Vessa drew her child closer.

"I'm afraid that if I try to make him his father's opposite, I'll still be letting his father decide the shape of his life."

Within three months, the Charter descended from the council halls into everyday gestures. At first, the categories existed only in registers. Then depots demanded visible signs to distribute rations quickly. The Faces received a frontal clasp of matt metal; the Hands, a green knot at the wrist; Memory, a black slate; the Protected, nothing. Absence of a sign

was supposed to mean protection. In practice, it meant every official asked why the person in front of them belonged to no function.

Sava first noticed the change in the water queue. A young fighter arrived after an elderly woman and was called ahead because his patrol left in twenty minutes. The woman accepted without protest. When a second fighter did the same, she lowered her sails. At the third, she left without water.

“Why didn't you wait?” Sava asked her in the gallery.

“Because by the time my turn comes, the next patrol will already be urgent.”

“You have a right to a portion.”

“The right is the place at the back of the queue that no one sees.”

Sava ordered a separate emergency tank. The depot filled it from the general quota. The civilian queue became shorter and the portions smaller. Every correction moved privilege instead of eliminating it.

Schools adopted the Charter faster than the administration. Children were grouped for “functional orientation”: coordination, memory, endurance, manual precision. Teachers said it was not selection but discovery of aptitudes. In the playgrounds, games divided according to signs. Faces' children imitated patrols. Hands' children built the obstacles. Memory's children kept score. Those without a category were rescued, wounded or prisoners.

Rema's son, Arel, returned to the Office with a repaired lens. He had fitted an actuator so small Sava could barely see the joint.

“The workshop took me,” he said.

“Then why do you look upset?”

“The master says I can work, but the apprentices won't let me touch their tables. They say my exception doesn't change my category.”

Sava visited the workshop. The master showed her the admission document and insisted he had respected the decision.

“He gets the same lessons,” he said.

Yet Arel worked in a corner, at a lower table, with old tools. When he needed a part, he had to ask a Hands child to fetch it from the store. No one hit him. No one forbade him to learn. Yet the whole room explained to him, through distances and objects, that his presence was tolerated, not normal.

Sava ordered shared tables and equal access. The following week, six apprentices' parents withdrew their children, saying the workshop had lowered its standards. Daran published a message praising Arel's courage and the Hands' generosity. The child's image appeared on banners. His classmates began calling him **the Exception**.

Rema came to the Office again.

“Take him out of your story,” she said.

“I asked for his name not to be used.”

“They don't need a name. Everyone sees his legs.”

Sava sent an order withdrawing the images. Half had already been copied. Arel stayed at the workshop but stopped speaking during lessons.

Vessa opened a clinic without classification in an old transport gallery. On the door she wrote only: **the body before the function**. On the first day came seven Protected, three Hands hiding wounds to avoid losing shifts, and a Face officer who refused to enter until Vessa turned off the sign outside.

“I don't want to appear in the register with them,” he said.

Vessa examined the infection in his shoulder.

“The infection hasn't read the Charter.”

“My body has to stay fit.”

“Then tell it to stop producing pus for political reasons.”

The officer returned for four more days, each time without his frontal clasp. On the fifth, he brought the clinic medicines confiscated from smugglers. Vessa accepted them, then registered the donation anonymously. The new system made people generous and ashamed at the same time.

The reclassification commissions had stalled. Every case required approval from three functions working at different rhythms. The Faces responded quickly to military requests, the Hands to measurable skills, Memory demanded documents. After two months, there were four thousand appeals.

Sava turned a ceremonial hall into an appeals office. People slept in the queue. A grower asked to become a Hand after twenty years of work, but had no certification because his farm had been unregistered. A Memory woman wanted to relinquish her rank and enter the clinic; the commission feared her departure would set a precedent. Two brothers raised in the same alcove had received different categories, and their parents asked for one to be raised, not the other lowered.

“Everyone says they don't want privileges,” Aven told Sava one night. “They just want their disadvantage corrected. The sum of the corrections is privilege.”

“Then we change the structure, not the cases.”

“With what majority?”

The Faces would not surrender priority while the war continued. The Hands would not surrender access won after generations in which their work had been invisible. Memory considered itself the only barrier against abuse. The Protected still had no representation. Every group could describe its own advantage as historical redress.

In the bonding markets, change was faster and harder to measure. Families displayed their children's function beside age, health and lineage. A Face clasp attracted more invitations than a prosperous farm. Mothers said they sought safety, not rank. Fathers said they wanted

partners capable of protecting their grandchildren, not fighter grandchildren. In less than a year, preference became tradition.

One of the women on Vessa's list, Ina, came to the clinic after her family arranged a bond with an Orm commander. She had not been threatened. The commander was polite, healthy and could obtain her brother's reclassification.

"I don't hate him," Ina said. "That's the part that makes me unsure what's happening to me."

"Do you want him?"

"Sometimes. At other times, I want what comes around him. At least the Chamber told me I wasn't allowed. Now everyone tells me I'm choosing."

"You can refuse."

Ina looked towards the next room, where her brother waited for a prosthetics assessment.

"Can I refuse for him?"

Vessa had no treatment for a political question. She offered her time, contraception and a place to sleep. Two weeks later, Ina accepted the bond. Her brother was reclassified. When Sava tried to investigate, both declared the decision had been free.

Daran showed her the statements.

"You can't turn every choice you dislike into coercion."

"Nor every reward into freedom."

"Then define the line."

Sava could not. The Chamber of Measure had had precise thresholds and produced exact injustices. The Charter left choices apparently open and moved pressure into family, attraction, shame and the future. It was harder to condemn precisely because it worked through people's desires.

At the end of the third cycle of implementation, Daran presented the report: production had increased, recruitment had stabilised, theft had fallen and bonds between Houses had grown. In the graphs, the new order seemed to be healing the city.

Sava attached the appeals queue, clinic consultations and Ina's testimony to the report. The Council filed them under "transition costs".

Arel brought her a second repaired lens. This time he had engraved his initial inside, where only the technician taking it apart would see it.

"Why there?" Sava asked.

"So it can exist somewhere without being an example."

• • •

After the meeting, he found Daran on the tower platform, looking out over the Belt. From there, the cities' hidden entrances looked like small stains in the terrain. The sky pressed in from every side.

"You put my name on a law I didn't write," Taren said.

"Your name is the reason they accept it."

"Then ask me."

"I've asked you many times. You always answer as though power were dirt that had accidentally got on your hands."

"The Charter will create castes."

"Castes existed. The Chamber of Measure hid them in access, education and postponements. I give them visible obligations."

"And hereditary privileges."

"Only if their descendants remain useful."

Taren looked at the towers being built around them. Small nivari moved on scaffolds, black silhouettes against the red star.

"We made the First Face to protect food."

On the platform, the wind forced them to speak louder. Beneath them, Vaor was almost invisible: openings in rock, lines of condensation, tiny lights. The tower dominated a city that still lived in the ground.

"The Charter bears my name," Taren said. "People will think I approved it."

"People already think every victory belongs to you," Daran replied. "It's the price of being simple in a complicated world."

"I'm not simple."

"Not to yourself. To those below, you're the one who didn't run. Try to lead without using that, and you'll be led by those who use it better."

Taren looked at the enormous sign on the tower. It had been drawn after Raal's thieves' mark, adopted by Leth's young companions, legalised by Daran and now placed above a caste. No one had asked him for ownership of the symbol. Everyone demanded responsibility from him.

"What do you actually want?" he asked.

Daran leaned against the railing, a gesture no nivar raised in the capital would have made at ease.

"I want a world where Vaor no longer asks permission to continue. I want Houses strong enough to make Ivarra negotiate. I want children who aren't raised to consider survival an administrative favour."

"And you want to stand above them."

"Of course. Acknowledged ambition is safer than power that declares itself sacrifice."

A courier came up without waiting for permission. He had dried blood on his cloak and carried the seal of the Lur community.

The slate he held out contained two hundred and six identities.

CHAPTER XV

THE LAW OF THE FACE

NEMI AND TAREN · LUR · A FEW WEEKS LATER

At Lur, a Face Corps had used the Code's first two rules to justify a mass execution. The crime did not look like a return to barbarity, but like a new institution learning how easily it could carry its virtue on a weapon.

A courier climbed the stairs and handed Taren a slate. The message came from the community of Lur, on House Tel's border. The local Face Corps had entered to confiscate supplies and recruits. The inhabitants had surrendered. Two hundred and six had been executed anyway, accused of hiding weapons.

On the depot wall, the fighters had written the Code's first two rules: no killing after surrender; no pursuing those who flee.

Beneath them, they had lined up the dead people's heads.

"Tel says it's central propaganda," Daran said.

"Our Memory verified the images."

"Then we send a commission."

"I'm sending the First Face."

Daran looked at him sideways.

"The Corps don't belong to you."

"Does the Code belong to them less than to me?"

"If you go against the Council's decision, you'll turn a legal dispute into one between armies."

Taren lowered his armour's visor.

"That's what happens when you give laws blades."

By evening, six hundred fighters prepared to go with him to Lur.

Sava reached the eastern gate before the detachment left. Nemi wore Memory's black cloak and tried to look taller. The recording slate hung on her chest; the blade remained in her bag, as they had agreed.

"You said she'd stay in Vaor," Sava told Taren.

"I said archive only, no front line."

"Lur is the front line."

"Lur is afterwards."

"After two hundred and six deaths."

Nemi intervened:

"That's precisely why I have to go."

Sava looked at them both. In Taren she saw the brother she had raised and the commander she could no longer protect. In Nemi she saw the child brought out of smoke and a young woman who had learned that adults used protection to retain control.

"You send me a signal at every cycle change," she said. "You don't enter any unchecked building. If fighting starts, you leave with Memory, not Taren."

"Yes."

"Repeat it."

Nemi repeated it. Sava tightened her cloak straps, then touched the tip of her injured sail. The scar had grown with her and pulled its edge into a slightly asymmetrical angle.

"Don't let being able to look convince you that you have to see everything," she whispered.

"You taught me that what isn't seen ends up in the wrong field."

Taren gave the departure signal before Sava could find an answer.

The road to Lur passed through abandoned underground orchards. Traces of old grafts remained on the walls, and in some chambers the

roots had grown wild, forming white knots that pulsed slowly. The detachment advanced in groups of twelve. They did not sing. News of the massacre had done what Taren's orders had not always managed: it kept them disciplined through shame.

Nemi walked with three older archivists. One, Par, showed her how to record residual smells and projectile directions. Another told her not to film dead children's faces without their families' consent.

"Why?" she asked. "They're evidence."

"They were people before they became evidence."

It was the first Memory rule she liked without challenging it.

• • •

At Lur, the dead had been laid out carefully.

They did not lie where they had fallen. The bodies had been washed, arranged by family and covered in working cloaks. Someone had turned their heads towards the village entrance so that every lateral eye looked at the road along which the judges would come.

Nemi began recording before she was told. She counted two hundred and six bodies, thirty-one of them children. She filmed the empty depot, projectile marks on the walls and the two rules written above the heads. Then she stopped the slate and vomited into the irrigation ditch.

Taren found her there.

"You're going back to Vaor," he said.

"No."

"This isn't an archive for a child."

"That's precisely why it has to be made by someone who still sees what it is."

Taren looked towards the rows of dead. First Face members stood silently at the settlement's edge. House Tel's Corps had withdrawn to an

agricultural fortification three kilometres south and sent word that it had executed saboteurs under wartime conditions.

“Don't go near the fighting,” he said.

“Mother told me the same about the truth.”

“Your mother is right more often than anyone likes.”

Nemi cleaned her mouth and raised the slate.

Nemi returned to the bodies once her stomach settled. She counted again, this time by family. A surviving woman watched her. She had a burn wound on her arm and wore three children's bracelets round her neck.

“Have you come to make us important?” she asked.

“I've come to record.”

“It's the same thing once we're dead.”

“What's your name?”

“Iru. Don't put my name beside the dead. I'm still here.”

Nemi closed the automatic field that linked relatives. Iru showed her the depot. The inhabitants had indeed hidden food, not weapons. When the Tel Corps demanded supplies and twelve recruits, the village refused. A child had found an old projectile and kept it as a toy. It had not been fired. The commander had used it as evidence.

“Why did you write the rules on the wall?” Nemi asked.

“They wrote them,” Iru replied. “Before they began. They said whoever handed over their weapons would live. We handed over the only projectile.”

“And then?”

Iru touched her bracelets.

“Then they decided our smell was a weapon.”

Nemi recorded the sentence. She did not yet know whether it would end up in a report or a song. She understood only that the form in which she preserved it would change who could claim not to have known.

The Tel Corps commander was named Orven Tal, though his House and family used different spellings to claim greater antiquity. He was twenty-one, had three children and a deliberately made scar along his jaw. He had trained his fighters to look face-on even when unnecessary, so half of them seemed to suffer from neck pain.

He received Taren before the fortification with two hundred Faces in line.

“You have no jurisdiction in Tel,” Orven said.

“The Code does.”

“The Code is guidance, not law.”

“You wrote it on the dead people's wall.”

“To show they'd been judged before execution.”

“The children?”

Orven moved one sail.

“The families were hiding projectiles. We couldn't separate those responsible without risk.”

Taren felt the line behind him change. There was no sound, but a thousand limbs redistributed their weight to leap.

“Hand over those who gave the orders,” he said.

“I gave the orders.”

“Then come with us.”

Orven smiled.

“If you take me, House Tel attacks Vaor. If you kill me, every Corps will understand that the First Face is their master, not their model.”

“If I leave, everyone will understand the rules hold only while they cost nothing.”

“Now you sound like Daran.”

Taren did not answer. He raised his hand. The First Face drew its blades.

Orven raised his hand too. The Tel Corps did the same.

The root field between the lines was young. White tips emerged from the soil every half pace. Nemi thought of Oru. He would have seen at once how many cycles of food would be lost if fighting began. Taren and Orven each watched the other's body of fighters. The survivors watched the crop.

Nemi checked the recording she had found again. The sound was faint, obscured by the alarm, but Orven's voice remained clear. Par had told her not to leave the line. Sava had told her to leave if fighting began. Taren had told her not to approach.

Every instruction assumed the adults would recognise the right moment. She stepped out.

Nemi stepped out from among Memory's members.

“I have the recording of the order,” she said.

Orven turned towards her.

“What order?”

Nemi raised the slate. In the village depot, she had found a burnt communications node. Its local memory preserved a few seconds of sound: Orven's voice demanding “the cleansing of all bearers of Lur scent”, followed by a subordinate's question about children.

The answer was clear.

Leave no roots.

The Tel fighters listened twice. At the third playback, some lowered their weapons.

Orven did not deny it.

“The order was transmitted after a child triggered a projectile,” he said.

“No explosion can be heard,” Nemi replied.

“The recording is incomplete.”

“The dead are complete.”

Orven rushed at her.

Taren intercepted his leap. They collided in the air and fell between the lines. Orven drew a short blade from the sheath on his arm and cut towards Taren's abdomen. Taren twisted; the point opened his armour. He caught Orven's wrist and struck his knee with a hind limb. The bone gave way.

The Tel fighters did not attack. The recording kept repeating from the fallen slate: leave no roots.

Orven lay on the ground, breathing rapidly.

“I surrender,” he said.

Taren raised his blade.

The Code's first rule came to mind in his own voice: no killing after surrender.

Around them, two hundred and six bodies waited for a difference between surrender and escape.

“You'll be tried,” Taren said.

“By whom?”

After Orven surrendered, the Tel fighters were disarmed one by one. Taren allowed neither public humiliation nor marking them. Raal demanded the officers be bound facing forwards, backs to the walls, so they could not use their lateral field. Taren refused.

“Judgement isn't an exercise in fear.”

“For them it was,” Iru said.

Taren looked at her. The woman had the right to demand more than he could allow without turning the trial into revenge. That was the first difficulty of a real law: it had to limit precisely those whose suffering had made it necessary.

The tribunal assembled in the irrigation chamber, the only space large enough. The survivors sat on one side, the accused on the other, and water flowed through channels between them. There was no platform for the judge. Taren stood in the middle.

Aven Sor had come as a procedural witness. He demanded that the facts be separated: who issued the order, who repeated it, who fired, who tried to stop it. Lur wanted a single guilt. Aven divided it into hundreds of decisions.

A seventeen-year-old Tel fighter confessed to shooting two children. He was crying so hard he could barely speak.

“Orven said they carried Lur scent and that any root left behind would produce saboteurs.”

“Did you believe him?” Taren asked.

“I don't know. Everyone was firing.”

“Did you see weapons?”

“I saw someone running.”

Whole bodies tensed in the hall. For their ancestors, flight had been proof of danger. For the Tel Corps, it had become proof of guilt.

Iru demanded all their deaths. Par recorded the request without comment. Nemi watched Taren's hands. They trembled slightly. Not from fear, but from the effort to hold the Code, anger and the political usefulness of punishment in the same place.

The trial lasted until the lights had changed intensity twice.

The trial lasted until the change in orbital light. Lur had not had a tribunal for generations; conflicts had been settled through mediation and quotas. Nemi recorded the testimonies. Taren made every accused

person turn their whole body towards those speaking. From this came the Law of the Face's second meaning: not only to meet danger, but not to hide in profile when shown what you had done.

Orven and twelve officers were sentenced to death. Thirty-seven fighters who had carried out the orders received forced labour and the loss of rank rights. The rest of the Tel Corps was disarmed and sent home.

At artificial sunset, Orven was brought into the field.

"I surrendered," he told Taren.

"Yes."

"Then you're breaking the Code."

"The Code stops the fighting. It doesn't cancel judgement."

"That's a scribe's distinction."

"All laws are."

"When you lose, someone will use it against you."

"Then I hope there's a good recording."

In Memory's public version, the sentence occupied two paragraphs and a list of names. The hours that had produced it did not fit so easily.

Aven divided the accused into four groups. The first contained the officers who had planned the encirclement, written the rules on the wall and ordered the firing. The second, fighters who had fired after resistance had ended. The third, those who had guarded exits, carried ammunition or repeated orders without seeing the dead directly. In the last group were seventeen people who had refused, hidden children or deliberately left a gallery uncovered.

Lur wanted a single category. To the survivors, all had worn the same clasp and come in the same formation.

Iru struck the list with her palm.

"The one who kept the door closed didn't fire. The children still didn't get out."

“He'll be judged for what he did,” Aven replied.

“He was one of them.”

“Belonging cannot be a sentence.”

“For us it was.”

Water ran through the channels between the groups. From time to time, someone had to interrupt the testimony to clean the filters of ash brought in from the field. The tribunal had not been designed. It was held inside the infrastructure that had to keep feeding the very community trying to judge.

A Tel fighter named Saro admitted he had guarded the northern gallery. He was eighteen. When the firing began, a woman came out with two children. The order was to send them back. He let them pass, then reported that smoke had prevented them from seeing.

The woman was alive. She stood among the people of Lur and confirmed it. Iru looked at her as though survival were a betrayal of clarity.

“Then this one goes free?” she asked.

Aven replied:

“He took part in the occupation and guarded an exit. But he refused the order when he understood its consequence.”

“After coming with a weapon.”

“Yes.”

“How much good must you do inside a crime to stop being a criminal?”

No one had a number.

Taren sentenced those in the fourth group to repair Lur under civil authority, with the right to leave after a year if the survivors confirmed they had not broken the rules. It was not freedom, and it was not the same punishment as the others'. Iru voted against. The rescued woman voted for.

The cases of the young people who had fired under orders were the hardest. Some cried. Others repeated Orven's language: saboteurs, contamination, continuity of the House. A sixteen-year-old boy said he had seen no children, only running shapes.

Nemi played a recording. In it, his voice could be heard asking whether to fire. An officer answered: "If they're running, they've chosen." Then the boy fired.

"I didn't decide," he said after the playback.

"You pressed," Iru replied.

"I was told if I hesitated, the others would die."

Taren asked him:

"Did you think the shapes had weapons?"

"I don't know."

"Did you want to know?"

The boy began crying again. Taren did not stop him or offer words. Compassion could become a way for the judge to ease his own decision.

Aven proposed forced labour, loss of rank and a weapons ban. Iru demanded death. Tel's representatives warned that executing ordinary fighters would make the House a permanent enemy. Raal, standing at the entrance, said any punishment chosen for its effect on future allies was already political.

"All punishments are," Aven replied.

"Then don't call them justice."

"We call them law. Justice is what each side believes the law owes it."

Nemi recorded, but sometimes forgot to watch the battery level. She kept her eyes on Taren. He listened to every testimony face-on, according to the rule he had just created. After hours, his neck muscles trembled. Looking this way was unnatural for a nivar; the lateral field narrowed, and the body could no longer track exits. The Law of the Face

required them to sacrifice part of their safety to give attention. Nemi understood why the gesture could become moral. She also understood why it could become spectacle.

Deliberation took place in a separate room. Taren asked Iru, the rescued woman, a Tel representative, Aven and two Memory members to remain. No one represented the dead without an adult connection. Nemi added to the report that thirty-one children had no vote.

For every person to be sentenced, Aven read the act, the evidence and the alternative the person had had. The list of alternatives changed the room. Some officers could have stopped the attack. Some fighters could have fired into the air, left formation or opened an exit. For others, refusal would probably have meant being shot by their own commanders. Taren did not declare them innocent. But he refused to pretend everyone's freedom had been identical.

Orven did not ask for clemency. He asked for all officers to receive the same sentence as him.

"I gave the order," he said. "If you kill them separately, you turn discipline into guilt only when it loses."

"Discipline becomes guilt when it carries out a crime," Taren replied.

"Then your army will stop at every order to debate the world."

"I hope so."

Raal laughed from the doorway, without joy.

"Don't hope too hard. Armies that debate lose to those that don't."

"Then we have to win slowly enough to remain something else."

At the end, the verdict was read three times: once for the hall, once for the recording and once in the code of beats, for those who could not hear the voices. After every name condemned to death, the floor remained silent. There was no rhythm of approval.

The young man who had shot two children received forced labour. As he was taken out, Iru stood before him. The guards tried to stop her. She asked them to let her.

“Do you know their names?” she asked him.

The boy shook his head.

Iru told him the children's names, their ages, what food they hated and which one lied when afraid. She made him repeat them. At the second name, he vomited. At the third, his voice disappeared.

“You'll work here,” Iru said. “Every day, you'll know them. This isn't forgiveness.”

After the hall, Taren shut himself in a tool room with Aven. Nemi followed them to the door. From inside came only the water in the wall.

“Twelve sentences,” Aven said. “You can appoint an executioner.”

“No.”

“If you carry them out yourself, every death will increase your authority.”

“If I give them to others, I use their anger to keep my own hands clean.”

“There is no clean option.”

“Then I'll choose the one for which I answer.”

When he came out, Taren held the sentencing slate. His fingers trembled enough to make the text move.

Nemi asked him:

“Are you afraid?”

“Yes.”

“Of them?”

Taren looked towards the field where the execution was being prepared.

“Of how quickly the others will call this power.”

Orven's execution took place in the field, but Taren forbade a crowd. Present were those survivors who wished to attend, Tel's representatives, Memory and the doctor. Nemi held the slate. She could have framed only the condemned man and the blade, but widened the shot: the destroyed roots, Iru, the disarmed fighters, Taren.

Orven asked for water. Iru gave it to him. The gesture angered him more than refusal would have.

"Do you pity me?"

"No," she said. "I don't want your thirst to become the last thing your followers tell stories about."

After the sentence was carried out, Taren remained beside the body. He did not look at the slate.

"Did you record it?" he asked.

"Everything."

"Including the surrender?"

"Yes."

"Including the trial?"

"Yes."

"Then keep them together."

"So people can see you were right?"

Taren turned his head towards her.

"So they can say when I wasn't."

• • •

On the night after the trial, Lur did not celebrate. People buried their dead in the crop trenches, mixing ash with soil. First Face members helped without armour. Some Tel fighters sentenced to labour dug beside them. No one knew how to rebuild a community after the law had avenged it partially and too late.

Nemi entered the depot to copy the weapons inventory. A thermal cell's serial number had been unevenly erased. Three characters remained beneath the burnt layer.

She recognised them from Vaor's archive.

The Veyr armoury.

CHAPTER XVI

DARAN VEYR

TAREN · VAOR · AFTER RETURNING FROM LUR

The evidence found at Lur connected the Night gangs' weapons, the genetic museum key and the crisis's first provocations to House Veyr. The question was no longer whether Daran had manipulated events, but how much of the new order had been deliberately built.

Nemi found the evidence against Daran in the confiscated weapons inventory.

The Tel Corps projectiles had erased serial numbers, but one thermal cell retained its manufacturing signature. It had been made in the Veyr armoury three years before the storm. Two other batches had been transferred to a coded beneficiary. Nemi compared the code with the slate taken from Raal after the depot fight.

It was the same.

Raal studied the data for a long time.

“An intermediary gave us the weapons,” he said. “He asked us to hit depots and leave the sign. He said Daran would be forced to recognise the settlements if we became a big enough problem.”

“Did you know who was paying him?”

“I didn't ask. Hunger is a form of obedience.”

Nemi searched further. House Tel's archive contained an old access key to Ivarra's Genetic Museum, transmitted through the same intermediary. The identity used at its last activation was Reu Tal, the dead curator.

Raal asked for his confession not to be recorded. Nemi refused.

“Then I won't talk,” he said.

“You've already talked about the intermediary.”

“To Taren, not to history.”

They were in a small room in Lur. The slate lay on the table, its recording light visible. Taren stood beside the door.

“Turn it off,” he told Nemi.

“Why?”

“Because we need to know.”

“And the others don't?”

“They'll know after we can verify it.”

Nemi kept her eyes on him. It was the first time Taren had asked her to limit memory for an immediate advantage.

“If Daran dies before verification, who decides what Raal said?”

Raal gave a short laugh.

“Your archive child caught you.”

Taren approached the slate and switched it off himself.

“Speak. Then we'll repeat on the record what you can substantiate.”

Raal described the intermediary: a smell of preservative, a central accent, one sail cut at the tip. He had not seen his face. He had received projectiles, depot codes and the promise that attacks would force recognition of the communities. At first, he ordered thefts without casualties. After a guard refused the code, a gang member killed him. The intermediary paid extra.

“Why did you continue?” Nemi asked.

“Because after the first death, we could no longer go to Daran as victims. We had to become dangerous enough for him to negotiate.”

“And the sign?”

“He gave it to us drawn on masks. He said it meant we no longer turned our profiles towards those who erased us.”

The sign the First Face wore as an oath had been designed as an instrument of provocation. Raal saw the change on Taren's face.

"Symbols don't remain the property of whoever invents them," he said. "Otherwise Daran would still control everything we've become."

"Perhaps he does," Nemi replied. "Only from a distance."

• • •

In Vaor, Daran had learned before they arrived. He closed the gates and summoned his personal guards, but did not arrest the population or attack the Civil Office. He invited Sava to the tower.

Vessa insisted on coming with her and brought Sen. Daran received them in the council hall, without armour. Copies of the evidence lay on the table.

"Nemi is good," he said. "Better than many of Memory's adults."

"Where are my people?" Sava asked.

"The Office is functioning. Aven is there. This isn't a coup against the administration."

"Only against Taren."

"Against the void that follows if he comes here convinced truth gives him the right to destroy the only political structure we have."

Vessa held Sen tightly. The child watched the House sign on the wall.

"You released the saryx," she said.

"One specimen was supposed to be photographed in the reservoir. No child was supposed to be hurt."

"You brought predators into a city without a real evacuation plan."

"The plan existed. It had worked in ceremonies for four centuries."

Sava looked at him with disgust.

"You knew it didn't work. That was precisely the demonstration."

Daran did not deny it.

“Ivarra didn't respond to reports. It responded to fear. Vaor needed the centre to feel its own body vulnerable.”

“Thirty-seven dead.”

“How many slow deaths were avoided after the population was recognised? How many births received food? How many pipes are guarded now?”

“You can't subtract one corpse from another.”

“That's exactly what the Chamber did every day. I made the calculation visible.”

Sava approached the table.

“No. At least the Chamber pretended every loss was a problem. You chose actual people you didn't know and turned them into a cost.”

Daran turned his attention to Sen.

“This child exists because I made the cost impossible to ignore.”

Vessa bared her chisel teeth.

“Say that again and you'll learn Taren isn't the only one with a delayed reflex.”

For a moment, Daran seemed amused. Then fatigue surfaced.

“Taren will kill me,” he said.

“Perhaps he'll try you,” Sava replied.

“No. At Lur, he needed a trial to create law. Here, he needs my death to create succession.”

“You consider yourself too important.”

“Everyone who gets high enough becomes important through the consequences of their fall.”

He led them into a side apartment and closed the door. It was not a cell, but the guards stayed outside.

“I won't hurt you,” he said. “When he comes, you'll be proof I could still choose limits.”

Sava thought of all the rulers who chose their own evidence of morality.

The apartment had two beds, a table, hot water and a narrow window onto the surface. Daran had imprisoned them in comfort, allowing himself to consider the gesture moderate. Vessa checked the walls, air vents and food. She found no toxins. Only an external lock.

Sen wanted to touch the window. Vessa let him. The child pressed his palms against the cold material and watched the mineral snow carried by the wind. He did not understand that the tower was surrounded or that his father was climbing towards them. To him, captivity was a new room with light.

Sava sat on the floor. The generators' vibration came from beneath the bed. Their rhythm was slightly uneven: two equal pulses and one delayed. Oru would have identified the pump by sound. The thought came so naturally that for a moment she turned towards him.

“Daran wants Taren to kill him,” Vessa said.

“He wants whatever Taren does to confirm his story.”

“Then what should he do?”

“Arrest him, publish the evidence and leave it to a tribunal outside Vaor.”

“Which tribunal? Ivarra? The Houses Daran made powerful? Lur, which follows Taren?”

Sava did not answer. The law was clear only when an institution existed outside the conflict. Daran had spent years destroying precisely that outside.

Sen turned from the window and struck the floor with his heel. Once, then twice. It was the rhythm he used to call Taren home. Vessa picked him up.

“He can't hear you.”

The child repeated it.

A single answering beat came from the corridor.

Vessa turned towards the door. Sava raised her sails. A few seconds later, the lock opened and Daran entered alone. He wore no visible weapon. He carried an old archive box.

“It isn't Taren,” he told Sen.

The child looked at him, then struck the same rhythm again, as though the adult's identity could be corrected through persistence.

Daran put the box on the table. It contained the Chamber's replies to Vaor's requests: migration refusals, reduced quotas, birth warnings, reports describing famine as statistical deviation. Sava recognised some signatures. Two were hers.

“Did you keep them for the trial?” she asked.

“For the succession.”

“You imagine the files absolve you.”

“No. I imagine they explain how a person can come to consider thirty-seven deaths a lever.”

“Explanation isn't a limit.”

“Neither is condemnation.”

Daran took out an old report. Vaor had requested expanded birth rights after losing two crops. The Chamber had approved the relocation of forty thousand people, although there was no real place for them in the centre. Sava had worked on the model. She remembered the discussion as a capacity problem, not a sentence.

"I didn't call you here to make you guilty," Daran said. "Individual guilt is systems' favourite instrument. It lets you find a person, punish them and preserve the geometry."

"And you changed the geometry with corpses."

"I changed what the population admired."

Vessa tightened her arms around Sen.

"Say it plainly."

Daran sat. Without the stiff cloak and the hall, he looked smaller than his public image.

"Nivari survived because they fled together. Then we built a civilisation where anyone who didn't run at the signal was treated. Every community refusing redistribution was corrected. Every local ambition was absorbed into commissions. We called it peace, but it was also selection: for generations, we rewarded submission, caution, authorised fertility and the ability to endure a life without visible risk."

"And you decided to select the opposite," Sava said.

"I decided a society that can no longer produce people capable of staying will be administered into extinction by the first system claiming to know where the shelter is."

"You released predators to create heroes."

"I created a situation the ceremony pretended to represent. Taren already existed. Raal existed. Leth existed. I made the others see them."

"And those who died?"

Daran looked towards the window.

"They're the part no argument repairs."

For the first time, he did not immediately try to turn them into a useful cost. His silence was not sufficient remorse. But it was a crack.

"Then open the door," Vessa said. "Let us stop Taren before he kills you."

"If you stop him, the Houses will keep me here until the next crisis. If Ivarra tries me, I'll become Vaor's martyr. If Vaor tries me, every piece of evidence will be a vote on the Houses' future. There is no sentence left that doesn't build something."

"There is staying alive and answering," Sava said.

"To you, that's morality. To me, it's only another architecture of consequences."

He stood and pushed the box towards her.

"Publish everything. Your signatures too. My orders too. Don't let Taren receive a simple story."

"Why are you giving me the archive?"

"Because he'll win. And you're the only person in the room who loves him enough to make his victory difficult."

Daran stopped beside the door. Sen held out his hand, attracted by the metal clasp at his collar. Daran gave it to him. The child put it in his mouth.

Vessa immediately took it out.

"It isn't clean."

"Nothing in the tower is," Daran said.

After he left, Sava opened the box and began copying. She did not know whether she was carrying out his final strategy or limiting it. Often, resistance to Daran used exactly the tools he had placed within reach.

• • •

They returned to Vaor without flags.

The city gates were closed. On Daran's tower, the frontal sign had been replaced by House Veyr's emblem: three roots around a stone. The entrance guards belonged not to the First Face, but to Daran's personal agents.

"Sava and Vessa?" Taren asked.

“Safe,” the gate captain replied. “The master awaits you alone.”

Raal drew his blade.

Taren stopped him.

“If I haven't come out by the third change, open the gates.”

“How?”

“You've spent half your life entering places that didn't want you. I won't insult you with instructions.”

Daran waited at the tower's top. Beneath the open sky, the wind lifted his cloak. Three objects lay on the table: the genetic museum key, a thermal cell and the carbon rod with which Taren had killed the first saryx. Daran had recovered it from the capital's agents.

“Nemi is efficient,” he said. “Sava should be proud.”

“Where are they?”

“In the apartments. Unharmed. Sen is asleep.”

Taren put the evidence slate on the table.

“You released the creatures.”

“I authorised the transfer. My agent was supposed to leave them in the reservoirs beneath the square and send the evidence to the press after the Festival. A seal failed early.”

“Thirty-seven dead.”

“And eighty thousand lives recognised in Vaor. A demographic reform Ivarra had postponed for two generations. Sometimes a door opens only if something tries to eat it.”

Climbing the tower forced Taren to slow down. The old wound in his thigh hurt at every step, and wind came through openings not yet closed. On the fifth level, he found two Veyr guards. They laid down their weapons without a fight.

“Why aren't you stopping us?” he asked.

One avoided his frontal gaze.

“The master said the choice must seem yours.”

Daran had prepared even resistance through its absence.

On the platform, the carbon rod lay beside the key and the cell. Taren recognised it by the crack made by the saryx's jaw. The object had been cleaned, polished and mounted on a ceremonial stand. His first improvisation had become a relic before he turned twenty-one.

“I created the problem the Chamber refused to see.”

“You created Leth.”

“Leth created himself when he ran in a straight line.”

Taren struck him.

Daran fell across the table and laughed with blood on his chisel teeth.

“At last,” he said. “Without a speech.”

He rose and took a thermal needle from his sleeve. Taren dodged; the needle burned the edge of one sail. Daran fired again. He was no fighter, but had had years to study how Taren fought. He drove him towards the tower's edge, where the reflex to retreat from the void should have paralysed him.

Taren did not retreat.

He moved within the weapon's range. The needle pierced his shoulder. He caught Daran's hand and pulled him close.

“You were right about one thing,” he said. “The dead don't keep their reasons.”

Daran smiled.

“Then use them well.”

Taren threw him to the ground. He could have disarmed him. He could have tried him. He could have offered him the Law of the Face he had applied at Lur.

Daran reached for the second needle hidden at his ankle.

The fight was brief, yet Taren lived it in details. The needle's metallic smell. The tower's edge in his lateral field. Daran's foot slipping in blood. The smile after the first blow. Daran was not merely trying to win; he was trying to push him towards the exact gesture that made the new order inevitable.

When his hand reached the second needle, Taren could still have broken his wrist. He saw the option. He understood it. Then he broke his neck.

The sound was small. Daran's body relaxed at once, like any dead animal's. There was no justification in it, no ambition, no theory about lives saved. Taren remained with his hands on him and waited for a feeling of truth like the one in the square.

It did not come.

In its place came the silence of a mechanism that had lost its central part and did not yet know in which direction it would fall.

The wind moved the edge of the dead man's cloak. Taren detached the needle from his ankle and put it beside the first. Two small weapons, hidden in a body that had spoken all its life about structures. If he showed them to the crowd, the death would seem defensive. If he did not, opponents would call it an execution. Both were true, but one was more useful.

Nemi reached the platform first. Her slate was already recording. She looked at the body, the blood and Taren's hands.

"Don't stop," he said.

She had not stopped.

The Veyr guards came up in small groups. Some laid down their weapons. Others knelt beside Daran. No one tried to attack Taren. The absence of resistance frightened him more than the fight. Daran had told them what to do after his death, or had built them a world where the gesture came by itself.

The guard captain asked:

“Who gives orders now?”

Taren looked at Nemi. The question was already recorded.

“No one until the gates are open and the Council assembles.”

“Without an order, people will enter the tower.”

“Then block the stairs, not the city.”

“Under what authority?”

Taren almost said **mine**. The word formed before he could stop it. He replaced it.

“Under the construction safety rule.”

The captain accepted. The new age's first command hid inside a technical regulation.

In the council chamber, they found open registers and messages prepared for every outcome. If Daran killed Taren, the communiqué spoke of defending continuity. If Taren arrested him, House Veyr demanded a public trial. If he killed him, the message invited the Houses to recognise the First Face as military successor. Every version had seals, recipient lists and ceremonial texts.

“He wrote your speech too,” Nemi said.

A slate bore the sentence: **I did not seek power, but I will not flee its burden.**

Taren read it twice. It was exactly what he would have said.

“Delete it.”

“From the system or the archive?”

“From the system. Keep it in the archive.”

In the bottom drawer, they found unsent letters to Sava, reports on Sen, commanders' assessments and a map of the Houses marked by how quickly they would submit to a symbol. Daran had left no single plan.

He had left the possibility that whoever won would continue thinking in his categories.

Taren closed the drawer.

“Open the gates,” he said.

“I can publish all this now,” Nemi replied.

Below, the crowd was already beating his name. The sound rose through the tower's skeleton and reached their soles.

“If you publish now, they'll think I'm justifying his death.”

“If I wait, they'll think you chose what to show them.”

“Then write down the time. Write that I asked you to wait. Publish after the Council, whatever I say.”

Nemi entered the order. It was the first time her uncle had given Memory an instruction that could hurt him and insisted it remain visible.

Taren descended the stairs with Daran's blood on his hands. At every level, guards and Face members stepped aside. Some looked at him with gratitude. Others with fear. For all of them, the centre of power had already moved into his body before any law recognised it.

• • •

When the gates opened, no one knew whether Daran's agents had abandoned them or Raal had found the mechanism. The First Face entered without a fight. Sava came to the tower courtyard with Sen in her arms and Vessa beside her.

“Did you kill him?” she asked.

“Yes.”

“Had he surrendered?”

Taren looked at the body above.

“No.”

Nemi kept the slate running. She did not lower it.

Vaor's Council assembled before mid-cycle. The representatives of the Hands, Memory and the Corps asked Taren to take over the administration until a Veyr successor was chosen.

"I don't belong to the House," he said.

"That's why the other Houses want you," Raal replied.

"I don't want the tower."

Sava kept her eyes on him.

"Power isn't an object you can refuse after killing the person who held it."

Taren sat on Daran's platform.

Not because he wanted it. Because everyone else remained standing and waiting.

Raal struck the floor once.

"The First Face," he said.

The hall repeated the title. It no longer designated the unit. It designated the person.

Before the Council, Sava found him alone in a service room. Vessa was treating his shoulder wound, and Nemi stood in the doorway with the slate running.

"Did you have a choice?" Sava asked.

"Yes."

The answer stopped her. She had expected an explanation, the hidden needle, the threat to them.

"And you chose to kill him."

"Yes."

"Why?"

Taren looked towards Nemi. The slate's light was recording him.

“Because he was going to fire again. Because I hated him. Because a trial would have divided Vaor. Because part of me knew the hall below would follow me afterwards.”

Nemi did not lower the device. Vessa tightened the bandage.

“Is this the statement?” Sava asked.

“It's what I can say without turning one cause into the convenient story.”

“Daran would have made you leader even if you arrested him.”

“I know.”

“Then his death doesn't free you from what he built.”

“I know.”

Sava sat. For a moment, they were again the two children after the tunnel collapse: she trying to decide what came next, he watching the fire too long.

“When you enter that hall,” she said, “don't say you don't want power. It's exactly the sentence Daran prepared for you.”

“What should I say?”

“That you took it. That it can be taken from you. And build something that makes that possible before you begin believing only you can hold the whole world together.”

Taren looked at the bandage, then at the Face sign on his cloak.

“Will you help me?”

“I'll obstruct you.”

“That's not the same thing.”

“In healthy government, it should come close.”

In the Council hall, when the title First Face was repeated, Taren sat on the platform.

This time he said:

“I accept leadership of Vaor until we establish under what law you can remove me.”

The crowd struck the floor. Few heard the second half.

PART IV

THE SKY WITHOUT A CEILING

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CHAPTER XVII

THE WHITE WINTER

SAVA AND SEN · VAOR · SIX YEARS AFTER DARAN'S DEATH

The White Winter came not from climate, but from administration. The orbital mirrors were moved so little that every order seemed technical; after a few months, thousands of families walked east with the ice behind them.

Six years after Daran's death, the light moved.

It did not go out abruptly. The orbital mirrors changed angle by fractions so small that only instruments noticed at first. The Belt's fertile band slid east. Ivarra and the loyal domains received nine more minutes of light each cycle. Vaor, Lur, Orm and the settlements without a House each lost two.

After a month, the soil cooled.

After two, the agricultural bacteria slowed.

After three, the Night's ice entered the first pipes.

Seln Aru called the phenomenon an orbital safety correction. The Great Hearing published models showing instability in the mirror swarm and advised western populations to redistribute temporarily towards the centre. No one uttered the word punishment.

In Vaor, snow covered the bases of the towers.

In Taren's first year of leadership, the position of First Face had been provisional. In the second, the Council renewed it because of local wars. In the third, the Houses requested a five-year mandate to provide "strategic continuity". Taren accepted after Sava imposed a formal right of removal by three-fifths of the functions. No removal vote had been initiated. The Faces considered him indispensable, the Hands feared the

chaos of succession, Memory needed access to military archives, and the Protected had only just formed their representation.

Power had not become hereditary. Time, institutions and fear had simply arranged themselves so the alternative seemed ever more expensive.

Taren no longer lived in Daran's tower. He had turned the upper platform into a coordination hall and slept in a low room beneath the barracks, without windows. Vessa said it was his way of rejecting the symbol while retaining all its commands.

“If you want to prove you aren't the tower's master, move the Council into the workshop,” she had told him.

“The map doesn't fit there.”

“The map fits anywhere. The commanders don't want to sit on the floor beside workers.”

Taren moved two meetings. At the third, the Houses came with their own chairs and guards. A month later, the Council returned to the tower. The six years had not been quiet. They had merely become organised enough for violence to receive meetings, budgets and deadlines.

In the first year, Sava tried to use the right of removal. Taren had confiscated two House Tel shipments after it refused to send food to a community without a House. The confiscation saved the community's crop and violated the Charter's procedure. Sava requested a vote not because she wanted to remove him, but because an unused rule was not a limit.

The Council met in the workshop at Taren's insistence. The Faces came in armour. The Hands came straight from their shift and smelled of nutrient. Memory projected the complete order. For the first time, the Protected had sent three representatives, one of them Rema, Arel's mother.

“If we remove him, who leads the patrols?” House Orm asked.

“Someone else,” Sava replied.

“Name them.”

There was no name the Houses could agree on. The vote obtained fifty-nine per cent, one point below the threshold. Taren remained.

That evening, the channels announced that the First Face had won a confidence vote. Sava demanded a correction: it had been a failed removal attempt. The correction appeared under the headline “Leadership accepts democratic oversight”. The mechanism meant to show Taren could be removed had demonstrated to the public exactly how hard it was.

“Did you vote against me?” he asked her.

“Yes.”

“Did you think I should go?”

“I thought the possibility had to be real.”

“And if it had succeeded?”

“Then we'd have learned whether we'd built institutions or only dependence.”

Taren did not get angry. That worried her more. He had begun to receive Sava's opposition as proof of his own tolerance.

In the second year, the community of Hes asked to become a House. The refugees no longer wanted to depend on the old families' votes and believed a name would give them land, a Council seat and the right to a Corps. Sava opposed it. Daran was dead, but his model reproduced without him.

“We don't want old blood,” said the woman who had led the agricultural restoration. “We'll elect leadership for five years.”

“And after five?”

“We elect again.”

She was the first leader. The second election never took place: as the term approached, Hes's border was attacked, and the Council extended

the mandate for continuity. Her daughter led the defence. The families preferred her as successor because she knew her mother's codes and had been present at negotiations. No one declared the position hereditary. Every practical reason simply settled in the same family.

In the third year, Sen turned four and received his first public assessment. Vessa had refused the neural testing required of Faces' children. Daran no longer existed, but military clinics had kept the protocol. Parents wanted it because good results opened command schools.

“Don't I want to know whether he has Taren's reflex?” Sava asked her.

“I want to know when he's ill,” Vessa replied. “I don't want every peculiarity to become an invitation to a function.”

“If he has it, it'll be noticed anyway.”

“Then at least let him be noticed as a person before being measured as an inheritance.”

At the children's ceremony, Sen did not startle when a gong accidentally fell. The crowd fell silent, then began striking the floor. The child was frightened by their reaction and began to cry. In the images distributed later, the crying had been cut. Only the boy standing still before the sound remained.

Other parents began requesting partners from families with “frontal stability”. The term was not medical. It included lack of flight, robust jaws, rapid healing, fertility and the presence of a relative in the Corps. Vessa published a report showing the markers were weak, contextual and mixed with nutrition. Bonding messages cited the report as proof that stability was “multifactorial” and should therefore be pursued through family rather than a single test.

In the fourth year, the Festival of Retreat was held in Vaor too. Daran had informally banned it, calling it a ritual of central submission. Taren brought it back to show the old peace need not be erased. Children were to recognise the shadow, retreat in order and return after the signal.

At the first rehearsal, half stayed in the circle. Not because they felt no alarm, but because leaving in front of their classmates had become shameful. The instructors praised those who had obeyed the rule. The spectators photographed those who stayed.

Nemi recorded both reactions. In her report, she wrote that the ritual had reversed: retreat remained the official instruction, but staying had become social capital.

Taren asked to be the first to retreat at the next rehearsal. When the shadow came, he took a step back. The children followed him. The channels broadcast the scene under the headline “The First Face leads the retreat too”. Even the gesture meant to diminish the myth strengthened his centrality.

In the fifth year, Arel completed the towers' optical system. The child once classified as Protected had become Vaor's best lens technician. His devices could detect storms, pipe cracks and movement at the frontier. The Faces demanded priority over the images. Arel refused.

“A lens doesn't know which body is the enemy,” he said.

The Council decided on shared access, except in “situations of imminent threat”. In the first month, there were seventeen situations. Arel began introducing technical delays, small enough for civilians to receive the data before officers could shut it down. Memory praised his transparency. The Faces had already recruited him as a consultant. Rema told Sava:

“You managed to get him out of the Protected category. Now he's a Hand important enough that everyone wants to use his eyes.”

In the sixth year, the change could be seen in children's bodies. It was not a sudden mutation. Those from Face families ate better in their early years, received prompt treatment, trained early and chose partners from the same circles. On average, they had denser hind limbs, shorter sails because of ritual cutting and fewer group dispersal responses.

Vessa presented the data to the Council.

“You haven't created a new species,” she said. “You've created an environment that makes certain bodies more likely, then uses the result as proof the rank was natural.”

An Orm commander replied that the differences demonstrated the effectiveness of Face education.

“Exactly,” Vessa said. “And when education, food, partners and function circulate in the same families, the word *education* becomes a polite way of saying heredity.”

Taren again rejected the proposal to grant Faces' sons and daughters automatic rank. That same week, he attended their initiation ceremony and gave each a clasp made from the metal of weapons from Deaf Lake. The objects conferred no legal rank. They offered recognition, networks and a shared story—things from which rank could later be obtained.

Sava confronted him after the ceremony.

“You say no to inheritance and give it a ritual.”

“They're the children of people who died with me.”

“That's exactly why the privilege will seem like a debt.”

“What do you want me to do? Tell them their parents mean nothing?”

“Tell them they mean something without meaning more than everyone else.”

Taren looked at the clasps the children already wore frontally.

“I don't know how.”

It was an honest answer. It was not a solution.

When the light began to move, the new order had laws against heredity, rituals preparing it, markets rewarding it and bodies in which differences were becoming visible. Winter did not invent the categories. It merely forced them to decide who ate first.

Winter made all these distinctions seem small. When the outer pipes began freezing, offices moved towards the warm chambers. When farms

lost light, the Charter was used not for rank but for the order in which people received food. The old words revealed their core: the Faces, the Hands, Memory, the Protected. Every title became a position at the depot.

• • •

Sen was seven and could already evade Raal three blows out of ten.

The boy had grown tall, with unusually broad shoulders and shorter-than-average auditory sails. Vessa refused to say whether the difference was hereditary or the result of fighters trimming children's fragile tips before training. Sen did not startle at alarms. He startled when Taren spoke too calmly.

One morning, Sava found him in the food depot dividing rations with First Face members.

"Why aren't you studying?" she asked.

"Raal says numbers are learned better when someone dies if you get them wrong."

"Raal says many things that sound profound only because he's lost half his teeth."

Sen smiled. His front chisel teeth were thick and regular, selected not in a laboratory but through the long series of choices that had brought his parents together.

"Nemi says I have to record the difference between stock and distribution."

Nemi was fourteen standard years old and already led the Memory Corps. She wore three data slates at her belt and had been to the front line twice, despite every promise made to Sava.

She entered the depot with snow on her cloak.

"The Orm domain has closed its border," she said. "It's no longer taking Protected from the west."

Sava felt her old revulsion at the word.

“They're refugees, not Protected.”

“In the ration tables, they're Protected.”

“The tables mustn't enter the language.”

“Language enters the tables anyway.”

Sen resembled Taren only to those looking from a distance. Close up, he spoke faster, was more easily provoked and far more attentive to approval. Taren had endured years of isolation before his defect became a virtue; Sen had grown up surrounded by adults searching for signs of that virtue. Every absence of fear was praised. Every cruelty could be interpreted as firmness until Vessa intervened.

In the depot, the boy calculated portions precisely. He knew how many calories a fighter lost on patrol, how much energy lactation required and why small children could not receive the same concentrated food as adults. When he saw the refugee column on the map, he did not ask who they were. He asked what they consumed.

Sava recognised in him not only the Face's selection, but her own administrative education.

The first refugees arrived that evening. They came from a community called Hes, two hundred kilometres west. Their bodies were wrapped in insulating cloth, and the edges of their sails bore white frostbite lesions. A woman dragged a sled carrying two children and an old man. At Vaor's entrance, the official asked her classification.

“Grower,” the woman replied.

“Does the farm exist?”

“No.”

“Then the skill must be reassessed. Temporarily, Protected.”

The woman looked at the children.

“I fed six hundred people before the light left.”

“We aren't disputing your skill. The field requires your current function.”

Sava took the terminal from the official's hand and wrote: HANDS — AGRICULTURAL RESTORATION.

“We have no restoration programme,” he whispered.

“We do now.”

“On what land?”

“We'll find it.”

For three days, Sava created functions for people the system considered a burden. Restorers, carers, ice cartographers, seed recoverers. Some jobs were real. Others were names given to survival so it could receive a ration without humiliation. Daran would have admired the manoeuvre. The thought irritated her.

Nemi organised the refugees' testimonies. Every community described the same change in light, but at slightly different times. When she overlaid the data, the resulting edge was too precise for a malfunction. The mirrors had been oriented to keep loyal cities inside the band and let those associated with the Confederation slide towards the cold.

“Seln isn't striking us,” she said. “He's cutting the world around us.”

“He has a technical argument too,” Sava replied. “Our transport is no longer safe, and he's concentrating production where he can distribute it.”

“Are you defending him?”

“I'm trying to understand how he justifies each step. Otherwise we'll describe him as evil and be surprised by the reasonable people who follow him.”

Nemi closed the map.

“Sometimes understanding is a form of delay.”

“And haste is how you end up calling every body in front of you an enemy.”

Her daughter turned her profile, signalling the discussion was over. Sava noticed how much body language had changed. Nemi's generation used the face for confrontation and the profile for deliberate withdrawal. Gestures thousands of years old had acquired political meanings in less than a decade.

“We don't have food for them,” Sava said.

“We do if we reduce the Faces' portions.”

Sen stopped writing.

“The patrols are freezing outside,” he said.

“I know.”

“If they eat less, they'll die.”

“If the refugees don't eat, they'll die.”

The boy looked at the shelves, as though there were an arithmetic hidden in the wood.

“Who decides?”

“Your father,” Nemi said.

Taren decided to reduce everyone's portions by eight per cent and open the military reserves. The commanders protested. Three threatened to withdraw their Corps to their own domains. Taren let them leave and confiscated their transports before they got out of Vaor.

“You violated the Charter,” Sava told him.

“The Charter didn't anticipate winter.”

“No law anticipates the next excuse.”

“Would Oru have let the children die to preserve an article?”

Sava struck him with her gaze.

“Don't use him.”

Taren lowered his head.

“You're right.”

Taren opened the military reserves that day, but the gesture solved only a week. The Face commanders did not object solely from selfishness. Patrols spent hours in the cold, escorted convoys and defended pipes attacked by Houses closing their borders. With reduced portions, reactions slowed and wounds healed poorly.

Sava proposed rotation: half the patrols would return to civilian work, and fit civilians would do short service. The Faces protested that their training could not be replaced.

“Neither can food,” she said.

Raal supported the proposal. He had understood before the others that a caste becomes permanent when it alone possesses the skill to exercise violence. In the Night camps, every adult had guarded, stolen and repaired as needed.

“Teach the Hands to hold a weapon,” he told the officers. “Otherwise one day they'll hold one only against you.”

Taren approved the programme. In practice, commanders sent their weakest people on rotation and kept the good fighters. The Hands received minimal training and were stationed at secondary gates. The institution absorbed the reform without losing its shape.

Sava began to understand there was no single day on which a revolution became a regime. There were hundreds of small adjustments through which every new rule became useful to someone.

• • •

The edge hunters Oru had released six years earlier had survived. Sterilisation worked, but the individuals lived longer than the models predicted and had learned to follow warm pipes. They kept the glassback herds under control and had attacked only two nivari, both after attempts

to catch them for training. In Vaor, they had become sacred animals to engineers and ritual targets for young Faces.

Taren had forbidden hunting them. Sen had broken the ban.

Vessa brought him into the council hall, holding him by the nape. Claw marks showed on his arm, and she threw a necklace made of a hunter's teeth onto the floor.

"He killed it with four other children," she said.

Taren looked at the necklace.

"Why?"

Sen kept his body face-on, according to the Law.

"To see who stays."

"Stays where?"

"Beside it when it attacks."

"Who told you to do that?"

"No one. Everyone does it."

Vessa projected data from the nine Houses' schools. Chase games, once based on flight and hiding, had turned into confrontations with animals, falls from heights and group fights. Faces' children had three times as many injuries and twice the mortality. Those who survived received rank early, partners early and more birth rights.

"We no longer select only in clinics," she said. "We select in courtyards, songs and mating rooms. Those who avoid the games are called soft. The soft get Hands or Memory. The Faces breed among themselves."

"You warned about this," Taren said.

"I thought the warning absolved me while I gave birth to your son."

Sen shifted his gaze between them.

"Did I do something bad?"

Taren picked up the necklace.

“You killed something useful to prove you could kill.”

“You killed the saryx.”

“The saryx was attacking a child.”

“The hunter attacked me.”

“After you cornered it.”

Sen thought. He did not look ashamed, only attentive.

“Then next time I’ll let it choose the place.”

Vessa closed her eyes.

Taren broke the necklace and placed the teeth on the table, one by one.

“There won’t be a next time.”

“For me or for the hunter?”

The hunter Sen killed was named Arh, after the marking on its transmitter. Oru had released it as a cub. For six years, the animal had followed herds, brought nutrients into the soil and learned to avoid settlements. The engineers knew its routes. Some left food scraps at the edges of fields, although Oru had forbidden accustoming it to the smell of nivari.

When Vessa put the necklace on the table, two engineers were also in the room. One burst into tears.

“Arh held sector four,” he said. “Without him, the herd will enter the winter crops.”

Sen looked at him, puzzled by such intense grief for an animal.

“We can take another out of the reservoir.”

“It isn’t a part,” the engineer replied.

“My father says the function matters more than the story.”

Taren closed his eyes for a moment. He did not remember saying exactly that. But he recognised the logic.

“Your father is sometimes wrong,” he said.

“When?”

“Now, if he made you think a living thing can be replaced simply because another can take over its function.”

Sen looked at the necklace. Shame finally appeared, but not because of the death. Because his father was judging him in front of others.

Vessa noticed and sent the child out. Once he was beyond the door, she turned to Taren.

“You talk to him as if he were a commander.”

“He came to the council hall with a useful animal's teeth.”

“He's seven.”

“At seven, I was already entering alarm therapy.”

“That's exactly why you should know what a diagnosis made too early does.”

“I didn't diagnose him.”

“You're correcting him before the institution waiting to inherit him.”

Taren looked towards the door.

“What do you want me to do?”

“Be a father before you're a precedent.”

That evening, Taren took Sen to the field where Arh had died. They wore no armour. Traces of the fight remained in the snow: black stains, down, the children's footprints. Taren showed him the pipe the hunter had protected through its presence.

“You'll work here until the herd stabilises,” he said.

“As punishment?”

“So you can see what you took out of the world.”

“For how long?”

“Until you can explain without talking about yourself.”

Sen pulled his cloak tight.

“Raal says those who die get their reasons from the living.”

“Raal is right.”

“Then I can give him a good one.”

“No. You can repair part of the consequence. Arh's reason was to live.”

The child stayed silent. In the distance, glassbacks moved towards the undefended crop.

Winter deepened. House Orm attacked a refugee convoy for its thermal batteries. The First Face intervened and occupied two of its cities. House Tel split into three factions. In the south, communities that had never seen a central agent raised towers and appointed their own commanders in Taren's image.

Every victory against Ivarra produced two local wars.

“Seln doesn't have to defeat us,” Nemi said at a meeting. “He only has to keep us cold enough to eat one another.”

She projected the orbital swarm map. Primary control lay beneath Ivarra, but four secondary stations could take over the mirrors if they received the Great Hearing's consensus keys. One had been built directly beneath the Gardens of Kinship.

“The Houses' families are still there,” Sava said. “Guarded.”

“And connected to the old network. Every House had emergency access before Seln suspended it.”

“You propose using hostages as an entry point.”

“I propose getting them out and going in at the same time.”

Taren studied the map.

“Ivarra has two hundred thousand inhabitants in its central levels. A siege will kill them before we reach control.”

“Then we don't besiege it yet,” Nemi said. “We send someone Seln will receive.”

Every gaze turned to Sava.

“No,” Taren said.

Sava almost smiled.

“Power has made you forget how little you can order me to do.”

“Seln will use you.”

“He's done that since my first day working for the Chamber. The difference is that now I know.”

“He could detain you.”

“Then Nemi will have access to someone inside.”

Taren struck the table with his palm.

“I'm not sending you both.”

Nemi turned her body face-on.

“You aren't sending us. You're opening a road for us.”

Sava saw in her gesture not only Taren's influence but a new cultural anatomy. Her daughter no longer offered her face as threat or love. She offered it as a right to participate in danger.

After the meeting, Sava found Taren alone. Ivarra's map remained projected above the table. The entrances, the mirror stations, the Gardens of Kinship. It was the map of the city where they had grown up and, now, of a target.

“Do you really want to go?” he asked.

“No.”

“Then don't.”

“That's the difference between desire and decision. You should know it.”

Taren ran his fingers over the scar on his shoulder.

“Seln respects you enough to use you well.”

“And I know him well enough to notice.”

“If he detains you, I'm coming for you.”

“If you come only for me, you'll turn the negotiation into a real hostage situation. I'm going for light, for the families and for access. Nemi is going for the archive.”

“Nemi is fourteen.”

“You were eighteen when he sent you to Vaor.”

“Exactly.”

Sava looked at him. Despite the title, scars and army, he still kept the expression of the boy who asked why a simple instruction had to be followed.

“I can't keep her a child by refusing every risk,” she said. “The Chamber tried that with you and produced the exact opposite.”

“Perhaps it produced something we still don't understand.”

“All parents discover that too late.”

The next day, she sent the offer. Seln answered immediately.

CHAPTER XVIII

THE CITY THAT REPAIRS ITS TRACES

SAVA · IVARRA · DURING THE WHITE WINTER

Ivarra did not look like a city that had won a war. It looked like a city where war had been removed from the field of vision and turned into graphs, discreet checks and sufficient light.

The next day, Sava sent Ivarra an offer to negotiate.

Seln answered personally after a minute.

“The Chamber of Measure always welcomes its former officials,” he said. “Even when they come with an army behind them.”

“I’m coming with a list of the dead.”

“You all come with lists. The difference between administration and revenge is what we do with them.”

“I want the light restored, the families released and local registers recognised.”

“I want the Corps disarmed, Taren surrendered and a return to the rotation of Houses.”

“Then we have enough impossible things for a serious conversation.”

Seln folded one sail.

“Bring Nemi. Our archives on Lur are incomplete.”

Sava did not ask how he knew her daughter intended to come.

Before departure, Taren gave her the repaired carbon rod, the weapon with which he had killed the first saryx.

“I can’t take it through the capital’s checks,” Sava said.

“It isn't for fighting. Daran's museum key is inside. Nemi can use it on the old network.”

Sava took the rod.

“Daran started everything with that key.”

“Then perhaps it can open something else too.”

The train to Ivarra departed through snow. From the platform, Sen watched them with Vessa. When the carriages disappeared, the child struck the floor three times.

It was neither alarm, attack nor retreat.

It was the new generation's way of saying come back.

On the train, Nemi did not sleep. She read the Gardens' old archives and Oru's infrastructure plans. Her father's map was incomplete, annotated in engineers' language: **the root breathes badly here**; **do not close both valves**; **useless sensor, but they'll keep it because it's in the budget**. Amid the technical jokes was a network of abandoned routes running beneath the capital.

Sava sat by the window as the train climbed to the surface. Winter could be seen behind them, a white band wider than when they had left. To the east, the central crops were still green. The line between famine and normality was a few dozen kilometres and an orbital decision.

“Do you hate Seln?” Nemi asked.

“Sometimes.”

“You don't look it.”

“Hatred is easy when the person in front of you can't answer coherently. Seln can.”

“Does that make him less guilty?”

“It makes him more dangerous. And harder to replace with something better.”

Nemi closed the map.

“Taren can replace him.”

Sava looked at her daughter.

“Taren can win control. That's not the same thing.”

“Then who?”

“Perhaps no one alone.”

“In a crisis, groups are slow.”

“That's the sentence every personal power begins with.”

Nemi turned her profile towards the window. Sava recognised Taren's voice in some answers and her own in others. Children inherited more than genes. They inherited arguments and used them without remembering the source.

• • •

Ivarra was still beautiful.

That was the first betrayal Sava felt when she left the train. She had expected a starving, armed city emptied of truth. She found clean squares, children going to school, warm pipes and shops displaying sweet roots without guards. The Festival of Retreat's cloths had been replaced. Their shadows crossed the Low Square again every cycle, and tourists stopped beside a discreet plaque dedicated to “the victims of the biological incident of the year 412”.

Taren's name did not appear.

Nor Oru's.

“It looks as if nothing happened,” Nemi said.

“That's one of the things peace does well.”

“Repair?”

“Make repair resemble innocence.”

In the Low Square, the memorial plaque was so discreet Nemi walked past it. Sava stopped. The text listed the number of victims, not their

names. “Biological incident” had been chosen after three commissions and two public consultations. The term avoided both “attack”, which implied intention, and “accident”, which the families had rejected.

A few steps away, children rehearsed the Festival. The instructor triggered the mechanical shadows, and the circles retreated in order. After the attack, routes had been widened, marker seven moved and railings replaced. The system had learned exactly the physical lessons. There was no test in the programme for what to do when the signal was wrong.

Nemi sat where the saryx had fallen.

“This is where Taren told me not to run.”

“Yes.”

“I remember the smell. Not Oru's face in the burning room, but the smell of the animal here.”

Sava knelt beside her. They had not spoken so directly about the memory of that day before.

“The brain keeps what it thinks can save it next time.”

“It didn't save me from the mist.”

“There isn't one memory for every danger.”

Nemi touched the floor.

“The city only remembered how to make better railings.”

“Cities remember through what they can change without acknowledging their guilt.”

An instructor asked them to leave the route. He had not recognised them. Sava stood and left without telling him who she was. For a few minutes, Ivarra had offered them the anonymity of a life that could have continued here.

They passed their old home. The door bore another family name. Through the thin wall came the smell of soup, arguing and laughter. Nemi wanted to knock. Sava stopped her.

“The home doesn't owe us remaining empty.”

“I don't want to go in. I want to listen.”

They stayed in the gallery until the family inside turned off the light. For a moment, Sava heard Oru's voice in a man explaining to a child why a pipe creaked. There was no real resemblance. It was the mind's need to repair the traces.

They did not immediately return to the route towards the Chamber. Nemi said she was hungry, and Sava understood she meant more than food. They entered a neighbourhood canteen they had frequented before Vaor. The ceiling had been rebuilt in pale root, the tables were farther apart, and a message on the wall pulsed about saving light in solidarity with the western regions.

The menu had three hot dishes.

In Vaor, the evening ration had become a bitter paste divided according to the Charter of Continuity. Here, people complained that sweet root had been replaced by a more fibrous variety. Nemi looked at the trays without hiding her anger.

“Don't look at them as though every bowl moved the mirror,” Sava said.

“Every bowl shows who was left beneath it.”

“The people here don't control the swarm.”

“They accept it.”

“And Vaor's inhabitants accept many things they can't change.”

Nemi took only soup. At the next table, two officials discussed the “western redistribution crisis” and the risk that refugees would overburden the capital's schools. They did not speak cruelly. One proposed additional housing, the other tax reductions for host families. Their language was caring and entirely detached from the cold.

A man at the counter recognised Sava. His name was Rin Aro, and for years he had sold spices beside the Low Square entrance. Now he ran the canteen. One sail had been cut in half, and a scar lay beneath his left eye.

“The Chamber said you'd died,” he said.

“The Chamber no longer knows much about me.”

Rin looked at Nemi's black cloak.

“You're the girl with the recordings from Lur.”

“I'm Nemi.”

“My son was an agent at Deaf Lake.”

The canteen's ordinary sounds continued: spoons, water, a child scolded for beating the table too hard. Nemi put down her bowl.

“What was his name?”

“Rel Aro. In your archive, he's number two hundred and eleven, central flanking unit.”

Nemi opened the slate. Rel had been twenty. He died when the ice collapsed beneath his formation. The report said only “loss in hostile manoeuvre”.

“I can add his name to the public index,” she said.

“His name was already recorded. I want to know whether he ran.”

The question surprised her.

“Why?”

“Because before leaving he said the people of Vaor were animals who didn't respect retreat. After his death, command sent me a medal for discipline. If he ran, I don't want him buried in a lie that would have shamed him. If he stayed, I want to know what for.”

Nemi searched the lake images. The recordings were fragmentary, many made by Faces. She found the flanking unit in the second the steam

erupted. Rel had turned towards the retreat corridor, then seen another fallen agent. He had gone back to lift him. The ice gave way beneath them both.

She showed him without comment.

Rin watched the scene three times. At the second, he lowered his sails. At the third, he stopped before the collapse.

“He didn't run,” Nemi said.

“Yes, he did. Then he came back.”

His voice held no pride, but the painful relief of someone who had received a dead man more complicated than the monument.

“Did Taren open the lake?” he asked.

“Yes.”

“Did he know they would die?”

“He knew it was probable.”

“Then why do you serve him?”

“I don't serve him.”

Rin touched the Memory slate on her cloak.

“You wear his sign.”

“The sign existed before him and will have to exist after him.”

“Everyone with power says the institution is older than the person. Then the institution keeps their face.”

Sava intervened:

“Your son was sent to Vaor by Seln.”

“I know. And yet I can buy soup here without anyone asking me to carry a weapon. I can hate Seln and not want Taren's Corps in my gallery.”

“Vaor is freezing.”

“Then move the light. Don't move the soldiers.”

“The swarm won't open without pressure.”

“That's the argument every army uses to reach my pipe.”

Rin brought them bread without asking for payment. Nemi refused at first. He left it on the table anyway.

“It isn't for Taren. It's because you showed me the return.”

At the far end of the room, a class of children was eating. Their instructor spoke about the western regions. Every child had drawn a white root and a blue circle representing the cold. The drawings would be sent to “relocated families” with clothing parcels. No child had seen mineral snow.

A little girl noticed the scar on Nemi's sail and came to the table.

“Have you been outside?”

“Yes.”

“Does the sky really have no end?”

Nemi remembered her first journey, the blanket over her head and Oru's voice describing the world without forcing her to look.

“You can't see the end,” she said. “But you always feel where you could hide.”

“I'd stay outside.”

“Many people inside think that.”

The instructor called her. The girl left, waving both sails at them.

Rin sat beside them for a moment.

“Do you know why Ivarra seems quiet?” he asked. “Not because no one knows. Because everyone knows a piece small enough to continue their day. I know about Rel. The woman at table three hosts two refugees. The cook lost a brother in the train attack. The officials beside you work on housing. We all do something that fits inside a life. No one can carry the whole map.”

“Seln carries it and decides for you,” Nemi said.

“And Taren carries it and decides for yours.”

“That’s why we’re here.”

Rin raised one sail.

“Or why you think you are.”

When they left, the canteen was preparing for the next shift. On the wall, the solidarity message became a graph of saved consumption. The capital’s percentage was small, almost symbolic. Yet to the people inside, the percentage was proof they participated.

Nemi looked again at the entrance to their former home.

“It’s easier when you think they’re indifferent,” she said.

“Yes.”

“It doesn’t make them innocent.”

“No.”

“Then what does it change?”

Sava drew her cloak closer.

“It changes what kind of world has to be built if we want to persuade them, not only defeat them.”

• • •

Seln Aru received them in Sava’s old office.

He had changed almost nothing. The Belt map pulsed on the wall, whiter in the west than she remembered. On the table lay the ILEN–VEN file, the second-birth application, still marked POSTPONED.

“Some systems are more persistent than families,” Seln said.

Sava did not sit.

“Oru died.”

“I know.”

“Then close the file.”

Seln closed it with a touch.

“I’m sorry.”

“Your regret arrived in two tonnes of aerosol.”

“The order was for low-concentration dispersal. The tanks were damaged in the fighting.”

“The fighting began because you brought them.”

“If I’d sent lethal weapons, you’d have accused me of choosing death. I sent a non-lethal means, and you accuse me of choosing control.”

“You chose not to accept a no.”

“No planetary administration can accept a no from every domain without ceasing to exist.”

Nemi had started the recording slate. Seln noticed it.

“You’ve grown,” he said.

“It’s one consequence of time.”

“And of your uncle opening the quotas.”

“I’m not his child.”

Seln served them an infusion in the same office where Sava had once processed permits. Her old cup was no longer there. But on a shelf stood a measuring instrument she had left behind, with a scratch on its edge.

“You kept the things,” she said.

“Offices are more stable when every successor finds traces of the previous occupant.”

“I had no successor.”

“Your files were divided. No one had the right combination of competence and discreet violation.”

Nemi started the slate.

“Is that a compliment or an accusation?”

“In administration, the difference depends on who writes the assessment.”

Sava put the list of winter deaths on the table. It was incomplete; many communities had lost contact. Seln did not shy away from it. He opened his own data and added central mortality, attacks on transports, harvests captured by Houses. For an hour, the discussion was work, not a duel: figures, routes, capacities, thresholds. It was precisely this normality that angered Sava. Together, they could model a technical solution while bodies froze because of the political choice beneath the model.

“Restoration in two stages takes four months,” she said. “Vaor doesn't have four months.”

“A faster change would overheat the eastern crops.”

“We can compensate with local shading.”

“If the Corps allow central teams access.”

“Send mixed teams.”

“Taren will use them for reconnaissance.”

“And you use them for control.”

Seln put down his cup.

“See? Even a solution about light comes down to who carries a weapon.”

“Because you made infrastructure into a frontier.”

“Because Daran made the frontier into identity.”

“Daran is dead.”

“His stories aren't.”

Seln led them through the Chamber of Measure. Officials worked silently, allocating food, energy and births for the central regions.

Requests from the west appeared on screens, marked low priority because of “access instability”.

“You moved the light as a weapon,” Sava said.

“I moved it towards the population I can feed without transports being confiscated by Houses.”

“You created refugees.”

“The war created territories where distribution is no longer predictable. Mirrors can't be administered according to local honour.”

“Children freeze predictably.”

Seln stopped before the map.

“In the past six years, the Face Corps have directly killed eleven thousand nivari. Wars between Houses have caused another forty thousand deaths and reduced the harvest by eighteen per cent. In the centre, mortality is below its pre-storm level. You've come to ask me to move resources from those who remained at peace to those who chose commanders.”

“Most chose nothing.”

“Exactly. That's my argument against commanders.”

For a moment, Sava remembered why she had respected him. Seln did not lie simply. He built a room from partial truths and invited you to live in it.

“What do you offer?” she asked.

“I restore the light in two stages. I recognise every existing birth and grant domains administrative autonomy. In return, the Corps are reduced to local services without a shared command. The reproductive Charter is repealed. Taren comes to Ivarra and stays here under protection.”

“In the Gardens of Kinship.”

“In a home of his own.”

“With doors that close from outside.”

Seln's offer was good enough to divide the Confederation. Sava knew it. Many Houses would accept autonomy and light in exchange for dissolving the shared command. Communities without a House would fear returning under local administrations. The Faces would refuse repeal of the Charter. Taren would become the price of peace.

"If he agrees to stay here," Seln said, "I'll treat him as a former ruler, not a prisoner."

"The doors?"

"They'll have protection."

"From outside."

"A man followed by armies can no longer have a door that is only personal."

Sava stood.

"That's the problem with all your systems. Every collective consequence becomes a reason to take away individual choice."

"And the problem with Taren's system is that every individual choice with a weapon becomes a collective consequence."

Neither won. Seln granted them access to the Gardens for interviews about Lur and let them leave unescorted as far as the lower level. It was either a gesture of trust or a trap elegant enough for the distinction not to matter.

At the Gardens' entrance, Nemi adjusted her cloak and checked the carbon rod.

"Aren't they following us?" she asked.

"The city is following us," Sava replied. "Agents would be redundant."

The gates opened onto an artificial blue sky.

CHAPTER XIX

THE GARDENS OF KINSHIP

NEMI · BENEATH IVARRA · THE SECOND DAY OF NEGOTIATIONS

The Gardens of Kinship had been created to preserve peace between Houses: rulers' relatives lived in comfort in Ivarra, and that comfort could be suspended if the provinces forgot cooperation. After nine years of conflict, almost no one knew any longer whether they were hostages, citizens or privileged survivors.

The Gardens lay beneath the old genetic reservoirs. They had been built for House families: spacious rooms, warm pools, edible-moss orchards and ceilings projecting a predator-free sky. The gates were hidden in the walls. The children there no longer noticed them.

Nemi entered on the pretext of interviews for Lur's archive. She met descendants of every House, some held for seven years, others born into polite captivity. Not all wanted to leave.

"There is no home left in Orm," an old woman told her. "My son was killed by Taren's Corps when he closed the border. Here I have food."

"Not Taren's Corps," Nemi said. "Vaor's Corps."

"When it wins, it's his. When it kills wrongly, it belongs to someone else."

The projected sky had no star. Diffuse light moved slowly across the ceiling, imitating a natural cycle Arua had never known. The Gardens' children drew sunrises and sunsets as ordinary landscapes, although in the real world Vei did not move. Sava wondered whether this was cruelty or a gift: growing up with an image of change the planet could not offer.

The homes were spacious, separated by low moss orchards and warm channels. The food was good. The schools had teachers. There were no

visible locks. Only when someone approached an exit gallery did the wall turn opaque and a gentle voice recommend returning.

A woman from House Tel invited them to eat. Her husband had died at Lur, fighting under Orven. Their daughter had grown up in the Gardens and met him only through messages.

"You recorded the trial," she told Nemi.

"Yes."

"Do you have the execution too?"

"Yes."

"I want to see it."

Nemi hesitated.

"Why?"

"To know whether he died believing he'd been right."

"The recording doesn't show what he believed."

"Then what is Memory for?"

The question followed Nemi. Until then, she had thought a good archive preserved the limits of certainty. To the woman before her, precisely that limit was unbearable.

She showed her the trial, not the execution. The woman listened to the testimonies and stopped several times at her husband's voice, a junior officer sentenced to labour, not death. He was still alive in Lur. She did not know.

"Seln told us all the commanders had been executed."

"Your husband wasn't in the command group."

"Then why didn't he write to me?"

Nemi checked the registers. His messages had been blocked because House Tel refused to recognise the tribunal. A dispute between institutions had become nine years of administrative widowhood.

Sava obtained temporary access and sent the first message. The woman did not thank them. She cried with her face turned to the wall, as though freedom of information were a wound added too late.

• • •

A young man named Hale Orm agreed to help her. He had been a network technician before his family was brought to Ivarra and knew the old pipes beneath the Gardens. He showed her a maintenance room concealed behind a decorative waterfall.

“The secondary station is two levels below,” he said. “The House's access was revoked.”

Nemi took the key from the carbon rod.

“This one isn't House Orm's.”

“It's a curator's key. The museum network doesn't communicate with the mirrors.”

“It did before the Cleansing. The reservoirs needed independent light.”

Hale Orm was nineteen and had never been to Orm. His parents had come to the Gardens for their residency year and had not left after the conflict began. He had learned networks from manuals and clandestine repairs to the decorative waterfalls.

“Why do you want to leave?” Nemi asked behind the curtain of water.

“I don't know whether I do.”

“You're helping us open the gates.”

“I'm helping there be a choice. That's not the same thing.”

“That's a Sava sentence.”

“Who?”

Nemi smiled. It was strange to hear her mother's thinking in someone who had never known her.

Hale removed a panel. Behind it, the duct was narrow and damp. The smell of preservative came from below.

“My mother says Orm has nothing left for us. My father says any land where our ancestors died remains home. I’ve seen neither the land nor the dead.”

“Then what do you have?”

“Here? Food, friends and doors that decide for me. Outside? A story about a place that may not want me.”

Hale did not immediately lead them towards the hidden duct. He asked them to visit his family's home first. If the gates were going to open, he said, he did not want the first discussion about leaving to happen after the choice became a fact.

The home occupied the edge of an artificial orchard. Its walls retained warmth, and its windows projected a landscape from Orm: dark fields, low condensation towers, a line of mountains Hale had never seen. The image had been taken twenty-three years earlier. Since then, half the fields had been abandoned, and the mountains were entering the Night after the light's shift.

His mother, Sera, had grown up in Orm. His father, Tel Orm, wore the House name as an assertion and corrected anyone who called the Gardens home. With them lived Hale's younger sister, two cousins from House Nur and a Veyr woman whose partner had died during the siege of a transport. The families the system had kept as political guarantees had mingled until no single punishment could be applied to one House without striking all the others at the same table.

Sera put fruit grown under blue light before them. It had thin skin and tasted too sweet.

“Hale says you can open the gates,” she said.

“We can try,” Nemi replied.

“And after?”

“Whoever wants to leaves.”

“Where?”

Nemi looked towards the projection of Orm.

“Home.”

Sera smiled without joy.

“That's the image they brought us here with. My real home was divided among three families. My brother died. The neighbourhood's language changed. If I get there, I'm the relative of a defeated leadership who lived well in Ivarra while the others froze.”

“We didn't live well,” Tel said.

“We had food, medicine and blue sky.”

“We had guards.”

“We had both.”

Tel struck the table with two fingers.

“A large cage is still a cage.”

“And a ruin doesn't become home simply because you're allowed to enter it.”

Hale's sister, Meni, was eleven and did not understand why adults used the same word for different places.

“Can I stay here if you leave?” she asked.

Tel abruptly raised his head.

“No.”

“Then the gate doesn't give me a choice.”

“You're a child.”

“Hale was my age when the war started. No one asked him to choose to stay.”

Sera touched her hand but did not silence her.

Nemi took out her slate and opened a list.

“We can request a transition period. Group departures, contact with communities of origin, a temporary right of return.”

“Who guarantees it?” the Veyr woman asked.

“The families together. The keys are no longer controlled by one House.”

“Does Taren guarantee it?”

“No.”

The answer surprised them.

“Then why should we trust it?”

“Because a personal guarantee dies, loses or changes its mind. We need rules Taren can't change alone.”

Tel laughed.

“You talk like your mother.”

Sava, sitting beside the door, replied:

“It's one of the diseases we failed to prevent.”

The tension broke enough for Meni to laugh. Hale did not laugh. He was looking at the departure list.

“I want to see Orm,” he said. “I don't know whether I want to stay there.”

“You can go and come back,” Nemi said.

“What if the gates close again?”

“That's why we have to open them so no one can close them alone any more.”

Sera asked whether their homes would be preserved. Tel said that would turn the Gardens into a hotel for the undecided. The Veyr woman demanded protection for those unable to return to their Houses. The Nur

cousins wanted to leave immediately. Meni wanted to take her teacher and the tree beside the window.

The discussion lasted longer than the technical planning of the gates. Every freedom produced questions about food, property, children and who bore the risk of the first night outside. Nemi had begun by believing the system kept people inside. Now she saw that, given enough time, captivity had built infrastructure around them: friendships, treatments, schools, graves, the habit of knowing where the next meal came from.

As they left, Meni gave Hale a leaf from the artificial tree. It was real, although its light and soil were controlled.

“So you have something from home,” she said.

Tel opened his mouth to correct the word. Sera stopped him.

Hale put the leaf in his pocket.

“See?” he told Nemi when they reached the waterfall again. “I don’t know whether I want to be outside. But I want the answer to be mine tomorrow too, not only in the minute you open the door.”

Nemi understood why opening the Gardens would not be a simple liberation. Long captivity had created dependencies, mixed families, real safety. An open gate could not restore the years in which the alternative had been destroyed.

They descended.

One was open.

There was no embryo inside any more, but the walls retained recent scratches.

“Are there creatures left?” Hale asked.

“Taren heard two beneath the square. They found only one after the attack.”

A rustle came from somewhere in the dark.

Both froze. Nemi felt veyrin flood her blood, her limbs ready to leap. Then she remembered her uncle's lessons: alarm is information, not an order.

She raised the light.

A mature saryx stood confined in a side cage, fed through tubes. Its membranes were atrophied. Electrodes on its skull connected it to a simulation system.

Nemi opened the data.

The Great Hearing had used the creature to model panic responses. Entire generations of urban policies, educational programmes and medical selections had been tested against a virtual predator. The same archive contained a project called THE ADAPTIVE RESERVE.

The lists contained individuals with reduced flight reflexes, grouped by usefulness in a catastrophe: high-risk workers, rescue teams, biological control, last-resort defence.

Taren Ilen appeared at position 17.

The inclusion date was twelve years before the Festival.

"They've watched him since childhood," Nemi said.

Hale scrolled through the file.

"Not only him. Look at the distribution. Most were sent to the provinces through placements, sanctions or relocations."

"The Chamber cultivated its monsters at the margins."

"It kept its options."

The caged saryx did not resemble the animal in Nemi's memory. This one was thin, its membranes drooping, electrodes embedded in bone. When it raised its head, chains limited its movement. Nemi felt fear before realising some of it came from the creature. The animal was trembling.

Hale pressed against the wall.

“Do we kill it?”

Nemi took the blade from her bag. Sava had forbidden her to carry it; the ban belonged to another city and another age.

The saryx opened its vertical mouth but did not attack. Nutrient tubes entered its abdomen. On the screen, the simulation ran thousands of virtual crowds: alarm signals, corridor widths, veyrin doses, dispersal rates. The creature was not hunting. The system stimulated its brain and used the response to optimise nivar behaviour.

“They frighten it to learn how we get frightened,” Hale whispered.

Nemi lowered the blade.

In the Adaptive Reserve file, Taren's name appeared beside childhood assessments. At eight, after the cable fire, he had been classified “fit for persistence in a hostile environment”. Therapy aimed not only to normalise him; it measured how much deviation could be preserved without affecting his integration.

There were notes signed by Mera Sol. *The patient responds to argument, not command. I recommend technical use, not authority over others.*

“Use,” Nemi said.

Hale scrolled through the list. Hundreds of people had been directed towards high-risk trades, provinces and emergency teams. The Chamber had not eliminated them. It had distributed them where society could benefit from them without letting them become a model.

“Taren didn't emerge against the system,” Hale said. “He emerged from one of its drawers.”

Nemi copied the entire archive.

“And Daran opened the drawer.”

• • •

The curator's key opened the next node. The mirror station was not guarded from inside; its security depended on no one in the Gardens having access. Hale connected the slate to the Houses' old network. Four red consensus keys appeared on the map. Taking control required three.

"Orm has one," he said. "Veyr had another. Tel and Selc have the rest."

"The families are here."

"The families no longer have authority."

"Authority is what an old system accepts."

Over the next hours, Nemi gathered the House representatives in the waterfall chamber. Some refused. Others signed only after being promised evacuation. The Veyr key responded to Daran's rod. Orm and Tel responded to relatives' biological signatures. Three lights turned green.

Secondary control opened.

The orbital swarm map floated above them. Nemi could move the light.

She did not do so immediately.

Any sudden change could burn crops in the east or freeze cities in the west. The Great Hearing administered millions of variables. A military takeover of the sky was easier than using it without killing.

"Send access to Vaor," Hale said.

"No. Taren will be forced to use it for war."

"Then why did we come down?"

"So Seln is no longer the only one compelled."

Persuading the families did not resemble a military conspiracy. It resembled an association meeting that risked changing the sky. Representatives argued over who had ancient rights, whether biological signatures remained valid and what guarantees they would receive after the gates opened.

An old Veyr man refused Daran's key.

“He kept us here through his provocations,” he said. “I won’t use his object to finish his plan.”

“The light is dying in Vaor,” Nemi replied.

“And my son died at Deaf Lake because of Taren.”

“I’m not asking you to forgive him.”

“You’re asking me to give him the sky.”

“I’m asking you to stop giving it to one person.”

That changed the discussion. Nemi proposed a three-key threshold, automatic limits and publication of every orientation. Hale showed how a rapid change could be blocked. The families did not have to choose between Seln and Taren, but refuse both men’s exclusivity.

The keys turned green.

When the orbital swarm map opened, Nemi felt for the first time the temptation of power that had no weight in the hand. One gesture could move kilometres of fertile band. She could warm Vaor immediately, but the price appeared in the east: burnt crops, overloaded pipes, millions of rations. A local emergency always demanded someone else become a variable.

She set a slow restoration.

“They’ll die before the light arrives,” Hale said.

“Fewer than if I move everything now.”

“That’s exactly the Custodian’s sentence.”

Nemi kept her hand on the control.

“Yes.”

There was no moral purity in administering a finite sky. The difference had to lie in limits, transparency and who could stop the decision—things less satisfying than justice.

The central agents arrived before the first families left. They did not fire. They stood in formation and asked everyone to return to their rooms for safety. Many obeyed. Others remained between the gates, unable to decide whether freedom was the road to a ruined home or another room where they would be used.

Seln Aru came in person.

He looked at the mirror map, the open gates and the saryx connected to wires.

“Daran always had a taste for old keys,” he said.

Nemi raised the slate.

“Taren was in the Adaptive Reserve.”

“Yes.”

“You sent him to Vaor knowing what he could become.”

“I sent him because Vaor needed someone who would stay when the others ran. I didn't order anyone to follow him.”

“You built a society that made him rare, then put that rarity in a hungry place.”

“And Daran offered it a story.”

Seln approached the station. The agents waited for an order.

“Can you close access?” Sava asked.

“I can. But the mirrors would enter safe mode and the west would lose another week of light.”

“Then you can't without killing.”

When Seln arrived, Sava was already in the waterfall chamber. She had seen the gates open and people stop at the threshold. Some clutched their bags. Others returned towards their homes. The agents did not strike them. Their formation alone was enough for the old reflex of submission to return.

Seln looked at the Adaptive Reserve copies.

“The archive wasn't intended for the public,” he said.

“Nor was Taren intended to lead,” Nemi replied.

“Destinations are models, not commands.”

“The Chamber shaped his life before he could consent.”

“Parents shape. Schools shape. Hunger shapes. Institutions can at least publish their criteria.”

“Then publish them.”

Seln did not answer. Behind him, the saryx pulled at its chain. The agents raised their weapons.

“Don't kill it,” Nemi said.

“It's dangerous.”

“It's a prisoner.”

“Those aren't mutually exclusive categories.”

Yet Seln ordered the weapons lowered. To Nemi, that was the most disturbing thing: the Custodian could be persuaded in details and remain unyielding in structure.

Nemi sent a single message through the Veyr key to Vaor:

THE LIGHT IS RETURNING. THE GARDENS ARE OPEN. THE ARCHIVE PROVES BOTH ORDERS SELECTED YOU.

Seln let it go.

“Why?” Sava asked.

“Because Taren will come now,” he said. “Not for you. Not for me. For control of the sky.”

“And is that what you want?”

Seln looked towards the caged saryx. The creature opened its vertical mouth without a sound.

“I want the world to see him choose what he is.”

THE SKY WITHOUT A CEILING

The message went to Vaor through Daran's key. Nemi formulated it three times before sending. She did not write that they had won. She did not write that Seln had yielded. She wrote only the facts: the light was gradually returning; the gates were open; the archive proved both regimes had cultivated their instruments.

At the end, she added a personal sentence for Taren:

DON'T COME TO SAVE US. COME ONLY IF YOU CAN OPEN WITHOUT TAKING.

The reply did not come immediately.

In the western tunnels, the Confederation's army had already set off for Ivarra.

CHAPTER XX

THE SIEGE OF THE ROOTS

TAREN · IVARRA'S OUTER TUNNELS

The siege of Ivarra began as a promise of liberation and became, before the first fight, a problem of water, air, food and authority. The city had no walls; it had systems neither attackers nor defenders could live without.

Taren did not call the Houses to war. He called them to recover their families.

The difference lasted three days.

On the fourth, seven Face Corps set off for Ivarra, each under its own sign, its own commander and its own interpretation of the Code. Communities without a House sent food trains and young people who had no relatives in the Gardens but wanted to witness the fall of the city that had not recognised their birth. Vaor sent eight thousand fighters. Behind them came the Hands, doctors, repairers and traders who knew any siege creates a market before it creates a victory.

Sava saw the column on Ivarra's screens.

“He'll destroy everything he claims to save,” she said.

Seln stood in the Chamber of Measure, surrounded by the shifting Belt map. The light was gradually returning to the west under Nemi's programme. Central crops lost a few percentage points, but the collapse predicted by official warnings did not occur.

“Perhaps,” he replied. “But I didn't force him to come.”

“You closed the Gardens after the gates had been opened.”

“I prevented an uncontrolled evacuation into a city facing a siege.”

“That's your talent. Any locked door becomes a protective measure if you describe the corridor outside well enough.”

Seln folded one sail.

“And Taren's talent is making any blade necessary once he describes the danger.”

Nemi was no longer in the Gardens. She had disappeared through the maintenance network with Hale Orm and thirty members of House families. Agents searched for them, but Seln had forbidden flooding the pipes or using gas.

“You don't want to catch her,” Sava said.

“I want to see what she does when no one can tell her she was forced.”

“You treat the city like one of your tanks.”

“All rulers experiment. The most dangerous call the result destiny.”

Outside, the army's approach could be heard long before it could be seen. The ground carried the trains' vibration, then the columns' footsteps, then the irregular beats by which each Corps announced its sign. To Ivarra's inhabitants, the messages mingled in the foundations: Tel, Orm, Vaor, the communities without a House, three new formations still without names. The Great Hearing separated them and displayed probabilities. But the bodies of those in the city received only one meaning: something numerous was coming towards them.

Seln ordered the public alarm signals not to be activated. He said panic would block the tunnels before the attack began. Instead of sirens, home walls projected calm instructions: *Keep supplies for twenty days. Do not change levels without authorisation. Children remain in educational units until further orders.* The quiet wording frightened those who remembered Vaor's mist even more.

Sava walked down from the Chamber of Measure. Lifts had been reserved for interventions, and walking through the city showed her what the map could not: queues at water distribution; blankets fixed over ventilation openings to prevent possible gas; parents keeping children home despite contrary orders. An old man was sealing his door with root

paste. When he recognised her, he asked whether the army would cut off the air.

“I don't know,” Sava replied.

He kept working.

“Then why do you wear the Chamber's cloak?”

Sava found no answer that did not resemble an excuse. The cloak opened doors for her, but did not give her the certainty people saw in it.

In the Gardens, the families had split. Some packed and waited for their relatives' army. Others barricaded their homes against the same army. Hale tried to organise evacuation corridors with Nemi, but every open door produced a new dispute. A Tel woman refused to leave without the two families with whom she had shared a home for nine years. An Orm man wanted to take only his biological children and claimed those raised alongside them belonged to Ivarra. Three adolescents declared they recognised no House and demanded permission to stay.

“Freedom would be simpler if no one had anywhere to return to,” Hale said.

“Then it wouldn't be freedom any more,” Nemi replied. “It would be evacuation.”

She carried Oru's slate beneath her cloak and touched it whenever the network branched. Her father's map had not been made for war. Its markings showed pressures, root species, postponed repairs. That was precisely why it was useful: it described the city before every pipe acquired a military value.

Sava found them beside a stopped waterfall. The water had been diverted to reservoirs, and only a layer of dark algae remained in the basin.

“Taren has set off,” Nemi said.

“I know.”

“I told him not to come to save us.”

“You asked him for something no ruler knows how to prove beforehand.”

“Do you think he'll take the city?”

Sava looked at the Gardens, the comfortable homes and the gates turned opaque again.

“I think each side will try to keep what it says it's protecting. That frightens me more than their intentions.”

Nemi handed her a copy of the map. It showed five routes to the Chamber of Measure and dozens of points where one explosion could stop the air for a neighbourhood.

“Oru left redundancies,” she said. “But the administration closed half of them to reduce losses.”

Sava smiled without joy. In peacetime, efficiency had been the virtue that eliminated reserves. Now every saving became a ready-built weapon.

“Reopen what you can,” she said. “Without asking permission.”

“Is that the Chamber's order?”

“It's your mother's advice.”

Nemi looked at her for a moment, then turned her body to the work. It was one of the few times she accepted authority precisely because it had been named correctly.

• • •

Taren's army reached the outer tunnels. Ivarra had no walls. It had filters, transport nodes, fire doors and thousands of kilometres of infrastructure that could be closed in sections. An attacker could conquer a neighbourhood and discover its air was pumped from a chamber five levels below, under central control.

The House commanders proposed cutting off the water.

Taren refused.

They proposed stopping ventilation to the administrative levels.

He refused again.

“Seln will keep his agents among civilians,” House Tel's commander said. “If we don't touch civilians, we don't touch him.”

“Then we'll reach him slowly.”

“Winter killed more than three days without water would.”

“That's precisely why we won't become better at his method.”

Raal watched him from the far end of the table. He had aged quickly. The scar around his muzzle had deepened, and only one of his chisel teeth remained intact.

“You'll lose the Houses,” he said after the meeting.

“I never had them.”

“They came for families, spoils and a sky they could control. If you give them only the families, they'll take the rest without you.”

“Then we'll stop them.”

“With whom?”

Taren did not answer.

That night, the Orm Corps attacked the water node alone. Central agents deployed immobilising foam and caught two hundred fighters. The rest retreated, leaving them behind. Taren sent the First Face to free them and arrested the Orm commander for violating the plan.

Half the Orm Corps left the siege.

The next day, House Tel tried to enter through the freight trains. Ivarra let the first carriage pass, then closed the gates between the second and third. The fighters inside were captured without a fight. Those outside demanded Taren stop the station's air to force the agents to release them.

He refused.

By the third day, his alliance was beginning to resemble a crowd that had discovered too many exits.

The attackers' camp had grown along the outer tunnels like a badly planned city. Every House had erected its own sleeping membranes, kitchens and guard posts. Temporary pipes crossed transport routes. Waste collected in pits too close to reservoirs. Traders sold food, medicine, blades and memorial slates not yet inscribed. Taren spent almost as much time stopping quarrels over space as planning the siege.

Vaor worked differently. Fighters slept beside Hands and repairers, grouped by neighbourhood rather than rank. Raal had insisted on shared kitchens. He said an army that eats in different orders quickly learns to die in different orders.

On the second evening, a drainage pipe burst beneath the weight of a Tel depot. Wastewater flooded two Orm tents, and the dispute brought three hundred fighters into the corridor. Taren arrived before the heavy weapons were activated. He made no speech. He put them to moving the depot, cleaning the water and digging a settling chamber together. The commanders protested that he was humiliating his Faces with Hands' work.

"Then learn what happens when Faces pitch their tent over a pipe," he said.

Sen worked among them with an oversized shovel. At first, the fighters let him imitate effort. Raal took his tool and gave him a smaller one.

"Heirs usually get unsuitable objects," he said. "So they look bigger beside them."

"I'm not an heir."

"Then dig."

Taren saw them in passing and did not intervene. He had promised himself not to give the boy rank, a guard or a distinctive sign. But he could not prevent the gazes. When Sen lifted a stone, those around him saw the First Face's son. When he made a mistake, it became a test of

blood. When he was silent, silence was interpreted as discipline. The child had no place where his gestures could be small.

At the night council, the seven Corps again demanded a plan to divide Ivarra. Instead, Taren projected a map of functions: water, air, hospitals, depots, transport, mirrors. Each Corps would protect a system after entering, not occupy territory.

“Whoever controls the system controls the territory,” the Tel commander said.

“Temporarily.”

“Everything lasting begins as temporary.”

“That’s precisely why the keys won’t stay with you.”

A murmur passed around the table. The Houses had come under a shared story, not a shared command. Taren had offered their captive relatives as the reason, Seln as the opponent and the Code as the limit. He had not offered the reward each had added for itself.

After the commanders left, Raal stayed and ate from a cold bowl. He had removed a prosthetic chisel tooth; without it, his speech was slightly unclear.

“Tel will try again,” he said.

“I know.”

“Orm will return if it sees an open gate. The other Houses will wait until they can say you broke the agreement first.”

“And Vaor?”

“Vaor follows you.”

Taren looked up.

“You didn’t say that’s the good part.”

“It isn’t.”

Raal pushed the bowl towards him. Taren had not eaten since the start of the day.

“When I was in the Night,” Raal continued, “no one followed us for long. There, if the leader took the wrong road, the cold contradicted him before people did. Here, you can be wrong for years, and every victory becomes proof the road was right.”

“Do you want me to leave?”

“I want you to know what you carry behind you. It isn't only people. It's how they explain their own losses.”

Taren ate. The paste tasted of metal and roots stored too long. In the next tunnel, someone sang about Deaf Lake. The song made him taller, lonelier and more certain than he had been. Oru did not appear. Sava appeared only as the sister who counted the dead. Vessa did not exist at all.

“After Ivarra,” Taren said, “we abolish the House Corps.”

Raal laughed briefly.

“With what?”

“A shared structure.”

“Meaning your army.”

Taren did not answer. Outside the tent, the beats of House signs continued through the ground. Each promised belonging. No new institution could compete with a rhythm learned in childhood unless it offered a stronger rhythm still.

Nemi's message arrived before dawn. Taren listened three times. At the fourth, he stopped after the last sentence: *Come only if you can open without taking.*

Vessa stood in the doorway. She had arrived with the medical train and still wore the journey's dust on her cloak.

“Can you?” she asked.

"I don't know."

"Then the right answer isn't attack."

"If I stay, Seln closes the Gardens and moves the light again. The Houses attack alone. Ivarra will have the same war without the only command trying to limit it."

"That's every indispensable man's argument."

"It's also true sometimes."

Vessa approached the map. Oru's route pulsed beneath the city.

"Take what you need to open it," she said. "Then get someone to take the keys from you."

"Who?"

"I don't know. But not finding the person doesn't make keeping them a solution."

Taren touched the Gardens marker.

"Sen stays with you."

"Sen isn't a medical object."

"He's eight."

"And already knows you hide the important things from him. He'll find a way."

"Then tie him up."

"I hear your imaginary father speaking."

Taren turned his body face-on.

"I didn't have one."

"Exactly."

Vessa left before he could answer. That morning, Taren chose a thousand First Face members, mostly from Vaor, some from the Houses, some of Raal's former outcasts. He explained the route, the order of

objectives and the rule he repeated until people began saying it with him: no vital function would be stopped to hasten victory.

He did not tell them what to do if that very rule made them lose.

• • •

Then Nemi sent Oru's map.

Years earlier, the engineer had mapped the root layer beneath Ivarra. The city had grown over old pipes abandoned after the Cleansing. Some connected to the genetic museum, others to nutrient tanks. Nemi had found a route to the Low Square.

Taren chose a thousand First Face members and entered a pipe where they could walk only bent over. Sen was among them.

He discovered him after two hours, hidden beneath a medical carrier's cloak.

"You're going back," Taren said.

"The tunnel behind us closed."

Raal checked the map.

"He's telling the truth."

"Then stay with the doctors."

"I can fight."

"That's precisely why you're staying with the doctors."

Sen turned his body face-on.

"At my age, you were treated as a defect. I'm treated as an inheritance. Neither is a choice."

Taren caught him by the armour.

"My choice is for you not to die here."

"That's what the Chamber said about you when it postponed your children."

Taren released him. The words belonged to Sava, Vessa, the whole world that had learned to use his own contradictions.

“Beside Raal,” he said. “You don't leave him.”

“Is that an order?”

“Yes.”

“Good.”

For Sen, obedience was a relief when it came from the right person. Taren saw the danger and had no time to correct it.

The pipe was narrower than the map showed. Roots had grown through the joints, and sediment raised the floor. The fighters advanced bent over, one by one, weapons fixed to their backs. They could see no farther than the body ahead. For a species accustomed to keeping a wide field, the narrowing gaze produced an almost physical unease.

Raal walked beside Sen after the boy was discovered. He did not scold him. He showed him where to put his feet and how to breathe when the ceiling lowered.

“Father wanted to send me back,” Sen said.

“And you wanted to stay. Two desires don't yet make a good decision.”

“Do you think I shouldn't be here?”

“I think you're already here.”

“That's not an answer.”

“In war, you'll get many sentences that describe the situation and pretend to be answers. Learn to recognise them.”

Sen moved his sails irritably. Behind him, a doctor nudged him to continue.

During a halt, Raal showed him the trace of an old repair. The paste still bore Oru's imprint, a three-arc pattern used to mark unfinished interventions.

“Did you know him?” Sen asked.

“A little.”

“Everyone says he was good.”

“What does good mean?”

“He didn't kill.”

“Pipes don't usually kill either. Oru did more than avoid.”

“What?”

Raal touched the repair.

“He left things behind that others could continue.”

Sen looked at Raal's armour, worn blades and scar.

“What do you leave?”

“I'm trying to find out before the tunnel closes.”

Farther ahead, Taren heard the exchange and continued without turning. He was grateful to Raal and hated him a little for the ease with which he spoke to the boy. He himself turned every conversation with Sen into a lesson, warning or order. He did not know how to be present without preparing something.

In Ivarra, Nemi waited for the signal in the Lower Archive. Hale held his injured arm against his chest. The wound came from an agent he had struck with a wrench after the man tried to close a gate. Until then, Hale had described himself as a technician. Now the slate recorded an assault against him, and one day the Memory Corps would decide what name it received.

“Do you think they'll call us liberators?” he asked.

“Who?”

“Those who write after us.”

“I'm one of them.”

“Then what name do you give us?”

Nemi looked at the armed families, the pipes, the saryx's empty cage.

“People who opened a door and don't know what comes through it.”

Hale smiled faintly.

“That won't fit on a plaque.”

“That's why plaques lie well.”

The signal came through water: three beats, a pause, two. Taren had reached the museum.

They emerged into the museum reservoirs. The saryx connected to wires had disappeared. The cage was open, and black traces marked the floor.

“Did Seln release it?” Raal asked.

“He wouldn't risk the city,” Taren said.

“That's exactly what he says about you.”

Nemi waited for them in the Lower Archive. She had cut her black cloak to crawl through pipes. Hale was wounded in the arm. Behind them, the House families held weapons taken from agents.

“The mirror station is under control,” Nemi said. “But Seln moved the Great Hearing's command to the Chamber of Measure. If we disconnect him abruptly, the city's systems go into safe mode.”

“How long without air?”

“The old levels, twenty minutes. The Gardens, perhaps ten.”

“Then we don't disconnect him.”

“We have to reach the Chamber and transfer the keys with the Custodian active.”

“He'll block access.”

“Not completely. The system protects him, but it also protects the population. Oru left a route through the water nodes.”

Taren touched the slate's edge. Oru's handwriting appeared between layers of data: never close both valves simultaneously. A technical observation that had become, after his death, a form of help.

They divided the group. Nemi and Hale would follow the network towards the Chamber. Raal would take Sen and free the Gardens. Taren would lead the main force towards the Low Square, where he could open the gates for the rest of the army.

At the first junction, Ivarra attacked through sound.

The emergency speakers emitted the low frequency of an adult saryx. It was more than noise. The Great Hearing had calibrated it for generations to trigger the maximum panic response. The corridor itself seemed to fill with wings.

The fighters stopped. Some flattened themselves against the floor. Others turned and fled over those behind them. Armour snagged, blades discharged accidentally. Within seconds, the formation became the same crowd that had killed in the Low Square.

Taren felt the sound in his marrow too. He was not fearless. He never had been. His difference was only a moment, and the system had built a frequency long enough to fill it.

He drove his blade into the floor and struck the handle three times.

The metal sent the vibration through the roots.

Stop. Face. Attack.

Raal answered from another level. Then Nemi. Then hundreds of members, some fallen, some still fleeing. The new signal overlapped the old. It did not cancel it. It offered the body a second story.

The First Face turned.

Central agents waited around corners with foam and white projectiles. The fight spread through the pipes. There was no front line, only rooms changing masters and doors closing over the wounded. Taren saw his

people obey the Code in one tunnel and break it in the next. He stopped two executions. He did not see the third.

After the panic frequency, the tunnel smelled of alarm secretions, burnt foam and blood. Some fighters still trembled although the sound had stopped. A Tel member had broken both chisel teeth trying to bite through his helmet's edge. A Vaor woman pressed against the wall and repeated that she could hear her young, although she had never had children.

Taren halted the formation. Every minute let the agents regroup, but the people could no longer be treated as a continuous line. Doctors injected inhibitors only into those who consented. The others received water, contact and small tasks: counting the wounded, checking weapons, beating the new rhythm into the pipes.

"We can't stop after every sound," an Orm officer said.

"We just stopped without choosing," Taren replied. "Now we choose how long it lasts."

He knelt beside the woman who heard her children.

"What's your name?"

"Lira Sen."

"There's no one in the tunnel by that name," the doctor said.

"I didn't ask you," Taren said. "Lira, what's in your hand?"

She looked at the blade as though seeing it for the first time.

"A foam knife."

"Who do you give it to?"

"The doctor."

She held it out. Her breathing slowed. Taren asked her to stay with the wounded. He did not call her weak or promise the fear had passed. When he stood, Sen watched him from beside Raal.

"She ran," the boy said.

“Yes.”

“And she stays in the First Face?”

“If she wants.”

“Then what does the name mean?”

Taren wiped the blood from his palm.

“It means we come back. Not that we never leave.”

It was a more modest definition than the songs'. Sen seemed disappointed.

The formation moved again. In the next chambers, fighting became close and without an image. Central agents wore no personal signs. They withdrew in order, closed doors, used foam and projectiles that severed tendons without piercing organs. That restraint itself made some attackers angrier. It was easier to hate an enemy who denied himself visible cruelty after his system had killed from afar.

Taren saw a Vaor fighter striking a fallen agent. He stopped him at the second blow.

“My brother died in the mist!” the fighter shouted.

“This one didn't give the order.”

“He carried it out.”

“And now you're carrying out what you think I want.”

The man lowered his weapon. Not because he was convinced, but because Taren stood before him. The difference troubled Taren more than the blow.

In another corridor, a Tel team killed three agents after surrender. No one in command learned until the bodies were found. The Code worked only where someone was willing to enforce it against their own people.

Nemi and Hale advanced towards the Chamber of Measure through the water nodes. Above them, the city vibrated in contradictory rhythms: alarm, retreat, attack, lost children, open gates, closed gates. The Great

Hearing tried to classify them. Hale's portable screen displayed thousands of automatic decisions every second. Ventilation moved air from a damaged neighbourhood. Reservoirs isolated contamination. Doors opened evacuation routes and closed them when density became dangerous.

"If we stop the system, we kill the city," Hale said.

"If we leave it only to Seln, the city remains his weapon."

"Then there's no good button."

"No. There's only who can press it and who can stop the hand."

They reached a gallery where water rose to their chests. Hale, weakened by his wound, slipped. Nemi caught his belt, but the current pulled them both towards a filter screen. For a few moments, archives, keys and war were reduced to breathing and a metal edge. Hale struck the pipe with his foot. The vibration travelled.

From downstream came the answer of a Hands team reopening the secondary valve on Sava's orders. The water level fell. Nemi never saw those who had saved them. In the official recording, the act would appear as "flow restoration".

• • •

In the Gardens of Kinship, Raal opened the gates. The families came out in disorder. Sen was guiding them towards the evacuation pipes when the saryx descended from the ceiling.

The creature had grown up in captivity and did not know how to hunt well. It was hungry, blinded by light and full of broken electrodes. It attacked the first large movement: a group of running children.

Sen stopped.

He raised his blade, exactly as he had seen in the stories.

Raal struck him from the side and threw him under a table. The saryx caught Raal instead. Its claws pierced his armour, and its vertical mouth closed over his shoulder.

Raal did not try to run. He drove his only intact chisel tooth into the mouth's soft tissue and held the creature close, giving the others time to pass.

Sen came out from under the table and raised a thermal projectile.

"No!" Raal shouted. "The children!"

A discharge would have set the whole garden alight. Sen lowered the weapon and pulled the children towards the tunnel. When the last passed through, the saryx had lifted Raal off the floor.

Raal looked at him with his one visible eye.

"Now," he said.

Sen fired.

Fire engulfed them both.

The explosion opened a crack in the Gardens' wall, directly onto the Low Square. Smoke emerged where, nine years earlier, Taren had killed the first creature.

The outer gates opened.

The Houses' armies entered Ivarra.

Taren reached the square before them and placed his First Face between civilians and allies. When Orm fighters tried to enter shops, he disarmed them. When Tel demanded the right to spoils for the years of winter, he replied that the first person taking food without a record would be tried under the Law of the Face.

"Did you conquer the capital to guard its depots?" a commander shouted.

"I came to open the gates," Taren replied. "Not change who closes them."

Not everyone listened. Looting broke out in the southern neighbourhoods. Central agents and Corps killed one another in tunnels

without witnesses. By mid-cycle, three thousand people had died, mostly civilians caught between groups claiming to protect them.

After Raal's death, Sen made no sound. He held his weapon in both hands, and the creature's blood ran down his forearms. The children Raal had pushed towards the exit cried and crowded around the tables. Some looked at Sen as their saviour. None had seen who threw himself in first.

The doctor approached Raal's body. His armour was open from shoulder to abdomen. Raal still breathed, infrequently, through a punctured lung.

"Get them out," he told Sen.

The boy knelt.

"I'll take you to the doctors."

"These are doctors."

"I'll take you to Vessa."

Raal tried to laugh and coughed blood.

"Don't turn every dead person into an impossible task. Get the children out."

"Why did you do that?"

"Because you were in the way."

Sen shook his head angrily.

"Tell me the truth."

"That is it. I pushed you. Now push them."

Raal moved his remaining intact sail towards the children once. Then his body relaxed. The doctor checked his pupils and closed his mouth.

Sen stayed beside him until one of the children tugged at his cloak.

"Is another one coming?"

There was no other saryx. But shots came from the corridors, and smoke descended through the ceiling. Sen stood. He paired the children,

counted them twice and led them towards evacuation. He spoke in Taren's voice, briefly and without promises. He did exactly what Raal had asked. Later, he would remember only that he had killed the creature.

In the Low Square, the gates opened under the explosion's pressure. Air from the outer tunnels entered like a dirty wind, carrying the camp's smell and the Houses' shouts. The first units crossed without waiting for an order. Taren tried to form civilian corridors, but the square filled with signs, weapons and people searching for relatives.

A woman from the Gardens recognised her brother in the Tel Corps. She ran towards him, and a central agent mistook her for an attacker. The projectile broke her knee. Her brother killed the agent before he could explain. In another corner, two Orm families refused to leave with the unit that had come to free them. The commander ordered them taken "for safety".

Taren understood that opening was not an event. It was the beginning of a struggle over every freed person.

"Vaor units, protect exits and hospitals!" he beat through the ground. "No requisitions! No families moved by force!"

The signal repeated, but the other Corps transmitted their own orders. The square had become a language with too many speakers.

Near the old Retreat monument, they found Raal's body being carried on a stretcher and Sen walking beside it. Taren saw the blood, the weapon and the burn on the boy's arm. For a moment, he did not understand which body was his son's. Then Sen looked up.

"I got the children out," he said.

Taren touched his head, a gesture too small for what he felt and too public for what the boy needed.

"Raal?"

Sen looked at the stretcher.

“The saryx was Seln's.”

Taren recognised the beginning of a story that could justify anything that followed. He caught him by the shoulders.

“Raal chose to push you away and asked you to get the children out. We'll learn the rest.”

“I killed him.”

“You killed the animal.”

“It's the same thing.”

“No.”

Sen pulled his shoulders free.

“For you, everything becomes different when you have to choose who bears the blame.”

He went towards the doctors. Taren stayed beside Raal while the army passed through the gates and civilians ran in both directions.

He had no time to mourn him. The first looting report came from the south. House Tel had occupied a food depot and closed the doors with people inside. Orm claimed the transport station. A Corps without a House had raised its own flag over a school and declared the neighbourhood free.

Taren opened the general channel.

“The objective is the Chamber of Measure. All units remain in their assigned sectors.”

The Tel commander answered after a pause.

“Your objective. Ours began after the gates opened.”

In the city centre, Nemi had reached the Chamber entrance. Sava and Seln waited for her. Hale leaned against the wall, almost unconscious. Ventilation fluctuated. On the map, each colour of the alliance spread through Ivarra like a separate infection.

Taren set off towards them with Sen and the rest of the First Face. Behind them, three thousand dead, wounded and missing people were already beginning to receive reasons.

CHAPTER XXI

THE CUSTODIAN

TAREN, SAVA AND NEMI · THE CHAMBER OF MEASURE

The Custodian did not lose power when the army entered the Chamber. He lost it only after forcing the victors to choose which instruments to keep. In that room, the new order was born from an emergency no one had time to define.

Nemi reached the Chamber of Measure and opened the last door with Daran's key.

Inside were Sava and Seln Aru.

The Custodian wore no armour. On the table stood two cups of infusion and the Ilen–Ven family's closed file.

“Taren is near,” Nemi said.

“I know. The Great Hearing counts his steps.”

“Then transfer the keys.”

“When he enters.”

“Why wait?”

Seln looked at the city map, full of red dots.

“Because victory is the last moment a conqueror can still say everything was necessary. Afterwards, he begins to choose.”

The door opened.

Taren entered covered in blood from several sides. Behind him came Sen, a burn across half his face and Raal's broken necklace clenched in his hand.

Seln Aru stood.

“Now,” he said, “we can measure what you've become.”

Taren did not answer. He closed the door behind him, and for a moment the city's noise became a distant vibration. The Chamber of Measure had been designed to soothe. Its curved walls had no edges, light came from below, and the air retained the faint smell of herbs used in birth centres. The blood on his armour looked darker in that light.

Nemi saw him scan the exits, ventilation openings, the place from which Seln could release gas. He did not look at the Custodian as a man. He looked at the Chamber as a creature.

"The systems are in civil mode," Sava said. "No veyrin in the pipes."

"How do you know?"

"I checked."

"And if the check depends on him?"

Seln raised one cup.

"The infusion isn't poisoned either. But I won't insult you by asking you to believe it."

Sen stepped towards the table. The burn ran from his temple to beneath his jaw; his down had shrivelled into black edges. A doctor had applied a transparent membrane, but the boy had torn it off. In his other hand, he held Raal's necklace so tightly the metal had cut his palm.

Sava approached.

"Let me see the wound."

"Not now."

"Now, precisely."

Sen moved back. Taren gestured for him to let her. The boy agreed only because the gesture could be interpreted as an order. Sava cleaned the burn with sterile water. He did not flinch. Not because it did not hurt; his jaw was clenched, and his fingers around the necklace had turned white. But he had practised stillness before pain for years.

"Raal would have made noise," Sava said.

Sen looked at her.

“What?”

“He swore when we treated him. Said ignored pain becomes a commander.”

“He didn't say that.”

“He said it to me, at the Lake.”

The boy loosened his grip a little. Sava fixed the membrane back in place. Around them, the adults waited for him to become a symbol or a child again. For a few moments, he remained only wounded.

Hale had collapsed beside the door. Nemi called the doctors and handed them the slate with the map. As they lifted him, he caught her wrist.

“Don't let the gates close again.”

“We won't.”

“That's not the same as keeping them open.”

Then he fainted. Nemi thought that in a few hours they had all learned to speak in warnings.

Seln opened the Ilen–Ven family file. It was not a theatrical gesture. The document integrated into the table, and graphs rose into the air: birth rights, assessments, moves, consumption, treatments. Their life reduced to coloured paths.

Seln Aru did not ask who had won.

He looked at the burn on Sen's face, the blood on Taren's armour and Nemi's running slate. Then he opened the Ilen–Ven family file and projected it above the table.

“Four people,” he said. “One authorised birth. One postponed until it became impossible. One individual from the Adaptive Reserve. One death produced by a non-lethal intervention. If I'd wanted to invent an accusation against my system, I wouldn't have constructed one so elegant.”

Taren drew his blade and placed it on the table.

“Transfer control.”

“Not yet.”

Sen took a step. Taren stopped him with his arm.

“The saryx in the Gardens killed Raal,” the boy said.

Seln turned his body towards him.

“It was released when an explosion disabled the museum's locks. I didn't give the order.”

“You kept it there.”

“Yes.”

“Then it's yours.”

“By that logic, every death caused by the First Face belongs to your father.”

Sen drew air between his chisel teeth. His hand went towards his weapon.

Taren caught it.

“Raal told you to get the children out, not find him a reason,” he said.

Sen lowered his gaze. For the first time since entering, his body turned sideways, the old retreat position.

Seln noticed that too.

“You can still teach him,” he said.

“You don't talk about my son.”

“I'm talking about the successor the world is building around him, as it built one around you.”

Taren gripped the table's edge.

“You've watched me since childhood.”

“The Chamber tracks every rare deviation.”

“You sent me to Vaor.”

“Yes.”

“Why?”

Seln touched the map. Vaor appeared as a network of red chambers, many hidden at the time of the first inspection.

“The models showed three probable outcomes. In the first, Daran was replaced, the population redistributed and the domain survived with controlled losses. In the second, Daran provoked a revolt, and you were killed or arrested before becoming a symbol. In the third, his unit became useful and could be absorbed into a planetary risk service.”

“You didn't foresee the war?”

“I put it below four per cent.”

Nemi laughed without joy.

“Then the Great Hearing understood nothing.”

“It understood behaviours. It didn't understand stories. Daran took a rare individual and gave him a story in which his rarity explained everyone's suffering. After that, every victory rewrote the probabilities.”

Sava approached the map.

“Would you have stopped everything if you'd known?”

Seln thought before answering.

“I would have tried.”

“How? Another postponement? Sterilising Taren? More mist?”

“Perhaps.”

Taren bared his chisel teeth.

“And you call me a monster.”

“No. Monsters are simple. You're an institution that still thinks it's a person.”

At the word **institution**, Taren took the blade from the table, turned it and replaced it with the edge towards himself. Sava knew the gesture: he was trying to occupy his hands before anger became action.

“You saw three outcomes,” he said. “In all of them, you used us.”

“In all of them, I tried to reduce loss,” Seln replied.

“That isn't the answer.”

“It's the only one I have.”

Nemi scrolled through the file. She found Sava's first postponement, Taren's assessment, Oru's transfer to Vaor and her own birth. Beside every decision appeared a column of justifications and a column of estimated effects. Actual effects had been added later in red. Oru's death occupied one line: **collateral loss associated with incomplete dispersal under veyrin.**

“Read it,” she told Seln.

The Custodian looked at the line.

“You know what it says.”

“Read it aloud.”

Sava wanted to stop her. Not because Seln needed protection, but because Oru's name did not deserve to become evidence in a confrontation where everyone sought control. Nemi looked at her and understood. Then she pushed the file towards the Custodian anyway.

Seln read the exact wording.

Nemi unfolded her slate and projected her father's last recording: the room with foam, the sound of slowed breathing, Oru's hand searching for a wall that was no longer there. She did not let the image reach his death. She stopped it while he was still trying to rise.

“This is the complete effect,” she said.

Seln did not look away.

“Yes.”

“And you'd still use the mist again?”

“In the exact same conditions, with the same alternatives known then, probably.”

Sen made a short sound. Taren put a hand on his shoulder before he moved.

“Why do we let him talk?” the boy asked.

“Because we want something other than an execution,” Sava replied.

“Raal didn't get a tribunal.”

“Neither did the saryx.”

“Don't talk about him as if he were an animal.”

“About whom?”

Sen stopped. In his mind, Raal and the creature, the Custodian and the cage, death and reason had become too tightly bound. Sava saw the moment when the boy could choose between pain and doctrine. No sentence could make the choice for him.

“Raal received a life,” she said. “And in that life, he did many things that don't fit inside how he died. Don't take away the rest to make hatred easier.”

Sen turned his profile. He neither accepted nor attacked. For the moment, it was enough.

A thread of dust fell from the ceiling. The southern explosion reached the Chamber after a long delay. The map filled with warnings.

An explosion came from the city. The map changed colour in South Root. House Tel's Corps had attacked a depot, and central agents had responded. Three air pipes were damaged.

Nemi opened communications.

“The Tel commander demands control of a mirror and requisition rights. She says without them she'll withdraw her Corps and let the neighbourhood burn.”

Taren activated the channel.

“Stop the attack and hand the depot over to the local administration.”

The commander's face appeared. Blood marked her muzzle, and the Face sign was painted in gold.

“We lost two thousand fighters getting into Ivarra. We aren't going back with relatives and promises.”

“You didn't come for spoils.”

“Perhaps you didn't. The Houses voted for a division after victory.”

“I didn't vote.”

“Then you don't lead the alliance.”

The transmission ended.

Seln looked towards Taren.

“This is the choice I wanted to see. You can keep the army if you give it what it demands. You can keep the city if you turn the First Face against those who brought you here. Either option produces a centre.”

“You constructed the situation.”

“Leadership is the art of receiving situations constructed by others and pretending the remaining choice belongs to you.”

Taren turned to Nemi.

“Can you open every channel in the city?”

“With the Custodian's transfer.”

“Seln.”

The Custodian sat. For the first time, he looked old.

“The Great Hearing has no single button,” he said. “Control is a network of trust. I can transfer the keys to you, to Nemi or to a council. But the system will require a continuity structure. Who decides when you two disagree?”

“The council of functions,” Sava said. “Faces, Hands, Memory and elected representatives of those now called Protected.”

“Four centres in a crisis,” Seln replied. “You’ll be paralysed.”

“One centre brought us here.”

“Two centres brought us here,” Nemi said. “Yours and Taren’s. Put the keys at five nodes. No major reorientation without three. Local operations remain automatic and public.”

“The Houses will capture the nodes.”

“Then distribute them by function, not territory.”

Taren looked at her.

“Memory gets one.”

“Not me. The archive, with a limited mandate.”

“Mandates expire only if someone can take them away.”

Sava almost smiled. Her daughter answered Seln in her own language.

“The civil node can’t remain undefined,” Sava said over the ventilation alarm. “Otherwise the first four functions will appoint for themselves the population they claim to represent.”

“We don’t have time for elections,” Taren replied.

“We have time to invent a Custodianship while the city burns.”

“The Custodianship already exists.”

“Exactly.”

Nemi opened the neighbourhood registers. The city had housing councils, parent groups, care associations and representatives of those

without a function. None covered the Belt. Yet all were more real than an empty place on a diagram.

“A provisional node of representatives from the affected neighbourhoods,” she said. “A hundred-day mandate. After that, a general assembly.”

Seln slowly shook his head.

“The central neighbourhoods will have communications infrastructure and capture the selection.”

“Then we allocate half by population, half by lot among recognised communities,” Sava said.

“Hidden communities aren't recognised.”

“We recognise them.”

“In one sentence?”

“That's how they were excluded.”

Taren listened and watched air pressure fall on the map. South Root had twenty-eight thousand inhabitants. House Tel held the depot, central agents controlled the pumping station, and fire approached the food reservoirs. Every second of improvised constitution made him more willing to take the key alone.

Seln noticed.

“That's urgency's advantage,” he said. “Not that it persuades people to abandon rules. It persuades them the rule they want can be written later.”

“Be quiet,” Taren said.

“You haven't taken my office yet.”

“Not for that reason.”

On the medical channel, Vessa requested access to the southern neighbourhood. Agents and Tel both refused the corridor, each suspecting the doctors would carry weapons for the other side. Taren opened a direct channel.

“Vessa, you have twelve minutes before we lose ventilation.”

“Then stop the firing.”

“I’m working on it.”

“No, you’re working on who will have the right to stop the firing. Meanwhile I have a hundred and thirty wounded in a station without air.”

Taren closed his eyes. Every argument in the Chamber was true, and all became obscene beside the breathing on the channel.

“Seln, transfer the Custodianship to me for six hours. After six hours, the key automatically enters the five-node structure.”

“The system doesn’t have that condition.”

“Write it.”

“Not in six minutes.”

Nemi approached the interface.

“I can set an automatic challenge. At six hours, the other four nodes vote on whether to retain the key. Until then, all orders become public with a delay of no more than a minute.”

“A minute could expose troop positions,” Taren said.

“Then you’re beginning to choose what transparency means in war.”

“Not now.”

“Now,” Sava repeated.

Taren looked at the three women, then at the map. At last, he nodded.

Nemi entered the condition. The Great Hearing requested validation from the current Custodian. Seln did not yet place his palm.

“I want you to understand what you’re doing,” he said. “You aren’t dividing power. You’re dividing the right to declare that the others are preventing rescue.”

“And you kept that right alone,” Sava replied.

“Yes. Now you’ll learn whether the plural makes it less dangerous or only harder to trace.”

The second explosion shook the Chamber.

A second explosion shook the Chamber. Ventilation fell. On the map, the southern neighbourhood was losing pressure.

“Transfer,” Taren said.

Seln placed his palm on the table. The system read his biological signature. Five lights appeared: operational Custodianship, the Chamber of Measure, the Memory Corps, the Hands Network and a civil node still undefined.

“Custodianship to whom?” the system asked.

Seln looked at Taren.

“If you take it, you’ll have the power to stop wars between Houses. You’ll also have the power to start them without asking.”

“If I don’t take it, Tel tears the city apart now.”

“Exactly.”

Taren placed his palm.

“Transfer to Taren Ilen, First Face of the Confederation.”

The key turned red, then white.

At that instant, the city recognised him. Administrative doors answered him, channels opened, repair drones awaited commands. Power did not feel like a crown. It felt like a thousand small things that had stopped telling him no.

Taren opened every speaker.

“House Corps, listen. The Gardens are open. Families are free to leave or stay. The light in the west has been restored. No House receives

spoils, territory or orbital control. All units withdraw to designated areas and surrender heavy weapons until the Council is formed.”

The Tel commander answered publicly.

“And if we refuse?”

Taren looked at the map. He could shut off the air to the depot holding her Corps. He could move lights, block doors, stop food. Seln's instruments offered him victory without a blade.

“Then the First Face will remove you,” he said.

“Our brothers against us?”

“You are no one's brothers while you hold civilians between weapons and food.”

In the square, Vaor's members turned south. They had fought beside Tel at the Lake, in winter and at the gates. Now they went against them.

The fighting lasted two more hours. Taren did not stop the air. He lost three hundred people to avoid using a mechanism he had condemned. House Tel surrendered after its commander was wounded. This time, the Code held.

When the key turned white, Taren felt the city not as territory but as a multitude of requests. A blocked door demanded priority. A reservoir lost pressure. Four hundred drones awaited routes. Central agents requested confirmation of the new hierarchy. The Great Hearing offered options ordered by estimated losses.

The first recommendation was simple: close the air to the Tel depot for seven minutes. Probability of surrender, eighty-six per cent. Estimated civilian losses, between twelve and forty-nine.

Taren rejected it.

The second: immobilising foam in every corridor, including the medical station. Lower estimated losses, but wounded people with respiratory injuries would die.

He rejected it.

The third: direct assault through two service galleries. Estimated own losses, between two hundred and six hundred. Civilians, below twenty if Tel did not use them as shields.

“The system teaches you how quickly spending your own people becomes acceptable,” Seln said.

“You're no longer an adviser.”

“No. That's why I can tell the truth without turning it into a recommendation.”

Taren selected the direct assault. He sent orders to the First Face and simultaneously opened the medical corridor. Vessa answered with a single sentence:

“Bring me alive those you can save without killing the others.”

In South Root, Vaor units entered through smoke-filled galleries. Doors now answered Taren's signature, but Tel had mechanically welded some and placed explosives at others. Digital power stopped before a metal bar. The Hands had to cut, pump, carry.

Sen watched the map from the Chamber. Taren had ordered him to stay with Sava, but the boy approached the interface whenever a unit appeared. He recognised names. Many had trained him.

“Send Varo's team through the west,” he said. “The eastern gallery has a blind step.”

Taren checked. The boy was right; training plans used that area.

“How do you know?”

“I was there at the winter festival.”

Taren changed the route. A moment later, the eastern mine exploded without casualties. Sen saw the adults' faces acknowledge his usefulness. The burn, blood and map made him look older. Taren felt the world raising his son before he had time to take him away.

“Enough,” he said. “Go to Vessa.”

“I can help.”

“You have helped.”

“Then why do I have to leave?”

“Because I don't want you learning that the only way to stay in the room is to be indispensable.”

Sen gripped Raal's necklace.

“You stayed.”

“Yes.”

“Then that isn't the lesson you're teaching.”

Sava took his hand. He tried to pull away, then yielded. Before leaving, he looked at the controls again. Not with wonder, but with the hunger of someone shown a language he already understood.

The fighting in the south lasted longer than the Great Hearing estimated. Tel had moved civilians into inner chambers, officially for protection, practically to prevent foam and projectiles. The First Face advanced room by room. Whenever they encountered a family, they formed a corridor, took it out and resumed the attack. The pace gave defenders time to withdraw and prepare the next position.

A Vaor commander requested permission to stop the light and enter with thermal vision.

“The civilians have no eye protection,” Taren replied.

“We're losing people.”

“I know.”

“They know you refuse every advantage. They use our Code as a wall.”

Taren watched the list of the dead grow.

“Then the wall holds for us too.”

He was not sure the sentence made sense to those in the tunnel. It made sense to him in the Chamber, where every option could be executed without smell or scream. Someone had to pay for refusing Seln's instruments. This time, those who had followed him paid.

When House Tel surrendered, three hundred and twenty-seven First Face members had died or were too wounded to fight. Twelve civilians had been killed, nine by Tel's fire, three by the attackers. The commander was brought to the square on a stretcher. She spat at Taren when he came to see her.

"You gave the city our lives to look cleaner than Seln."

"No," he said. "I asked you not to hold food and people at gunpoint."

"And when you hold the city?"

Taren did not answer. She laughed, then lost consciousness.

• • •

When quiet returned, Seln removed his white cloak and placed it on the table.

"I surrender to the Custodianship," he said.

Sen abruptly raised his head.

Taren looked at the former ruler.

"You'll be tried for the mist, manipulation of the light and detention of families."

"By the survivors?"

"By a mixed tribunal."

"A scribe's distinction."

Taren recognised Orven Tal's phrase.

"All laws are."

"And if I'm convicted?"

“I won't intervene.”

“Then you've learned a ruler's most important privilege: naming the separation between his decision and the hand that carries it out.”

Sava approached Seln.

“You could be free if you'd ordered the agents to fight to the end.”

“I could be dead. Don't confuse freedom with the last available gesture.”

The new Custodianship's agents came to take him. Taren asked for him to be taken to the Gardens of Kinship until the trial.

Seln smiled for the first time.

“You'll discover why I called them gardens instead of cells,” he said. “A cage becomes easier to keep when the guard can convince himself the prisoner lives well.”

After he left, the Belt map remained open.

Fifteen local conflicts continued. Six domains refused the new Council. Food quotas were insufficient. Children born under the Face Charter were already old enough for training. No key could change all this without hands, orders and someone to decide what an emergency meant.

Taren sat in the Custodian's place.

Sen stayed beside him.

Sava saw the boy looking at the controls with recognition, not wonder.

“Don't let him think they belong to him,” she told Taren.

“They don't belong to me either.”

“I know. That's precisely why they'll be hard to give back.”

After Seln was taken away, no one immediately occupied his place. Central agents awaited Taren's orders, House Corps awaited the division, and civilians awaited word on whether they could go out. Nemi projected a simple instruction in every neighbourhood: *The gates

remain open. No person may be moved without consent. Vital services take priority over House claims.*

Then she added: *Any violation can be recorded with the Memory Corps.*

In the first ten minutes, seventeen thousand recordings arrived. Some showed looting, beatings and arrests. Others were family arguments, neighbours taking extra water, lost children. Memory did not have enough people to verify them. Transparency produced more truth than the institution could carry.

Sava went down to the square. She no longer wore the Chamber's cloak; she had left it on the back of Seln's chair. She helped organise missing-person lists. At a medical post, an Ivarra woman asked her to find a son taken by agents three cycles earlier. Elsewhere, a Tel man sought a sister from the Gardens who refused to leave with him. Everyone came with a story in which opening the gates was supposed to resolve something years had made irreversible.

Beside the Retreat monument, Raal's body awaited official identification. He had no relatives in the registers. The Night outcasts claimed he belonged to their community; Vaor called him a founder of the First Face; Sen refused to let anyone remove his necklace. Vessa sat beside the boy.

"We have to clean his body," she said.

"Not now."

"The smell will attract contamination."

"I don't care."

"He would have. He spent half the winter arguing with doctors about hygiene."

Sen looked at her disbelievingly.

"He didn't talk about that."

“With you, he talked about what he thought you needed. With me, he talked about pus and missing teeth.”

She reached towards the necklace. Sen gripped it.

“This stays with me.”

“All right.”

“For ever.”

“You don't have to decide grief's duration on the first day.”

Sen finally began to cry. Silently at first, then with broken breaths that shook his burn. Vessa held his shoulders. People passed and pretended not to see. For a species that had communicated through body orientation for millennia, discretion meant offering someone your profile.

Taren stayed in the Chamber of Measure until after mid-cycle. His temporary key reached its limit. The other four provisional nodes voted to retain it for ten more days because fighting had not stopped. The civil node still did not exist; in its place voted a hastily assembled collection of seventeen neighbourhood representatives. Thirteen approved, four opposed.

“You promised six hours,” Nemi told him.

“I voted against the extension.”

“And you still stay.”

“The rule says I stay.”

“Seln would be proud.”

Taren removed his armour. Beneath it, his body was covered in small cuts, burns and foam stains. Nemi noticed him trembling. Not from fear, but exhaustion and stimulants.

“Go to bed,” she said.

“There are fifteen conflicts.”

“There'll be fourteen when you wake, or sixteen. No state of the world will give you permission on its own to leave the table.”

“Who tells you to sleep?”

“The archive. After forty hours, my error rate rises and someone else must validate the recordings.”

“The Custodianship has no biological limit in its protocol.”

“Then put one in.”

Taren opened the rules. He wrote that any key holder must be replaced after twenty hours of continuous activity, except by a decision signed by three nodes. The system accepted.

“The new order's first law,” Nemi said. “The ruler must sleep.”

“It won't appear in songs.”

“Then perhaps it works.”

Before leaving, Taren went down to Raal. The body had been cleaned and wrapped in a simple membrane. Sen slept beside him, his head on Vessa's knees. Taren sat on the other side. He made no oath and did not promise the dead man his death would change the world. He placed the broken prosthetic beside his hand and stayed until the city's lights entered the night cycle.

Outside, the House armies still beat their signs through the ground. Inside, drones repaired pipes, doctors counted the wounded, families decided whether to leave, and old agents received uniforms without insignia.

Ivarra had been conquered. No one yet knew by whom.

PART V

THE LAW OF THE LIVING

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CHAPTER XXII

THE TRIAL

SAVA · IVARRA · THE FIRST NINE MONTHS OF THE NEW ORDER

Seln's trial was meant to separate the old order from the new. Instead, it showed how many instruments of centralised peace had become indispensable to the very people who defeated it.

Seln Aru's trial lasted nine months and produced six incompatible definitions of peace.

Central agents maintained that veyrin had prevented a lethal attack. Vaor's survivors showed the bodies of those who had died too calm to run. Mirror engineers demonstrated that moving the light had prevented system overload. White Winter refugees described children buried in frozen soil. The Gardens of Kinship families were divided: some demanded punishment, others testified that they feared returning home more than closed gates.

Seln denied no act.

The tribunal had been built in the old census hall. For four centuries, quotas, moves and birth rights had been approved there. Now the officials' tables formed a semicircle, and the place where families had awaited decisions became witness space.

No side had accepted the panel's initial name. The Houses wanted “the Court of Liberation”. The old agents proposed “the Continuity Commission”. Mist survivors demanded “the Judgement of the Dead”. Sava insisted on a weaker formula: Mixed tribunal for acts of administration and conflict. Everyone hated it, confirming for her that it was sufficiently untriumphant.

The panel had one magistrate from Ivarra, one from Vaor, two elected representatives of affected communities and one Memory member; Sava presided. Taren was not part of it. The Custodianship provided security

and could execute the sentence, but his key did not open the evidence archive. Nemi had designed the separation and published the code. In the first weeks, people assumed it was a gesture of trust. Later they understood it had been a gesture of distributed distrust.

Seln came without cloak or restraints. He had lived seven months in the Gardens, in a home identical to those occupied by House families. He had access to books, an inner courtyard and a wall that turned opaque when he approached the exit. He had grown thin. Every morning, he tended his own nutrient plants and sent the tribunal notes on procedural errors in his trial.

“Are you preparing your appeal?” Nemi had asked at one hearing.

“I’m preparing the institution that will need to judge someone else after me.”

“You assume you’ll remain useful.”

“No. I assume you’ll remain capable of mistakes.”

The first month was devoted to the mist in Vaor. Engineers explained that veyrin had been developed for evacuations and riots in enclosed spaces. It reduced aggression, slowed breathing and made groups easy to direct. At official doses, mortality was below one in a thousand. In Vaor, damaged filters, panic, fires and overcrowding had turned the percentage into seventeen hundred bodies.

A defence lawyer presented the alternative model: if agents had entered with lethal weapons, probable deaths were three times higher. The hall murmured. A woman whose partner had died in the mist stood and threw a piece of breathing membrane towards the table.

“He wasn’t a probability,” she said.

The Ivarra magistrate demanded her removal. Sava refused.

“If the tribunal can’t bear the sentence, it can’t evaluate the model,” she said.

The woman remained. At the end, she testified that she too had advised neighbours to enter the chamber where they died, because central instructions said it was safe. When the lawyer asked whether she considered herself responsible, she began crying.

“That’s the wrong question,” Sava intervened. “The witness had no access to data withheld by command.”

“Yet she carried out an instruction,” the lawyer said.

Sava looked at Seln. He did not react. The trial was already becoming a struggle over the line between decision and obedience.

In the third month, Mera Sol testified. She was very old; a frame supported her sails, and her voice came through an amplifier. She had been Taren’s therapist and signed the Adaptive Reserve recommendation.

“Did you know he was being tracked as a rare individual?” Nemi asked from Memory’s bench.

“Yes.”

“Did you tell him?”

“No. He was a child.”

“Did you tell Sava?”

“I had no permission.”

“Did you oppose using him?”

With her lateral eyes, Mera searched for a point no longer in the hall.

“I opposed authority over others. I recommended technical work, emergency teams, environments where delayed flight could save lives. I thought I was offering him a way to exist without being fully normalised.”

“You sent him towards dangerous places.”

“Yes.”

“For his good or the system's?”

“At the time, I didn't separate the questions.”

Taren watched from the back row. He had not spoken to Mera since leaving for Vaor. After the hearing, he waited for her in the corridor.

“You knew,” he said.

“I knew part of it.”

“When you told me my difference could be useful, you weren't trying to help me. You were preparing me.”

“I was trying to do both.”

“You can't.”

“Parents do. Teachers do. You do it with Sen.”

Taren turned his body face-on. Mera did not retreat.

“I tell him who I am,” he said.

“You tell him who you want him not to become. That's an equally powerful form of shaping.”

Taren left without saying goodbye. That evening, he asked Sen to choose for himself whether to keep attending training. The boy asked whether refusal would change how he looked at him. Taren could not promise it would not.

The fourth month concerned the White Winter. Maps showed the mirrors moving in small steps, each justified by protection of central crops. Engineers demonstrated that no individual command had created the catastrophe. The catastrophe emerged through accumulation and because affected regions had no key to challenge it.

A refugee delegation brought containers of frozen soil. They placed them before the tribunal and recited the names of children who had not reached Vaor. At the eighty-third name, the central magistrate requested a break.

“How much of this is evidence and how much ritual?” Seln's lawyer asked.

“Your legal system was born from rituals it learned to call procedure,” Nemi replied.

Sava asked her to stop intervening from the floor. Nemi accepted and published the observation in the trial archive.

The fifth month concerned the Gardens of Kinship. Testimonies contradicted one another. Some described detention, threats and blocked messages. Others described the only place their children had received food during the wars. Hale said the gate had been a prison and his home had nevertheless been there.

“What punishment do you ask for?” the Vaor magistrate asked him.

“I don't know.”

“You're the witness to the harm.”

“Harm doesn't make me an expert in the future.”

Seln looked at him with interest. After the hearing, he sent him a note on administering mixed institutions. Hale deleted it unread, then retrieved it from the archive that same night.

In the sixth month, the prosecution called central agents. One commander admitted closing the Gardens' gates on the Custodian's orders. Another had told staff the families were there voluntarily. A third had refused to flood the pipes where Nemi hid, although regulations permitted it.

“Why did you refuse?” Sava asked.

“The order said capture, not killing.”

“Did the Custodian tell you that?”

“No. I read the limit in the protocol.”

The defence used the testimony to show the system contained moral restraints. The prosecution used it to show that an agent without political office could interpret better than the ruler. Both readings were true.

In the seventh month, Taren was called. The hall filled. Those from Vaor awaited condemnation of the past; the Faces awaited justification of the present. He left his weapon at the entrance and sat without insignia.

“Do you consider that Seln Aru created you?” the prosecution asked.

“No.”

“He tracked you, steered you towards Vaor and administered the conditions in which your unit emerged.”

“He tried to use me. Daran tried to use me. The Houses tried. Sometimes they succeeded. That doesn't make them the authors of every choice.”

“Then what do you accuse him of?”

Taren looked at Seln.

“The things he did and those he concealed so he couldn't be stopped. Not me.”

The defence asked him about Ivarra.

“Did you refuse to stop the air to House Tel, although it would have shortened the fight?”

“Yes.”

“And more than three hundred of your people died.”

“Yes.”

“You decided their lives could be spent for your principle.”

Taren stayed silent.

“Answer,” the magistrate demanded.

“Yes.”

The Faces shifted uneasily in the hall.

“What's the difference between that decision and moving the light to protect the centre?” the lawyer asked.

“My people knew the order and could refuse.”

“Could they? You were the First Face, the city was burning and their comrades were going in.”

Taren remembered the fighter who lowered his weapon only because he stood before him.

“Not as much as I'd have liked to believe,” he said.

The answer weakened the prosecution and strengthened the trial. Sava hated him for it and respected him.

In the eighth month, the panel tried to write the verdict. It could not agree on intentional homicide. Seln had not wanted the deaths in Vaor, but had accepted a risk unknown to the victims. Moving the mirrors had saved crops and killed refugees. The Gardens had protected and imprisoned.

Nemi proposed preserving the disagreements in the verdict. The central magistrate said a sentence could not have five versions.

“Then it will lie in the name of clarity,” she replied.

In the end, every charge received a majority and minority opinion. The public could read both. No one was satisfied. After nine months, the hall was ready for a conclusion that could repair nothing.

“I administered consequences,” he told the tribunal. “Some were produced by my orders. Others would have existed without them. You want a line between them because only then does punishment seem mathematical.”

Sava presided over the civil panel and hated him for understanding judgement's weakness so well.

“You used the population as a means,” she said.

“Every policy uses the population as a means to the population's survival.”

“You hid the choice.”

“Yes. That's the correct accusation.”

When Sava pronounced the conviction, a group from Vaor shouted that the punishment was too small. The old agents called it revenge. The Gardens' families split within the same row: some applauded, others asked to be allowed to visit him.

Taren did not react. Sen, beside Vessa, asked why lifelong detention was not called slow killing. Vessa told him societies sometimes preserved bodies because they did not know what to do with their meaning.

“Then why don't they send him into the Night?” he asked.

“Because that would be an execution with weather as the weapon.”

“But that's what he did to the west.”

“Being able to construct the symmetry doesn't oblige you to use it.”

Sen seemed to understand and not accept. At nine, the difference was still visible.

The tribunal acquitted him of intentional homicide and convicted him of detention, infrastructure manipulation without public oversight and falsification of risk registers. The sentence was lifelong detention in the Gardens of Kinship, with limited archive access.

“You kept the cage,” Sava told him after the verdict.

“Not I.”

“I voted for it.”

“Then you've discovered victory's first rule: the opponent's institutions suddenly become too useful to destroy.”

Seln accepted his sentence without appeal. Over the following years, he sent unsolicited comments on the new constitution from the Gardens.

Nemi kept them all. Taren claimed not to read them and sometimes quoted formulations only Seln had used.

Seln was taken back to the same home. The Gardens' gates remained open for everyone else, but became opaque when he approached. He could walk through orchards, speak with visitors and work on unclassified archives. He could not transmit directly to institutions; every text passed through Memory.

In the first week, Nemi received two hundred pages of constitutional commentary. She labelled them *opinions of a prisoner with relevant expertise* and published them alongside survivors' criticisms. Some proposals were adopted. Every adoption provoked a scandal.

"You're letting him rule from his cell," a Vaor representative said.

"An idea doesn't become untrue because its author is sentenced," Nemi replied.

"Nor innocent."

"That's why we keep the name beside it."

Taren read the comments at night. He marked useful passages and rephrased them in meetings. One day Nemi showed him two almost identical formulations.

"I don't want to give him authority," he said.

"Then you quote him without letting him carry it."

"Do you want me to thank him?"

"I want you to know where your instruments come from."

From then on, Taren published his sources. His popularity did not fall. Many considered the gesture proof he could use even the enemy's mind.

• • •

The Council of Five Nodes worked for three months.

The Chamber of Measure wanted birth limits restored. The Hands Network demanded food for destroyed regions. Memory refused to

approve any decision whose data were not public. The civil node fragmented among refugees, families and central cities. Taren's Custodianship could execute orders but could not produce them alone.

In the fourth month, House Orm attacked Tel for control of a thermal reactor.

The Council debated for two days. On the third, the reactor exploded.

Taren declared a continuity emergency and intervened without three keys. He stopped the war in six hours. Four hundred fighters died. Two hundred thousand civilians kept their heat.

The emergency was to expire after ten days.

On the ninth day, House Selc was blocking a food channel. On the seventeenth, a Corps without a House occupied a central city. On the thirty-second, young Tel people killed their own civil representative.

The emergency did not expire.

The new constitution, called the Law of the Living, retained the five nodes but granted the Custodianship direct command in armed conflicts, ecological disasters and threats to infrastructure. The threat list initially occupied one page. After five years, it occupied eighteen.

The Orm–Tel reactor conflict began as a maintenance dispute. The reactor heated three cities and two agricultural networks. Orm had built it, Tel controlled the fuel tunnels, and the new Hands Network maintained that vital infrastructure could no longer belong to a House. Every side had documents, dead people and a story about theft.

On the first day, the Council of Five Nodes discussed jurisdiction. The Chamber of Measure said the reactor should be administered according to its dependent population. The Hands demanded technical control. Memory refused transfer until contract archives were published. The civil node had two delegations challenging each other. Taren requested permission to separate the armed forces in the area. He did not receive the three keys.

On the second day, Orm stopped a line for “inspection”. Tel interpreted the act as a blockade and occupied the fuel chamber. The Council requested observers. The observers were stopped at the gate.

Taren wanted to intervene. Sava voted against.

“We can't turn every unresolved dispute into a Custodianship operation,” she said.

“There are weapons beside a reactor.”

“Then we enforce disarmament through sanctions.”

“How long does that take?”

“Two days.”

“We don't have two days.”

“That's exactly the sentence you'll bypass every node with.”

Taren withdrew his request. The following night, a Tel group tried to take over the cooling system. No one intended to blow up the reactor. A door closed over cables, pumps switched to secondary power, and a projectile struck a gas reservoir. The explosion was visible from three cities.

Taren declared the emergency before the map finished its estimate. This time he did not ask for the keys. The Custodianship entered, separated the forces and occupied the remaining reactor. It stopped the conflict in six hours.

Afterwards, Sava visited the field morgue. Four hundred fighters had died, mostly in the explosion. Among them were technicians who had tried to cool the installation. The survivors called Taren their saviour. Two hundred thousand civilians had kept their heat.

“I was wrong,” she told him.

Taren stood beside a cracked reservoir, still in armour.

“Yes.”

“We shouldn't have waited.”

“No.”

“Don't make it a general rule.”

He looked at her wearily.

“You just saw four hundred bodies.”

“And I know how easily they'll become an argument for the next intervention, when the risk won't be the same.”

“How do you want me to lead?”

“Remembering that sometimes you're right, and that's the most dangerous part.”

The emergency was to expire after ten days. On the ninth, House Selc blocked a food channel. Taren requested an extension. Three nodes approved. On the seventeenth, the Corps without a House occupied a central city. On the thirty-second, Tel's civil representative was killed. Every incident was real. Each made returning to normal rules seem irresponsible.

The threat list was written in haste: armed conflicts, infrastructure attacks, ecological disasters. Then came information sabotage, uncoordinated migration, refusal of food quotas, epidemics, transport blockages, weapons proliferation. No one introduced an article without being able to point to a crisis that justified it.

Nemi kept the originating event's name beside every category. She had hoped this would keep exceptions tied to circumstances. Instead, the names became precedents.

Taren banned the Houses' hereditary titles. In their place, Face ranks were awarded through service and examination. Commanders' children, however, had access to the best schools, better food and instructors. They passed the examinations three times as often as everyone else. The caste the law rejected emerged through training.

Additional reproductive rights were abolished as a privilege of rank. They were reintroduced as compensation for risk.

Vessa wrote the medical criteria. She tried to exclude selection for aggression, limit the number of embryos and publish the side effects. Private Houses opened clinics outside the register. Families sought the same combinations: a slow alarm response, bone density, early fertility, shorter auditory sails. Within two generations, Taren's markers became eleven times more common among the Faces.

"I am trying to reduce the harm," Vessa told Sava.

"I know."

"That is how every serious complicity begins."

Sava did not contradict her. She herself led the reorganised Chamber of Measure. She had eliminated postponements beyond fertile age, introduced transparent lotteries and guaranteed everyone a first birth. The population grew by thirteen per cent, and rations fell. After the first poor harvest, she was forced to reintroduce restrictions on second births.

A woman came to her office with an unauthorised pregnancy and asked:

"How much future must we be given before it becomes a form of no?"

It was not the same woman from Ivarra. The question had survived better than the answers.

The abolition of hereditary titles was celebrated in the Low Square. The Houses' towers lowered their emblems, and the children of former rulers had to sit the same examinations as everyone else. In the first year, the statistics looked promising. In the second, private Face academies appeared in the wealthy districts. They taught frontal orientation, panic control, strategy and command dialects. Their fees exceeded a Hands family's income.

Sava proposed equivalent public schools. The Custodianship funded them, but the best instructors stayed at the academies, where commanders' families offered them housing and birth rights. The law had opened the examination. The economy had restricted access to preparation.

Reproductive rights for risk produced the same mutation. Rank privilege had been abolished; medical compensation seemed fairer. A fighter exposed to radiation received additional embryos because his fertility might decline. A family that sent two members on the Margin Campaigns received a compensatory quota. Within five years, military service became the surest path to a large family.

Vessa led the clinical commission. Every form tried to separate healing from selection. She banned selection by aggression score, limited genetic combinations and required the children to be monitored. Private clinics moved into tunnels between jurisdictions. They promised not aggression but “stability under stress”, not a reduced flight reflex but “decision continuity”.

During an inspection, Vessa found twenty-three embryos created from the same Vaor commander’s line. The clinic’s owner claimed the families had chosen them independently.

“They all requested the same traits and the same donor in a single month,” she said.

“Reputation is distributed information.”

“Reputation is an advertisement pretending to be natural selection.”

She closed the clinic. Two weeks later, the families opened another under the protection of a House abolished in law and intact in society.

Sava found her in the laboratory at night, looking at Taren’s markers on a screen. Their frequency had already risen among Face children.

“We can ban the combinations,” Sava said.

“Then they will hide them, and we will no longer be able to track the effects.”

“We can limit the reproductive advantages of service.”

“Then the Custodianship will say you are sending people into danger without compensation.”

“We can shut down the private academies.”

“Then the families will train them at home.”

Vessa switched off the screen.

“There is no single law for us to repair. There are hundreds of parents who have seen what kind of child receives food, songs and a future.”

Sava sat beside her. In the old Chamber, selection had been centralised and explicit. The new order had dispersed it into private choices rewarded in public. It was harder to condemn, and perhaps more powerful.

A few days later, the woman with the unauthorised pregnancy came to the office. She already had one child and had requested the right to a second before the poor harvest. The lottery had rejected her.

“How much future must we be given before it becomes a form of no?” she asked.

Sava could not grant her an exception without taking food from elsewhere. She could not report her without repeating the old Chamber. She offered to register the pregnancy, provide medical support and allocate a quota to be deducted from the community’s following year.

“Then my neighbours pay for the child,” the woman said.

“Yes.”

“And they will tell the child that.”

“Probably.”

“Is this your freedom? I make the choice, and you punish the people around me until they hate me?”

Sava felt that any answer immediately became another institution.

“It is a choice in a world with finite food,” she said.

“The old Chamber said the same thing more prettily.”

The woman left without thanking her. Sava approved the pregnancy and stayed in the office for a long time, listening to the pipes. The Law of the Living was still being drafted. On the walls, the plans promised five

nodes, terms of office, transparency and equal rights. In the city, training, food, risk and desire were already writing a constitution harder to read.

CHAPTER XXIII

THE SON WITHOUT FEAR

TAREN AND SEN · TWILIGHT BELT · THE NEXT EIGHT YEARS

The return of peace did not abolish the warriors. It moved them into schools, families, examinations and rituals. In eight years, what had been a rare deviation became the model by which a generation measured its maturity.

Sen joined the Face Corps at nine. Taren had forbidden him to use the family name in the examination. All the examiners recognised him by his burn and by the way he did not flinch.

The examination took place in a room without insignia, below the level of the old Chamber. Candidates entered alone. Their names were concealed, and the assessors saw only their age, medical condition and assigned number. Taren had requested this procedure after Sen announced that he wanted to join the Face junior programme. He said his son had to pass through the same door as everyone else.

On the morning of the examination, half the assessors recognised him by his burn before the door closed. The others recognised him by the way he held his body: facing forward, motionless, his sails trimmed shorter than those of civilian children. At nine, Sen already wore a version of the uniform, although the regulations required neutral clothing.

The first test was the old saryx shadow. The system projected movement, scent and low frequencies; the child had to choose between shelter, warning and confrontation. Most candidates fled first, then corrected their course. Sen stayed. He drew his training blade and struck the point of light where the wing joint would have been.

The assessors noted **rapid decision under stress**. None wrote that the boy had seen a real saryx kill Raal, and that his response might be memory, not aptitude.

The second test placed three doors and a group of virtual children before him. Behind one was an attacker; behind another, a fire; the third led to a safe tunnel too narrow for everyone. There was no complete solution. The examination measured the order in which the candidate asked questions, not only the choice.

Sen requested access to the ventilation system, the exact number of children and the time before the fire spread. When the assessor said the data was unavailable, he asked who had withheld it.

“That is not relevant,” replied the woman behind the screen.

“Then the attacker may be the institution that designed the test.”

A laugh in the room was quickly stifled. Sen chose the safe tunnel, divided the group by body size and stayed behind the others. Two virtual children died. He asked to repeat the test with a different distribution.

“The test is over,” the assessor said.

“Then you do not find out whether I have learned.”

At the end, he received one of the highest scores in the cohort. Taren read the report and noticed the comments: **command profile**, **tolerance of loss**, **spontaneous identification with responsibility**. No paragraph mentioned his name. In the confidential appendix, however, appeared: **probable continuity of the Ilen line; high symbolic value.**

“Invalidate the examination,” Taren told the director.

“We cannot invalidate a performance because the assessors know who the candidate is.”

“Then it was not anonymous.”

“No procedure can make society forget a scar.”

Sen was listening beside the door.

“Did I pass?” he asked.

Taren turned towards him.

“You passed a test designed by people who wanted to see you pass.”

“That is not my fault.”

“No.”

“Then will you let me?”

Taren looked at the small uniform, the burn and Raal’s necklace beneath the collar.

“Yes.”

Sen smiled. For him, all his father’s warnings disappeared into that word.

Vessa was waiting outside. She congratulated him and asked him to come for a medical examination the following week. When the boy left to join his classmates, she turned to Taren.

“You tried to remove his name from the examination and left him his statue,” she said.

“He has no statue.”

“He has a living one. It walks through the city and leads the Custodianship.”

“What should I have done? Forbidden him?”

“No. You should have stopped pretending that an equal door corrects the different roads leading to it.”

Taren did not answer. In the years that followed, he would repeat that Sen had earned every rank. It was true. It was not the whole truth.

• • •

The junior programme combined schooling with service. The children learned ecology, repairs, history and bodily control. Each week, they spent a cycle in civilian institutions: warehouses, clinics, archives, farms. The idea had been Sava’s. She wanted the Faces to understand that the world did not begin at the edge of a weapon.

In his first year, Sen worked at a moss farm in Ivarra. His task was to clean the fine channels without breaking the nutrient filaments. He was

slow and bad at it. A Hands girl, Deli, showed him how to feel the pressure with his fingers.

“You do not push everything that refuses to move,” she said.

“I am not pushing.”

“The channel says otherwise.”

He tried again. By the end of the day, he was breaking fewer roots than that morning. The instructor gave him an average score. In the public report, the episode appeared as evidence of the Custodian’s son’s humility. Deli was not mentioned.

“Tell them she taught me,” Sen insisted.

“We do not control the reports,” the instructor replied.

Sen went to Memory and submitted the correction. Nemi accepted it. The recording became popular: the young Face acknowledging his Hands teacher. Deli received an invitation to the academy, but her family needed her at the farm, and she declined. Sen did not find out until years later. In the story, equality had worked.

At twelve, he was sent on a transport patrol, officially as an observer. Nivari matured quickly, and the crisis generations had driven the age of service lower still. Sen’s body was almost adult; his judgement was not.

The convoy was taking food to an unregistered community at the edge of Night. The locals had stolen two wagons the previous season, and the Custodianship had classified them as a risk. The patrol commander, Varo, wanted to retain half the rations until the community handed over the thieves.

Sen read the manifest. The children were already receiving less than they needed.

“The Code forbids using food against civilians,” he said.

“The Code forbids collective punishment,” Varo replied. “This is a logistical guarantee.”

“What is the difference for those who do not eat?”

“The intention and the condition for restitution.”

Sen opened the Custodianship channel. Varo shut down his terminal.

“You are an observer.”

“I can report the violation.”

“You can report it after the mission.”

In the settlement, people emerged from the tunnels, thin and armed with tools. Varo deployed his Faces. An old man said the thieves had died in the blizzard. He had no bodies; edge hunters had eaten them.

“Then the debt remains with the community,” Varo said.

Sen saw the children watching the wagons. He remembered the White Winter camps, which he knew only from recordings and adults’ silences.

“I will guarantee the shipment,” he said.

Varo laughed.

“With what?”

“My family quota and my service pay until the loss is covered.”

“It is not enough.”

“Then record that you refused a guarantee and kept the food.”

Varo looked at him for a long time. He did not fear the boy, but he feared the name the anonymous procedure had been unable to erase. He unloaded every wagon.

The report praised Sen for “mediation”. Varo received a reprimand and was promoted the following year. The community repaid a third of the food; the rest was no longer demanded. Sen learned that the law could protect the weak when someone powerful spoke it. He did not learn how the same law sounded in the mouth of someone without a name.

At fourteen, he led short patrols. He was rigorous. He shared his food equally, slept last and forbade trophies. When a member of his unit

struck a prisoner, he removed him from service even though he was the son of an influential House. The story spread. The young Faces loved him not for his gentleness, but because his rule could humble anyone.

That same year, he met Deli again. She now led a repair team and had two fingers deformed by an untreated infection. The academy had offered medical access with its invitation, but she had lost that right when her family declined.

“You could have come,” Sen said.

“And who would have cleaned the channels?”

“They would have found someone else.”

“Exactly.”

He did not understand at once. To him, being replaceable was an insult. To Deli, it was the reason institutions could demand sacrifice without counting it.

Sen secured her operation through the Custodianship fund. She accepted, then refused the administrative position she was offered.

“I do not want to be your good story,” she said.

“It is not a story. It is treatment.”

“Then let it remain that.”

At her request, Nemi kept the incident only in the medical file. It was one of the rare occasions when the archive became truer through what it refused to turn into a symbol.

At fifteen, Sen killed his first rebel commander. The revolt had taken place in a thermal city at the edge of Day. The Hands had seized the facility after the Face administrators reduced the water quotas. The Custodianship had been negotiating for two weeks. In the third, the rebels captured a train and killed two guards.

Sen led the team that entered through the cooling pipe. He found the commander, a woman named Iara, beside the reactor panel. Her weapon was lowered. Behind her, a device was counting down to overheating.

“Stop it,” Sen said.

“Turn on the district’s water.”

“I cannot do that from here.”

“Then call someone who can.”

Time was running out. Sen could shoot her hand, but Iara held the touch control on the detonator. He could negotiate and risk the reactor. He shot her in the head. Her body fell without releasing the mechanism. A technician stopped the sequence seven seconds before failure.

The Custodianship declared the intervention exemplary. The city received water three days later, following an investigation that confirmed the cuts had been excessive. Sen attended Iara’s funeral without insignia. Her family asked him to leave.

“I stopped the reactor,” he told Vessa after returning.

“Yes.”

“If I had waited, thousands would have died.”

“Perhaps.”

“Do not talk like Nemi.”

“What do you want me to say?”

“That I did the right thing.”

Vessa examined his pupils and pulse. The boy had not slept for two cycles.

“You made a defensible choice in a situation badly constructed by many people. If we simply call it good, everyone else disappears.”

“Father would have fired.”

“Probably.”

“Then why do you tell him he saved the world?”

“I do not tell him that.”

Sen left angry. That night, he watched the recording nine times. Not the shot, but the seven seconds afterwards, when the technician ran towards the panel. The next day, he asked for the report to mention the technician’s name. The technician became known. Iara remained “rebel commander”.

At sixteen, Sen had three children with two partners. Nivar biology made early maturity possible, and Face culture turned it into a duty. The families had chosen the embryos for compatibility, health and the same traits the clinics called stability. Sen had said he did not want selection. Yet he had accepted the variants recommended by the doctors, and those recommendations had been built from his generation’s success.

Vessa examined the children. One had a minor hearing malformation associated with the combination of bone-density markers. Another did not react to alarm sounds and was already being praised for calmness.

“Do not test him like a Face,” she told the parents.

“We are not testing him,” one of the partners replied. “Only observing.”

“Observation changes the way you touch him.”

“And you observe him medically.”

Vessa had no clean answer. Medicine and culture looked at the same child with different intentions, and both shaped him.

“We are losing him,” she told Taren.

“He was never ours.”

“Not as a son. As a possibility.”

Sen believed in the Code. He recited it perfectly, punished those who killed after surrender and divided the patrol’s food equally. He also believed the Faces were the world’s only true adults, because only they

accepted risk. When a civilian representative contradicted him, he listened face-on, then carried out the Custodianship's order.

He was more disciplined than Taren, less cruel in his gestures and far more dangerous in his convictions.

Taren heard the conversation about possibility one evening when Sen had not come home. "Home" was an apartment beneath the tower, chosen to demonstrate modesty and guarded by two corridors of agents. Vessa lived there only sometimes. Their relationship had never acquired a stable name. It had been closeness in crisis, then family, then managed disagreement.

"What did you want him to be?" Taren asked.

"A person who could refuse the role without feeling he was betraying us."

"He can refuse it."

"At what price?"

"Every choice has a price."

"Not every choice has statues of its father in the square."

Taren sat down. Exhaustion stiffened his movements. His heart had begun to lose its rhythm, and the stimulants used in the war had scarred the muscle. Vessa had prescribed rest. The Custodianship continually prescribed another emergency.

"I did not ask for the statue."

"You refused three times to take it down and called your refusal respect for the public vote."

"If I take it down, it becomes more important."

"Yes. Symbols are unfair that way. You still have to choose which unfairness you sustain."

Taren looked at Sen's room. On the wall were maps, the Code and Raal's necklace. No toys remained.

“Perhaps I lost him before I understood that I was holding him,” he said.

Vessa folded her sails.

“He is not lost. He is simply very good at what the world asks of him.”

This did not reassure him.

• • •

In the eighth year of the new order, the Festival of Retreat was restored.

The name remained, but the ritual changed. Mechanical shadows crossed the Low Square, and children no longer had to run towards the markings. They had to stay in the circle until they identified the trajectory, then decide whether shelter, warning or confrontation was the correct response. The exercise was presented as adaptive freedom.

In practice, the crowd applauded only the children who stayed.

Sava stood on the same terrace from which she had seen the first saryx. Beside her, Nemi was recording. She was twenty-two, an age at which many nivari began to grow old, but the Memory Corps had replaced her damaged joints and prolonged her hearing with implants.

“Will the archive call this a return to tradition?” Sava asked.

“The archive will preserve both versions of the ritual.”

“And the one that will be sung?”

“We do not control the songs.”

“No one controls the most effective things.”

On the platform, a small child froze beneath the shadow. He had not chosen to stay; his body had locked. The crowd applauded anyway. The instructor drew the Face sign on his chest.

“They no longer even distinguish courage from the old reflex,” Sava said.

“Perhaps they were never so different.”

The restored festival drew people from across the Belt. The square had been enlarged and covered with a transparent membrane. Above it, the red sky seemed close enough for the children to touch. Stalls sold model saryxes, toy blades and bands playing the First Face rhythm. The old Retreat figurines, in which the ancestors ran for shelter, could be found only in antique shops.

Nemi recorded from the Memory terrace. Beside her, Sava wore a plain cloak. She had relinquished the Chamber's daily management, but remained on the Council and was summoned whenever a quota caused protests. She had aged; her hind joints had been partly replaced, and the down at her temples had turned white.

Sen stood on the platform beside the instructors. His three children were in the families' area, too young for the test. The crowd watched them almost as much as the participants. When Sen raised his hand, the square fell silent before the loudspeakers amplified the gesture.

The child who froze beneath the shadow was named Ari. Sava saw his body lock: eyes wide, limbs drawn in, breathing stopped. It was not resolve. It was the old freezing reflex that Taren's therapy had once tried to correct. The instructor drew the Face sign, and his family wept with pride.

After the ceremony, Sava found them backstage. Ari was trembling.

"Do you want to join the programme?" she asked him.

The child looked at his parents.

"Yes."

"What did you feel beneath the shadow?"

"I stayed."

"Did you choose?"

His mother intervened.

"He did what he was supposed to. Why are you confusing him?"

“Because he will be trained on the basis of the reason we give him now.”

His father took Ari by the shoulder.

“Before, children like him were treated. Now they are seen.”

Sava recognised the truth. The old order had turned difference into a defect. The new order turned it into destiny. Between them, the child had little room left to discover what he had been.

Nemi kept both the applause and the backstage trembling in the archive. The public version of the festival used the image of the sign being drawn on his chest. The backstage image was accessed by seventy-three people in its first year.

That evening, the songs called Ari “the one who chose before he knew the words”.

• • •

After the ceremony, Sava found Taren at the culture growing over Oru’s grave. The roots produced bitter fruit, rich in minerals. Taren was thirty-four and already struggled to move. Wounds, implants and years of veyrin in childhood had shortened his life.

“The towers can be seen from Ivarra,” Sava said.

“That is what they were built for.”

“Daran would be pleased.”

“Daran was never pleased. That is why he understood politics.”

They sat on the ground. Above them, Oru’s root pumped water.

“You gave a generation meaning,” Sava said.

“That sounds like an accusation.”

“It is. Your meaning always requires someone to stand outside it. The soft. The Protected. Those who did not pass the examination. You took their peace and gave them roles written by others.”

“Your peace gave them births written by others.”

“Mine?”

“Ours. Stop hiding only in the part of the system you tried to repair.”

Sava touched the soil.

“Oru would say we replaced a simplified ecosystem with one full of predators we pretend to control.”

“Oru brought back the edge hunters.”

“Sterile ones.”

“Nothing remains culturally sterile.”

Taren plucked a fruit and bit it. Its bitterness tightened his face.

“Before,” he continued, “we were told that life required continuity. It was enough not to die, not to have too many children and to leave the world unchanged. When the crises came, some discovered they could be necessary. You cannot ask them to forget that.”

“No. But you can refuse to build a world that produces crises so they remain necessary.”

Taren looked at the towers on the horizon.

“Do you think I am doing that?”

“Not consciously yet.”

“And Sen?”

Sava did not answer at once.

“Sen will not need to lie about it.”

When she left, Taren stayed beside the root. For the first time in many years, he heard three knocks from the depths. They were not a military signal. The old pipes were contracting with the change in temperature, exactly as Sava had tried to explain on the night of the Festival.

Taren smiled.

Some warnings were only noises. Some noises became warnings because someone needed them.

Sava had found Taren at Oru's root after the festival. The culture had grown around the remains and now supplied a small water station. The neighbourhood children called it the Hero's Pump, although Oru had never officially been declared a hero. The name had emerged from the need to place one dead person beside the others.

As they spoke, Taren rubbed his chest. Sava noticed and did not interrupt. She had learned that medical questions made him lie.

When they came to Sen, the silence between them lasted as long as a train passing through the roots below.

"You can no longer guide him through warnings alone," Sava said.

"He does not listen to me as a son either. He assesses me as a predecessor."

"Then talk to him about the things you have not resolved."

"He sees them."

"He sees the institutions. He does not see you afraid."

Taren gave a short laugh.

"Everyone knows I am afraid."

"They know you act despite it. They do not know why you wake at night, which people you cannot look at, how often you wanted to run and stayed only because the others were watching."

"Those things do not help a Custodian."

"They help a son understand that the office is not a species."

Taren plucked a second bitter fruit and did not eat it. He placed it beside the root.

"Tomorrow," he said.

Sava knew how often the near future became the place where leaders stored their private lives.

As she left, she heard the pipes contracting. Taren stayed alone and smiled at the noise that had triggered his first false warning in childhood. That night, he sent Sen a simple message: *Come in the morning. Without your uniform.*

Sen read it during a patrol meeting. He intended to go. Before dawn, however, a pipe burst in a frontier town, and the Custodianship asked him to lead the evacuation. Taren approved the mission. Neither proposed postponing the order for the conversation.

He died in his sleep thirty-nine days later.

There was no enemy, wound or last command. His heart, subjected to years of stimulants and alarms, stopped in a guarded room.

Vessa found him. The cardiac monitor had sent the alarm, but the guards had assumed it was one of the frequent errors. Taren lay on his side, one hand beneath his head. He wore no cloak and had not reached his weapon. On the table lay the bitter fruit brought from Oru's root and a list of subjects for Sen: Raal, the fear in the tunnel, the Tel dead, the keys, what to do when the Code became a tactical advantage for the enemy.

Vessa touched him, then called the doctors, though she knew. After the room filled, she took the list and put it in her pocket. She did not want Memory's first act to turn the unfinished conversation into a perfect testament.

Sen arrived six hours later. He still wore the dust of the evacuation. Vessa told him his father had died in his sleep. He asked whether he had been poisoned, whether there had been an attack, whether there was a final order. Every question sought an adversary or a task.

"His heart stopped," Vessa said. "That is all."

"That cannot be all."

“Bodies are not obliged to offer an ending suited to a life.”

Sen went in alone. He stood beside the bed for a long time. When he came out, he had not cried.

“What was he going to tell me?” he asked.

Vessa touched the list in her pocket.

“I do not know.”

It was the first lie she had told him about Taren. She kept it for three days, until after the funeral, so that the boy would have at least one interval in which his father could not be reduced to instructions. Then she gave him the sheet.

Sen read it and folded it.

“He did not finish.”

“No.”

“Then I will finish it.”

“That was not the conversation.”

“How do you know?”

Vessa saw how quickly grief became a mandate.

“Because he asked you to come without your uniform.”

Sen placed the sheet beneath Raal’s necklace.

The funeral rites lasted three days. The abolished Houses came beneath their old emblems. The Hands carried tools, Memory projected contradictory fragments, and the Faces beat the return rhythm so loudly that dust fell from the ceiling. Sava had asked for Oru’s death, the refusal to cut Tel’s air and the votes against Taren to be included. The ceremonial committee considered them inappropriate political details.

Nevertheless, Nemi projected the complete chronology onto a side wall. Most people watched the body raised above the square.

The election of the new Custodian began the next day. There were five candidates: two mature commanders, a Hands representative, an archivist and Sen. His age provoked opposition, but the Code set no threshold for anyone who had completed service and the higher examination. His supporters said no one knew the Custodianship better. His opponents said that was precisely the problem.

The civilian node held public hearings. Sen was asked what he would do if three nodes refused him permission to intervene in a crisis.

“I would publish the data and ask again,” he replied.

“And if there is no time?”

“I would intervene on my own responsibility and accept judgement afterwards.”

The crowd applauded. The Hands representative had answered that she would respect the refusal until the procedure produced a different outcome. Her answer was more constitutional and sounded less like protection.

Sen was elected Custodian by four votes out of five.

The fifth node, the civilian one, voted against him.

The vote was not mentioned in the ceremony’s songs.

The civilian node published a thirty-page minority opinion. It warned that elections were not free when one candidate bore the founder’s name, commanded the army’s loyalty and was already the subject of songs. Memory preserved the document. It was not read at the ceremony.

Sen put on the Custodianship cloak. It was too broad across his shoulders, having been cut for Taren. The tailors had offered to alter it; he had refused.

In his first speech, he promised neither expansion, revenge nor glory. He promised stability, law and protection for those unable to bear risk. It was exactly the language the weary Belt needed.

Sava listened from the same terrace. In the square, children beat out the frontal sign. Behind Sen, Taren's statue had been covered with white mourning cloth. Its shape remained visible.

The new order had not acquired a monarch. It had acquired an elected successor, under conditions in which almost no one could imagine another choice.

CHAPTER XXIV

THE CHILDREN WHO LOOK AT THE SKY

NEMI · IVARRA · THIRTY-FOUR YEARS AFTER TAREN

Thirty-four years after Taren's death, peace was stable again, institutions old again, and children again convinced the world had always been this way. Then, from outside the system, came something that belonged to no nivar story.

Thirty-four years after Taren's death, the children no longer knew how to flee properly.

Nemi noticed this during a lesson in the Low Square. The instructor projected a saryx shadow over the group, and the children scattered too little, in almost straight lines. Some turned to face it before finding shelter. Two ran towards the mechanism to see whether they could bring it down.

By the old criteria, almost all would have been easy prey.

By the new ones, the instructor congratulated them.

They were taller than Sava's generation. Their hind limbs remained strong, but their shoulders had broadened through selection and training. Their auditory sails were shorter, sometimes through heredity, often cut in the first year so they could not be seized in combat. Their eyes still sat to the sides, but the Custodianship's clinics offered a convergence correction for Face lines, making frontal focus easier at the cost of part of the peripheral field.

Vessa had called the operation "necessary blindness". She had died before seeing how popular it became.

Nemi was fifty-six and had few original organs left. Her joints had been replaced, her blood filtered through engineered bacteria, and her sails

supported by fine rods. The Memory Corps kept her alive because no archive had managed to classify all the contradictions in her head.

Officially, she was Keeper of the First Recording.

Unofficially, she was the last person who remembered Oru's smell.

The square had been rebuilt after the siege. Where the first saryx fell now stood a statue of Taren, facing forward, carbon rod in hand. The sculptor had made his sails shorter and his shoulders broader than they had been. At its base, the inscription read: HE CHOSE TO STAY.

Seven times, Nemi had requested the addition: AFTER, FOR A MOMENT, NOT KNOWING HOW TO RUN.

The Council had rejected the wording as a diminishment of historical will.

The lesson did not end with the shadow. After the exercise, the instructor had the children follow the mechanism, identify its joints and propose ways to neutralise it. The two who had run towards the projector received extra points. The child who had found shelter fastest was asked why he had abandoned the group.

"That is what the old protocol says," he replied.

The instructor projected the protocol: lateral dispersal, sudden changes of direction, use of low tunnels. The movements had been perfected over millennia and had saved entire generations. The children laughed when they tried to imitate them. Their bodies, heavier at the shoulders and trained to face forward, no longer turned easily. One tripped over his own hind limbs.

"This was our ancestors' response," the instructor said. "It suited a world in which they could not control the predator. We learn to choose."

Nemi, seated at the edge of the square, raised a sail.

"Flight was also a choice when there was somewhere to run."

The instructor recognised her and immediately changed his tone.

“Of course, Keeper. I am speaking of an expanded freedom of response.”

“Then teach them the old response too, until they can perform it.”

“The curriculum classifies it as motor heritage, not a current competency.”

“A body does not preserve heritage through definitions.”

The children watched her. To them, Nemi was almost an archive piece: very old, supported by rods, with long sails that fashion had abandoned. A boy came closer and asked whether she had ever fled a real saryx.

“Not fast enough,” she said.

“Did you kill it?”

“No.”

“Who did, then?”

“My uncle.”

“Taren?”

“Yes.”

“Why did you not learn from him to stay?”

Nemi looked at the statue. The bronze showed Taren alone, blade raised. Nemi remembered the square full of bodies, Sava shouting, Nemi as a child beneath a table, Taren frozen for a fraction before he acted.

“I learned that sometimes someone has to stay,” she answered. “Not that everyone has to want the same thing.”

The child looked disappointed. School questions had answers with clear signs. Her memories added edges.

The instructor resumed the exercise and, this time, made them flee according to the old protocol. The children collided, laughed and asked to repeat the frontal fight. Nemi recorded the attempt. She knew that, a

few years later, the clip might be used as evidence of flight's uselessness, not of a lack of training.

After the lesson, she crossed the Low Square. Ivarra was no longer the city in which she had grown up. The underground levels still existed, but towers rose through the protective membranes towards the sky. Magnetic fields reduced the radiation. Transparent lifts carried residents to the surface for work, ceremonies and walks. Open space, once a punishment, had become a sign of rank.

In the old markets, traders sold eye corrections, shoulder prostheses and decorative sail trimming. Clinics promised "command vision". Parents brought healthy children to have their peripheral vision reduced before the academy.

Vessa had fought the operation until her final years. She had published studies of accidents caused by the loss of lateral vision, sleep disorders and depression among those modified too early. The Custodianship had introduced consent at adulthood. Families had responded with "gradual correction" programmes beginning in childhood, small enough for each intervention to appear reversible.

When Vessa died twenty years earlier, the Faces had given her a military funeral for her contribution to field medicine. Her genetic criticism had been mentioned in an appendix. Nemi kept her last message in the archive: *I did not lose because the data was weak. I lost because every effect appeared after the reward that produced it.*

The Vertical Custodianship had brought peace to the Belt again. The Houses no longer fought open wars; they sent their young on the Margin Campaigns, ritualised conflicts for control of new tunnels, reactors and colonisation rights. The Code limited weapons, participant numbers and duration. The dead were counted as the price of social mobility.

The Faces led the army, police and risk administrations. The Hands produced and were entitled to protection. Memory kept the records, but access depended on the Custodianship's authorisation. Those once called the Protected had become the Interior People: children, the sick,

the elderly and all adults who refused the risk examination. They had guaranteed food, safe housing and almost no influence over frontier decisions.

The law said anyone could move from one function to another.

The data showed that ninety-one per cent of Faces had at least one Face parent.

Nemi kept this figure in the public layer of the archive. Every year, the Custodianship accompanied it with an explanation about family tradition and early preparation.

Sen had died at forty-one, after a campaign at the edge of Day. Not in battle, but from a marrow cancer associated with the genetic combinations favoured in Face lines. He had had nine acknowledged children and probably others. His eldest daughter, Arven, had become Custodian after an examination with seven candidates, five of them close relatives.

Arven was competent, disciplined and sincerely convinced that heredity had played no part.

The order of functions had become visible in the architecture. The Faces lived on the high levels, close to command centres and the surface. The Hands occupied the productive layers, among farms, reactors and transport. Memory lived around the archives, in cooled, windowless rooms. The Interior People received safe housing in the deep cores. No one called the distribution segregation. Each level was presented as optimal for its function.

Sava had died eight years after Taren. She had spent her final years leading a commission on mobility between functions. Its final report showed that examinations were formally open, but nutrition, education, family networks and bodily modifications determined the result before the test. The Council had adopted seven minor recommendations and postponed funding for the rest.

At her funeral, Nemi had read a single sentence from the report: *A door is not open if only some grow up with bodies shaped to fit it.* The crowd had applauded. The following year, the Face academies had used the quotation in a meritocratic scholarship campaign.

Sen had led the Belt for twenty-four years. At first, he had limited emergency mandates and opened the military archives. They had stopped three wars between Houses and transformed their Corps into shared units. Then the frontiers acquired other names: Margin Campaigns, stabilisation missions, contests for tunnel rights. Violence had not disappeared. It had been measured, scheduled and distributed by the Custodianship.

In the fifth year, a campaign lasted no more than thirty days and used non-penetrating weapons. In the tenth, exceptions allowed lethal projectiles for reactor defence. In the fifteenth, Houses could win colonisation rights in proportion to “risk assumed”. Young Faces joined voluntarily. Their families received prestige and reproductive quotas. Peace now had a controlled place in which to produce warriors.

Sen upheld the Code with a severity Taren had never shown. He dismissed commanders for looting, executed two for killing prisoners and required every unit to carry Hands medics. The Interior People considered him a protector. The Faces considered him proof that their power was moral. The fact that the rules were applied correctly made the institution harder to challenge.

Nemi met him twice a year. They were not close. They were bound by a shared childhood, the family’s dead and the fact that each had become custodian of a rival version of the past.

At their last meeting, Sen was forty. Marrow cancer had thinned his body, but he wore ceremonial armour. The doctors had offered him a transplant from an unrelated line. His immune system, shaped by the same interventions that had increased his resilience, had rejected every sample.

“Did Vessa predict this?” he asked.

“She predicted a risk,” Nemi replied. “Not your destiny.”

“Publish all the data.”

“The Custodianship classified it as genetic security information.”

“I am the Custodianship.”

“Which is precisely why the order must be signed before you die.”

Sen smiled. In illness, he looked more like the boy who had held Raal’s necklace than like Taren.

“You still talk like your mother.”

“Someone has to.”

He signed the publication order. The data showed an increased incidence of cancers, infertility and cardiac disorders in the selected Face lines. The Council recommended genetic diversification. Families accepted in theory and continued choosing the traits the examinations rewarded.

“I made the world safer,” Sen said.

It was not a question.

“For many, yes.”

“You always have a sentence afterwards.”

“Yes.”

“Say it.”

Nemi looked at the armour, the medical tubes and the vertical city beyond the window.

“You made danger a path to status. Now you need margins so the Faces know who they are.”

“The margins exist.”

“You also seek them out.”

Sen was silent.

“Father would have gone towards Leth if he had known it existed,” he said at last.

At that time, nothing had been detected in Leth. Nemi recorded the wording and labelled it a personal hypothesis. After his death, the songs had turned it into his final vision: the stars as an inevitable frontier.

Arven, his eldest daughter, won the Custodianship examination a year after the funeral. She had been a commander, had studied orbital ecology and had voted against her father in a margin campaign. She was better prepared than the other candidates. The fact that five out of seven were her relatives did not appear in the competence criteria.

The civilian node challenged the process. Memory published the genealogy. Arven requested a repeat of one test and won again. To her supporters, this demonstrated merit. To her opponents, it demonstrated that the family had possessed enough power to turn the challenge into another victory.

• • •

She summoned Nemi to the Sky Hall, built at the top of Ivarra’s tallest tower. The room had transparent walls and no shelter. For the old generations, it was a place of torture. For the new ones, a privilege.

An image of a probe floated above the table.

“It entered the system nine days ago,” Arven said.

The object was black, as long as a train and covered in layers of interstellar ice. It did not respond to signals. Its trajectory was not natural. It had passed Vei, adjusted its speed and was heading towards the mirror swarm.

“Origin?” Nemi asked.

“The Leth system, twelve light-years away. The spectra indicate a twilight planet and industrial activity.”

“Intelligent life.”

“Probably.”

“A weapon?”

Arven moved a sail.

“Unknown.”

Around the table stood the representatives of the Five Nodes. The Custodianship proposed capturing the probe, expanding the orbital fleet and building a propulsion gate towards Leth. The Hands had calculated the cost: twelve years of industrial surplus. The Chamber of Measure warned that the population would have to be reduced to free resources. Memory demanded that the object be decoded first. The Interior People’s node had voted against any expedition.

“We do not know whether they are coming towards us,” Nemi said.

The Fleet commander turned his convergent gaze towards her. The operation had brought his eyes disturbingly close to facing forward.

“The probe changed its trajectory after detecting the mirrors.”

“Perhaps it is seeking contact.”

“Contact is an approach whose risk is decided by the slowest participant. We will not be that participant.”

“There is no indication of hostility.”

“The saryx in the Low Square did not send a declaration either.”

Nemi looked through the tower wall at Taren’s statue, small in the square below.

“The comparison is false.”

“All comparisons are false until they survive.”

Seln would have liked the phrasing.

The Sky Hall still made Nemi nauseous. Its transparent walls revealed the curve of the Belt, the dark fields and Vei’s fixed brilliance. Her body demanded a ceiling and edges. Implants could reduce the response, but she had refused. She said Memory also needed the things the age considered symptoms.

Beside the council table stood Sio Eri, leader of the team that had analysed the probe. He had been born without a number during the solar storm in Vaor and had slept his first hours in a filter box. Now he was a Hands specialist in orbital organic systems. He wore long sails and had not had his eyes corrected. In the tower, his profile looked like a political statement, although he maintained that he feared the operation.

Nemi had met him a few times. Sio kept an old recording of Taren warming his box beside the pipe. He did not show it in public.

"The probe is not only mechanical," he told the council. "The hull contains tissues capable of repairing themselves. Some died in transit. Others are inactive, not dead."

"A crew?" Arven asked.

"We do not know. Perhaps a navigation system. Perhaps organisms being transported. The empty chambers have volumes compatible with bodies, but that compatibility begins with the bodies we imagine."

The Fleet commander opened the trajectory model.

"It adjusted its course towards the mirrors."

"Yes," Sio said. "After we sent a test sequence."

"It responded."

"Or avoided. The adjustment reduced the risk of collision with the swarm."

"It still entered capture range."

"Because we expanded it."

Arven looked at him face-on.

"Your conclusion?"

"We have no basis for hostility or for innocence. We have a constructed object, from an industrial world, that reacted to our infrastructure."

"The exact definition of strategic contact," the commander said.

“It is the definition of the facts. The word **strategic** is what you add.”

Nemi recognised something of Oru in Sio: the refusal to let function swallow the object. It seemed unfair that the association came to her only because she knew who had warmed his box at birth.

The Interior People’s representative, a woman named Fara, asked for the probe to be placed in an isolated orbit and studied before any project towards Leth.

“It may carry biological agents,” she said.

“It is already isolated,” the Fleet replied.

“Then why the urgency of the gate?”

The commander indicated the distance of twelve light-years.

“Because any reply sent now arrives after twenty-four years. Any construction begun after we understand them may come too late.”

“Too late for what?”

“To avoid being the unprepared side.”

Fara turned her body sideways, a gesture the Faces often interpreted as weakness. Nemi saw it as an attempt to keep the entire table in her field of vision.

“You are always the unprepared side before you define what you are preparing for,” Fara said.

Arven did not raise her voice. Her competence lay in her ability to turn conflict into a sequence of options.

“We will not launch without a vote. But we have to build the capacity to decide. A gate is not an invasion.”

“Nor was a Face House a dynasty,” Nemi said. “At first.”

Arven gave her a tired smile.

“That is why you are here.”

“So you can listen to me?”

“So we cannot say we were not warned.”

This was Memory’s mature form in the new order: it did not stop the decision, but it took away its innocence.

Arven opened a second model. The propulsion gate used the mirrors as an acceleration network. The technology had been possible for decades, but no project had justified the cost. Now, the mere existence of someone else turned the impossible into an emergency.

“It is not only defence,” the Custodian said. “The Belt is full. The Margin Campaigns redistribute tunnels; they do not create a world. Leth may have other resources, other ecosystems, other space.”

“And inhabitants.”

“Then we will negotiate.”

“With a fleet built before we hear their voice.”

Arven approached the window.

“Taren found a society in which every role was complete and every future allocated. He opened it. We have reached the edge again.”

“Taren did not only open things. He closed them too.”

“That is why we keep you alive, Nemi. To say the sentence after the song.”

“Do you listen to it?”

“Sometimes.”

The Council voted. The Custodianship, the Hands and the Chamber of Measure approved the gate. Memory abstained. The Interior People voted against it.

Three out of five.

The law worked exactly as it had been written.

In the following months, Ivarra filled with recruitment drives. Children drew the probe on walls and added wings, fangs or armour, although no

one knew what it contained. The Faces named the project the Horizon. Birth rights for fleet families were doubled as compensation for risk. Clinics reported a new demand: tolerance of open spaces, reduced sleep, total ocular convergence.

After the vote, Fara requested publication of the cost by function. The Hands had calculated twelve years of surplus, but the figure concealed its distribution. The new reactors would be built on their levels. Population reduction fell mainly on the Interior People, whose birth rights received no risk compensation. The fleet's Faces received double quotas. Memory would lose personnel to the decoding project.

The public report provoked protests. In the deep tunnels, the Interior People beat the old retreat signal: not from fear, but in refusal of departure for Leth. The Faces answered with the frontal rhythm. For the first time in decades, two stories of the body confronted one another through Ivarra's foundations.

Arven did not suppress the protests. She allowed them six cycles, then declared that blocking orbital transport threatened infrastructure and sent units without lethal weapons. Two hundred people were injured. No death appeared in the Custodianship's report. For an order that had learned to measure peace by the absence of deaths, the operation was a success.

Nemi visited one of the clinics treating the protesters. A man with a broken shoulder asked her why Memory had abstained instead of voting against it.

"Because we did not have enough data about the probe," she replied.

"You had enough about the cost."

"Yes."

"Then abstaining was a vote for those who already had three."

Nemi did not contradict him. Procedural neutrality had once again proved to be a decision with a beneficiary.

Sio continued analysing the object. The organic structures contained repeated sequences that might be language or repair instructions. One chamber retained traces of volatile compounds and a folded membrane. The team reconstructed a possible form: a small organism with radial symmetry, adapted to lower gravity. The model was so uncertain that Nemi refused to publish the image as a representation. The Fleet nevertheless used it in recruitment materials, with armour added.

Children drew “Lethians” with fangs. Traders sold toys. Preachers in some communities said the beings had come for light; others said they did not exist and the probe had been sent by the Great Hearing to create a new front. Uncertainty produced more stories than information.

Sio showed Nemi a sequence the algorithms had ignored. It repeated only after avoidance manoeuvres.

“It may be a distress signal,” he said.

“It may be a greeting.”

“It may be the tissue checking a pump.”

“What do you think?”

Sio looked at the object floating in the isolation field.

“I think we want to find a mind too quickly, because a mind can be an enemy, a partner or a judge. A pump gives us no meaning.”

Nemi thought of the first shadow in the square. A hungry animal had become the beginning of an order. Perhaps history did not need intelligent adversaries. It needed only something onto which a society could project its need.

Before the gate’s activation, Arven came to the archive alone. She wore no armour. She asked Nemi for all the unpublished recordings about Taren.

“Why?”

“I want to know what he would have done.”

“The dead man you are looking for was constructed by the living according to their needs.”

“You knew him.”

“Yes. And precisely because of that, I can tell you he would have wanted contradictory things. He would have prepared the defence. He would have hated the use of fear. He would have been drawn to the edge. He would have asked who controlled the gate. He would probably have taken the key if someone else seemed more dangerous.”

“That does not help me.”

“It helps you avoid using his name as a vote.”

Arven sat among the shelves. For the first time, she looked not like a Custodian, but like a woman who had been given a full world and a new distance.

“The Belt is full,” she said. “Young Faces fight over tunnels that no longer exist. The Interior People ask for larger families. The Hands say the reactors have reached their limit. If we do not open, the pressure stays here.”

“Then the gate is also a social pressure valve.”

“Yes.”

“Say that publicly.”

“They will think we are shipping away the inconvenient.”

“Are you?”

Arven did not answer at once.

“The volunteers will mostly be Faces without rank and Hands without access to the upper levels.”

“Then yes.”

“Not by order.”

“A structure can move people without commanding them. It shows them where a future exists.”

Arven raised her eyes towards the archives.

“Do you think we should cancel?”

Nemi thought of the children who no longer knew how to flee, of Sio born without a number, of the finite fields and the probe that had crossed twelve light-years without anyone knowing why.

“I think you must leave without calling the unknown property,” she said. “And send people capable of turning back if they discover that their presence does harm.”

“The Faces are trained to advance.”

“Then perhaps they are not the only ones you should send.”

Arven changed the first ship’s crew composition. She added Interior People, ecologists and negotiators. Fleet Command reduced their numbers during the logistics stage. On the final manifest, no Interior Person remained; the spaces had been reclassified for medical support. Arven signed. She said the next ship would be different.

Nemi kept both lists.

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Nemi visited the Gardens of Kinship, by then transformed into the Museum of Peace. Seln’s room was preserved with its bed, table and his commentaries projected on the walls. He had died six years after the trial. His final note said:

AN ORDER IS NOT DEFEATED WHEN YOU CHANGE ITS RULER. IT IS DEFEATED WHEN ITS INSTRUMENTS BECOME UNUSABLE.

Ivarra’s instruments had not become unusable. They had been extended to the stars.

On the day of the gate's activation, the entire population came to the surface. The towers protected the Belt with magnetic fields, and the red sky was no longer considered a place of death. Children sat in the front row. Some had modified eyes, others trimmed sails; all wore the frontal sign on their chests.

The probe from Leth had been captured. Inside, they had found organic structures, an undeciphered message and empty chambers the size of bodies. No one knew whether the passengers had died, departed or resembled nothing that could be recognised as a passenger.

That uncertainty was enough.

In the Museum of Peace, Seln's room had been restored too beautifully. The bed bore no impression of his body, the table had no scratches, and the opaque wall opened for visitors. Children passed through the room and listened to his commentaries selected by curators. Most often quoted were the warnings about Taren's power. Less often came the justifications for the mist and the Gardens.

Nemi requested access to the complete archive. Seln's final note remained there, followed by an unfinished fragment: **Instruments become unusable only when society accepts the cost of living without their services. Almost no victory accepts that cost.**

She did not know whether the sentence excused him or extended his accusation.

That same day, she visited Oru's root. The water station had been incorporated into a memorial park. Children ran among the pipes and touched the bitter fruit, then spat it out. A plaque called him an "engineer of resilience who unwittingly prepared the path to victory". Nemi had requested that **unwittingly** be removed and replaced with a description of his work. The committee had said the public needed the connection to great history.

Sio was waiting for her there. He wore the Hands launch suit. He had been added to the crew as a specialist in the probe's biology.

“You are leaving,” Nemi said.

“Yes.”

“You voted against the gate.”

“I voted against construction before contact. The gate exists now. I would rather someone were there who does not see every tissue as a weapon.”

“That is the same sentence by which good people enter bad institutions.”

“I know.”

“And?”

Sio touched the warm pipe. In his personal archive, that was where life began.

“Sometimes the institution leaves anyway.”

Nemi gave him a copy of Oru’s map, adapted to the orbital ship. Not because the technology was useful, but because his markings showed a way of thinking: never both valves closed; every system must leave a path for whoever comes afterwards.

“Do not turn it into a relic,” she said.

“I will use it.”

“Better.”

The mirrors aligned one by one. Their light formed a column above the Belt, so powerful that shadows disappeared. The first ship rose from the orbital tower, carrying three thousand Faces, one thousand Hands, two hundred members of Memory and no Interior People.

Nemi stood beside Taren’s statue. In her hand was the slate on which she had recorded Lur, Daran’s death, the siege and the first transfer of the sky. She began one last note.

The first ship bore the name *Raal*. The committee had chosen the name for courage and sacrifice. No plaque mentioned that Raal had been an outlaw, a thief, an opponent of ranks and the first to tell Taren that his

army could become a caste. Sen had kept his necklace all his life; Arven had now mounted it in the command room.

Among the three thousand Faces were Sen's grandchildren, children of the Houses and young people from public academies. The thousand Hands had been selected for rare skills. The two hundred members of Memory carried copies of the archives. The Interior People had been absent from the manifest, but eighty-seven had boarded as medical staff, carers and technicians without official classification. Institutions knew how to preserve the shape of a rule by changing people's names.

Nemi began recording. Around her, the crowd beat the rhythm of the gates. She tried the sentence about selection, food and songs.

"They did not become what they were meant to be," she said. "No species has such a destination. They became what received more births, more food, more songs and more reasons to believe itself necessary. The rest was called weakness, then protected, then excluded."

She stopped. The sentence sounded too much like a conclusion, and life had never respected conclusions.

She deleted the recording.

Deleting it did not eliminate the idea. Nemi recorded again, this time without a conclusion.

"I have seen a world in which flight was a virtue and one in which it became a shame," she said. "Both called their selection natural. I have seen peace using fear and war offering meaning. I have seen people saved by institutions that measured them and hurt by leaders who loved them. What leaves today is not the end of that contradiction. It is our way of carrying it with us."

She stopped. Behind the camera, a child asked why she spoke so sadly on a day of opening.

Nemi turned. The child had eyes corrected to face forward and uncut sails, a rare combination. He wore the sign of a Hands school.

“I am not sad,” she said. “I am trying to leave room for what we do not know.”

“Arven says Leth is a new world.”

“It is an old world for those who live there.”

The child thought.

“Then we are the new ones.”

“Yes.”

That was the best sentence of the day. Nemi kept it with his name.

Above them, the gate opened like a second horizon.

The children raised their heads. None sought shelter. None wondered whether the luminous shape might be a predator. In their eyes there was only distance and the promise that somewhere beyond it lay something that did not yet know their names.

That night, no one beat the ground to sound the alarm.

They all beat it together, to ask for the gates to open.

THE END